

Cultures of Continuity

Traditions in Transformation. Thinking with Theology



Edited by
Ufuk Topkara

Volume 2

Cultures of Continuity

Jewish-Muslim Conversations on a Contested Ideal

Edited by
Ufuk Topkara and Asher D. Biemann



DE GRUYTER

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ISSN 2942-6510

ISBN 978-3-11-133131-7

ISBN 978-3-11-133158-4 (PDF)

ISBN 978-3-11-133167-6 (EPUB)

DOI <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783111331584>

Library of Congress Control Number: 2026933748

Bibliographic information published by the Deutsche Nationalbibliothek

The Deutsche Nationalbibliothek lists this publication in the Deutsche Nationalbibliografie; detailed bibliographic data are available on the Internet at <http://dnb.dnb.de>.

© 2026 the author(s)/editor(s), published by Walter de Gruyter GmbH, Genthiner Straße 13, 10785 Berlin, Germany

De Gruyter and Walter de Gruyter GmbH are part of De Gruyter Brill.
www.degruyterbrill.com

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Cover illustration: ©Asher Biemann: „Nr. 40“ (1994)

Printing: CPI books GmbH, Leck

Preface

The present volume emerged from an international and interdisciplinary conference held at the Humboldt Universität zu Berlin in September 2022 under the auspices of the *Forum on Jewish-Muslim Thought & Theology*. Founded in 2020, the Forum seeks to imagine a contemporary Islamic thought that oscillates between its own tradition, the other monotheistic traditions, as well as secular knowledge, and which is independent, while remaining open to engaging with multiple discourses. Among them, the Forum contends, 20th-century Jewish thought can serve as prominent inspiration and interlocutor for the development of contemporary Islamic thought and theology. This discursive approach is not merely comparative. Rather, it assumes a correlative relationship, allowing us to learn not only from, but also *with* each other. By expanding our knowledge through this engagement, the Forum hopes to foster the importance of Islamic theology and thought in contemporary discourses and to expand and proliferate the common understanding of Islamic intellectual heritage. By the same token, contemporary Jewish thought can draw inspiration and receive new impulses from its encounter with the rich Islamic intellectual tradition.

In this spirit, “Cultures of Continuity” embarks on a profound and multifaceted exploration of the dynamic interplay between continuity and rupture, examining how these forces shape religious thought and experience across diverse traditions. Employing a rich tapestry of methodologies, the chapters in this volume skillfully interweave inter-theological perspectives with socio-historical analyses, delving into the intricate ways in which religious traditions evolve, adapt, and sometimes fracture in the face of continued change.

A central thread woven throughout this exploration is the persistent and often productive tension between inherited wisdom—the bedrock of established religious frameworks—and contemporary innovation, which challenges and reshapes these frameworks. This tension is particularly evident in the search for “resonance” in an increasingly fragmented and secularized world, where traditional meanings can struggle to find purchase. The collection carefully lays the groundwork for understanding how various traditions grapple with historical trauma, such as persecution, displacement, and internal schisms, as well as broader societal upheaval, including rapid technological change, globalization, and shifting moral landscapes. By considering viewpoints from the margins or from different faith traditions, the volume underscores how new insights can emerge, challenging insular interpretations and fostering greater empathy.

These diverse case studies, though distinct in their focus, converge in a shared and profound commitment to interreligious dialogue. This commitment is not merely an academic exercise but a practical imperative, aiming for the redis-

covery of shared values and ethical principles between Judaism and Islam that can transcend theological differences. Furthermore, the volume explores the complex and often intertwined interdependencies between Jewish and Muslim identity, providing nuanced insights into their historical interactions, shared challenges, and potential for mutual understanding.

The ultimate goal of this volume is to offer a compelling and hopeful vision for how religious traditions, rather than retreating into rigid fundamentalism or succumbing to irrelevance, can remain dynamic, relevant, and constructive forces in an ever-evolving global landscape. The volume concludes by emphasizing the importance of self-reflection within each tradition, coupled with humility—acknowledging the limits of one’s own understanding—and an ongoing, active engagement in inter-theological work. This continuous dialogue and collaboration are presented as vital pathways to fostering deeper understanding, cultivating mutual respect, and ultimately promoting greater cooperation in our increasingly interconnected and interdependent world.

This publication is funded by the German Federal Ministry of Research Technology and Space (BMFTR) (Funding Code: 01UD2407Y).

Our thanks goes to Dr. Torsten Wollina from DeGruyter Brill publishing house for his attentive support of the volume and his assistance in establishing the series “Traditions in Transformation. Thinking with Theology.” We also would like to thank Ashley Fritsch also from DeGruyter Brill, for her diligent and ongoing supervision.

We would like to thank all the authors for their valuable contributions that made this volume possible and enrich it. A very special thank you goes to Dr. Maeve McGrath for her dedicated work in copy-editing the contributions. We also would like to mention the assistance of Ammar Aldudak and Furgan Sözen throughout the process of finishing the manuscript. Without their involvement, the volume would not have been completed in this form and time.

Ufuk Topkara, Berlin

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Introduction

“The thread of historical continuity,” Hannah Arendt once remarked, “was the first substitute for tradition.” To the historian, the assumed continuity of historical events became an *Ersatzreligion* of sorts, a substitute religion that rejected not the ideas of tradition and transmission as such but, rather, their unquestioned authority. Yet, while seemingly secular and rooted in culture, the idea, or ideal, of continuity is propagated also by traditional religious groups and forces. It appears as much as a resistance to cultural discontinuities as it functions as a critique of modernity itself.

Continuity, therefore, has remained a contested concept not only among modern thinkers, but also with the post-modern turn; here, assumed historical linearities have been brought into question and deconstructed with force. We are rightly concerned about hegemonic continuities and about continuity for its own sake. Why, if at all, should continuity matter? Is there a legitimate place for continuity and, thus, for *cultures* of continuity, in a world where change and rupture have assumed their own kind of normativity? Is continuity a “conservative” value by default that must necessarily resist progressive ideals of reform, or is it something more complex that can open spaces for cultural self-knowledge and self-revision? Can conscious continuities offer helpful insights into enduring debates on pluralistic societies, collective identity, and cultural resilience?

This volume offers a profound and multifaceted exploration of continuity and rupture as dynamic forces shaping modern religious thought and experience. It employs a rich tapestry of methodologies, drawing upon diverse inter-theological perspectives and socio-historical analyses to unpack the intricate ways in which religious traditions evolve, adapt, and sometimes fracture.

The contributing articles are the product of deep intellectual engagement with the enduring challenges of tradition and modernity. They delve into the persistent tension between inherited wisdom and contemporary innovation, examining how religious communities and individual thinkers grapple with the need to preserve core values while simultaneously embracing necessary change. A central theme explored is the search for resonance in an increasingly accelerated and fragmented world, investigating how religious practices and beliefs can maintain their salience and meaning amidst rapid societal shifts and technological advancements. Furthermore, the collection thoughtfully addresses the active process of re-beginning—the spiritual, intellectual, and communal imperative to re-evaluate, reinterpret, and re-establish foundations in the face of historical trauma, displacement, and profound societal upheavals.

The scope of this volume is broad by intention, spanning a vast historical and geographical landscape. It meticulously examines a range of influential figures and movements, from the nuanced intellectual history of the medieval period and the mystical traditions of Sufism, through the complex reform movements of the late Ottoman era, to the profound philosophical contributions of German-Jewish thought, and finally, to contemporary French postcolonial identity. Through these diverse case studies, the collection incisively analyzes how various communities and scholars navigate the delicate and often fraught tension between upholding essential, immutable values and embracing the imperative for necessary change and adaptation.

Ultimately, this work transcends a mere descriptive account to illuminate the shared ethical and epistemological imperatives that are crucial for the sustained vitality of religious life and the fostering of interconnectedness in our complex, globalized world. It highlights the profound importance of virtues such as humility in understanding diverse perspectives, mutual engagement in fostering inter-faith dialogue, and critical self-reflection in continually refining one's own beliefs and practices. These imperatives are particularly emphasized within the context of Jewish-Muslim relations, where the volume seeks to demonstrate how shared values and ethical principles can bridge historical divides and cultivate deeper understanding and cooperation. By doing so, it offers a compelling vision for how religious traditions can remain dynamic, relevant, and constructive forces in an ever-evolving global landscape.

In "The Limits of Continuity," Elias Sacks examines Nachman Krochmal's perspective on historical continuity in Jewish thought. While Krochmal acknowledges historical precedents for philosophy, he argues that its value lies in its "practical continuity"—its connection to everyday Jewish life. He views philosophy as a rigorous form of the conceptual reflection needed to address the inherent contradictions and questions within Jewish traditions like holidays and prayer. Sacks concludes that Krochmal's defense offers contemporary scholars a model for grounding philosophy in community needs, but questions whether scholars have sufficient expertise to effectively apply this approach. This raises crucial questions about how scholars can gain the necessary expertise and authentically connect their work to the lived realities of the communities they seek to engage.

In "Conscious Continuities: On Re-beginning as Modern Jewish Imperative," Asher D. Biemann emphasizes that "continuous rebirth" is a vital, active principle in modern Jewish thought, especially after events like the Holocaust. Thinkers like Leo Baeck interpret Jewish history as marked not by simple continuity but by ongoing renewal and resilience, even amid past traumas. This mindset, rooted in optimism and defiance ("despite"), sees rebirth as an active human obligation

rather than a passive event. The concept is linked to Karl Löwith's idea of "conscious continuity," inspired by the Renaissance, which involves intentionally preserving and renewing tradition. The essay outlines three imperatives: Revision (moral optimism for improvement), Permanence (ongoing preservation of humanity), and Correlation (humility and mutual cultural engagement). Together, these form a project of spiritual interconnectedness, actively confronting rupture with life-affirming responsibility.

In his article "Islam as Theurgy", Arthur Schechter uses the writings of the major Mongol-era Sufi authority 'Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī (d. 1329) to explore how the well-known shift in late-medieval Islamdom from rationalism and theology toward a Sufi blend of emanationist thought was not confined to intellectual history, but extended across different areas of life in Islamic society. Drawing examples from Kāshānī and related figures, as well as their earlier sources in the Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā*) and even more distant Hellenistic background, he shows how late medieval Sufis rationalized religious practice in publicly accessible terms that, for both historical and descriptive reasons, deserve classification as theurgy. Key to this account for Kāshānī was the status of universals, whose extramental existence in the substance of divine emanation and further identification with divine attributes, virtues and perfections made the goal of Islamic religious observance the attraction of these emanations through a kind of sympathetic correspondence. Given Kāshānī's wide reception, he considers the broader viability of his teachings for interpreting religious practice as theurgy across other areas of later Islamic history. In particular, he suggests that the rise of Iranian Shi'ism, viewed through the lens of Kāshānī's thought, becomes ethically legible as a mode of seeking theurgic participation in the universal, manifest in the realm of particulars.

In "Continuity and Renewal: İsmail Hakkı İzmirli's *Yeni 'ilm-i Kalām*", Esma Ünsal explores İsmail Hakkı İzmirli's "Yeni 'ilm-i Kalām" (New Science of Kalām) movement in the late Ottoman era, focusing on İzmirli's attempt to reconcile Islamic tradition with Western philosophy and modern science. She argues that İzmirli sought continuity through renewal, strategically integrating innovation to preserve the essence of Kalām. The article discusses the challenges İzmirli faced, including criticisms from contemporaries and the difficulty of defining Kalām in a post-metaphysical world. Ünsal concludes by highlighting the relevance of İzmirli's work for contemporary Islamic theology, particularly in Germany, where the discipline is relatively new and grappling with similar questions of tradition and modernity. Ünsal emphasizes the importance of understanding and critically examining Kalām in the context of modern philosophy to ensure its continued vitality.

In her article “Beyond Simmel’s Stranger: A Theory of Critical Strangerhood,” Elisabeth Becker introduces the concept of “critical strangerhood” in the context of Jewish and Muslim experiences in modern Europe. She builds upon the theories of Simmel, Arendt, and Bauman regarding the “stranger” figure, arguing that strangerhood can be a productive positionality that enables agency and critique. She analyzes the works of Stefan Zweig, Albert Memmi, Zafer Şenocak, and Fatima Besnaci-Lancou to illustrate different configurations of strangerhood: exile, colonial, postwar, and postcolonial. These authors use their experiences as insider-outsiders to challenge dominant narratives, reframe history, and advocate for more inclusive societies. The article concludes that critical strangerhood allows for a unique perspective on Europe, fostering understanding and promoting social change.

In “Albert Memmi’s concept of the Arab-Jew and the mobilisation of hybridity in France today,” Samia Hathroubi argues that Albert Memmi’s concept of the “Arab-Jew” is a vital framework for analysing and challenging contemporary processes of identification and racialization in France. Memmi’s writings and biography—marked by tensions of continuity and rupture and an ambivalent relationship with Tunisia—serve as point of departure. Hathroubi documents how contemporary artists and intellectuals are drawing on Memmi to revive the “Arab-Jew” idea within postcolonial French debates, probing hybrid identities and promoting forms of reconciliation. This revival is evident among diasporic communities in Paris, Tunis, and Israel, which use the “Arab-Jew” figure to move beyond binary categories. The study also restores attention to Jewish presence in the Arab-Muslim world and to a history now being reclaimed by third-generation French Jews of Tunisian and Maghrebi origin. The reappearance of the term “Arab-Jew” is therefore significant in postcolonial France, as it contests the dominant narrative of Jewish–Muslim conflict and opens up alternative perspectives.

In their article “The Hidden and Revealed in an Istanbul Cabaret,” Esra Almas and Jack Kugelmass analyze the Turkish Netflix series “The Club” (2021–2023) as a narrative exploring the complex relationship between Jews and Muslims in Turkey, set against the backdrop of historical events like the 1942 Wealth Tax and the 1955 anti-Greek pogrom. Almas and Kugelmass highlight the series’ significance as the first Turkish production to feature a sympathetic Jewish main character and incorporate Ladino, thus challenging the Turkish Republic’s promotion of a unified Turkish identity. The series explores themes of identity, memory, and the possibility of transcendence through love, drawing parallels between Jewish and Sufi religious sensibilities. *The Club* is viewed as a “contact zone” where different backgrounds intersect, using music and ritual to bridge cultural divides and offer a message of ecumenism and hope in the face of historical trauma and state-sanctioned violence, ultimately promoting the idea of Turkey as a home and refuge.

In “Knowing People. Discontinuities in Modern Jewish Political Epistemology,” Elad Lapidot analyzes the continuities and discontinuities between modern academic knowledge and the modern project of Judaism by examining four models of academic Jewish studies: *Wissenschaft des Judentums* (German University), *khokhmat yisrael* (Hebrew University), Cultural Jewish Studies (American University), and Torah study in Lithuanian yeshivas. He focuses on the epistemo-political tensions arising from the encounter between academic knowledge and Jewish knowledge, exploring how each model understands and constructs its Jewish object of knowledge. The chapter argues that each model negotiates this tension differently, with varying degrees of engagement with, or negation of, traditional Jewish knowledge, highlighting the power dynamics inherent in these approaches and the resulting implications for the self-conception of academic Jewish studies and the collective identity of the Jewish people.

In “Dialogical Theology and its Relevance for Jewish-Muslim Relations” Ephraim Meir discusses the importance of interreligious dialogue for fostering understanding and cooperation between Muslims and Jews. He critiques the fixity of identity politics and promotes a “trans-difference” approach that respects distinctiveness while emphasizing shared values and a common world. He advocates for a dialogical theology that emphasizes humility, openness to learning, and the development of competencies such as presence, readiness to learn, and a focus on human rights. Ultimately, the article argues that interreligious dialogue is essential for creating a more peaceful and interconnected society where traditions are preserved, reinvented, and reimaged to address contemporary challenges.

In “The Interdependency of Jews and Muslims in Medieval Intellectual History: Muslim Impact on Saadia Gaon (d. 942) and his Reception,” Tuğrul Kurt examines the influence of Muslim sources and discussions on Saadia Gaon, a foundational figure in Jewish Philosophy and Intellectual History. Saadia Gaon systematically articulated Jewish religion in rational terms, and his translation of the Hebrew Bible is notably titled *tafsīr* (“explanation” or “interpretation”) rather than *tarjama* (“translation”). This distinction highlights that Saadia not only provided a linguistic translation but also an interpretation drawing from both Muslim and Jewish sources. He even diverged from traditional rabbinic understanding to incorporate interpretations from Islamic sources. Despite earlier “translations,” Saadia’s *tafsīr* gained widespread acceptance among Arabic-speaking Jews, primarily due to its inherent nature rather than his personal authority. Kurt points out that Saadia Gaon deliberately used specific Islamic terms, especially Neo-Platonic concepts, believing them to be precise and appropriate for an “assimilated Jewish audience.”

In her article “Reciprocal Illumination. A Quasi-Midrashic Orientation for Inter-Theological Inquiry,” Marcia Pally proposes an approach to inter-theological

scholarship called “reciprocal illumination” to foster productive exchanges characterized by curiosity, respect, and interest in new perspectives, focusing on Jewish-Christian dialogue. She argues that inter-theological exchanges have been integral to Jewish tradition since the Amoraic period, citing examples of cultural adaptations and intertextuality. She highlights past and present efforts in Jewish-Christian dialogue, emphasizing the need for self-reflexivity to avoid cultural biases, referencing Konrad Schmid’s work on the influence of anti-Semitism on Hebrew Bible scholarship. The chapter explores human relationality as “distinction-amid-relation” and introduces a quasi-Midrashic approach to inter-theological inquiry with five key aspects: heterogeneity of experience, epistemological humility, broad-based study, suspension of imposing judgment, and bracketing of syncretism. The concepts of Trinity and covenant are used as examples of how this approach can illuminate relationality in both traditions. The chapter concludes by advocating for continued self-reflection and open engagement in inter-theological work to challenge biases and foster genuine understanding.

In “Leo Baeck’s Double-Critique of Christianity and Islam,” Yanniv Feller reconstructs Leo Baeck’s interpretation of Islam by examining minor texts and major works spanning seven decades. Feller contributes to an understanding of this central German-Jewish thinker by positioning Baeck’s understanding of Islam alongside his critique of Christianity and his faith in the value of Judaism. Baeck lauded the achievements of medieval Jewry under Muslim rule as a means of critiquing Christian majority society. However, Feller notes that Baeck differed from other Jewish scholars who did the same because he did not consider al-Andalus to be the pinnacle of Jewish life in the medieval period. Instead, Baeck viewed it as only one of two equally important poles: Sepharad and Ashkenaz. Despite his generally positive assessment of Islam, Feller reveals that Baeck’s thought also exhibits prejudices, portraying Islam as a static religion whose success is attributed to the simplicity of its message. Feller explains that Baeck believed in the legitimacy and success of Muslim, and at times Christian, missionizing, as he saw the potential for propagating monotheism through these efforts. Baeck viewed them as proxies for Jewish missionizing, which he believed should be resumed after the Holocaust.

I Continuity, Discontinuity, and Re-continuity in Jewish and Islamic Thought

Elias Sacks

Chapter 1

The Limits of Continuity: Nachman Krochmal and the Case for Philosophy

1 Introduction

The theme at the heart of this volume—“historical continuity” and its status as a “contested ideal”—looms large in modern Jewish thought. Many figures, in fact, might be said to enact a contestation over this ideal within their own writings, expressing both attraction to, and wariness of, religious arguments that invoke the importance of links between present and past. Consider the theologian Judith Plaskow, whose groundbreaking *Standing Again at Sinai* calls for a feminism that involves “the thoroughgoing transformation of religion and society”:

The notion of feminism as a process of radical transformation raises . . . the issue of boundaries. For many Jews . . . the notion of women taking power to shape the Jewish tradition provokes not just a sense of contradiction but a feeling of dislocation and chaos. Once women begin radically altering Judaism, where will change stop? How much of what lies rooted in childhood memory, of what many Jews love and value, will be eroded by criticism and destroyed? At what point in the reinterpretation of Judaism does the Jewish tradition cease being Jewish and become something else? . . . [However,] rabbinic Judaism itself was the product of enormous changes—a shift from Temple sacrifice as the center of worship, to study and prayer as the dual focus of Judaism. This profound change was perceived as a transition rather than a break only because the Jewish community willed it so, and undertook to reinterpret the past to meet the needs of a radically different present . . . The Jews of the past, drawing on the religious forms available to them, created and recreated a living Judaism, reshaping tradition in ways consonant with their needs. What determined the “Jewishness” of their formulations was . . . the “workability” of such formulations for the Jewish people: the capacity of stories and laws and liturgy to adapt to new conditions, to make sense and provide meaning . . . Jewish feminism does involve a radical discontinuity with the tradition . . . But the mechanisms that will decide the success or failure of Jewish feminism are old and tried. Some feminist changes will endure because they are appropriate, because they speak to felt needs within the community and ring true to the Jewish imagination.¹

Affirming that “Jewish feminism does involve . . . radical discontinuity,” Plaskow criticizes attempts to resist such transformations in the name of continuity with

1 Judith Plaskow, *Standing Again at Sinai: Judaism from a Feminist Perspective* (San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1990), xvii–xix.

the past—attempts to limit or delegitimize change by stressing the need to preserve patterns of Jewish life “rooted in childhood memory,” or by raising the specter of a feminism that is so radically new that it will “cease being Jewish and become something else.” At the same time, however, her critique of these continuity-based claims *itself* appeals to this value. Far from simply representing a break with the prior course of Jewish history, she argues in the lines quoted above, her call for “thoroughgoing transformation” is itself continuous with the Jewish past, both in the sense that earlier movements such as rabbinic Judaism themselves enacted “enormous changes,” and in the sense that the fate of feminist innovations will rely on “mechanisms” that are “old and tried.” Just as “Jews of the past . . . recreated a living Judaism” that gained acceptance because it “reshap[ed] tradition in ways consonant with their needs,” so too will “some feminist changes . . . endure because . . . they speak to felt needs within the community and ring true to the Jewish imagination.”

This dynamic is hardly restricted to late twentieth-century texts such as *Standing Again at Sinai*. On the contrary, a willingness to both deploy and critique appeals to continuity has a long history in modern Jewish thought. This essay illuminates that history by recovering another (albeit very different), and much earlier, instance of internal ambivalence towards or contestation over continuity, focusing on an eastern European Jewish philosopher who is at once well-known and rarely read: Nachman Krochmal. Born in 1785 in eastern Galicia (now Ukraine), Krochmal has long been recognized as a central figure in Jewish encounters with developments such as historicism, biblical criticism, and German Idealism. A businessperson and communal leader who taught himself German, French, Latin, Arabic, and Syriac, he is remembered for *The Guide of the Perplexed of the Time* (*Moreh Nevukhei Ha-zeman*), an opaque Hebrew treatise that—despite being unfinished when he died in 1840—remains one of the most significant attempts to construct a Jewish philosophy of history. He also exercised considerable influence (especially on early figures in the academic study of Judaism),² and the late nineteenth and early-to-mid-twentieth centuries saw many leading Jewish intellectuals devote substantial

2 Examples include Zechariah Fränkel, Isaac Hirsh Weiss, Chaim Tchernowitz, and Hanokh Albeck: see Jay Harris, *Nachman Krochmal: Guiding the Perplexed of the Modern Age*, *Modern Jewish Masters* 4 (New York: New York University Press, 1991), 322–3. Another intriguing possibility is Leopold Zunz, who would edit the *Guide* after Krochmal's death. Although Zunz has been identified as a potential source for Krochmal (Harris, *Nachman Krochmal*, 178–9, 295, 303n20), one reader has suggested that Krochmal's ideas, yet-to-be-formulated in the *Guide*, might have also reached and influenced Zunz through the Galician scholar Solomon Judah Rapoport: see Andreas Lehnardt, “Nachman Krochmal and Leopold Zunz: On the Influence of the *Moreh Nevukhe Ha-zeman* on the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*,” *European Journal of Jewish Studies* 7 (2013): 182–3. Both Harris and Lehnardt contrast their evaluations of Krochmal's influence with the assessment

attention to his work.³ Nevertheless, Krochmal is now rarely studied, at least in North America. Despite scholarship in Israel and Europe (including a new Hebrew edition and German translation of the *Guide*),⁴ the most recent English-language book on his thought appeared in 1991,⁵ and little of the *Guide* has been translated for Anglophone audiences.⁶

My article explores the role of historical continuity in one aspect of Krochmal's thought: his defense of philosophy. The *Guide* sometimes follows a line of Jewish thinkers who defend philosophy with appeals to this ideal—with arguments purporting to show that influential Jewish figures throughout history have engaged in philosophical inquiry, and that such reflection therefore occupies a legitimate place within Jewish life. I will show, however, that Krochmal is also keenly interested in the limits of this strategy. More specifically, I will argue that he criticizes defenses of philosophy that valorize historical continuity, and I will

offered by Gershom Scholem, who minimizes Krochmal's impact on the academic study of Judaism.

3 See, e.g., Solomon Schechter, "Nachman Krochmal and the 'Perplexities of the Time,'" in *Studies in Judaism* (London: Black, 1896): 56–88; Steven Schwarzschild, "Two Modern Jewish Philosophies of History: Nachman Krochmal and Hermann Cohen" (PhD diss.; HUC, 1955); Simon Rawidowicz, *Introductions to Kitvei Rabbi Nachman Krochmal*, 2nd ed. (Waltham: Ararat, 1961): 6–225; Jacob Taubes, "Nachman Krochmal and Modern Historicism," *Judaism* 12(2) (1963): 150–64.

4 Nachman Krochmal, *Moreh Nevukhei Ha-zeman*, ed. Yehoyada Amir (Jerusalem: Carmel, 2010); *Führer der Verwirrten der Zeit*, 2 vols., trans. Andreas Lehnardt, Philosophische Bibliothek 615a–b (Hamburg: Felix Meiner, 2012).

5 The English monograph is Harris, *Nachman Krochmal*. For recent English-language discussions, see, e.g., Yehoyada Amir, "The Perplexity of Our Time: Rabbi Nachman Krochmal and Modern Jewish Existence," *Modern Judaism* 23(3) (2003): 264–301; Olga Litvak, *Haskalah: The Romantic Movement in Judaism* (New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 2012), 124–30; Lawrence Kaplan, "Yehezkel Kaufmann, R. Nachman Krochmal, and the 'Anxiety of Influence,'" in *Yehezkel Kaufmann and the Reinvention of Jewish Biblical Scholarship*, eds. Job Jindo et al., *Orbis Biblicus et Orientalis* 283 (Fribourg: Academic; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2017): 122–46. For a recent book-length Hebrew study, see Yehoyada Amir, *She'arim Le-emunah Tzerufah: Hithadshut Ha-hayyim Ha-yehudiyim Be-mishnato shel Nachman Krochmal* (Raanana: Open University of Israel Press, 2018). I explore some of the issues in the present essay, albeit in a different context, in Elias Sacks "The Promise and Perils of Perplexity: Jewish Philosophy and Public Culture, Yesterday and Today," in *The Future of Jewish Philosophy*, eds. Hava Tirosh-Samuelson and Aaron Hughes, *Library of Contemporary Jewish Philosophy* 21 (Brill, 2018): 79–97.

6 For English selections, see, e.g., Michael Meyer, ed., *Ideas of Jewish History* (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 1987), 187–214; Gershon Greenberg, ed. *Modern Jewish Thinkers: From Mendelssohn to Rosenzweig*, Emunot: Jewish Philosophy and Kabbalah (Brighton: Academic Studies Press, 2011), 81–118; Leora Batnitzky and Yonatan Brafman, eds., *Jewish Legal Theories: Writings on State, Religion, and Morality*, Brandeis Library of Modern Jewish Thought (Waltham: Brandeis University Press, 2018), 58–64.

suggest that his critique both offers resources, and poses questions, for contemporary thinkers. Despite sometimes defending philosophical inquiry by invoking its long history in Jewish life, Krochmal also raises concerns about this apologetic strategy, challenging the idea that historical longevity is a reliable mark of religious value. His response is to focus not only on *historical* continuity, but also on what we might call *practical* continuity—to connect philosophy not only to towering figures from Jewish history, but also to the ordinary activities of Jewish communities. This approach, I conclude, remains relevant today, including for scholars of Jewish and Muslim thought like those represented in this volume. Krochmal's work at once outlines a path for those of us who wish to defend philosophy and rigorous intellectual reflection in the face of indifference and hostility, while also raising questions about whether we possess the expertise to do so in a manner that will prove effective in religious communities and in society more broadly.

2 Krochmal and the History of Jewish Philosophy

Published posthumously in 1851, the *Guide* seeks, among other goals, to describe a mode of inquiry that Krochmal calls the “science of faith” or “the science of the Torah.” One of his most detailed accounts of this intellectual endeavor appears in the treatise's sixteenth chapter:

In the Toraitic faith and the hearts of those who adhere to it, there are already representations and feelings regarding the Lord, Blessed be He (regarding His attributes and relation to the world in its totality and particulars), regarding the human being's soul and destiny, and regarding the good, the bad, and similar matters. The activity of the science of faith is simply to cognize the truth of these representations—that is to say, to abstract from their particulars and transform them into universal principles and concepts of the understanding. Thus, ever since our predecessors began to dwell on the roots of religion and the secrets of the Torah (privately or by means of chapter headings, at any rate, since the middle of the Second Temple Period [515 BCE–70 CE], and openly and by means of ordered lines of argumentation since the days of Rav Saadia [882–942 CE] and the early kabbalists), new concepts of thought would emerge for them . . . and they would be forced to define them and signify them with terms such as “infinite and finite,” “necessary and possible existence,” “the eternal and the temporal,” “existence and nonexistence,” “the material and the spiritual,” [and] “free will and fate” . . . The sages never hesitated to take the aforementioned concepts and terms, as required by their investigations, from other sciences—and, in particular, from logical philosophy.⁷

⁷ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 272. All translations of Krochmal are mine.

The background here is Krochmal's view, developed elsewhere in the *Guide*, that religious communities and their sources express, through "representations" or images, content which might also be articulated in a more theoretically adequate manner—that the language employed by religious communities constitutes concrete, vivid imagery expressing more sophisticated ideas which might not be fully explicit for most members of those communities.⁸ The "science of faith," in turn, is an activity that uncovers such ideas in the language employed by the Jewish tradition. This endeavor, Krochmal suggests, takes "representations" present in "the Toraitic faith and the hearts of those who adhere to it" and "transforms them into universal principles and concepts of the understanding," analyzing those claims and reframing them in terms of ideas such as "infinite and finite," "material and spiritual," and "necessary and possible existence." His vision is of a mode of inquiry in which we begin with claims in Jewish sources, or with Jews' intuitive judgements about various matters, and then elevate those descriptions to a more conceptually rigorous form in the sense of reflecting on them and recasting them in more theoretically sophisticated terms. Encountering biblical claims that God created the cosmos, we might reflect on the meaning of such statements, determining that the image of divine creation points to the idea that the "material" world is real but rooted in something "spiritual," something more than the physical; intuitively grasping that I am alive only because of causes outside of me (such as my parents, the circumstances that led them to meet, and other factors), I might reflect on these contingencies, concluding that the existence of a being like me is merely "possible," but that we can conceive of an entity—for example, a deity—whose existence is "necessary."

Krochmal is also making a claim about the intellectual genre of this type of inquiry. While this science might employ concepts from various sources, he notes, it is "particularly" indebted to "logical philosophy," borrowing numerous terms from that discipline. He goes further elsewhere in the *Guide*, insisting not merely that the science of faith draws on philosophy, but that this rigorous conceptual reflection is itself a form of philosophy:

Just as science in general involves transforming representations into concepts of the understanding and reason, in a like manner . . . do we comprehend the relationship and value of *the Toraitic faith* to the science of faith—whether one calls it, with the master [Maimonides], *the science of the Torah* . . . or, with recent thinkers, *philosophy of religion*.⁹

8 On "representations" and religious communities, see, e.g., Krochmal, *Moreh*, 11–12, 29–41 et al.

9 Krochmal, *Moreh*, 30.

What the *Guide* calls “the science of faith,” and what an earlier figure such as Maimonides calls “the science of the Torah,” is simply what modern thinkers call “philosophy of religion.”

Finally, Krochmal is making a claim not only about the content and genre of the science of faith, but also about its place in Jewish history. Far from being a recent innovation, he declares in the first passage quoted above, this endeavor goes back roughly two millennia, encompassing figures ranging from “sages” of antiquity to the medieval philosopher Saadia Gaon to the early kabbalists or Jewish mystics. He echoes this point elsewhere in the *Guide*, both in the second passage quoted above—which associates the science of faith with Maimonides—and in the book’s opening chapters, which assert that “what is called by [Maimonides] . . . *the science of the Torah*” is also “scattered across [rabbinic works such as] the two Talmuds and the midrashic collections.”¹⁰ One of the *Guide*’s key claims, then, is a narrative about historical continuity and Jewish philosophy—a narrative about how, for at least two thousand years, influential Jewish thinkers have engaged in rigorous conceptual reflection.

3 Krochmal and the Defense of Jewish Philosophy

There is more to say about Krochmal’s position, including his debts to German Idealism.¹¹ What’s crucial for us, though, is that when he presents his narrative about continuity, he is doing so not simply to describe Jewish philosophy’s history, but also to defend its legitimacy—to suggest that if influential figures throughout history have engaged in philosophical inquiry, then such reflection occupies a legitimate place within Jewish life, constituting an acceptable pursuit for faithful adherents of the Jewish tradition. Consider his observation that the

¹⁰ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 10.

¹¹ The precise nature of Krochmal’s relationship to German Idealism—both what he owes this movement, and which figures are most crucial for him—has long been a matter of debate. See, e.g., J.L. Landau, *Nachman Krochmal: Ein Hegelianer* (Berlin: Calvary, 1904); Simon Rawidowicz, “War Nachman Krochmal Hegelianer?” *Hebrew Union College Annual* 5 (1928): 535–82; Joseph Klausner, “Hashpa’ato shel Hegel ‘al R. Nachman Krochmal,” in *Jewish Studies Issued in Honor of the Chief Rabbi J.L. Landau* (Tel Aviv: Va’ad Ha-yovel, 1936): 71–81; Abraham Katsh, “Nachman Krochmal and the German Idealists,” *Jewish Social Studies* 8 (1946): 87–102; Shlomo Avineri, “The Fossil and the Phoenix: Hegel and Krochmal on the Jewish *Volksgeist*,” in *History and System*, ed. Robert Perkins (Albany: SUNY Press, 1984): 47–63; Harris, *Nachman Krochmal*; Amir, *She’arim Le-emunah Tzerufah*.

science of faith has a two-thousand-year lineage going back to the “sages” of antiquity. Shortly after making this claim, Krochmal expresses his concern that “what diverts the heart of many believers from this approach is, in truth, something [merely] accidental, namely, that [philosophy’s] premises and lines of speculation became known in a nation other than our own.”¹² He appears to be suggesting that one of his reasons for emphasizing philosophy’s continuous, millennia-long history is the hostility with which this endeavor is viewed by some of his contemporaries, who see it less as an acceptable mode of inquiry native to the Jewish tradition, and more as a problematic mode of thinking borrowed from non-Jewish sources. His argument about historical continuity thus serves to address these concerns, suggesting that if influential figures throughout the Jewish past have engaged in such philosophical reflection, there is nothing problematically foreign about this mode of inquiry.¹³

Krochmal’s decision to adopt this strategy is hardly surprising. On the contrary, he is following a long line of thinkers, from medieval figures such as Maimonides to the eighteenth-century German Jewish philosopher Moses Mendelssohn, who suggest that if prominent individuals throughout history have engaged in philosophical inquiry, such reflection occupies a well-established place within Jewish life. For example, in a 1761 Hebrew treatise, Mendelssohn addresses Jewish readers who “fear the *outspreed net* of human inquiry” associated with figures such as “Aristotle and his students,” and Mendelssohn does so, in part, by showing that one area of what “philosophers” study—logic—has long been embraced by Jewish thinkers. “In fact,” he insists, “we see that almost all [biblical] exegetes did not refrain from engaging in these matters, and some even delved deeply into them, such as R. Samuel b. Meir, R. Abraham Ibn Ezra, R. Elijah Mizrahi, etc. . . . This should suffice to remove any objections.”¹⁴

¹² Krochmal, *Moreh*, 273.

¹³ Krochmal also raises the possibility of earlier, lost Jewish philosophical traditions, as well as the prospect that Jews and Judaism might have shaped non-Jewish philosophy (Krochmal, *Moreh*, 273).

¹⁴ Moses Mendelssohn, “Selections from *Be’ur Millot Ha-higgayon*,” in *Moses Mendelssohn’s Hebrew Writings*, eds. Edward Breuer and David Sorkin, trans. Breuer, Yale Judaica Series 33 (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2018): 69, 72–4. This is only one of the strategies that Mendelssohn uses to defend philosophy: see Breuer and Sorkin, “Editors’ Introduction” to *Be’ur Millot Ha-higgayon*, in *Moses Mendelssohn’s Hebrew Writings*: 57–8. While Maimonides’s use of this strategy lies beyond this essay, one example is his portrayal of the biblical patriarch Abraham as someone who grasped monotheism through philosophical reflection—a portrayal that, according to one commentator, helps show that “philosophy, rather than being the enemy of faith, is in fact

What I wish to suggest, however, is that despite Krochmal's willingness to employ this longstanding apologetic strategy, he is also keenly interested in the limits of such arguments. After describing the science of faith early in the *Guide*,¹⁵ he writes the following:

For an adherent of a religion, there is some sort of necessity that leads him to take up the path of the studies and inquiries mentioned above But behold, this necessity does not appear upon initial reflection. Similarly, most rabbis are accustomed to raise questions regarding speculative science "Who has brought us into all of this? Why should he, or a believer, be brought into modes of inquiry that, as even the person involved admits, are fraught with great perils? Surely it is good for us to accept Toraitic beliefs and terms as the masses and as children, without stepping even one pace beyond them!"¹⁶

Krochmal highlights additional reasons for resistance to philosophy, suggesting that some of his contemporaries are unaware of its "necessity" while others are actively hostile to its practice, preferring to remain with a simplistic, almost child-like understanding of "Toraitic beliefs" because they view "speculative science" as a source of "great perils." Beyond being troubled by philosophy's allegedly foreign sources, Krochmal worries, many Jews are either unaware of why it might be beneficial or concerned about the dangers it might pose, opposing it as an endeavor that might upend or go "beyond" cherished assumptions crucial to the life of a "believer."

What is needed, therefore, is a defense of philosophy that will prove effective against these forms of resistance. Strikingly, however, Krochmal's first move is not to outline the contours of a successful defense, but rather to single out one strategy as inadequate:

If we respond that "surely we have clear testimonies that for a period of time that, at any rate, is close to two thousand years, the number of those engaged in these studies has grown," they will say "so what? You must also acknowledge that from that time to the time of the master [Maimonides] until this very day, the number of individuals perplexed by these [studies] has grown and grown. As long as you have not proven the necessity of the matter in itself and its basis in the soul of the believer, do not bring proof from this problem for the sake of resolving it."¹⁷

its stimulus." See Moshe Halbertal, *Maimonides: Life and Thought*, trans. Joel Linsider (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014), 213. Maimonides, too, does not rely exclusively on this approach.

¹⁵ While Krochmal does not use the term "science of faith" here, he is concerned with "what is called by [Maimonides] . . . *the science of the Torah*" (Krochmal, *Moreh*, 10)—a phrase that, as we have seen, the *Guide* identifies with "the science of faith" and "philosophy of religion."

¹⁶ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 11.

¹⁷ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 11.

Krochmal considers precisely the type of appeal to historical continuity outlined above, contemplating a defense which argues that “for . . . two thousand years, the number of those engaged in [philosophical] studies has grown.” Rather than tout the success of such appeals, however, he envisions their failure. “So what?” he imagines his interlocutors responding. What does it matter that philosophy goes back millennia “as long as” its defenders have not “proven the necessity of the matter . . . and its basis in the soul of the believer”—as long as the significance or value of such inquiry in the life of a faithful Jew remains unclear? What does it matter that philosophy has a long history if that history can be narrated as a cautionary tale in which “the number of individuals perplexed by these [studies] has grown and grown”? What does it matter that philosophy appears throughout the Jewish past if its value “does not appear” clearly, and if all that is evident, instead, is the manner in which it can disturb loyal believers?

Krochmal is developing a critique of the very type of valorization of historical continuity to which he otherwise seems attracted. To be sure, he admits when discussing philosophy’s alleged roots in “a nation other than our own,” there are cases where such arguments are needed—where individuals are worried less about philosophy’s value and more about its non-Jewish origins, and where claims about a millennia-long history might help establish the Jewish bona fides of such reflection. These appeals to historical continuity, however, will not be effective “as long as” the “necessity of the matter” has not been “proven.” Such appeals, that is, must exist alongside arguments which establish philosophy’s value by showing it to be crucial to the life of a “believer.” Otherwise, what such appeals might demonstrate is not that philosophy is a legitimate pursuit, but rather that it has long been a “problem” and source of perplexity.

Put differently, Krochmal’s point is that historical continuity is not a reliable indication of religious value. Beneficial phenomena can have long, continuous histories, but so, too, can harmful phenomena; there might be “inquiries” crucial to “the soul of the believer” that can be traced back “for . . . close to two thousand years,” but there might also be “problem[s]” that have “grown and grown” from “that time . . . until this very day.” Taken on their own, then, appeals to historical continuity are inadequate. Such arguments can contribute to legitimizing philosophy, but only if they exist alongside reasoning demonstrating its value; they can enhance the legitimacy of an intellectual endeavor whose importance has already been made clear, but there must be some other argumentative strategy which establishes that importance in the first place.

Krochmal’s response, therefore, is to take up this task of establishing philosophy’s value:

Know that the entire principle of the intellect and the superiority of a human being over a beast is its activity of taking the sensible representations transmitted to it from outside the soul, or from the soul itself, and forming concepts from them . . . Every human being, even the most brutish, engages in this activity, every day, in his thought and speech. If a person asks “what is this?” and someone responds by answering (for example) “house” or saying “six-sided figure,” then he has already formed, from sensible representations (this particular thing that stands . . . before him), universal concepts: “house” (a term and concept encompassing any place designated for dwelling) or “six-sided figure” (a concept encompassing in itself the figure as a whole, six-ness, length, proportion, and the nature of sides and angles) . . . Representations . . . are isolated, each one on its own, lacking any cognitively generated connection—just as is the case with Toraitic representations among the masses. Even among the masses, the understanding’s knowledge does not rest until, according to the individual’s ability, universal and ordered concepts emerge from those representations at the beginning of thought. In truth, the difference between the empty-headed and the wise is merely the difference in the degree of clarity and confusion with respect to concepts and the manner of comprehending them. Nearly all of them engage in this intellectual activity as a matter of course for their soul.¹⁸

Krochmal is advancing three claims. The first is that the type of reflection involved in philosophy—“taking . . . representations . . . and forming concepts from them”—is also involved in the activities that “every human being . . . engages in . . . every day.” More precisely, the work of elevating initial representations into more theoretically sophisticated judgements is just what human beings do “as a matter of course.” Consider someone who sees a “thing” and thinks of it as a “house” or a “six-sided figure.” Without necessarily being aware of doing so, this individual has elevated some preliminary content into a more conceptually rigorous form, taking a representation generated by the senses, analyzing it, and recasting it as a structure that might be used for dwelling and possesses various geometrical properties. All that separates philosophy from the thinking of the “masses,” therefore, is “the degree of clarity . . . with respect to concepts and the manner of comprehending them.” Philosophy involves more precise concepts (and a clearer grasp of their nature and use), but this is a matter of degree rather than kind: philosophy remains an extension of a type of reflection present in the ordinary activities of any human being.

Krochmal’s second claim is that the type of reflection involved in philosophy is not merely involved in ordinary human activities; rather, it’s crucial to such activities. The reason that the intellect “does not rest until . . . universal and ordered concepts emerge,” he argues, is that our “representations . . . are isolated, each one on its own, lacking any cognitively generated connection.” Our initial representations generate further reflection because they are “isolated . . . cogni-

¹⁸ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 11–12.

tively,” because they do not immediately fit into a coherent picture of reality. For example, we apply concepts such as “house” to representations of “things” because doing so is necessary if we are to incorporate those “things” into a broader scheme for making sense of the world—if we are to determine which structures are fit for dwelling and which are fit for other purposes. More than an extension of a cognitive process *present* in our ordinary activities, then, philosophy is an extension of a cognitive process *necessary* to such activities. It is a more sophisticated version of a process that is crucial if we are to experience the world not as a cascade of indeterminate objects without any order, but as a constellation of houses and other structures that can be related to one another in a coherent fashion.

Krochmal’s third point is that this is also the case for “Toraitic representations among the masses,” for content that is present in Jewish sources and encountered by all adherents of the Jewish tradition. This content, too, does not immediately fit together into a coherent picture of reality; this content, too, will therefore require conceptual reflection that is not fundamentally different from what occurs in the science of faith. More precisely, the claims and images that emerge from the ordinary operations of Jewish life generate problems such that “every person, according to his own path and level, embarks upon the conceptual activity outlined above”.¹⁹

One finds in these matters profound questions and opposed statements whose two contradictory components offer a significant point of entry for the soul and intellect . . . Questions include . . . Are action and intention both essential or is one essential and one [merely] beneficial (and which is which)? . . . How do atonement by means of Yom Kippur and atonement by means of death work, and how effective are they? . . . Examples of opposed pronouncements include: “His glory fills the earth” and “The attending angels ask: where is the place of His glory?” [Sabbath liturgy]; “You saw no likeness [when the Lord your God spoke to you]” and “He beholds the likeness of the Lord” [Deuteronomy 4:15 and Numbers 12:8]; “The soul that you have placed in me is pure” [daily liturgy] and “Our will is to perform your will, but what prevents us? The yeast in the dough [the evil inclination]” [Babylonian Talmud Berakhot 17a];²⁰ . . . “Children will not be put to death for their parents” and “They will rot away over the sins of their fathers” [Deuteronomy 24:16 and Leviticus 26:39]. Behold, all of these questions and pronouncements, along with countless others that are similar to them and branch out from them, are great and profound investigations—some in theoretical philosophy, some in practical philosophy, and some in the divine, Toraitic science.²¹

19 Krochmal, *Moreh*, 14.

20 On “yeast in the dough” as referring to the evil inclination or evil impulse, see, e.g., I. Epstein, ed., *Seder Zera'im*, vol. 1, *The Babylonian Talmud* (London: Soncino, 1948), 100n1.

21 Krochmal, *Moreh*, 14. English renderings of biblical verses draw on, but also deviate from, the New Jewish Publication Society translation.

Krochmal moves through diverse activities traditionally associated with Jewish life to argue that they are riddled with questions and tensions which “offer a significant point of entry for the . . . intellect,” requiring the type of conceptual reflection also involved in the science of faith. Consider Yom Kippur (the Day of Atonement). Individuals who observe this holiday will engage in ritual behavior that is portrayed in Jewish sources as altering their moral status, reconciling them with God and fellow humans; these individuals will therefore have a reason to take up the idea of holiday-induced moral transformation, analyze it, and produce a coherent account of how it could take place, lest they find themselves plagued by questions and doubts about how “atonement by means of” a specific day could prove “effective.” Another example is prayer. The Sabbath liturgy presents diametrically opposed statements about God’s presence, just as the daily liturgy praises human innocence in a manner that contradicts other texts’ lament of human sinfulness; worshipers will thus have a reason to take up these statements, reflect on them, and formulate more sophisticated accounts of God’s presence and human nature, lest they conclude that it is impossible to think about these weighty issues in a consistent manner. Yet another case is the activity of reading the Bible. Encountering this text will confront individuals with contradictory statements about topics such as God’s accessibility and visibility and humanity’s transgenerational guilt; readers will therefore have reason to take up such claims, reflect on the issues they raise, and produce more rigorous accounts of these topics, lest they find themselves worrying that there is no coherent way to think about divinity and morality.

For the *Guide*, then, the ordinary dynamics of Jewish life are inextricably linked to “conceptual activity” associated with philosophy. This endeavor of taking content, reflecting on it, and elevating it to a more theoretically coherent form will be crucial for “every person” because it allows Judaism to *make sense*, addressing questions and worries that arise from ordinary practices such as holidays, prayer, and biblical study. Philosophy, in turn, is just an especially rigorous or sophisticated form of this activity, possessing a heightened “degree of clarity” but involving the same basic cognitive moves. So close is this relationship, in fact, that Krochmal concludes the passage quoted above by suggesting that the concerns which arise out of the activities of Jewish life are themselves “great and profound investigations . . . in . . . philosophy.” Philosophy’s “necessity” and “basis in the soul of the believer” therefore derive from its status as an instance of the type of reflection that “every person . . . embarks upon” to lend coherence and sense to Judaism. Philosophy is valuable because it is an extension of reflection necessary to the ordinary operations of Jewish life, enacting a conceptual process that is crucial if adherents are to experience this tradition not as a series

of activities that yield irresolvable questions and contradictions, but as a constellation of practices that generate a coherent way of viewing reality.

Krochmal thus defends the science of faith by going beyond historical continuity to also stress what we might call practical continuity—by linking philosophy not only to the towering figures of Jewish history, but also to the ordinary activities of Jewish communities. He does not abandon appeals to the past. On the contrary, after the passage cited above, he notes that rigorous conceptual reflection “consumed the days of the wise and pious individuals across the generations.”²² Similarly, even as he discusses philosophy’s value, he also shows how the project of elevating representations into more theoretically coherent judgements has long been central to practices such as Jewish legal reasoning.²³ On his view, however, such appeals can be effective only if another type of case has been also made. Claims about history can reveal that philosophy has long been present in Judaism, but such longevity is not, in itself, a reliable mark of religious value; to establish that value, we need an analysis that shows philosophy to be a particularly rigorous form of a cognitive process indispensable to Jewish life. Krochmal’s own writings thus enact a type of contestation over continuity. Attracted to claims of historical continuity but worried about their efficacy, he seeks out additional ways to make the case for philosophy.

4 Krochmal Today

A longer essay might explore further topics, such as the role of appeals to continuity in Krochmal’s approach to biblical criticism.²⁴ I wish to conclude, however, with a different question: what his arguments might offer us today.

I raise this issue with some trepidation. Although I have largely bracketed issues of historical context in this essay, I am mindful that Krochmal lived in a nineteenth-century Galician setting very different from the world inhabited by most of this volume’s contributors and readers. This book grows out of a conference organized by universities in Germany and North America, whereas Krochmal worked as a liquor merchant and communal leader in cities across what is now Ukraine; most (perhaps all) of those who attended that conference came

²² Krochmal, *Moreh*, 14.

²³ Krochmal, *Moreh*, 13.

²⁴ While the *Guide*’s introduction cites premodern Jewish precedents for an approach similar to biblical criticism, it also goes further and explicates the value of such historically focused exegesis for Jewish life (Krochmal, *Moreh*, 5). More generally, see Harris, *Nachman Krochmal*, 156–205.

from societies striving to be pluralistic democracies, whereas Krochmal lived in an eastern European imperial province.²⁵

Nevertheless, I cannot help but perceive some degree of resonance between Krochmal's concerns and our own. This volume brings together scholars of Jewish and Muslim thought, and I imagine that many of us—alongside colleagues who study other religious traditions, as well as peers who work in other fields—may share Krochmal's desire to defend the importance of philosophy and rigorous intellectual reflection in the face of indifference and hostility. Indeed, despite all of the differences between his context and our own, there is a decidedly contemporary ring to his expressions of worry about individuals who doubt the value of conceptually rigorous “modes of inquiry” and are wary of “stepping even one pace beyond” simplistic understanding of cherished topics, especially given the rising tide of anti-intellectualism in the United States and many other societies.²⁶ For those of us who share Krochmal's commitment to defending serious “conceptual activity,” then, his arguments outline a potential path forward. There may be many individuals who are wary of “stepping even one pace beyond” simplistic understandings of religion and other matters (from politics to science to history), but the *Guide's* wager is that this anti-intellectualism can be overcome with the right type of strategy: one that roots philosophy and rigorous intellectual inquiry in the dynamics of communal life, moving through the everyday activities of a given group, and showing that those activities are rife with contradictions, questions, and other challenges that can be addressed through rigorous conceptual reflection. Applied to our context, Krochmal's position suggests that if we begin with the concerns that animate the communities we hope to address, we might be

25 On Krochmal's life and context, see Harris, *Nachman Krochmal*; Nancy Sinkoff, *Out of the Shtetl: Making Jews Modern in the Polish Borderlands*, Brown Judaic Studies 336 (Providence: Brown Judaic Studies, 2004), 203–70; Israel Bartal, *The Jews of Eastern Europe, 1772–1881*, trans. Chaya Naor, Jewish Culture and Contexts (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2005), 70–81; Rachel Manekin, “Galician Haskalah and the Discourse of *Schwärmerei*,” in *Secularism in Question*, eds. Ari Joskowicz and Ethan Katz, Jewish Culture and Contexts (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2015): 196–8; Iryna Vushko, *The Politics of Cultural Retreat: Imperial Bureaucracy in Austrian Galicia, 1772–1867* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2015).

26 I am thinking of attacks on higher education in the United States, where “the proportion of Americans who feel positively about the impact of colleges and universities . . . dropped by 14 percentage points” from 2020 to 2022: see Rachel Fishman, Sophie Nguyen, and Louisa Woodhouse, “Findings,” *Varying Degrees 2022: New America's Sixth Annual Survey on Higher Education*. 26.07.22 <https://www.newamerica.org/education-policy/reports/varying-degrees-2022/findings/>. These attacks have only accelerated—in ways that many of us likely never imagined—since I submitted the first version of this essay in 2023. I am also thinking of controversies about the study and teaching of American history, where many individuals seem to prefer not to “step even one pace beyond” inherited narratives.

able to show that those concerns *themselves* cry out for “conceptual activity.” We might ask what sorts of tensions and worries are most salient in particular groups, institutions, and areas across the United States and other societies today, and show how rigorous intellectual inquiry is a path to addressing those issues.²⁷

Yet if Krochmal’s vision offers constructive resources, it also raises questions. How many of us possess the expertise to enact his approach? Let’s say that those of us who work on Jewish and Muslim thought wish to illuminate philosophy’s importance for Jewish and Muslim communities. How many of us are sufficiently steeped in the dynamics of those communities to identify specific challenges and questions that are particularly salient today, and then show how those challenges and questions are likely to benefit from rigorous conceptual reflection? Let’s say that we aspire to establish philosophy’s value not only for Jewish and Muslim communities, but also for society more broadly. How many of us are sufficiently familiar with other religious groups—or, for that matter, with the operations of non-religious institutions such as businesses and civic organizations, or with the economic and political dynamics that exist across different regions in our own societies—to pick out specific tensions and concerns that surface in such settings, and then tell a compelling story about how those specific tensions and concerns might be addressed through “conceptual activity” continuous with philosophy?

Some of us might answer these questions in the affirmative, but I suspect that others among us might be skeptical about our ability to offer such assessments or make such claims. We may be experts in Jewish studies, Islamic studies, or other fields, but that does not necessarily qualify us to advance arguments about contemporary Jewish and Muslim communities, let alone society more broadly. In fact, I suspect that some of us may feel more confident making the claims about historical continuity which Krochmal downplays than the claims about practical continuity which he elevates—that some of us may feel better equipped to highlight traditions of premodern Jewish and Muslim philosophy than to address contemporary communal concerns.

If Krochmal’s move from historical to practical continuity charts out a potential path forward, then, it also raises questions. How can we acquire the expertise

²⁷ I do not mean suggest that this strategy, on its own, will be sufficient; on the contrary, given the intensity and forms of anti-intellectualism emerging since I submitted the first version of this essay in 2023, a broad range of legal, institutional, and other strategies will likely be required. My point is that the focus on communities and their concerns envisioned by Krochmal may form one key element of this more comprehensive approach, providing a framework for cultivating habits of—and openness to—intellectual inquiry from the ground up. Building this type of grass-roots interest in and support for rigorous reflection is unlikely to be sufficient, but it may nevertheless prove indispensable.

needed to articulate the type of arguments he envisions? How can we become sufficiently immersed in the lives of Jewish, Muslim, and other communities to persuasively connect their concerns to philosophical reflection? How can we ensure that if we choose to take on the task of defending philosophy and rigorous intellectual reflection, we do so in a manner that resonates with the lives of the individuals and groups we seek to address?

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Asher D. Biemann

Chapter 2

Conscious Continuities: On Re-beginning as Modern Jewish Imperative

1 A Lecture in London

In July 1956, only a few months before his death in November of that same year, Leo Baeck, a liberal rabbi and one of the leading German Jewish intellectuals who had survived the Nazi concentration camp of Terezin, delivered his last public lecture in the *Montagsseminar* in London. His students and friends, themselves predominantly German Jewish emigres, refugees, survivors, had organized the seminar in an effort to recreate a tradition they still knew from their better days in Berlin. In fact, as one of his students later recalled, the weekly *Montagsseminar* was a sort of “spiritual home” for them during a time of uprootedness and disorientation.¹ Baeck lectured in German with only a few handwritten notes on a sheet of paper the size of a tramway ticket. At the end of the seminar, he arrived at the conclusion of more than three-thousand years of Jewish history. “One cannot write Jewish history in its total course,” he spoke, “without regarding it as a history of continuous rebirth”—a “rebirth from epoch to epoch,” a “continuous beginning anew.”²

What Baeck believed to have discovered in Jewish history, was not its continuity but precisely its *discontinuity* and its ability for continuous recontinuation. In that sense, Jewish history defied the popular Hegelian principle that a people could make history twice. It also defied the Spenglerian pessimism that it was the “inescapable destiny of culture”—of all culture and any culture—to end in petrification, closure and, finally, self-dissolution. Rebirth, for Baeck, was the *Leitfaden*, the leading theme of Jewish history. However, it was not itself a concept belonging to history: It described neither a period in time, nor an historical phenomenon, but rather a way of thinking, a *Denkweise*, as Baeck put it, a style of thought perfected not by ancient chroniclers of the past, nor by modern philosophers of history, but by the Hebrew prophets who were the first to develop an idea of world-history, and who were able to see, or rather listen to, the future of human-

1 Leo Baeck, “Epochen der jüdischen Geschichte,” *Leo Baeck Werke 5: Nach der Schoa—Warum sind Juden in der Welt?*, eds. Albert H. Friedlander and Berthold Klappert (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2003), 215. All translations, unless noted otherwise, are by the author.

2 Baeck, “Epochen der jüdischen Geschichte,” 352, 231.

ity being planted in the present. This added a secondary layer of meaning to Baeck's conclusion: One cannot write Jewish history—which, naturally, is not the same as writing *about* Jewish history—without viewing it under some “Spirit of Utopia.”

Baeck deliberately invoked Ernst Bloch's 1918 book of the same title, a book written under the impression of World War I, in which Bloch tried to articulate what he called an “active anticipation,” a present pregnant with future, a “mottoric messianism” that would create the “will to rethink the entire world” (*Umdenkenwollen der ganzen Welt*).³ Bloch's essay opened with the classic motto of all renaissance and renewal—*incipit vita nova*—and concluded with yet another motif well known from the older days of the Renaissance—the motif of the non-finito, the category of unfinishedness as a commitment to negative knowledge in the sense of *docta ignorantia*.⁴ Baeck understood Bloch's vision as a “true utopia”—a utopia which was no complacent fantasy but which, like law and commandment, made demands on us, and which, like the pursuit of justice, should not divide but encompass all. Rebirth, for Baeck, was a utopian idea and, therefore, a demand echoing from the not-yet. Thus, rebirth became not only Jewish history's continuous *Leifaden*, but also its ever-renewed imperative.

2 Survival and Rebirth

To some extent, Baeck's lecture of 1956 reflected common Jewish postwar sensibilities. For many Jewish refugees and survivors of the Holocaust, survival alone appeared already as a miracle akin to miraculous rebirth. To the German Jewish philosopher Trude Weiss-Rosmarin, for instance, who arrived in New York in 1931 – where she quickly established herself as a leading feminist intellectual – survival became the key theme of Jewish history; an anti-lachrymose *Leitmotif* that defined and sustained, as she wrote in her 1949 Manifesto on Diaspora Survivalism, the “zest for life, unbroken and undoubting even after the most harrowing tragedies.”⁵ Mordecai Kaplan, writing in 1947, found that there was a “certain inevitability to Jewish survival” that necessitated and mandated a “renaissance of

3 Ernst Bloch, *Geist der Utopie. Erste Fassung* (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1971), 340. On the theme of anticipation see also Cedric Cohen-Skalli, “The Motif of Anticipation and the First World War,” in *Comparative Studies in the Humanities*, ed. Guy Stroumsa (Jerusalem: Israeli Academy of Sciences, 2018), 55–88.

4 Bloch, *Geist der Utopie*, 9; 388–389.

5 Trude Weiss-Rosmarin, “A Manifesto of Diaspora Survivalism,” in *Jewish Survival: Essays and Studies* (New York: Philosophical Library, 1949), 199.

the Jewish people.”⁶ Indeed, Kaplan opened his reflections on the future of American Judaism with a chapter on the “Resurrection of a People” asking one of the signature questions defining post-war Jewish literature, the very question known from the prophet Ezekiel: “Can these bones live?”⁷ Salo Wittmayer Baron, the most prominent American Jewish historian at the time, who was trained as a Rabbi in Vienna before moving to the United States in 1926, inaugurated his monumental *Social and Religious History of the Jews* of 1937 with a testimony to Jewish survival throughout the ages and, in April 1945, allowed himself “to dream of some great awakening of Central European Jewry and the emergence of some new vital spiritual and religious forces out of its untold sufferings.”⁸ Baron attributed his own expression of hope to his understanding of Judaism as an “essentially optimistic creed.”⁹ Indeed, a critical reviewer of his 1937 *Social and Religious History*, Jacob Rader Marcus, himself an eminent historian and (Reform) Rabbi, noted Baron’s “inherent optimism” adding his own words of confidence in dire times: “And, as for the Jews, they will survive the present crisis if they rebuild their ethnic, communal and religious life, if they revitalize it, through culture and education, and if they have leaders who will prepare the Jewish masses adequately for the new social order.”¹⁰ Likewise, for Weiss-Rosmarin, Jewish survivalism expressed an optimism “as unique as Jewish destiny” itself. “As a Jew, I have to be an optimist,” said Ignaz Maybaum, a Vienna-born Rabbi, who arrived in London in 1939, where he would later become one of the participants in Leo Baeck’s *Montagsseminar*.¹¹ Baeck himself had written of Judaism’s “optimistic certitude” already in his 1905 *Essence of Judaism*.¹² The Jewish community, Baeck insisted, never succumbed to pessimism, nor did it ever turn away from culture. It never engaged in *Kulturverneinung*, no matter how adverse and hostile some cultures had been to its survival.¹³ “The Jewish people did not become the eternal people because it was allowed to live,” wrote Martin Buber in 1928, “but because

6 Mordecai Kaplan, *The Future of the American Jew* (New York: Macmillan, 1948), xvi; xvii.

7 Kaplan, *The Future of the American Jew*, 3.

8 Salo Wittmayer Baron, “At the Turning Point,” *The Menorah Journal*, vol. XXXIII, (April-June 1945): 2.

9 Salo Wittmayer Baron, *A Social and Religious History of the Jews*, vol. 1, part 1 (Philadelphia: JPS, 1952), 9.

10 Jacob R. Marcus, “A Social and Religious History of the Jews by Salo Wittmayer Baron” (review), *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 29 (1, July 1938): 50.

11 Ignaz Maybaum: *A Reader*, ed. Nicholas de Lange (New York and Oxford: Berghahn Books, 2001), xv.

12 Leo Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums. Leo Baeck Werke 1*, ed. Albert H. Friedlander and Bert-hold Klappert (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 1998), 144.

13 Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums*, 42.

it was *not* allowed to live. Because it was asked to give more than life, it won life.”¹⁴ And in 1941, now writing after his flight from Nazi-Germany, Buber turned to the 19th-century Jewish philosopher Nachman Krochmal to confront the idol of nationalism with the biblical motif of the eternal people: “The nations make idols of their supreme faculties, and are thus rendered subject to the judgment of history. Israel knows only one God, the Eternal, and thus knows the secret of rebirth.”¹⁵

3 “What a Resurrection!”

One might read Jewish affirmations of survival and rebirth after the war as the sort of “Hurra optimism” Theodor Adorno ridiculed in his *Reflections from Damaged Life*, written between 1944 and 1945, or as the kind of tragic, forced optimism Hannah Arendt observed among many emigres in her harrowing 1943 essay “We Refugees.”¹⁶ But this would ignore the profoundly imperatival character of “rebirth” that had already defined earlier conceptions of Jewish history, such as Leo Baeck’s or Martin Buber’s, and, in fact, much of modern Judaism’s self-representation altogether. It is no accident that Baeck’s 1956 lecture calling for “continuous rebirth” was itself based on a manuscript he had begun to write in Terezin.¹⁷ To be sure, the curious optimism often expressed around 1945, to which we shall later return, was soon strengthened by another miraculous rebirth: the rebirth of Jewish sovereignty—the State of Israel—in May 1948, which, to many—though certainly not all and certainly not only—Jewish survivors and emigres, appeared as history’s ultimate vindication. But it did not *originate* there. Rather than viewing Jewish optimism or, as we would more aptly say today, resilience, as the result of political independence gained at last, many Jewish commentators viewed the Jewish state as one of many possible outcomes of Jewish optimism and its unperturbed will to survive. Thus, Simon Rawido-

14 Martin Buber, “Der Aufbau Palästinas,” in *Kampf um Israel. Reden und Schriften, 1921–1932* (Berlin: Schocken, 1933), 297.

15 Martin Buber, “The Gods of the Nations and God,” in *Israel and the World: Essays in a Time of Crisis* (New York: Schocken, 1948), 197.

16 Theodor Adorno, *Minima Moralia. Reflexionen aus dem beschädigten Leben* (Gesammelte Schriften 4), ed. Rolf Tiedemann, 127. Hannah Arendt, “We Refugees,” in *The Jewish Writings*, ed. Jerome Kohn and Ron H. Feldman (New York: Schocken Books, 2007), 264.

17 On Baeck’s active writing and lecturing during his internment in Terezin, see most recently Yaniv Feller, *The Jewish Imperial Imagination: Leo Baeck and German-Jewish Thought* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 2023), 130–153.

wicz, the Polish-born Jewish philosopher and Hebraist who, in 1926, graduated from the Friedrich-Wilhelms University in Berlin with a dissertation on Ludwig Feuerbach and, after his emigration to London and, subsequently, the United States, continued to write on Krochmal's philosophy, described the phenomenon of Jewish survival as one entirely independent of political sovereignty and intimately tied to diaspora existence.¹⁸ Though rejecting the language of Jewish optimism in his famous 1948 essay on the "Ever-dying People," he advocated a "Jewish realism" that had its own positive qualities. Optimism and pessimism, as Rawidowicz insisted, were but synonymous with hope and fear. Jewish realism, by contrast, constituted a task and an imperative, yet one grounded not in the future but in the past. "A people dying for thousands of years, means a living people," writes Rawidowicz. "Our incessant dying means uninterrupted living, rising, standing up, beginning anew."¹⁹ This, of course, had been Krochmal's own lesson from history, or as he wrote in his posthumously published *Guide for the Perplexed of our Time* (1851): "[W]hen breakdown, decomposition, and decay have become complete, and new and reviving spirit always takes shape within us; though we fall, we arise again invigorated."²⁰

Thus, while Jewish writers after 1945 may have developed a particular penchant for rhetorical word-pairs such as catastrophe and resurrection or destruction and rebirth, they could also draw upon an already well-established topos of thought linking crisis to rebirth in Jewish history.²¹ This rebirth, of course, was rarely seen in literal terms, nor did it remain entirely uncontested. "Auschwitz was the terrible cradle of the new Jewish consciousness and the new Jewish nation," wrote Isaac Deutscher who was raised in a traditional Galician-Jewish home before adopting Marxist sensibilities and a strictly atheist "non-Jewish Judaism," as he put it. Yet, no real phoenix arose from the ashes. No skeletons began

18 An expanded version of Rawidowicz's dissertation appeared as *Ludwig Feuerbachs Philosophie: Ursprung und Schicksal* (Berlin: Reuther & Reichard, 1931) which, among other contributions, established the affinities between Feuerbach and Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (Ibid., 140). See also Benjamin Ravid, "The Berlin Period of Simon Rawidowicz: The university and Ludwig Feuerbach in Context," in *Feuerbach und der Judentum*, ed. Ursula Reitemeyer, Takayuki Shibata, and Francesco Tomasoni (Münster: Waxman, 2009), 135–157.

19 Simon Rawidowicz, *State of Israel, Diaspora, and Jewish Continuity*, ed. Benjamin C. I. Ravid (Hanover and London: Brandeis University Press, 1997), 63.

20 Nachman Krochmal, *Moreh Nevuchei Ha-Zman*, ed. Leopold Zunz (Warsaw: Israel Alapin, 1894), 31. Translated in Michael Meyer (ed.), *Ideas of Jewish History* (Detroit: Wayne State, 1987), 203.

21 On this theme, see my recent essay *Die verlorene Einheit des Menschengeschlechts: Zu einer Figur (deutsch) jüdischen Denkens um 1945*. Vorlesungen des Centrums für jüdische Studien 16 (Graz: Clio, 2025), 19–21.

to move, no dry bones came to life. “For those who have always stressed Jewishness and its continuity,” he continues, “it is strange and bitter to think that the extermination of six million Jews should have given such a new lease of life to Jewry. I would have preferred the six million men, women, and children to survive and Jewry to perish.” And then he gasped: “What a resurrection!”²²

What a resurrection, indeed. What is the meaning of rebirth and restoration, what consolation does the recontinuation of an idea, a people, or of history itself, offer us if the individuals, the concrete human beings embodying the idea, are no longer alive? How, then, can history be written, in good conscience, under such grandiose concepts as rebirth and rebeginning? And how, one might also ask, can it be written *without* the idea of rebirth in mind and without the notion of a perpetual *she’ar yashuv*, a symbolic returning remnant, which Baron invoked in his otherwise “realistic” history of the Jews?²³

4 Three Propositions

Let us pause here to establish three propositions for the purpose of this essay: First, even though rabbinic Judaism unequivocally postulated the physical resurrection of the dead (*tchivat ha-metim*), which came to be inscribed also in Judaism’s principal beliefs and liturgy, bodily resurrection, along with the immortality of the soul, has long fallen out of favor in modern Judaism.²⁴ Writing in 1956, Mordecai Kaplan called these ideas effectively “obsolete.” But this did not mean for him that we should treat them as mere figments of imagination: “They are undoubtedly an expression of the divine urge in man not to live only for himself and for the present moment, but also for mankind and its future.”²⁵ Even if discarded from modern Jewish “theology” at large, and even if philosophically disembodied, resurrection and rebirth may still exist, and act, as regulative metaphors and ideas in the Kantian sense. For Halakhic Man, to invoke Joseph B. Soloveichik’s treatise of the same title, the “life-giving dew of resurrection, to

22 Isaac Deutscher, “Who is a Jew?”, in *The Non-Jewish Jew and Other Essays*, ed. Tamara Deutscher (London: Oxford University Press, 1968), 50.

23 Baron, *A Social and Religious History of the Jews*, 30.

24 On this subject see, most recently, Leora Batnizky, “From Resurrection to Immortality: Theological and Political Implications in Modern Jewish Thought,” *The Harvard Theological Review*, 102:3 (2009): 279–296.

25 Mordecai Kaplan, *Questions Jews Ask: Reconstructionist Answers* (New York: Reconstructionist Press, 1956), 181.

which history so amply testifies,” can indeed, from time to time, “descend upon the dry bones.”²⁶

Second, common parlance and religious imaginary imagine resurrection and rebirth as events happening to us by some power of higher judgment, often at an appointed time beyond our grasp. In the following, however, they will appear as actions of our own agency. For Leo Baeck, the idea of rebirth was not something done to us by fiat or grace, nor a miracle rewarding the faithful, but something upon us *to do*. As an imperative and demand it originated from human action, perhaps, as Hannah Arendt argued, from the idea of action itself. For if every action is a beginning that “corresponds to the fact of birth,” as Arendt believed, then every action of rebirth would repeat and reenact our deeply human condition of natality.²⁷ Rebirth, then, belongs not to the exalted heights of spiritual life, but to the lowly realm of *vita activa*.

Finally, as we consider ruptures or turning points in Jewish history, and as we think of crises as temporary eclipses of continuity, we are tempted to accept the most common verdict of historical consciousness: that everything passes and nothing endures. Radical impermanence has become a universal sentiment in modern times, though it has always been a motif of human existence from the Pre-Socratics to Kohelet to the Buddha. A suffering soul might find deep consolation in time’s assurance that this dark moment, too, will pass. Lovers, on the other hand, will cling to the fleeting instants of ecstasy, for they too will pass and be buried under the sand of quotidian life. The law recognizes that some deeds expire under the statute of limitations, if only enough time has passed. But not everything passes with the passage of time. There are ruptures, crises, chasms, that remain gaping like open wounds, or infeasible like grotesquely healed scars, “healed to pieces,” as Paul Celan famously put it.²⁸ When Vladimir Jankélévitch, in an essay of 1965, called these gaps in human history the “imprescriptible,” he had in mind first and foremost crimes against humanity or, as he put it, against *l’essence humaine*, the very essence of our humanness.²⁹ Some events do

26 Josef B. Soloveitchik, *Halakhic Man*, trans. Lawrence Kaplan (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1983), 117.

27 Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press, 1998), 178.

28 Paul Celan’s neologism “zerheilt” is related by the author Ilana Shmueli: “Ich wurde zerheilt, wiederholte er oft.” Ilana Shmueli, Nachwort. *Briefwechsel Paul Celan and Ilana Shmueli*, ed. Ilana Shmueli and Thomas Sparr (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 2004), 175. It has since become a popular trope to describe the German Jewish experience, adopted also by the photographer Frédéric Brenner in his 2021 exhibit of the same title.

29 Vladimir Jankélévitch, *L’imprescriptible. Pardonner? Dans l’honneur et la dignité* (Paris: Editions du Seuil, 1986), 22.

not allow for a time that forgets, forgives, heals, and consoles, writes Jankélévitch. Some events are imprescriptible. Time has no power over them.³⁰ Thus Natan Sznajder could recently articulate what has been undoubtedly true still in this generation, though it may no longer be true in the next: “For Jews there has never been a postwar era. The time following the Shoah is never ‘after’. It is always *now*.”³¹

Our third proposition, then, assumes the inextinguishable presence of certain past events, which no sense of broken or unbroken continuity, no sense of rebirth, could ever trivialize. To write Jewish history—or any history at all—as continuous rebirth, as Leo Baeck suggested, means, therefore, no annulment, not even a tempering, of imprescriptible pasts, but an affirmation of continuity, a conscious act of continuation, *despite* the presence of these pasts. In fact, it was precisely this *despite*—the *af-al-pi-khen* of defiance—that inspired Baeck’s early conceptions of Jewish history and would continue to inspire them during and after the Holocaust. His *Essence of Judaism* emphasized the “defiant despite” with which the Jewish people had faced all changes and challenges of time; in a lecture of 1946, Baeck spoke of the “categorical commandment of the great and-yet”; in the 1956 lecture that opened our essay, he spoke of the “and-yet of faith” uniting Jewish vision and patience.³² A confidence in the “eternal, firm despite” defined also Margarete Susman’s 1946 reflections on Job.³³ Thus, the idea and reality of the “despite” became a Jewish *Leitmotif* of its own. Like Jewish optimism, it acted as a form of protest.

5 Conscious Continuity

These, then, are the three propositions with which we approach the question of conscious continuities in modern Judaism. “Conscious continuity” is a concept

30 Jankélévitch, *L’imprescriptible*, 26. Dagegen Jean Améry in einem Aufsatz von 1978: “Gegen die nivellierende Zeit ist nicht anzukommen. Aber alles Humane fordert—nicht ‚Recht‘, das es hier nicht geben kann, noch Rache, die unausdenkbar wäre!—nur dass man die Opfer begnadige, nicht die Henker.” Jean Améry, “Das Unverjähbare,” in Jean Améry, *Werke 7: Aufsätze zur Politik und Geschichte*, ed. Stephan Steiner (Stuttgart: Klett-Kotta, 2005), 130.

31 Natan Sznajder, *Die jüdische Wunde. Leben zwischen Anpassung und Autonomie* (Munich: Hanser, 2024), 108.

32 Baeck, *Wesen des Judentums*, 147. Baeck, “Der Sinn der Geschichte,” *Leo Baeck Werke* 5, 28. Baeck, “Dieses Volk,” *Leo Baeck Werke* 2, 67.

33 Margarete Susman, *Das Buch Hiob und das Schicksal des jüdischen Volkes* (Frankfurt/M.: Jüdischer Verlag, 2018), 168.

coined by Karl Löwith drawing on the work of Jacob Burckhardt, whom Löwith had studied at length. “Continuity is more than mere going on,” he later wrote in 1949, “because it implies a conscious effort in remembering and renewing our heritage”—because it requires—and here Löwith explicitly referred to Burckhardt—rebirths and revivals.³⁴ Burckhardt’s idea of the renaissance constituted a conscious continuity, a recontinuation beyond and despite an historical rupture, the age of *Tenebrae*—an age repeating itself, in one form or another, in every generation. Löwith dedicated, in 1936, as another age of darkness came to manifest itself, an entire monograph to Burckhardt’s thought in which continuity functioned as a sort of *Leitmotiv* not only of Burckhardt’s self-positioning over against Hegelian historicism, but also of his curious “conservatism.” “Burckhardt, who by nature was no ‘agitator and revolutionary,’ decided to become a ‘conservator,’” writes Löwith, “turned backward towards salvaging ancient education and turned forward towards serenely and undauntedly representing the spirit in a time that would otherwise have succumbed to the world of matter.”³⁵ Burckhardt’s “conservatism” was neither of the social nor of the reactionary kind. It was a “spiritual” conservatism informed by a consciousness that spiritual things are interconnected, and that this interconnectedness (*Zusammenhang des Geistes*), stretched over generations past and yet to come, lived in us.³⁶ In this acute sense of simultaneity and the recognition that every single thing in history “exists for the sake of the *entire* past and the *entire* future,” Burckhardt, at least in Löwith’s reading, located the meaning of history as one of preserving continuity. “The symbol of historicity,” Löwith writes, “is a conscious continuation through which all past flows into the present—but not like a blind stream emptying itself. Rather, by our ever renewed remembering of what once was, we make the past our own.”³⁷ Deeply skeptical of modern day “progress” and revolutionary anarchy; Burckhardt—and Löwith himself—put the emphasis on ever renewed remembrance as an act of establishing, or restoring, continuities where historical ruptures, or crises, had torn the stream of time apart. Contrary to Nietzsche’s imperative of forgetting, Burckhardt found value in contemplating historical continuity not only as a “totality” of past and present events but also as humanity’s total *inheritance*. And contrary to the modern and modernist indictments of the concept “totality” itself, the vexing “All” competing with the modern penchant for the fragment, Burckhardt viewed the affirmation of historical continuity in toto

³⁴ Karl Löwith, *Meaning in History* (London and Toronto: Phoenix Books, 1949), 21.

³⁵ Karl Löwith, *Jacob Burckhardt (Sämtliche Schriften 7)*, ed. Henning Ritter (Stuttgart: Metzler, 1984), 340–341.

³⁶ Löwith, *Jacob Burckhardt*, 224.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, 227.

not as an act of hybris, nor as denial of the necessary fragment, but as an acknowledgment of human insufficiency: “Contemplating continuity and thus the whole,” writes Löwith paraphrasing Burckhardt, “man is liberated from the foolish glorification of any particular past, or the foolish despair at any given present, of the foolish hope for any imagined future.”³⁸ Conscious continuity, in other words, has a humbling effect.

6 Renaissance as an Idea

If Renaissance was Burckhardt’s most creative and audacious consciousness of historical continuity, then we may, of course, wonder whether the age of powerful popes, self-centered artists, and ruthless tyrants was truly distinguished by humility. Most likely, it was not. But neither Löwith nor Burckhardt thought of the *Italian* Renaissance as an exemplary or unified historical phenomenon. Rather, to the extent that Burckhardt, as Löwith put it in an earlier essay of 1928, sought to understand the “modes of thought and perception” (*Denk- und Anschauungsweise*) of any given epoch, he understood Renaissance as an idea, as a way of thinking—a *Denkweise*, just as Leo Baeck would later understand the Jewish motif of rebirth—that allowed him to articulate a cultural continuity and, at the same time, a cultural *critique*.³⁹ What inspired Löwith in Burckhardt’s understanding of the Renaissance Idea was precisely the fact that it did *not* constitute a “violent rupture of tradition” and that its proverbial discovery of the modern individual did not simply occur under the aegis of “progressive novelty” but under “preservation of the old.”⁴⁰ The Renaissance idea, in short, achieved what medieval permanence and modern Reformation failed to do: It established a restored, repaired continuity between old and new, a *conscious* continuity, as Löwith put it in 1949, that “constitutes tradition and frees us in relation to it.”⁴¹ In a similar vein, Hannah Arendt argued that the Renaissance, by (re-)discovering antiquity and by resuming the past, was “a first attempt to break the fetters of tradition.”⁴² Renaissances, then, mend our relationship to the past without subjecting us to it. And like all

³⁸ Löwith, *Jacob Burckhardt*, 223.

³⁹ Karl Löwith, “Burckhardts Stellung zu Hegels Geschichtsphilosophie,” in Löwith, *Jacob Burckhardt*, 7.

⁴⁰ Löwith, *Jacob Burckhardt*, 237.

⁴¹ Löwith, *Meaning in History*, 22.

⁴² Arendt, *Between Past and Future*, 26.

things mended, they require a profound sense of wreckage, a gaping tear in the fabric of time.

With that in mind, let us take a closer look at the Renaissance idea. Much, of course, has been written about his idea and its place in modern history.⁴³ For our purposes, we shall focus on three aspects of this rather protean concept: Its religious foundations of rebirth, the cultural concept of repentance, and the imperative notion of new beginnings.

When, in 1840, the French historian Jules Michelet “invented” the renaissance, he could, of course, draw on its Italian antecedents—especially Giorgio Vasari’s art-historical concept of *rinascità* and the French tradition of *la renaissance des lettres*. But he also understood renaissance to be a national, or as some would argue, *nationalist* term. France had been reborn, and Michelet, a lapsed Catholic and somewhat mystical thinker, took rebirth seriously as physical *resurrection*. “What is the great Malheur of dying,” he asked in his *History of France*. “Is it not the price to pay to be reborn to better life?”⁴⁴ Renaissance, for Michelet was not only a national-historical or cultural concept. It was also a deeply *religious* idea. The German humanist Karl Burdach later found the roots of the renaissance idea—and of the Italian Rinascimento—in Christian baptism and atonement, in the *sacramentum regenerationis* and the *sacramentum resurgendum*.⁴⁵

To the deeply religious—and at first blush specifically *Christian* roots of renaissance—one could add a second aspect of its idea: The *sacramentum regenerationis* relates to the act of *reformatio*, it is a *conversio*, a complete transformation involving a change of heart, or even the creation of a *new heart*. Renaissance is a form of repentance, just as repentance is a form of renaissance. The German Jewish-Catholic-Protestant Philosopher Max Scheler, who considered repentance to be the “most revolutionary force in the moral world,” spoke, shortly after World War I, of a collective “rebirth” that would bring forth a “new heart rising from the ashes of the old.”⁴⁶ Likewise, the Jewish philosopher Hermann Cohen understood repentance—or *teshuvah*—as the “creation of a new heart and a new

43 An enduring classic remains Wallace K. Ferguson, *The Renaissance Idea in Historical Thought: Five Centuries of Interpretation* (Cambridge: Houghton Mifflin, 1948).

44 Jules Michelet, *Histoire de France. Œuvres complètes*, vol. 7 (Paris: Flammarion, 1975), 50. On this subject see also Asher Biemann, “Revival as Imperative: Reflections on the Normativity of Jewish Renaissance,” in *Jewish Revival Inside Out: Remaking Jewishness in a Transnational Age*, ed. Daniel Monterescu and Rachel Werczberger (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 2023), 23–42.

45 Karl Burdach, *Reformation, Renaissance, Humanismus: Zwei Abhandlungen über die Grundlage moderner Bildung und Sprachkunst* (Berlin: G. Paetel, 1918), 43.

46 Max Scheler, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen. Gesammelte Werke 5* (Bern: Francke Verlag, 1954), 50.

spirit.”⁴⁷ Drawing on Ezekiel, whom we have already encountered as the prophet of the dry bones, and following the medieval Jewish philosopher Maimonides, who explained the Jewish concept of resurrection—*tchivat ha-metim*—as a distinctly moral concept in connection with repentance—Cohen viewed the new heart not as a gift given to the penitent, nor as a phoenix rising from the ashes, but as a *task*. It was the infinite task of *creating* a new heart and a new mind that had the power to transform the self, to establish, at any moment in one’s life, a new “I,” a “true I,” as Cohen puts it. “Repentance should never grow old,” writes Cohen, “and it must and can constantly rejuvenate and renew itself.”⁴⁸ And thus, he continues, “the I is steadily rejuvenated to new life.” And in this “continuous rejuvenation the I has its only existence and permanence.”⁴⁹ The human self, then, receives its continuity precisely through continuous rebirth, and it is continuously reborn through the interruptions of repentance, the discontinuities of turning, the ruptures of beginning anew.

And this brings us to the third element of the renaissance idea. “In every single action,” writes Hermann Cohen in his *Ethics* of 1904, “commences a new beginning.”⁵⁰ Cohen distinguished passive continuance (*Fortbestand*) from active continuation, or maintenance (*Forterhaltung*). While continuance requires only a strong beginning in the past, the work of continuation requires the periodic renewal of that beginning, at whose fissures the unexpected can occur. Thus, for Cohen, the idea of *chidush olam*—the renewal of the world—was one of the most important revisions of the concept of creation. “Not creation at the beginning shall be the adequate term,” Cohen writes, “but renewal, which idealizes the beginning and renders creation a matter of continuity, within which every day constitutes a new beginning.”⁵¹ Hannah Arendt would later remind us of that very same principal identity of action and beginning. “To act, in its most general sense,” she writes in the *Human Condition*, “means to take an initiative, to begin.”⁵² This beginning, however, is not the beginning of something, like the beginning of the world. Rather, it is the beginning of *someone*; it is the beginning of

47 Hermann Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft aus den Quellen des Judentums* (Frankfurt/M.: Kauffmann, 1929), 237.

48 Hermann Cohen, *Religion of Reason Out of the Sources of Judaism*, trans. Simon Kaplan (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1995), 204.

49 Cohen, *Religion of Reason*, 205.

50 Hermann Cohen, *Ethik des reinen Willens* (Berlin: Bruno Cassirer, 1904), 331.

51 Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 78.

52 Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 177. On this theme, see also Agnes Heller, “Hannah Arendt on Tradition and New Beginnings,” in *Hannah Arendt in Jerusalem*, ed. Steven Aschheim (Berkeley et al.: University of California Press, 2001), 19–32.

the beginner himself, or herself, or themselves.⁵³ It is the “new beginning inherent in birth,” our very own natality, that makes itself felt in the world through our capacity of beginning something anew, which is our capacity to act and which, ultimately, vouchsafes our freedom.⁵⁴ “With word and deed we insert ourselves into the human world,” writes Arendt, “and this insertion is like a second birth.”⁵⁵ We are, in that sense, “reborn” in every beginning, in every action, and in this sheer endlessly repeated rebirth we resist our own mortality.

Renaissance resists mortality. It can be argued, as Zygmunt Bauman did, that culture—that “huge and never stopping factory of permanence”—is itself a permanent resistance to mortality.⁵⁶ This is not to say that renaissance cultures are credible sources of immortality or that any human deed or memory could, in any form, defy the finality of death. Natality and mortality depend on each other in our human condition, or as Jans Jonas put it, “mortality is but the other side of the perennial spring of ‘natality’ (to use Hannah Arendt’s term).”⁵⁷ Immortality itself is a category of our active lives and, therefore, cannot compete with abstract eternity, in which contemplation alone can participate. However, there is a difference whether we think of our lives as being-onto-death, or as being-onto-life: whether we think-in-fate or whether we think-in-rebirth. Hannah Arendt herself chastised in an essay of 1946 the “superstition of doom” (*Untergangs-Aberglaube*) that had become the “foundation of the nihilism of our time.”⁵⁸

Perhaps we can now understand why Max Scheler, in 1917, insisted on the correlation of repentance and rebirth, and why he insisted on the possibility not only of individual but of *collective* repentance (*Gesamtreue*). “Repentance,” he writes, “is the powerful self-regeneration of the moral world, constantly working against its extinction.”⁵⁹ Not the annihilation of nations, nor the decay of culture, was Scheler’s resolution after the Great War (which, as many other intellectuals, he had initially supported with shameful enthusiasm), but the “remorseful dissolution and, as it were, withdrawal of its structural elements into a creative spirit of rebirth and vitality.”⁶⁰ No revolutions and no “new men” could initiate such remorse. It required, instead, something in the people themselves, a “change of

⁵³ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 177.

⁵⁴ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 9.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, 176.

⁵⁶ Zygmunt Bauman, *Mortality, Immortality, and Other Life Strategies* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1992), 4.

⁵⁷ Hans Jonas, *The Imperative of Responsibility: In Search of an Ethics for the Technological Age* (Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press, 1984), 19.

⁵⁸ Hannah Arendt, „Über den Imperialismus,“ *Die Wandlung* 1.8 (1946): 661.

⁵⁹ Scheler, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen*, 49.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*, 53.

heart of the nations.” Scheler called this the “great principle of solidarity of all of Adam’s children,” a solidarity created by a shared sense of shared responsibility. This co-responsibility (*Mitverantwortlichkeit*), he continues, is “the steady consciousness that the entire moral world between past and future, between stars and heavens, could be radically different, if only ‘I’ could be ‘different.’”⁶¹

7 A Communion of Time

I have focused on religious transformation, repentance, and new beginnings as three interrelated elements of the Renaissance idea because they have something in common: Each one presupposes a simultaneity of distant times. Simultaneity is both a classical and a modernist theme familiar to us from Boethius’s *Consolation of Philosophy*, Augustine’s *Confessions*, and Dante’s *Divine Comedy*, where *il punto a cui tutti li tempi sono presenti* marks a distinct moment of resolution in Canto XVII (in Paradise, needless to say). As a modernist trope, simultaneity, which Sigmund Freud discovered as the mysterious “and” of dream-events, inspired poets, writers, and artists from T.S. Eliot to Scott Fitzgerald, to the painters of Expressionism and Surrealism.⁶² Walter Benjamin, in his *Passagen-Werk*, called simultaneity the “foundation of the new lifestyle.”⁶³

As Henri Bergson observed already in 1888, our experience of time is not one of linear succession but one of a simultaneous “side by side,” a simultaneous perception of “before and after,” which offered also the peculiar experience of *reversibility*: Not mythic recurrence as such, but the co-presence and interpenetration of past and future.⁶⁴ Thus, time, according to Bergson, should not be viewed as a continuum, but understood as a *communion* across its tenses. Karl Barth expressed this almost dialogical simultaneity in his 1922 *Epistle to the Romans*: “The past can speak to the present; for there is between them a simultaneity which heals the past of its dumbness and the present of its deafness (. . .). This simultaneity makes possible an intercourse in which time is at once dissolved and ful-

61 Scheler, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen*, 51.

62 “The dream knows no either/or, but only a simultaneous next-to-each-other (*Nebeneinander*).” Sigmund Freud, *Gesammelte Werke 6: Der Witz und seine Beziehung zum Unbewußten* (London: Imago, 1940), 234.

63 Walter Benjamin, *Das Passagen-Werk. Gesammelte Schriften*, vol. 5–1, ed. Rolf Tiedemann (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1991), 498: “(. . .) die Simultaneität, diese Grundlage des neuen Lebensstils (. . .)”

64 Henri Bergson, *Time and Free Will: An Essay on the Immediate Data of Consciousness*, trans. F. L. Pogson (London: Allen & Unwin, 1910), 101–2.

filled, for its theme is the non-historical, the invisible, and the incomprehensible.”⁶⁵ To Walter Benjamin it was the “secret agreement between past generations and the present one,” that constituted not only the silent coexistence of past and future generations, but their hushed conversation, their secret “date,” their *Vera-bredung*.⁶⁶ Also echoing modernism’s visual metaphors, Franz Rosenzweig wrote in his 1921 *Star of Redemption*: “In the midst of time, the contemporaries, the co-temporal ones, catch sight of each other.”⁶⁷

There is still much to be written about the modern concept of the contemporary—the *Zeitgenosse* (the comrade-in-time), which was explored already in the early Nineteenth Century by the conservative yet, in some ways remarkably progressive, Catholic philosopher and economist Adam Müller, who also coined the concept of the *Raumgenosse* (best translated perhaps by the Spanish term *coterráneo*).⁶⁸ Gustav Landauer, a consciously Jewish religious socialist, who was murdered by right-wing paramilitaries during the German Revolution in 1919, later envisioned a reality of “neighborly companionship” (*Nachbargenossenschaft*) in which we “regard the nations we know as contemporaries,” rather than territorial units.⁶⁹ “Both, the unity of nations and the unity of times constitute the human world,” wrote Leo Baeck, to whom we shall return momentarily.⁷⁰ And Abraham Joshua Heschel, in his seminal essay on the Sabbath notes that “it is only it is only within time that there is fellowship and *togetherness* of all beings.”⁷¹

Renaissances require the co-presence—the communion—of distant times for the same reason repentance and *teshuvah* (which are by no means neatly identical) require simultaneous vision. The penitent, as Scheler wrote, is a like a moun-

65 Karl Barth, *The Epistle to the Romans*, trans. Edwyn C. Hoskyns (London: Oxford University Press, 1963), 145.

66 Walter Benjamin, *Illuminationen* (Ausgewählte Schriften 1), ed. Siegfried Unseld (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1977), 252.

67 Franz Rosenzweig, *Der Stern der Erlösung. Gesammelte Schriften 2*, ed. Reinhold Mayer (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1976), 384: “In der Mitte der Zeit erblicken sich die Gleichzeitigen.”

68 Adam Müller, *Schriften zur Staatsphilosophie*, ed. Rudolf Kohler (Munich: Theatiner Verlag, 1923), 31–33. Müller’s distinction between *Zeitgenosse* and *Raumgenosse* is not entirely intuitive. *Zeitgenosse* refers to the “Neben-einander-Stehenden,” whereas *Raumgenossen* applies to the “Allianz der Generationen.”

69 Gustav Landauer, *Die Revolution* (Frankfurt/M.: Rütten & Loening, 1919), 31. For the term *Nachbargenossenschaft*, see Gustav Landauer, “Sind das Ketzergedanken?,” in *Dichter, Ketzler, Außenseiter. Essays und Reden zu Literatur, Philosophie, Judentum* (Werkausgabe 3), ed. Gert Matthenklott and Hanna Delf (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1997), 174.

70 Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums*, 252.

71 Abraham Joshua Heschel, *The Earth is the Lord’s & The Sabbath* (Cleveland and New York: Meridian Books, 1963), 99.

taineer stopping somewhere along the way to look back at the valley and forward towards the summit. This, to Scheler, was the “great paradox” of atonement: “that it *looks* back with tears and yet, at the same time, joyfully and forcefully *works* towards the future, towards renewal, and towards liberation from moral death.”⁷² Repentance, then, belongs to both *vita activa* and *vita contemplativa*. Hermann Cohen described *teshuvah* with a wonderful German wordplay, we cannot easily replicate: *Einkehr und Umkehr*—introspection and turning. Scheler used a wordplay of his own: *Umkehr und Vorkehr*—turning and provision. Franz Rosenzweig, in a lecture of 1920, called his entire generation as a generation of *ba’alei teshuvah* (re-turners), warning, however, against *Umkehr* remaining but *Umkehr* and *Einkehr* remaining but *Rückkehr* (return).⁷³ Likewise, Leo Baeck insisted that *Umkehr* must not be reduced to *Rückkehr*: “It is return to the beginning,” he writes of *Umkehr* in his *Essence of Judaism*, “and every beginning is the beginning of a path towards a goal, every renewal is an advancement.”⁷⁴ Then he continues that humanity owes its history to the fact that it possesses the capability of “always renewing itself, of always being reborn, of always beginning anew.”⁷⁵

8 Renaissance as Imperative

We have now indeed returned to Leo Baeck. But we have yet to make sense of our reflections on renaissance and the continuity of new beginnings. Let me propose, then, three possible imperatives derived from the renaissance idea and its imperative of rebeginning.

There is a reason why imperatives, as the Jewish-Protestant thinker Eugen Rosenstock-Huessy once put it, are “verbs without ending.”⁷⁶ Imperative language indicates “unfinished creation,” it signifies the “world of tomorrow” and gestures, therefore, towards the utopian, which, as we saw in Leo Baeck, makes demands on us.⁷⁷ Imperatives can be prophetic, political, or cultural. And as all language, they can be abused. We must, therefore, take care for words not to become “frozen or petrified imperatives,” as Rosenstock-Huessy put it. Speech must

⁷² Scheler, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen*, 49.

⁷³ Franz Rosenzweig, “Der jüdische Mensch,” in *Zweistromland. Kleinere Schriften zu Glauben und Denken (Gesammelte Schriften III)*, ed. Reinhold and Annemarie Mayer (Dordrecht et al.: Martinus Nijhoff, 1984), 573.

⁷⁴ Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums*, 254.

⁷⁵ Ibid.

⁷⁶ Eugen Rosenstock-Huessy, *Speech and Reality* (Norwich, Vermont: Argo Books, 1970), 149.

⁷⁷ Rosenstock-Huessy, *Speech and Reality*, 132.

always be concerned with the resuscitation of a word's "life." "[S]peaker and listener," Rosenstock-Huessy writes, "insist on the resurrection of the otherwise forgotten, by resuscitating life 'in the wise' of the word by which all things are made."⁷⁸ Through word and deed we insert ourselves into the world, we recall from Hannah Arendt, and this insertion is like a second birth, which at once empowers us and makes us vulnerable. Beginners are, after all, *mere* beginners, still to be shaped and transformed by their own words and deeds. *Respondeo etsi mutabar*—I respond although I will be changed, was Rosenstock-Huessy's most famous maxim; *audi, ne moriamur*—Listen, lest we die, the other.⁷⁹ Indeed, "human survival and revival," Rosenstock-Huessy wrote in 1939, "depends on speech," and speech, like renaissance, repentance, *teshuvah*, is always a risk—the risk of revision and response.⁸⁰

The first imperative renaissances share, is an imperative of revision, which requires a certain degree of optimism. Optimism, as is well known, was the subject of Voltaire's great satire *Candide*, published in 1759 as a rightful mockery of Leibniz's "best of all possible worlds." However, as an imperative, optimism recognizes exactly the opposite: that this world is not in perfect harmony but in need of constant repair. "Optimism," as Hermann Cohen wrote towards the end of World War I—and towards the end of his own life—"is by no means the ruthless way of thought defamed by Schopenhauer. Rather, it is the practical wisdom a true theodicy has always confirmed: that the world can be morally improved, and that human suffering can be helped."⁸¹ There is cruel optimism and there is critical optimism. For Leo Baeck, the Hebrew prophets were the "great optimists" in history because they refused to succumb to "pessimism and the denial of culture." Their optimism, then, was not naïve and indifferent to human suffering. To the contrary, it was a form of protest, a "contempt for the day and a derision of the hour."⁸² It was an optimism that exposed injustice, poverty, and human evil, and yet refused to despair despite its realism. W. E. B. Du Bois, the great leader of what is widely known as the Harlem Renaissance, once wrote that it was the "highest optimism to bring forward the dark side of any human picture."⁸³ Like Leo Baeck, he refused to succumb to the "crushing pessimism" that "takes hold of the world when people say things are so bad that they are not worth complaining

⁷⁸ Ibid., 149.

⁷⁹ Ibid., 24.

⁸⁰ Rosenstock-Huessy, *Speech and Reality*, 25.

⁸¹ Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 20–21.

⁸² Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums*, 256.

⁸³ W. E. B. Du Bois, "We Claim Our Rights," in *W. E. B. Du Bois Speaks: Speeches and Addresses 1890–1919*, ed. Philip S. Foner (New York: Pathfinder Press, 1977), 177.

of because they cannot be made better.”⁸⁴ For Du Bois, optimism was not only a protest, but moral outrage. Hans Jonas, who, in 1933, fled Germany first to Palestine, then to North America, and who lost his mother in Auschwitz, understood his entire philosophy to be a resistance to “ruthless pessimism” articulating his own imperative: “We must know what the human being should be, and most of all, that humanity, no matter what it has made of itself, must not disappear.”⁸⁵ To “[a]ct so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life,” became Jonas’s famous revision of Kant’s categorical imperative.⁸⁶ It also anticipated the second imperative of renaissance: the imperative of permanence.

Permanence rarely is among the cultural values or virtues we nowadays admire. It suggests a lack of change and agency. It signals inflexibility, inertia, dogma, religious “orthodoxy.” However, as an imperative, permanence recognizes, once again, the opposite: It *questions* unbroken continuity rendering it, as we have seen, a conscious act. For Karl Löwith, continuity was more than “mere going on” because it was more than everlasting duration. Continuity, he argued, “points out not merely the significance of formal duration but also the need of preservation.”⁸⁷ Preservation, however, requires not only maintenance and conservation—imperatives we today associate almost exclusively with ecological sustainability. It also requires, Löwith continues, a “conscious continuation of history as a tradition (. . .) preserved against a revolutionary will to permanent revisions.”⁸⁸ Permanence, then, must be more than that ever-lasting *Immerwährende* which Franz Rosenzweig, in his *Star of Redemption*, identified with the static, self-enclosed “plastic proto-cosmos” of a deaf and wordless world. True permanence, and indeed “eternity,” for Rosenzweig, had to be achieved by bringing what he considered the fundamental elements—God, world, and man—into relation to each other. It could only be achieved through the intervention of revelation as an act of entering the reality of speech, effecting transformation, renewal, rebeginning, and rebirth. To Rosenzweig, revelation and *teshuvah* were correlates, because both established paradoxical interruptions creating continuity. “Preservation,” wrote Hermann Cohen, “is itself a continuous revival.”⁸⁹ That the Creator appeared not only as the preserver but also as the *renewer* of the world repre-

⁸⁴ Du Bois, “We Claim Our Rights,” 177.

⁸⁵ Hans Jonas, *Technik, Medizin und Ethik. Praxis des Prinzips Verantwortung* (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1987), 74.

⁸⁶ Hans Jonas, *The Imperative of Responsibility*, 11.

⁸⁷ Löwith, *Meaning in History*, 22.

⁸⁸ *Ibid.*

⁸⁹ Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 359.

sented, to Cohen, the idea of continuity as continuous transformation. Likewise, Hans Jonas, expanded his imperative of permanence to an imperative towards an “indefinite continuation of humanity on earth” as an act of continual self-transcendence.⁹⁰ Humanity’s necessary continuation remained unthinkable without the fundamental condition Hannah Arendt had described as natality and the imperative of new beginnings. Accordingly, Hans Jonas considered human birth as the paradigm of human continuity: “With every newborn child humanity begins anew, and in that sense also the responsibility for the continuation of mankind is involved.”⁹¹ Because human continuity—unlike the duration of Rosenzweig’s mute proto-cosmos—requires rebirth, it cannot be seen *sub specie aeternitatis*, but must, rather, be viewed *sub specie temporis*, in relation to the “vulnerability of being” requiring, and demanding from us, by its own internal “Ought,” an affirmative act of continuation.⁹² Thus, we understand why Rosenzweig understood “true” eternity not as a given but as something that must be created and recreated, a “*selbstgeschaffene Ewigkeit*” that had to be achieved within the evanescence of time.⁹³

There can be no meaningful continuation, Löwith argued, without rebirths and re-beginnings. Renaissance is no effortless continuance. It is the act of recontinuation, a conscious continuity as paradoxical as the continuity of our interrupted selves.⁹⁴ What is the value of such continuity? Jacob Burckhardt himself spoke of a “spiritual continuity” that connects all generations and all humankind. By restoring this spiritual continuity, by maintaining it, repairing it, we become each other’s contemporaries, we begin to live, as Leo Baeck put it, *with* each other (*miteinander*) rather than *next* to each other (*nebeneinander*). Because every next-to-each-other, as Baeck knew after World War I, will inevitably turn into an against-each-other (*gegeneinander*). The imperative of permanence, for Leo Baeck, was an imperative inseparable from the idea of humanity, as inseparable as Jewish history, for Baeck, was from the idea of human history (*Menschheitsgeschichte*). This correlation runs through most of modern Jewish thought. “The unity of nations *and* the unity of ages,” we recall from Baeck, “constitute the human world.” This meant, for, Baeck,

⁹⁰ Jonas, *The Imperative of Responsibility*, 11.

⁹¹ *Ibid.*, 134.

⁹² *Ibid.*, 135.

⁹³ Rosenzweig, *Stern der Erlösung*, 338.

⁹⁴ A similar paradox appears in Hannah Arendt’s reflections on forgiveness as interruption of the necessary course of events: “Only through this mutual release from what they do can men remain free agents, only by constant willingness to change their minds and start again can they be trusted with so great a power as that to begin something anew.” Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 240.

as it did for Martin Buber, or Hermann Cohen, Hannah Arendt, or Margarete Susman, that a people can live only “if it is able to always look beyond itself, if knows how to view itself in the midst of humanity, and if clings to itself for the sake of humanity, and to humanity for the sake of itself.”⁹⁵ The necessity of holding on to itself, Baeck considered the “commandment of immortality”—not the fact, not the mystery, but the task, the imperative shared by individuals, nations, and humanity at large. “If humanity is to be eternal, then its eternal value must be founded upon its tendency towards eternity. This tendency fulfills itself in the nations striving for unification,” writes Hermann Cohen.⁹⁶ Margarete Susman, in her testament to European Jewry, called this moral striving for eternity the defiant refusal to die (*Nichtsterbenkönnen*) that was, at the same time, a necessary lingering (*Verweilenmüssen*) on earth, albeit in profound homelessness.⁹⁷ Franz Kafka, in his aphorisms, called it the indestructible (*das Unzerstörbare*) secretly connecting us. “The Indestructible,” he wrote, “is one; every human being is it and at the same time it is common to all and, thus, it is the uniquely inseparable bond among people.”⁹⁸

This brings us to our last imperative. “The truly historical,” Leo Baeck wrote in the preface to the 1922 edition of his *Essence of Judaism*, “is always the whole” (*das Ganze*).⁹⁹ It requires a total view or, as we would colloquially say, a “bigger picture.” But considering the whole, Baeck continues, always involves a judgment and a form of critique. It obliges us to view the permanent in relation to the transient, the present in relation to the past, the self in relation to the other. To be sure, there exists an uncomfortable kinship between totality and the totalitarian. Critical thought, therefore, has readily abandoned the whole in praise of the fragment, totality in praise of infinity. The totum is the totem, as Adorno famously noted in his *Negative Dialectics*.¹⁰⁰ Yet, as Ernst Simon, a student of Martin Buber, noted in an essay of 1969, the affirmation of totality can also be a form of *anti-totalitarianism*. “Totality,” he writes, “is a system of values and, accordingly, an order of life that encompasses and shapes all human realms.” Totalitarianism, by contrast, is a “system of power” that forces itself upon us and by

95 Leo Baeck, *Dieses Volk. Jüdische Existenz. Leo Baeck Werke* 2, 359.

96 Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 297.

97 Susman, *Das Buch Hiob*, 91.

98 Franz Kafka, *Er* (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1968), 200.

99 Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums*, 35–36.

100 Theodor Adorno, *Negative Dialektik. Gesammelte Schriften* 6 (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1997), 370.

necessity excludes.¹⁰¹ Totality is a whole that humbles, totalitarianism a part that devours. As such, totalitarianism bears the closest resemblance to modern idolatry, an observation later shared by the Jewish philosopher Emil Fackenheim, who understood modern idolatry as the conflation of finitude and infinity, and the idol as total absence of ideals.¹⁰² Simon was, of course, deeply aware that an ideal of totality can easily shift into totalitarianism. He understood his Judaism as a critical commitment to the whole as the totality of its historical manifestations and textual traditions. What lent this totality value, however, was not the whole itself, but the constant negotiation of values in light of ever increasing and historically accumulating possibilities. Totality allows and obliges to make distinctions and decisions, and in this process, argues Simon, “truth” falls always somewhere “in between.”¹⁰³

The imperative, then, I would like to propose, is an imperative of such “in-betweenness.” Renaissance, as the contemporaneous vision of distant times, is always in a temporal in-between, and a such a form of critique and a form of protest against a merely present present. Renaissances imagine the present not as the “Now” at which the past has arrived at any given moment, but as a launchpad, as it were, into the open horizons of time. Hannah Arendt has explored this in-betweenness as a universal condition of human time. “Seen from the viewpoint of man,” she writes, “who always lives in the interval between past and future, time is not a continuum, a flow of uninterrupted succession; it is broken in the middle, at the point where ‘he’ stands; and ‘his’ standpoint is not the present as we usually understand it but rather a gap in time which ‘his’ constant fighting, ‘his’ making a stand against past and future, keeps in existence.”¹⁰⁴ For Arendt, “the insertion of man (. . .) breaks up the continuum,” just as the act of beginning inserts us into the world, simultaneously interrupting and constituting it with our deed and speech. It restores continuity precisely by bringing the horizons of

101 Ernst Simon, “Totalität und Antitotalitarismus als Wesenszüge des überlieferten Judentums,” in *Entscheidung zum Judentum: Essays und Vorträge* (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1980), 33. One might think here also of Ernst Bloch’s concept of “critical totality” in his 1932 reflections on philosophical Gleichzeitigkeit und Ungleichzeitigkeit. Cf. Ernst Bloch, *Erbschaft dieser Zeit. Erweiterte Ausgabe* (Frankfurt/M.: Suhrkamp, 1962), 124–125.

102 Emil Fackenheim, “Idolatry as a Modern Possibility,” in *Encounters Between Judaism and Modern Philosophy: A Preface to Future Jewish Thought* (New York: Schocken Books, 1980), esp. 188–195.

103 Simon, “Totalität und Antitotalitarismus,” 41. Simon draws on the work of Moritz Heimann building on Aristotle and Maimonides. See Moritz Heimann, *Die Wahrheit liegt nicht in der Mitte. Essays* (Frankfurt/M.: S. Fischer, 1966).

104 Hannah Arendt, *Between Past and Future: Eight Exercises in Political Thought* (New York: Penguin Books, 1993), 11.

remembrance and anticipation into correlation. It is, in fact, history “stretching into the twofold infinity of past and future” that bestows on our existence a new sense of permanence, even “immortality,” even if only through the conscious act of *immortalizing*.¹⁰⁵ What endures in historical time endures between the ages and between the generations. Thus, Karl Mannheim could write in 1927: “Generations are in a state of constant interaction.”¹⁰⁶

Let us call, then, this final imperative the imperative of correlation. Correlation had a very specific meaning in Hermann Cohen’s philosophy concerning, primarily, the divine-human relationship. However, I would like to use it in the much broader sense of interaction, interplay, reciprocity, interdependence, mutuality—all the nuances contained in the simple German term *Wechselwirkung*. *Wechselwirkung*, Hermann Cohen once wrote, is the “true magic of historical development.”¹⁰⁷ To view history as a whole—to view it as human history rather than national history or personal biography—means to view it in its infinite correlations, in its constant cultural reciprocity, in the interplay of past, present, and future, in its irreducible ambiguity and, indeed, in its impurity. “Cultural purity is an oxymoron,” Kwame Anthony Appiah would later write to advocate for a cosmopolitan correlation he deliberately called “cultural contamination.”¹⁰⁸ Eugen Rosenstock-Huussy, who conceived of humanity as a living system of grammar, often described himself as an “impure thinker.”¹⁰⁹ Hermann Cohen, while known as a philosopher in pursuit of “pure concepts”, rejected the purity of human consciousness—because it was always already *con-scientia*, a joined, participatory cultural knowledge (*Mitwissenschaft*).¹¹⁰ Thus, he maintained that Jewish theology could develop only in the “most intimate interconnection with Islamic thought,” and that modern Jewish culture was the product of its intimate encounter, and

105 Arendt, *Between Past and Future*, 75.

106 Karl Mannheim, “The Problem of Generations,” in *Essays on the Sociology of Knowledge*, ed. Paul Kecskemeti (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1968), 301.

107 Hermann Cohen, “Was einigt die Konfessionen?,” *Jüdische Schriften* 1, ed. Bruno Strauß (Berlin: Schwetschke & Sohn, 1924), 84.

108 Kwame Anthony Appiah, *Cosmopolitanism: Ethics in a World of Strangers* (New York and London: W. W. Norton, 2006), 113.

109 “I am an impure thinker. I am hurt, shaken, swayed, elated, disillusioned, comforted, and I have to transmit my mental experiences lest I die.” Eugen Rosenstock-Huussy, *I am an Impure Thinker* (Norwich, Vermont: Argo Books, 1970), 2. Similarly, yet with different nuances, Rosenstock-Huussy writes in his *Soziologie*: “Ich bin ein unreiner, temporaler Denker. Ich kann nicht aus dem Todesraum der idealistischen Zeitlosigkeit auf die drei Zeiten der Lebendigen wissenschaftlich blicken.” Accordingly, Rosenstock-Huussy seeks a “neue Verwurzelung der Geister.” Rosenstock-Huussy, *Soziologie II: Die Vollzahl der Zeiten* (Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 1958), 19.

110 Hermann Cohen, *Ethik des reinen Willens* (Berlin: Bruno Cassirer, 1904), 90.

indeed *con-scientia*, with Christianity.¹¹¹ To be sure, Cohen did not look far beyond the European continent to find additional examples of cultural correlations, but the *principle* of culture was one of mutual encounter for him, an ongoing, inevitable cultural correlation.

How could such inevitable correlation become an imperative? For Cohen, by virtue of mere acceptance and acknowledgment. Correlation is an imperative not of doing, but of allowing it to happen. Correlations occur, just as “true dialogue,” in Buber’s philosophy, seizes us, and just as love, in Margarete Susman’s early reflections, awakens the “soul” to surrender: As it “loses itself to the shoreless whole,” and as it “surrenders to another eternity,” the soul, Susman writes, returns transformed.¹¹² *Respondeo etsi mutabar* was Rosenstock-Huessy’s maxim, and we can now better understand why the imperative of correlation comprises a willingness to be transformed and why this willingness applies not only to our innermost selves, but to cultural institutions as well. Religions, Cohen writes in 1917, seem to be “rigidly enclosed in their institutions; yet they soar and breathe in a constant flux of correlation to which they are subjugated.” And he continues that once we acknowledge this flux of correlation, “all illusion of absoluteness disappears.”¹¹³ Thus, the imperative of correlation becomes itself an “admonition and illumination” of our own religion, “an expansion of the confessional horizon into self-critique.”¹¹⁴ Looking at human history in this total view of correlation, then, exemplifies, for Cohen, the most difficult of virtues—the virtue of humility. The acknowledgement of our cultural impurity, the awareness of cultural correlations, is always a source of embarrassment, a loss of innocence. Correlation humbles. But it also establishes new continuities, continuities which Rosenstock-Huessy expressed in the mysterious grammatical conjunction of the “and,” a small and unassuming word that has the power to conjoin and differentiate, to establish relations and to break open horizons. “Using the word ‘And,’ a thinker or a speaker concedes that there is more to say,” writes Rosenstock-Huessy, “and that their statement reaches into an horizon far wider than a finished sentence could possibly suggest.”¹¹⁵ Thus, concludes Rosenstock-Huessy, “as long as we con-

111 Hermann Cohen, “Was einigt die Konfessionen?,” in *Jüdische Schriften* 1, 79.

112 Margarete Susman, „Vom Sinn der Liebe“ (1912), in *Gesammelte Schriften* 3, ed. Anke Gilleir and Barbara Hahn (Göttingen: Wallstein Verlag, 2022), 138.

113 Cohen, “Was einigt die Konfessionen?,” 80.

114 Cohen, “Was einigt die Konfessionen?,” 81.

115 Eugen Rosenstock-Huessy, *Die Sprache des Menschengeschlechts. Eine leibhaftige Grammatik in vier Teilen* 1 (Heidelberg: Lambert Schneider, 1963), 283.

tinue speaking and muster the courage to say ‘And,’ we will remain above our own dogmas (. . .) The word ‘And’ refutes dogmatism.”¹¹⁶

9 Entangled Continuities at Work

With the unassuming word “and” I shall conclude my reflections. Intellectual historians are always confronted by the “ands” of history, by entangled continuities that hold together ideas as disparate as they may seem, and ages, as distant as they may be. The world of ideas is always an embarrassment of riches. It must humble any historian, let alone an historian of thought. There is much truth to Emerson’s observation that ideas are “in the air.”¹¹⁷ But this does not render them disembodied and elevated to be “above” the thicket of history and the individuality of personal lives. All it means is that ideas are, by habit, unfaithful to their thinkers, “migratory,” as Arthur Lovejoy once put it; that ideas live in no one’s mind, but between us, precisely in the spaces of correlation, the in-betweens, which are, in truth, spaces of contemporaneity. Rosenstock-Huessy called these spaces spaces of “mental presence,” which can also be a mental *present* (*Geistesgegenwart*).¹¹⁸

The idea of renaissance lives in such a present. It belongs to no one, but occurs, or is ever reinvented, across different cultural contexts and ages. We often think of Renaissance and Reformation as foundations of the “modern West.” But for many Jewish thinkers, the historical Renaissance was but *one* manifestations of an idea that had to be “renewed from and for the margins.”¹¹⁹ I have reflected on this idea not only because it became a commonly used trope in modern Juda-

¹¹⁶ Rosenstock-Huessy, *Die Sprache des Menschengeschlechts* 1, 283–284.

¹¹⁷ Ralph Waldo Emerson, “Fate,” in *Essays & Lectures* (New York: The Library of America, 1983), 565.

¹¹⁸ Rosenstock-Huessy, *Die Sprache des Menschengeschlechts* 1, 284. Articulating what we might call the “lyrical turn” towards dialogue in 20th-century Jewish and Christian thought Rosenstock-Huessy writes: “The word ‘and’ keeps us in a mental present between the pasts of logic and the futures of lyricism.” In his aesthetics, Hermann Cohen presented “mental lyricism” (*Gedankenlyrik*) as the fundamental force of the dialogical: “[O]nly lovers speak the language of feeling, only they create a true I, an I in a You, a You in an I.” Cf. *Ästhetik des reinen Gefühls* 2 (Berlin: Bruno Cassirer, 1912), 24.

¹¹⁹ I believe that Dipesh Chakrabarty’s notion of “provincializing” the European intellectual tradition can also be applied to the self-conception of Modern Jewish thought: “European thought is at once indispensable and inadequate in helping us to think through the experiences of political modernity in non-Western nations, and provincializing Europe becomes the task of exploring how this thought—which is not everybody’s heritage and which affects us all—may be renewed

ism but because it functioned, and continues to function, as a metaphor of human history and human continuity as such. Renaissances are usually born in times of crisis, and they often emerge as calls for self-realization and restoration of “self-hood.” Here, in the reactionary temptations of the *restaurateur*, lurks perhaps their intrinsic danger, for all renaissances are prone to enter the services of national nostalgia. Homecoming always risks a closure of horizons, and this closure often means exclusion. But renaissances, understood as cultural introspection and transformation for the sake of continuation, can also establish *inclusive* continuities, a communion of time, that ruptures this very nostalgia by disrupting the singularities of recovered pasts and inhabited spaces. The renaissance idea was born from displacement and from the recognition that the ages of history, like human generations, are not separated from one another, but interrelated, correlated, constantly working upon, and reworking, each other. “Contemplating continuity and thus the whole,” we read earlier in this essay, “man is liberated from the foolish glorification of any particular past, or the foolish despair at any given present, of the foolish hope for any imagined future.” These were Burckhardt’s wry and seemingly conservative words which, for Löwith, expressed a peculiar interconnectedness of the “spirit”—a *Zusammenhang des Geistes*. They captured, perhaps, the deeper meaning of Leo Baeck’s insistence to write Jewish history, or any history at all, in its “total course.” For only a “unity of nations” and a “unity of times” could constitute, for Baeck, the human world. And it was the mode of thought, the *Denkweise*, of Renaissance that exemplified for him this constitution. “Symblyisma between entire epochs, symmorphie between entire human lives, syllogism between entire sentences,” these, for Rosenstock-Huessy, were the grammatical signs of the “unity of spirit” that defined human history.¹²⁰

What spirit—*Geist*—truly meant to this generation of thinkers cannot easily be reconstructed, nor can it be reduced to the Hegelian tradition. Hermann Cohen referred to Psalm 51:12 to clarify its concept: “Fashion for me, God, a pure heart, and renew in me a steadfast spirit.” The Hebrew *ruach nachon* Cohen translates as a *gegründeter Geist*, a spirit that is grounded, rooted, reasoned and yet always made anew.¹²¹ “It is the spirit that fashions for itself a body,” Franz Rosenzweig wrote at about the same time.¹²² Here, the concept of man and the concept of the spirit complemented each other. For Rosenzweig, “spirit” always

from and for the margins.” Dipesh Chakrabarty, *Provincializing Europe: Postcolonial Thought and Historical Difference* (Princeton and Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2000), 16.

120 Rosenstock-Huessy, *Die Sprache des Menschengeschlechts* 1, 287.

121 Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 119.

122 Franz Rosenzweig, „Geist und Epochen der jüdischen Geschichte,” *Kleinere Schriften* (Berlin: Schocken, 1937), 15.

meant a “spiritual interconnectedness” (*geistiger Zusammenhang*) connecting individuals beyond their bodily lives, beyond even their lifetimes, into a “spiritual community” (*geistige Gemeinschaft*).¹²³ For Cohen, the spirit itself became the “connecting link of correlation,” the emblematic in-between, and as such the ground for “continuous renewal.”¹²⁴ “The spirit is ‘renaissance’ while love is naissance,” writes Rosenstock-Huessy in a similar vein.¹²⁵

To speak of entangled continuities means to de-linearize the concept of conscious continuities Löwith had recovered from Burckhardt’s idea of the renaissance and to take seriously the mystery of correlations as “spiritual” continuities or, to be more up-to-date, contiguities.¹²⁶ Cultural correlations and entanglements have, of course, become commonplaces in recent scholarship. Yet we rarely think of correlations and continuities *at work*, even if it means the work of letting something occur. By presenting the idea of renaissance not only as an idea but as a mode of thought, I have tried to articulate a series of cultural imperatives offering distinct, yet entangled continuities envisioning interrelations across time and space. They are indeed disrupted continuities more akin to contiguities yet still concerned with continuity emerging precisely from the “in-betweens” where the “ands” of culture and history are nestled.

Whether continuity is a value, virtue or desirable end in itself, unless accompanied by an “indestructible idea,” is a question that has confounded many a modern Jewish thinker. Mordecai Kaplan’s insistence on the intrinsic value of Jewish “self-perpetuation” as a civilization stood in stark contrast to the traditional view of continuity as an infinite obligation.¹²⁷ Indeed, halakhic Judaism—a Judaism accepting the covenantal axiom that the Jewish people exists for the sake

123 Rosenzweig, „Geist und Epochen der jüdischen Geschichte,“ 12.

124 Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 119–121.

125 Rosenstock-Huessy, *Die Sprache des Menschengeschlechts* 1, 287.

126 Dan Miron, *From Continuity to Contiguity: Toward a New Jewish Literary Thinking* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2010), 305: “The new thinking should leave continuities behind (not that they do not exist, at least as helpful ancillary syntagms; but they are of secondary importance and have been overly studied and focused on) and focus instead on contiguities and tangentialities.” Accordingly, Miron defines contiguity as “a kind of light and diminished contact . . . a contact that avoids all permanencies, is in flux, can be seen as random, and yet is indicative of mobility—free and unfettered—within a space that is vast and open, but then also, in the final analysis, not infinite, because it is inscribed by a borderline, which can be very fine and barely noticed or deeply and clearly etched.” (306).

127 In his well-known exchange with Kaplan, Arthur Cohen refused to justify the “continued existence” of the Jewish people without a Jewish idea “as being an indestructible, impermeable asset to human civilization.” *If not Now, When: Toward a Reconstitution of the Jewish People. Conversations Between Mordecai M. Kaplan and Arthur A. Cohen* (New York: Schocken Books, 1977), 30–36.

of the Torah rather than the reverse, can tolerate no continuity other than a continuity continuous with the eternity of what is, for lack of better term, referred to as “the Law.” “The Law counts on ages, future, continuation,” writes Rosenzweig in his *Star*.¹²⁸ The “essence of the Law,” as Leo Baeck put it in an essay of 1947, is to “encompass all” and to be, as it were, “infinite and eternal.” Under the aegis of the Law, writes Baeck, “all that is side by side enters something that encompasses it,” and “all discontinuity is submerged, time and again, into an all-enclosing continuity.”¹²⁹ The Law itself becomes the idea, or as Hermann Cohen put it, the “symbol” around which Jewish continuity is organized. As any symbol, the Law itself, for Cohen, has “no intrinsic value.” Yet it *awakens* value and establishes and maintains the correlation between knowledge and deed.¹³⁰ Thus, the Law, whose pivotal cornerstone remains the idea of *teshuvah*, an idea so timeless and enduring that the Rabbis considered it preexisting the creation of the world (*teshuvah kadmah le’olam*), establishes both the *moral* concept of continuity and the *moral* concept rebeginning.¹³¹ It is from the perspective of the Law as the otherworldly symbol of moral continuity that we can understand Cohen’s conviction that the ethical task would remain even if “heaven and earth might vanish” and that “more than the earth,” the history of the Jewish people and of messianic humanity deserved to be considered eternal.¹³² And it is this notion of an eternity in need not only of continuous renewal and rebirth but also of the eternal Law, that might explain Franz Rosenzweig’s startling certitude that “the last Jew will be none other than the last human being.”¹³³

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¹²⁸ Rosenzweig, *Stern der Erlösung*, 197.

¹²⁹ Leo Baeck, „Individuum ineffabile,” *Leo Baeck Werke* 5, 77.

¹³⁰ Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 430.

¹³¹ On the preexistence of *teshuvah* see, among other sources, Midrash Bereshit Rabba 1:4; Midrash Tehillim 90:7.

¹³² Cohen, *Religion der Vernunft*, 351.

¹³³ Franz Rosenzweig, “Der jüdische Mensch,” in *Zweistromland*, 575.

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Chapter 3

Islam as a Theurgy of Virtues? Emanationist Ethics, Lay Practice and Shī'ism in the Vernacular Writings of 'Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī (d. 1329)

1 Introduction

Scholarship has long recognized a shift in Islamic learning, beginning in the 12th-13th c. CE, from a focus on philosophy and classical theology as distinct disciplines toward more emanationist forms of Sufi thought that often sought to unite both fields.¹ These frameworks of theoretical Sufism also rehabilitated Neoplatonic, Pythagorean and Hermetic teachings that had been marginalized since their initial translation into Arabic several centuries before.² More strikingly, this new Sufi intellectual synthesis rationalized Islamic religious observances in terms arguably closer to Hellenic theurgy than any other concept readily available to the study of religion.³ Finally, these major developments in Islamic thought coincided with Sufi institutions' rise to prevalence across all areas of Islamic society during the

1 For an overview of the development and beginnings of interaction between different branches of Islamic learning, see Marshall G. S. Hodgson, *The Venture of Islam, Vol. II: The Expansion of Islam in the Middle Periods* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1975), esp. chapter 3, "Maturity and Dialogue among the Intellectual Traditions, c. 945-1111," 152–200. On the ascent of Sufism and its role in the synthesis between disciplines, see chapter 4, "The Šūfism of the Ṭarīqah Orders," c. 945-1273, 201–254. For the synthesis of theology and philosophy in this context, see Robert Wisonovsky, "One Aspect of the Avicennian Turn in Sunni Theology," *Arabic Sciences and Philosophy* 14/1 (2004): 65–100.

2 On the later Sufi reception of the "occult" Hellenistic material in general, see e.g. Liana Saif, "From *Gāyat al-Ḥakīm* to *Šams al-Ma'ārif*: Ways of Knowing and Paths of Power in Medieval Islam," *Arabica* 64/3–4 (2017): 297–345; there is also the transmission of this material to Sufism via Ismā'īlī thought specifically, as first seriously explored by Michael Ebstein, *Mysticism and Philosophy in Al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra, Ibn al-'Arabī and the Ismā'īlī Tradition* (Leiden: Brill, 2014).

3 See Michael Ebstein, "'In Truth You Are the Polytheist!': Mythic Elements in Ibn al-'Arabī's Teachings on the Divine Names," *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 6/3 (May 30, 2018): 359–387; "God-Perfecting Man: Theurgical Elements in the Mysticism of Muḥyi l-Dīn Ibn al-'Arabī (560/1165–638/1240) and Their Historical Significance," in *Religions* 16/2 (2025): 234, <https://doi.org/10.3390/rel16020234>. In the later Islamic context, the scope of this study is mainly limited to the School of Ibn 'Arabī (d. 1240). However, I am also aware that the legacy of Illuminationist

same period.⁴ And yet, we remain without any focused scholarly investigation into whether or to what extent this distinctly late medieval, theurgic conception of Muslim religious practice was reflected across other areas of life beyond elite learning, or otherwise considering its possible significance for the history of mentalities and Islamic society more broadly.

It is within this context that the present study situates the writings of ‘Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī (d. 1329), a major Sufi authority and polymath linked with the first three Muslim imperial courts of Mongol Iran, all of which saw major transformations in Islamic culture and society.⁵ A prolific author who wrote for a range of audiences, Kāshānī has been credited with systematically developing the visionary teachings of the Andalusian sage Muḥyī al-Dīn ibn ‘Arabī (d. 1240) into a “Sufi orthodoxy”⁶ whose circulation would reach from Islam’s central lands to the Indo-Malay world and across sectarian boundaries, well into modern times. This study is intended to show how even Kāshānī’s vernacular, moralistic writings which were geared toward a popular audience exemplified the broader intellectual shift going on around him from a largely Aristotelian discourse to one dominated by a synthesis of Sufi ethical teachings and the emanationism of antiquity. On that basis, I argue that both Kāshānī’s thought, and the form of Islamic practice it prescribes, are best described as “theurgic.” Yet, I further show how for Kāshānī this vision

thought, following the teachings of Shihāb al-Dīn Yaḥyā Suhrawardī (d. 1191) may merit attention as representing a similar development. See below, no. 30.

4 Ahmet Karamustafa has described this era in Islamic religious culture in terms of “sainthood triumphant,” in his *Sufism: The Formative Period* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007). This state of affairs, in which Sufis were viewed as ideal religious authorities while also wielding real political power and entrenched social influence well into the modern colonial encounter, is also neatly encapsulated in Nile Green’s assessment, “Sufism was Islam” throughout the late pre-modern context. Nile Green, *Sufism: A Global History* (Malden: Wiley-Blackwell, 2016), 126.

5 For an overview of Kāshānī’s life and works in English, see Pierre Lory, “‘Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī,” in *Encyclopaedia of Islam Three*. A more detailed look including sources for his writings and overview of some key themes can be found in chapter 1 of Ismail Lala, *Knowing God: Ibn ‘Arabī and ‘Abd al-Razzāq al-Qāshānī’s Metaphysics of the Divine* (Leiden: Brill, 2019), 17–57. For a more exhaustive account of Kāshānī’s life, works, and historical context, see Necmettin Ergül, “Abdurrezzāk Kāshānī (ö.730/1330)’nin Hayatı, İlmi-Tasavvufi Kişiliği ve Eserleri,” *Bürey ve Toplum* 3/5 (2013): 93–125, and above all Majid Hādizādah, editor’s introduction to ‘Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī, *Majmū‘ah-yi rasā’il wa muṣannafāt*, (Tehran: Mirāth-i Maktūb, 2000). The works of Kāshānī translated into European languages are his *Risāla fī al-qadā’ wa-al-qadar*, available in French as *Traité sur la prédestination et le libre arbitre*, ed. Stanislas Guyard, trans. Michel Allard (Paris: Éditions Orientales, 1978), and his *Ta’wīlāt al-Qur’ān*, available in English as *A Sufi Commentary on the Qur’an: Ta’wīlāt al-Qur’ān*, vol. 1 trans. Feras Hamza, vol. 2 trans. Khalid Williams (Cambridge: The Islamic Texts Society, 2021-22).

6 Lory, “‘Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī.”

extended well beyond the private esoteric practices of ritual specialists, to which existing comparisons of Islam (and Judaism) with theurgy have been limited. At the same time, because of the equivalencies it posits between God's reality, the Good as such, and the substance of the divine emanation of virtue to which Muslims sought access through religious observance, this understanding of practice retained an indelible ethical dimension also largely absent from these topics' handling in the scholarship. Finally, because of the breadth of Kāshānī's audience and reception, I consider his formulation of Islam as a theurgy of virtues to be a valuable source of insight into the rise of Shi'ism in Iran. Through a lens that is at once vernacular and deeply rooted in "high" traditions of Islamic learning and religious culture, Kāshānī's thought suggests a view of sectarian difference and ethical universality not as opposed, but logically interrelated.

To begin, I make my argument by showing a surprisingly robust theoretical basis for the particular, concrete forms of pious conduct through which Kāshānī exhorted even his lay readers to seek emanation (*fayḍ*) from God, precisely in a philosophical position of his on an issue that could hardly seem more abstract: the existence of universals (*kullīyyāt*).⁷ While Kāshānī's contribution to the latter topic was soon forgotten in Islamic intellectual traditions while also going completely overlooked in their academic study, it was not only exemplary of major ongoing transformations in his broader intellectual environment, but also key to his ethical vision and account of where the practices of his broader religious culture derived their efficacy. In Kāshānī's worldview, the goals of a range

7 On emanationism in Sufi thought, see Michael Ebstein, "Emanation (*Fayḍ*) in Classical Islamic Mysticism," in *Handbook of Sufi Studies, Volume 2: Sufi Cosmology*, ed. Christian Lange and Alexander Knysh (Leiden: Brill, 2022), 299–331. On the problem of universals in Arabic and Islamic philosophy, see Michael E. Marmura, "Avicenna's Chapter on Universals in the *Isagoge* of His *Shifā'*," in *Islam: Past Influence and Present Challenge*, ed. Alford T. Welch and Pierre Cachia (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1979), 34–56; Muhammad U. Faruque, "Mullā Ṣadrā on the Problem of Natural Universals," *Arabic Sciences and Philosophy* 27/2 (2017): 269–302; Wahid M. Amin, "Qutb Al-Din al-Razi and the Problem of Universals: A Fourteenth-Century Critique of Avicenna's Theory of Natural Universals," *Nazariyat* 5/2 (2019): 25–58; İbrahim Halil Üçer, "Realism Transformed: The Ontology of Universals in Avicennan Philosophy and Qutb al-Din al-Rāzī's Theory of Mental Exemplars," *Nazariyat* 6/2 (November 15, 2020): 23–68; and now Peter Adamson and Fedor Benevich, "Universals," in *The Heirs of Avicenna: Philosophy in the Islamic East, 12–13th Centuries* (Leiden: Brill, 2024), 189–256. The only focused investigation of Sufi approaches to this topic, a tradition in which Kāshānī occupies an important place that has, however, still gone unexamined, see Justin Cancelliere, "Traversing the Barzakh: The Problem of Universals in Islamic Philosophy and Theoretical Sufism" (MA Thesis, University of Georgia, 2019). I have previously shown the theoretical importance of universals' existence prior to their particulars for applied Sufi practice in "Nearness to the Real: Sainthood as Ontological Proximity in the Thought of Dāwūd al-Qaysārī," *Journal of Sufi Studies* 11/1 (2022): 1–44.

of observances including obligatory and voluntary prayers, general moral self-cultivation, and even practices of saint veneration typically branded in scholarship as “popular,” were all made tangible by giving the universals that were their ethical content extramental existence in the substance of divine emanations. Through a kind of sympathy, religious practices attracted this emanation by embodying in particular actions the universals that characterized it, variously identified with divine attributes (*ṣifāt*), perfections (*kamālāt*), virtues (*faḍā'il*), or even moral beauties (*maḥāsin*). The resulting, highly explanatory view of Islamic practice Kāshānī espoused thus bears an undeniable structural resemblance to Hellenic theurgy, as theorized by the Neoplatonist Iamblichus’ application of similar Platonic and Pythagorean ideas to Greek rites. At the same time, even Kāshānī’s argument for an extramental existence of universals that informed his own theurgic view of religious practice can itself be traced to the Arabic-Islamic reception for precisely the more “esoteric” areas of Greek thought to which Iamblichan theurgy in turn belonged, and which were enjoying a resurgence in post-classical Islam after a period of early neglect due to the difficulty of harmonizing them with the strict rationalism prevalent in the early translation movements.

For this combination of descriptive and historical reasons, then, the present article characterizes Kāshānī’s vision of not only certain specialized Sufi rites, but the entirety of Islamic practice, as a form of theurgy meant to attract God’s emanation, whose substance was also virtue. Meanwhile, to the extent that Kāshānī’s teachings are fairly representative of his broader society, this case study further suggests that theurgy as a descriptive category may provide a key for interpreting other aspects of later Islamic history, including swaths of its piety and religious culture that have so far eluded satisfactory classification in such binary terms frequently cluttering the study of Islam as high/popular, theoretical/applied, or intellectual/embodied. To illustrate, my exploration of Kāshānī’s teachings concludes by noting some of their implications for sectarian difference, which was notably more flexible during his time than the centuries to follow. Here, Kāshānī’s vision of Islam as a theurgy of virtues effectively recast Sunni-Shi’a difference as a question of positioning oneself most appropriately to receive divine emanation through the intermediaries of certain holy people, chief among them Muhammad and his family. Yet, despite this apparently non-polemical basis, the application of Kāshānī’s emanationist ethics to Shi’ism also proved entirely consistent with its subsequent sectarian expression in the form we recognize today. Here, viewed through the lens of Kāshānī’s teachings, the rise of Shi’ism in Iran becomes ethically legible as a mode of seeking theurgic participation in the divine emanation of virtues that depends on recognizing the exclusivity and primacy of their em-

bodiment in certain individuals – or put another way, an appearance of the universal in the particular.

2 The Existence of Universals from Late Antiquity to Early Islamic Thought

The locus classicus for the so-called “problem of universals” is arguably found in the *Isagoge* of Porphyry (d. 305 CE), his “introduction” to the *Organon*, Aristotle’s classic on logic. Here, Porphyry endeavors to clarify the definitions and correct use of such logical terms as “genus” and “species” (i.e. universals) though without delving into their ontology. He opens this discussion with the famous proviso that:

“For example, about genera and species—whether they subsist, whether they actually depend on bare thoughts alone, whether if they actually subsist they are bodies or incorporeal and whether they are separable or are in perceptible items and subsist about them—these matters I shall decline to discuss, such a subject being very deep and demanding another and a larger investigation.”⁸

As is well known in the history of European philosophy, universals were widely held in Latin thought to have a kind of existence, a position known as realism, until the late Middle Ages, when the view that they are simply mental constructs with no external existence, known as nominalism, gradually began to take precedence. By contrast to this well-documented history, the development of the same question in Islamic contexts, though an extensive and sophisticated legacy, received little comprehensive attention in secondary scholarship until quite recently.⁹ The extent of the scholarship, however, has shown that “realism” of some kind generally prevailed in Arabic and Islamic philosophy. Though the details of this view were frequently debated, the nature and extent of existence generally thought possible for universals in mainstream philosophical thought was neatly embodied in Avicenna, who held for example that the genus “animal” does indeed exist in the world independently of the mind, but is never encountered outside of individual animals.¹⁰

⁸ Porphyry, *Introduction*, ed. Jonathan Barnes (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), 1.

⁹ See above, no. 6.

¹⁰ Avicenna, *The Metaphysics of the Healing*, trans. Michael E. Marmura (Provo: Brigham Young University Press, 2005), 5.1, 26. See also discussion in Faruque, “Mullā Ṣadrā,” 274–288. Here we should note that the specific sense of universal (*kullī*) intended here, and for which alone main-

This particular intellectual genealogy to which Avicenna belonged, however, was only one branch of the Arabic-Islamic reception of Greek thought, namely the philosophical, peripatetic one – which, despite viewing Aristotle as an authority, did also incorporate extensive Neoplatonic material viewing the two schools of thought as one tradition, including Porphyry. But indeed, there also existed in Islamic history a more “esoteric” reception, less well-known but of equal antiquity, for Greek sources less conducive to rational exposition, such as Pythagorean and Hermetic thought, and that also incorporated Neoplatonic thought, but without giving the rational faculty the same pride of place as the peripatetics. From this intellectual lineage, which given its association with Isma‘ilism was generally more secretive and diffuse in its textual production, the earliest and most seminal works that survive belong to the 9th c. CE. Basran group known as the Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-ṣafā*), who articulate their own view on the dilemma that Porphyry left open ended.¹¹

In their direct discussion of the *Isagoge*, the Brethren acknowledge that what they call the “six terms” of logic (i.e. genus, species, individual, differentium, property, and accident) are, in one sense, only “terms (*alfāz*) that the philosophers employ in their utterances and allusions to the meanings that are in human thought,” whose correct usage they proceed to define.¹² And while this alone

stream Arabic-Islamic philosophy entertained the possibility of extramental existence, is the “natural universal” (*kullī ṭabī‘ī*), a concept Avicenna originated. This was contrasted with the “mental universal” (*kullī ‘aqlī*), which referred to the abstracted concept of a universal quality, and the “logical universal” (*kullī mantiqī*) which referred to the concept of universality itself, both of which Avicenna and the wider tradition denied any ontological status. For an in-depth discussion of these types, see Marmura, “Avicenna’s Chapter on Universals.”

¹¹ On the Brethren of Purity, see Seyyed Hossein Nasr, *An Introduction to Islamic Cosmological Doctrines: Conceptions of Nature and Methods Used for its Study by the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, al-Bīrūnī, and Ibn Sīnā* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1993); Ian Richard Netton, *Muslim Neoplatonists: An Introduction to the Thought of the Brethren of Purity* (London: Routledge, 2016). I have also benefited greatly from consulting a recent unpublished dissertation that explores in new depth the range of Hellenistic ideas present in the thought of the Brethren, graciously shared by its author, Syed Zaidi, “Hermeticism and the Treatises of the Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’*)” (PhD Thesis, Emory University, 2023). Incidentally, the Brethren’s reception in both later Sufism and Judaic thought make Ibn ‘Arabī’s school and Kāshānī’s tradition within it meaningful cognates for the more local but contemporary phenomenon of “Jewish Ismailism” in Yemen and its “philosophical mysticism.” See: e.g. Ronald C. Kiener, “Jewish Ismā‘īlism in Twelfth Century Yemen: R. Nethanel Ben al-Fayyūmī,” *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 74/3 (1984): 249–266; David R. Blumenthal, “An Illustration of the Concept of ‘Philosophic Mysticism’ from Fifteenth Century Yemen,” in *Hommages à Georges Vajda*, ed. Gérard Nahon and Charles Touati (Louvain: Peeters, 1980).

¹² *Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, Rasā’il Ikhwān Al-Ṣafā’* (Beirut: al-Dār al-Islāmiyya, 1992), 1:395.

might seem to set the stage for a conventional or even nominalist position on the ontological status of these terms' referents, the Brethren proceed to draw a distinction between the forgoing discussion as merely "verbal logic" (*al-mantiq al-laḥẓī*) and something they call "intellectual logic" (*al-mantiq al-fikrī*). That latter is the origin or principle (*aṣl*) of the former, whose "terms are only marks (*simāt*) that refer to the meanings that are in the thoughts of souls." Intellectual logic, however, deals with these meanings themselves, which are not abstractions or creations of the mind, but the forms (*ṣuwar*) of things themselves as they are emanated through a cosmic hierarchy from God to the First Intellect, followed by the Universal Soul, eventually giving form to matter resulting in individual bodies, which are the last intermediary by which this emanation finally reaches "particular human souls" to inform their thoughts.¹³ Clearly, then, there is no meaningful difference in this schema between mental existence and extramental existence, though we do see in the superficial, partial character of "verbal logic" a counterpart to the former's diminished status. At the same time, here even a spurious figure of speech or thought inaccurate in its relation to the "objective" world would still be reducible to a confused mixing or incomplete apprehension of mental contents whose basic components, ultimately, are still the forms of things as they are, projected into the sensory world in an uninterrupted emanation from the highest levels of reality.¹⁴

Now, while these points themselves leave unresolved the question of whether universals *qua* "forms" or "meanings" have any kind of existence independent of particular things, elsewhere the Brethren write that the Universal Soul should be thought of "like the primary genus," and its division according to different forms

13 Ibid., 1:398. Here it is ambiguous if the terms of "verbal logic" the Brethren are dismissing would map onto mental universals (e.g. the concept of animality), logical universals (e.g. the terms genus, species, etc. themselves), or include both. At any rate, by introducing the concept of "intellectual logic" they appear to have been pursuing in their own way a move analogous to Avicenna's "natural universal" by seeking to articulate a sense of universal natures themselves unbound by any given mode of existence.

14 Though at the nadir of this hierarchy, human beings are in the unique position of being capable, in principle, of learning directly from the universal soul, i.e. to take from it the emanations that shape the material world rather than receive these forms from that world secondhand and piecemeal, as it were. To escape the constraints of particularity in this way however is only possible with the aid of those knowers (*ʿallāma*, pl. *ʿulamā*) in greater proximity to the Universal Soul, in whom this potential (*quwwa*) is already actualized (*bi-al-fīl*). Ibid., 1:399. For the Brethren, this seems likely an allusion to functionaries in an Ismaʿili pedagogical and religious hierarchy (given especially their use of the verb *taʿlīm*), but it clearly anticipates similar formulations in later Sufi settings, as in the role of the spiritual master or shaykh. I have looked at the way Kāshānī's student Qayṣarī (d. 1350) considered the shaykh as a sort of gateway from the particular to the universal in "Nearness to the Real," esp. at 35–37.

into simple, composite and individual souls as primary and secondary species.¹⁵ The Brethren then go on to give the following account:

“Particular individual [souls] (. . .) are the ones specified to control individual bodies, and species souls (*al-anfus al-naw'iyya*) support them. Genus [souls] (*al-jinsiyya*) support the species [souls] (*al-naw'iyya*), simple souls support the genus [souls], the Universal Soul that is the Soul of the World supports the simple souls, the Universal Intellect supports the Universal Soul, and the Creator, exalted be His praise, supports the Universal Intellect.”¹⁶

This passage thus makes clear that for the Brethren, there are levels of reality or certain cosmic settings where universal forms or meanings can indeed be encountered inhering in substance, but apart from and prior to particulars, to whose existence they also have a causal relationship that goes beyond the simple kind of definitional or logical priority admitted by the peripatetics. This early stance of the Brethren on universals appears to have gone almost wholly overlooked both in modern scholarship and later, developed commentarial traditions—as has its transmission through Kāshānī, who adapted it to related discussions of the “Greatest Master” (*al-shaykh al-akbar*) himself, Ibn 'Arabī. However, despite its neglect, I will show that Kāshānī's position on the existence of universals had significant implications for how he envisioned the goal of human life, not simply in terms of a philosophical knowledge of things as they are, but a tangible, theurgic quest where this knowledge meant both receiving and ethically embodying divine emanations of virtue.

3 The Existence of Universals in the School of Ibn 'Arabī: Attributes, Perfections, Virtues

The imprint of the Brethren's worldview on the thought of Ibn 'Arabī and his commentators is unmistakable, though the exact nature and means of their different ideas' adoption in such later figures has only been minimally investi-

¹⁵ Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', *Rasā'il*, 3:216. Here, the Brethren stop short of identifying the two completely presumably to avoid confusion between the World Soul and the logical universal of the genus itself or a comparable construct, which would either risk the impression of reducing the World Soul to an abstraction, or exaggerating the ontological status of precisely the abstractions of “verbal logic” that the Brethren wish to transcend.

¹⁶ Ibid. The compatibility of this schema with the school of Ibn 'Arabī has been pointed out by Mukhtar H. Ali, whose translation of this passage I consulted and alerted me to its existence in *The Horizons of Being: The Metaphysics of Ibn al-'Arabī in the Muqaddimat al-Qayṣarī* (Leiden: Brill, 2020), 133, no. 1.

gated.¹⁷ One place this connection is particularly clear, however, is on the topic of universals, whose status for the Brethren as Platonic forms or ideas the school of Ibn 'Arabī instead transformed into its understanding of divine attributes, as well as their reflections in the perfections (*kamālāt*) of creation, including even human virtues (*ḡaḡā'il*) specifically. To begin with, Ibn 'Arabī himself gives some terse but consequential remarks on the topic in his widely read and commented-upon visionary treatise *The Ringstones of Wisdom* (*Fuṣūṣ al-hikam*), where he writes that universals (*umūr kullīyya*), “though not possessing existence in themselves (. . .) have determination (*ḡukm*) and effect (*athar*) over whatever has external existence. Indeed, [the latter] is identical with [the former] – I mean the external existents [are identical with universals].”¹⁸ Ibn 'Arabī's remark here that universals do not possess existence themselves, as well as his reference to their identity with external existents, are clearly nods to the peripatetic account that makes their external existence impossible without individuals in which to inhere. However, his phrasing is also deceptive, in that existence (*wujūd*) for Ibn 'Arabī is a sole reality identical with God's essence. That is, on Ibn 'Arabī's account, nothing at all but God can really be said to exist, and “external existents” or things coming into existence are only figurative ways of referring to how God causes the forms in His infinite self-knowledge to appear outwardly in an existence that is equally and absolutely His.

Now in the long run, the result of this view in later philosophical adaptations of Ibn 'Arabī's thought was for the status of universals to become decidedly fixed as only “accidental” (*'araḡī*) in relation to *wujūd*, as in the major synthesis of

17 The most important work to this end remains Ebstein, *Mysticism and Philosophy in Al-Andalus*. However, the imprint of the Brethren's cosmology, including its Hermetic elements, on e.g. Ibn 'Arabī's disciple and stepson Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnawī (d. 1274) has been noted in Richard Todd, *The Sufi Doctrine of Man: Ṣadr al-Dīn al-Qūnawī's Metaphysical Anthropology* (Leiden: Brill, 2014), esp. at 4–5, 60–79. The (neo-)Pythagoreanism of the Brethren can elsewhere be glimpsed in how Kāshānī's student Qayṣarī compares the relation of God to creation with the relationship between the number one and all other numbers, e.g. in *Er-Resā'il* (Kayseri: Kayseri Büyükşehir Belediyesi Kültür Yayınları), ed. Mehmet Bayrakdar, 114. Kāshānī, for his part, also follows the Brethren's general cosmology, and even in one treatise examined below (see no. 61) refers to his readers as “the Brethren of Purity and Lords of Fidelity” (*ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-arbāb al-wafā'*). This is a remarkable precedent for the same term of address lending one 15th c. group its name in modern scholarship as the “neo-Ikhwān al-Ṣafā,” explored in İlker Evrim Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks in Timurid Iran, Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī and the Islamic Republic of Letters* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016).

18 Ibn 'Arabī, *Fuṣūṣ al-hikam*, ed. Abul Ela Afifi (Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-'Arabīyya, 1966), 51. Translation has been modified from Caner Dagli, *The Ringstones of Wisdom* (Chicago: Kazi Publications, 2004), 20.

Mullā Ṣadrā (d. 1641).¹⁹ But at the same time, closer examination will show that a more immediate consequence of Ibn ‘Arabī’s position, at least in Kāshānī’s hands, was to admit levels of cosmic existence where the manifestation of universals preceded their appearance in particulars, and could thus be sought as modes of divine emanation. Altogether, this was a view that closely matched the Brethren’s view of the world as a single substance populated by different forms. So the issue of the “existence” of universals is in both settings more a question of if and in what ways universal forms (for Ibn ‘Arabī here, e.g. life, knowledge, humanness) appear in the world prior to and independent of individual things, as in the Brethren’s discussion of species and genera as levels of the Universal Substance or World Soul. In this way, universals envisioned strictly as qualities or forms rather than existents could certainly be the content of God’s emanation. But when further developed among commentators like Kāshānī, “universals” also come to refer clearly to the levels of substance in which these forms first appear. Ibn ‘Arabī’s open-ended reference to “universal things” can thus serve to denote, in addition to simply the forms conveyed by God’s emanations to creation as accidents, the very substance of these emanations when so qualified by them, and thus also the more universal kinds of substance out of which particulars are formed.²⁰ Accordingly, in Kāshānī’s commentary on Ibn ‘Arabī’s discussion of universals in the *Fuṣūṣ*, he writes that:

The dependence of every individual existent returns to these universal existents (*al-mawjūdāt al-kullīyya*) forever, notwithstanding their abiding in the World of the Intellect by virtue of their universality. They never cease from that unseen existence. This is all to say that the external is existent within [the unseen].²¹

Here, Kāshānī harmonizes the Brethren’s view with the peripatetic stance by adeptly glossing Ibn ‘Arabī’s denial of external (*‘aynī*) existence for universals in apparent agreement with the philosophers, as actually referring only to corporeal, visible existence, while envisioning the latter as inhering in the universal, rather than the reverse. At the same time, the “mental” (*‘aqlī*) existence to which

¹⁹ This has in part to do with the controversy over whether a thing’s quiddity (*māhiyya*) or existence (*wujūd*) has priority as the reality of a thing. Because Avicenna’s natural universals were identical with quiddities as such, the establishment of *wujūd* as primary against this philosophical backdrop necessarily meant an overall deemphasis of the status of natural universals. See Faruque, “Mullā Ṣadrā,” 301.

²⁰ I have examined these different perspectives in detail as formulated by Kāshānī’s main student, Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī (see below), in Schechter, “Nearness to the Real”.

²¹ ‘Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī, *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, ed. Majīd Hādizādah (Tehran: Anjuman-i Āthār wa Mafākhir-i Farhangī, 2005), 101.

philosophers relegate universals conceived as disengaged from their particulars Kāshānī here makes refer to the World of the Intellect as a kind of transcendent, macrocosmic realm on which lower worlds depend, as seen in the Brethren.²² Re-stated in some of the terminology for which Ibn ‘Arabī and his school are better known, Kāshānī here is referring to the way God’s attributes, after becoming objects of His self-knowledge in every conceivable combination and yielding the forms of all possible things before the act of creation, “descend” from God into external existence, beginning with the archangelic world (*jabarūt*). We can compare Kāshānī’s account and the place of universals in it with the statements of his student Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī (d. 1351). Because “divine attributes are nothing but universal meanings emanating from the Essence,” Qayṣarī would write that “it is necessary for the universal meanings to permeate and descend to all the degrees of existence from their original degree (. . .) do you not see how the universal meanings descend and become particular?”²³ Elsewhere, Qayṣarī would likewise affirm that “the particular is the universal, descended from its original station.”²⁴

Given the equivalency of universals with divine attributes, we can indeed take “life” or “knowledge,” as Ibn ‘Arabī mentioned, for examples of the universal forms that God’s emanation to creation initially takes. However, it is clear that the forms, ideas, or quiddities of created things being emanated into creation also belong under this heading, as Ibn ‘Arabī alludes to with the example of “human-ness” (*insāniyya*).²⁵ Now, logical objections may well seem bound to arise from this way of attributing substantive existence, somewhere in the cosmos, to all manner of such “universals,” while simultaneously expanding the definition of this term in a seemingly indeterminate way. Indeed, this is probably why Kāshānī and Qayṣarī’s interpretation of Ibn ‘Arabī as speaking of independent “universal existents” did not survive the major synthesis of Mullā Ṣadrā. Yet, even with Kāshānī and Qayṣarī’s goal of standardizing Ibn ‘Arabī’s teachings, it would be a mistake to judge them by the standards of a more complete philosophical system like

22 Tracing Ibn ‘Arabī’s reception of this point of cosmology to the Brethren specifically, see Richard Todd, *The Sufi Doctrine of Man*, 66.

23 Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī, *Kashf al-ḥijāb ‘an kalām Rabb al-arbāb*, in *Er-Resāil*, 97–98.

24 Qayṣarī, *Asās al-wahdāniyya*, in *ibid.*, 159.

25 A succinct overview of these equivalencies can be found in Qayṣarī’s “Prolegomenon” (*Muqaddimat*) which remains an introductory text to Ibn ‘Arabī’s metaphysics in Iranian seminary education until today. See Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī, *The Horizons of Being: The Metaphysics of Ibn al-‘Arabī in the Muqaddimat al-Qayṣarī*, ed. Mukhtar H. Ali (Leiden: Brill, 2020), 92–93. In an interesting move, Qayṣarī also holds that individual forms are in fact present at these higher levels of reality, only “hidden” (*bāṭin*) in their universals. This gives a sense in which the peripatetic view that universals are never truly disengaged (*mujarrad*) of their particulars receives direct accommodation.

Şadrā arguably achieved. Rather, their ultimate aim even in engaging philosophical discourse was always a Sufi pedagogical one, which was not simply to train the individual intellect in the proper exercise of reason, but to support adepts in disciplines of spiritual wayfaring aimed at purifying and transforming the human soul into its primordial state, which is both a reflection of every name and attribute of God, as well as a microcosm (*‘ālam ṣaghīr*) containing all possible forms and perfections of God’s creatures—which are, after all, themselves only privative reflections of divine characteristics.

Seen in this way, the Sufi goals of the Ibn ‘Arabī school correspond quite neatly to what the Brethren called “intellectual logic,” that is the proper establishment in the human soul of the meanings (*ma‘ānī*) or forms of all things as they really are. Philosophy (*falsafa*), meanwhile, to the extent that either group was concerned with it, dealt only in a derivative practice of “verbal logic,” which could serve to indicate or point to (*dalla*) the forms and facilitate coherent communication about them, to a point.²⁶ However, the utility and scope of this discipline was necessarily limited for both groups, subordinate to the goal of a tangible connection to the emanations of more universal levels of reality that had to be established through the aid of human intermediaries in conjunction with different ascetic and contemplative practices. The study of arithmetic, logic, natural philosophy and related disciplines was certainly preparatory for deeper spiritual insight, and for the Brethren as well as later figures like Şadrā may have risen to the level of a necessity. However, placed in this broader cosmic context it is clear that such training alone was not an end in itself, nor alone sufficient to reaching the highest good and goal of human life.

Altogether, admitting a certain independent existence for universals made this goal of human life for Kāshānī significantly more tangible – in a sense, making the meaning of life itself a substance to be assimilated. And yet, there was also a definite fashion, rhyming with Avicenna, in which encountering the universal for Kāshānī would still remain inseparable from the particular, in the form of specific religious practices – beginning with, and never excluding, the body and individual consciousness; but also penetrating the depths of the soul to grad-

²⁶ It does not seem self-evidently absurd to suggest that, despite being simpler and presumably fewer in number than particular things, really existing species and genera could still outnumber or exceed the possibilities of human language, to say nothing of their numerous, untold subdivisions and apparent modes of overlap or combination that both the Brethren and Ibn ‘Arabī school seem to envision. For the latter, especially, such a conclusion is really inescapable, since the divine names to which each corresponds an attribute (i.e. universal) are themselves unlimited in number, and with each, furthermore, containing every other name, but in different modalities.

ually transform it into a more universal substance. It is from this standpoint that Ibn ‘Arabī’s commentators further equated the universals or divine attributes that the individual soul seeks through emanation from God specifically with virtues or perfections, whose embodiment established a sympathetic relationship with the divine that was the basis of ritual action. More in-depth examination of these points in connection with the specific pedagogical objectives and cosmological framework in which this Sufi pursuit was situated will help us appreciate why Kāshānī’s “theurgy” was both inseparable from an ethical framework, and extended well into his prescriptions and understandings of lay and “popular” practice – both characteristics largely absent from established discussions of theurgy in the scholarship. At the same time, it is with same impossibility of ever fully separating the universal from the particular that we will ultimately see Kāshānī’s emanationist ethics go on to color his account of Shi’ism as well, as it relates to the Imams as the sole complete embodiments after Muhammad of universal attributes of perfection.

4 Theurgy and “Emanationist Ethics” from Late Antiquity to Medieval Islam

Theurgy (Gr. *theourgía*), literally meaning “divine action,” is a concept developed by the Neoplatonic philosopher and student of Porphyry, Iamblichus (d. 325 CE), which employed concepts of sympathy and connectivity between the worldly and divine realms to explain the efficacy of various cultic rites, divinatory practices and initiations in the Greco-Roman world. The idea was a major part of Iamblichus’ subsequent popularity among later Neoplatonists and even won the approval of the emperor Julian in his efforts to restore Greco-Roman paganism.²⁷ As for an Islamic reception, while no Arabic translations of Iamblichus’ major works are attested, the Neoplatonic cosmology that made his explanatory account of pagan ritual possible is another story, with both his teacher Porphyry and avid reader Proclus translated and studied extensively in Arabic, among other related figures and sources.²⁸ While the peripatetic reception of Neoplatonism in Islam firmly rationalized this cosmology, falling largely silent on either “mystical”

²⁷ Gregory Shaw, *Theurgy and the Soul: The Neoplatonism of Iamblichus* (University Park: Penn State University Press, 1995).

²⁸ However, cf. Hans Daiber, “Neuplatonische Pythagorica in Arabischem Gewande – Der Kommentar des Iamblichus Zu den Carmina Aurea,” in *From the Greeks to the Arabs and Beyond, Volume I: Graeco-Syriaca and Arabica* (Leiden: Brill, 2021), 536–635.

modes of knowledge or the question of ritual action, the Brethren of Purity again stand out as having preserved these aspects of the Neoplatonic, as well as Neopythagorean and Hermetic legacies in their writing.

Though they do not cite Iamblichus directly, the Brethren give some historical accounts of Greek pagan rituals and their associated cosmology. They even compare the reported rites of the “Sabians” of Harran, which they construe as “philosophical,” with major Islamic rites, such as breaking the fast or the Eid sacrifice.²⁹ However, the areas of their writings with the most enduring reception that can be considered “theurgic” deal specifically with such branches of knowledge as the science of letters, talismans, magic, or angelology.³⁰ It is to such private, “esoteric” disciplines that direct comparative study of Islamic practice and theurgy has been limited—analogue to the treatment of Kabbalah in Judaism. Discussions of a potential public or popular aspect to “theurgy” in Islam are, to my knowledge, non-existent, as are investigations into its ethical dimension. The present investigation of Kāshānī, however, leads us in precisely these directions.

Much remains historically obscure about the status and circulation of such sciences before the late medieval period of Islam’s history (12th–15th c. CE), when both Sufism and esoteric disciplines of all kinds began to enjoy greater public visibility and popularity. And though the occultist and scholar of lettrism Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. 1225 or 1232–3) certainly deserves recognition as a foundational figure for this period, the most influential religious authority by far to propound a recognizably theurgic account of Islamic practice remains none other than Ibn ‘Arabī himself.³¹ Specifically, this has to do with how his heavily Neoplatonic–Pythagorean cosmology and mystical theology of God’s names animated Ibn ‘Arabī’s under-

29 Janne Mattila, “The Philosophical Worship of the Ikhwān Al-Ṣafā,” *Journal of Islamic Studies* 27/1 (2015): 1–23.

30 See introduction to Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, *On Magic I: An Arabic Critical Edition and English Translation of Epistle 52a*, ed. Godefroid de Callataÿ and Bruno Halflants (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012). However, note that notwithstanding the Brethren’s wide reception, the designations “magic” (*siḥr*) and “magician” (*sāḥir*) themselves soon became and remained largely polemical accusations for most of Islam’s history. For an account of this transformation, see Saif, “From *Ġāyat al-ḥakīm* to *Šams al-ma’ārif*.”

31 For a compelling construal of Būnī’s work as theurgy that does not, however, historicize this choice of translation, there is John D. Martin, “Theurgy in the Medieval Islamic World: Conceptions of Cosmology in al-Būnī’s Doctrine of the Divine Names” (MA Thesis, The American University in Cairo, 2011). For Būnī’s work and reception, see Noah Gardiner, “Forbidden Knowledge? Notes on the Production, Transmission, and Reception of the Major Works of Aḥmad al-Būnī,” *Journal of Arabic and Islamic Studies* 12 (2012): 81–143. For Ibn ‘Arabī and theurgy, see Ebstein, “In Truth, You are the Polytheist!” and “God-Perfecting Man.” There is also the case of the infamously executed Sufi philosopher Shihāb al-Dīn Yaḥyā Suhrawardī (d. 1191), whom John Walbridge has argued persuasively for viewing as deliberately carrying on key intellectual and reli-

standing of Islamic rites of worship and Sufi practices, which center precisely on the recitation of God's own names and speech. Here, Michael Ebstein has made the important observation, paralleling Moshe Idel and Charles Mopsik on the Kabbalah, that Ibn 'Arabī's theurgic understanding of the power of God's names and their role in the efficacy of prayer seems to complicate, if not invert, ordinary religious understandings of human and divine agency.³² On this reading, it might even appear that for Ibn 'Arabī, God is somehow dependent on a spiritual elect that invokes Him to achieve His purpose in the cosmos, and that the prayers of that elect, through the sympathy they establish with God by invoking His names and attributes, in turn have the power to "actually [manipulate]" God.³³ The way Ibn 'Arabī and his readers attended to the possible ethical implications of such questions, however, has not received focused attention in scholarship—a point of all the more historical interest given Ibn 'Arabī's staggering influence throughout the Islamic world, which itself raises the further neglected question of what bearing or possible place such "esoteric" ideas themselves might have had in wider religious culture.

Kāshānī's writings, as it happens, are a perfect lens through which to approach such questions, as he was well aware of this possibility inherent in the reading of Ibn 'Arabī and even addresses the issue head-on in one of his better-known works, the wildly influential lexicon entitled *Terminology of the Sufis* (*Iṣṭilāḥāt al-ṣūfiyya*). In this work intended for a general readership, the two pertinent entries Kāshānī gives are entitled "the Secret of Lordship" and "the Secret of the Secret of Lordship." They read:

The Secret of Lordship is its dependence on the subject.³⁴ This is due to its being a relation necessitating two parties. One of these two parties is the subject, which is none other than the nonexistent Immutable Entities, and the one who depends upon the nonexistent is also

gious elements of Hellenism into an Islamic context, even though his work has largely been recognized only for its engagement with Zoroastrian themes. Though aspects of religious practice according to Suhrawardī might thus well deserve characterization as theurgic, such an assessment would depend on its own sweeping investigation of his thought and reception with this topic in view, on which Walbridge does not focus. Like Ibn 'Arabī, meanwhile, Suhrawardī's legacy has also been studied almost exclusively as intellectual history, with any hope to assess its bearing on wider Islamic practice a question demanding even further study. See John Walbridge, *The Leaven of the Ancients: Suhrawardi and the Heritage of the Greeks* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2000), with mentions of theurgy at 40, 54, and 264–265.

³² Ebstein, "In Truth You Are the Polytheist!," 375.

³³ This is the assessment of Ebstein, in "God-Perfecting Man," 13.

³⁴ Ar. *marbūb*, lit. "lorded over." The word has no connotations of subjectivity or individuality and is not intended this way as a translation choice.

nonexistent. This is why Sahl [al-Tustarī] said, 'lordship has a secret: if it manifested, lordship would perish.' That is because of the nothingness of that on which it depends.

The Secret of the Secret of Lordship is the manifestation of the Lord in the forms of the Entities. In respect of their being places of manifestation for the Lord who subsists by His Essence and manifests by His determinations, they therefore subsist by Him, exist with His existence, and are thus utterly dependent subjects in this respect, while the Real is their Lord. Thus, lordship is not actualized in reality except by the Real, while the Entities are nonexistent in their pre-eternal state. Therefore, the Secret of Lordship has a secret of its own by which it manifests and does not perish.³⁵

What is remarkable about Kāshānī's body of work is that, unlike Ibn 'Arabī, it deliberately lays out the latter's teachings to a general readership assuming no first-hand knowledge of the visionary states in which they were acquired. Indeed, rather than obscure the more controversial of Ibn 'Arabī's ideas, Kāshānī instead sought to develop a terminology to explicitly defend both the logical coherence, and compatibility with scripture and Islamic orthopraxy, of even their most startling claims. Thus, in the passages just cited, Kāshānī fully acknowledges the appearance in Ibn 'Arabī's teachings of a certain interdependence between humanity and divinity, but uses his credibility and authoritative command of Sufi terminology to insist that this apparent tension is itself simply a divinely ordained expression of God's inner nature, in fact a consequence of His very absoluteness that is resolved in the fact of His sole existence, leaving the standard legal and ethical prescriptions of Islam unchanged.³⁶ The resulting formulation was one of

35 'Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī, *Iṣṭilāḥāt al-sūfiyya*, ed. 'Abd al-Āl Shāhīn (Cairo: Dār al-Manār, 1992), 121–122. Modified from tr. Nabil Safwat, *A Glossary of Sufi Technical Terms*, ed. David Pendlebury (London: Octagon Press, 1991), 61. Notably, Ebstein's argument in "God-Perfecting Man," 13 relies on understanding these "Immutable Entities" (*ayān thābita*) as the means by which the human individual acts upon God. This is at variance with the standard reading of this teaching of Ibn 'Arabī, who makes clear in numerous instances alongside his commentators that the immutable entities themselves not only rely completely upon on God to achieve existence, but are in all their particularities that dictate the conditions of their earthly existence (and thus in a fashion God's role therein) still only a derivative consequence of God's Essence knowing itself, in the intradivine stage of manifestation called the "Holiest Emanation" (*al-fayḍ al-aqdas*). For the locus classicus of God's Holiest Emanation, see Ibn 'Arabī, *Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, 49; for commentary on the Entities and their origins therein see e.g. Kāshānī, *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, 89–92; Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī, *Horizons of Being*, 93–112.

36 Or, indeed, strengthened. Not to mention the fact that Ibn 'Arabī himself adhered to what is reputed to have been the strictest of all forms of Sunni jurisprudence, the now defunct "*ẓāhirī*" school, the so-called "Oneness of Being" proved to be remarkably compatible in the long run with the similarly exacting Hanbali school. This phenomenon was identified and examined extensively in Khaled El-Rouayheb, *Islamic Intellectual History in the Seventeenth Century: Scholarly Currents in the Ottoman Empire and the Maghreb* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015).

widespread and enduring popularity, the “Sufi orthodoxy” that Kāshānī is credited as spearheading and which prevailed throughout much of late medieval and early modern Islam.

As for the place of practice in this worldview, in a previous study I examined in detail the account that Kāshānī’s main student, Dāwūd al-Qayṣarī, gives of Sufi wayfaring and disciplines of the spiritual path. For Qayṣarī, the kind of emanationist cosmology common to late antiquity and esoteric currents from early to post-classical Islam makes every act of religious observance a means of increasing one’s sympathy with divine attributes, thus drawing down the emanations that transform the soul into an increasingly universal substance and facilitating its progressive ascent through a hierarchy of ontological states, while simultaneously fulfilling the cosmic role of the human being as a conduit for God’s emanation to the rest of creation.³⁷ Seen in this way, all the disciplines of Sufism are a form of theurgy *par excellence*. For both descriptive and historical reasons, then, this makes theurgy a better term for Sufi practice, at least in its late medieval context as seen through some of its leading authorities, than a range of other relevant, but only partly adequate terms like asceticism or mysticism.

At the same time, however, Sufism as theurgy has an immanent and inseparable ethical dimension owing to its emphasis on God as the Sovereign Good, and the contents of His emanations as not only universals, but precisely as modalities of the Good, or “perfections” (*kamālāt*).³⁸ In this schema, the paradox of an ethically problematic, or at least neutral character for theurgy is resolved by the fact that ritual actions, already depending on a sincere intention, increase the practitioner’s virtue when correctly and successfully performed, even as virtuous conduct and corresponding attitudes outside the recognizable scope of ritual function by the same token as a complementary means of drawing down divine emanation. Put another way, sympathetic correspondence between levels of reality in this formulation necessarily includes virtue.³⁹ And while this is exceptionally clear and undeniable in Sufi accounts of practice, the latter draw our attention to

37 Schechter, “Nearness to the Real,” esp. 32–43. I did not directly develop the role of “sympathy” (*munāsaba*) for Qayṣarī in this study, but for more on this point, see below, no. 39.

38 I examined how Qayṣarī established equivalency between perfections and Ibn ‘Arabī’s understanding of universals and divine attributes in Schechter, “Nearness to the Real,” 21–32. I was unaware at the time of Robert Wisnovsky’s detailed account of the term’s Aristotelian-Avicennan history given in his *Avicenna’s Metaphysics in Context* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2003). There also appears to be a remarkable parallel between the focus on this term in Sufi theurgy, and its central significance for the Kabbalah according to Moshe Idel, in his *Absorbing Perfections: Kabbalah and Interpretation* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002).

39 “Sympathy” here renders the Arabic *munāsaba* (Pr. *munāsabat*). In this choice I am following Paul Fenton, “Some Judaeo-Arabic Fragments by Rabbi Abraham he-Ḥasīd, the Jewish Sufi,” in

what has been perhaps a neglected, overlooked, or otherwise dismissed aspect original to Hellenic theurgy as well. Indeed, Iamblichus himself had chastised those who seek tangible benefits through selective and rote employment of particular symbols:

They disdain the order of the sacred observance, its holiness and long-protracted endurance of toils, and, rejecting the customs, prayers and other rituals, they believe the simple standing on the characters to be sufficient, and when they have done this for a mere hour, they believe that they have caused some spirit to enter. And yet how could anything noble or perfect result from this? Or how can the eternal and truly existing essence of the gods be united with ephemeral acts in sacred procedures? Hence, because of these things, such rash men go wholly astray, and are not worthy to be counted among diviners.⁴⁰

In a strikingly similar way, Ibn 'Arabī framed the esoteric discipline of the science of letters with numerous ethical provisos, noting that the spirits (*arwāh*) of letters are angels who alone guarantee the efficacy of ritual action ('amal), which cannot therefore be brought about by simple manipulation of their "bodies," i.e. the written, spoken or imagined forms of letters.⁴¹ On the other hand, Ibn 'Arabī notes that even accomplished saints can stray from doing God's will, while holding the deliberate "summoning" of letter spirits especially to be avoided.⁴² The commen-

Journal of Semitic Studies 26/1 (1981): 47–72. For "spiritual sympathy" (*munāsaba rūḥāniyya*), see 66, which Fenton actually glosses with reference to Kāshānī. Kāshānī gives an account of the different kinds of sympathy between God and humanity in *Iṣṭilāḥāt al-ṣūfiyya*, 109, and in greater detail in the more extensive lexicon, *Laṭā'if al-i'lām fī ishārāt ahl al-ilhām* (Cairo: Maṭba' Dār al-Kutub al-Miṣriyya bi-al-Qāhira, 1995), 2:339–340, likening the human relationship with God to that of a mirror for his attributes. While *munāsaba* also carries the more basic meaning of appropriateness, similarity or correspondence in attributes more generally, I find Fenton's translation (or "correspondence" understood Neoplatonically) suitable for most of its usage throughout writers like Kāshānī and Qayṣarī. This is because simply sharing in attributes, according to their worldview, unites things in a relationship I call "ontological proximity," which also connects particulars with the more universal levels of reality that transmit divine emanation to them. See Schechter, "Nearness to the Real," esp. 26. For further relevant usage of *munāsaba* in this connection, see e.g. Qayṣarī, *Horizons of Being*, 134–135, 154–155, 158–159; Kāshānī, *Majmū'ah rasā'il wa muṣannafāt*, 283, 330, 489, 504.

⁴⁰ Iamblichus, *De mysteriis*, trans. John Myles Dillon, Emma C. Clarke, and Jackson P. Hershbell (Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature, 2003), 151. I am grateful to Syed Zaidi for directing my attention to this reference.

⁴¹ Ibn 'Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* (Cairo: Būlāq, 1911), 2:448.

⁴² On the former point, Ibn 'Arabī mentions one Muhammad b. Qā'id who reportedly exercised the control over creation afforded to him by his sainthood but against God's will, for which see Michel Chodkiewicz, *Seal of the Saints: Prophethood and Sainthood in the Doctrine of Ibn 'Arabī* (Cambridge: Islamic Texts Society, 1993), 109. The development of this power, something Ibn 'Arabī himself discusses in some detail, also receives much-needed attention now with the study

tarial tradition, meanwhile, repeatedly reproduces Ibn 'Arabī's eschewal of turning Sufi practice toward worldly aims, considering the actual exercise of supernatural powers gained in the course of the spiritual path to be inconsistent with its final goal of perfect servanthood.⁴³ Thus, when read here according to the full combined accounts of their inseparable normative and cosmological frameworks, it is clear that Sufism and Hellenic theurgy both presupposed and were intended, at least in their formulation by religious authorities, to promote above all a kind

of Ismail Lala, "Turning Religious Experience into Reality: The Spiritual Power of *Himma*," *Religions* 14/3 (2023): 385. On the latter point, see Dunja Rasic, *The Written World of God: The Cosmic Script and the Art of Ibn 'Arabi* (Oxford: Anqa Publishing, 2022), 8.

43 E.g. Ibn 'Arabī indicates in the *Fuṣūṣ*, 127–129, that control (*taṣarruf*) of things in the world is a gift of gnostics (*ārifūn*) and prophets alike, but that the latter, and the highest among the saints, abstain from it, which is the ethically superior attitude. Cf. the commentary of the direct student of Ibn 'Arabī, 'Afīf al-Dīn al-Tilimsānī (d. 1291), *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* (Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-Ilmiyya, 2015), 199. Kāshānī expands on Ibn 'Arabī's view that the exercise of *taṣarruf* among the spiritually gifted is a sign of their knowledge of God still being incomplete, lacking the realization that simply because He has granted it to His friends does not negate the fact that control of creation is rightfully His alone. Kāshānī, *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, 324–327. However, it appears that such actions really exist on a broad spectrum. In taking the actual use of spiritual gifts acquired through Sufi disciplines as a sign of spiritual imperfection, Ibn 'Arabī and his commentators clearly mean the voluntary exercise of these powers, in contradistinction to those who are entrusted by God with certain cosmic functions (compare discussion in Chodkiewicz, 108–109). Meanwhile, Qayṣarī in the introduction to his commentary on the *Fuṣūṣ* mentions intriguingly that a range of individuals simply through exceptional strength of soul may work apparent miracles, whether a "successful believer" or "wicked sorcerer." Qayṣarī, *The Horizons of Being*, 234–237. Echoing these views, the early commentator also active in Anatolia, Mu'ayyad al-Dīn Jandī (d. ca. 1301) remarks that Pharoah's magicians (*saḥara*) in the Qur'an are an allegory for the "the egoic spirit" (*al-rūḥ al-naḥsānī*) ruling the "corporeal kingdom" (*al-mamlaka al-haykaliyya*) through the assimilation of the powers of natural and animal spirits. Jandī, *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, (Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-Ilmiyya, 2007), 555. In this connection, the first commentator from the Indian subcontinent, 'Alā al-Dīn Mahā'imī (d. 1431), acknowledges the outward similarity between the prophetic miracle (*mu'jiza*) and sorcery (*shu'ūdha*) while noting simply that the former issues from "the good soul connected to angels calling to the good" and the latter from "the wicked soul connected to devils," in his *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, (Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-Ilmiyya, 2007), 371. However, he also indicates that the subjugation (*taskhīr*) of nature by means of incantations (*azā'im*) is an activity of certain "[spiritual] men," i.e. Sufi saints (*al-rijāl*), wholly distinct from "magic," at 248. All the same, these methods, which still involve human will, effort, and a narrow scope, belong to a decisively lower rank than Solomon's subjugation (*taskhīr*) of the natural world which was comprehensive and originated directly in God's will and power, at 469. (My sincere thanks to Nariman Aavani for alerting me to Mahā'imī's commentary, as well as the discussions in Tilimsānī and Jandī.) Clear throughout is the ethical superiority of servanthood as the goal of human perfection, being essential (*dhātī*) to it, while in the advanced stages of its pursuit seekers may occasionally experience divine attribute of lordship manifest within their souls, but only as accidental (*araḍī*). Cf. Kāshānī, *Sharḥ*, 324–327.

of “emanationist ethics” whose objective is strengthening the sympathetic connection with a God or transcendent One who is not simply the source of being, but also always the Sovereign Good.⁴⁴

⁴⁴ Here I do not at all mean to give an idealized, overly normative account where Sufis eschewed the use of all “occult” means to achieve particular ends other than human salvation. This would be overlooking the reality of deep Sufi involvement in the vast body of sources on different occult disciplines (“strange sciences,” Ar. *al-ʿulūm al-gharība*) receiving serious attention for the first time in the growing field of Islamicate Occult Studies through the efforts of such pioneering scholars as Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, as well as Liana Saif already cited. Instead, my descriptive use of the category of theurgy, including the ethical entailments I propose, is meant to reflect precisely the ways in which Sufis *qua* religious establishment used their own normative frameworks to authorize a wide array of particular ways to engage the supernatural through ritual action. Here, then, to the extent that I am interested in arriving at a historically specific view of (late medieval) Islam as theurgy, I am taking definite inspiration from Melvin-Koushki’s remarkable formulation of “Islam as magic,” in his “How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,” *Journal of Persianate Studies* 1/2 (2018): 140–154. I am, however, also departing somewhat, for the philological reason that late medieval Muslims did not self-apply any term as polemically charged as “magic.” As Gardiner has observed, in “Forbidden Knowledge,” 130–131, probably no late medieval Muslim practitioner of occult sciences would have wished to be seen as practicing “sorcery” (*siḥr*), the best Arabic match for “magic,” while the overarching sense of pious duty and concern for the afterlife that formed the normative context for these sciences cannot be dismissed either (but on the historically contingent process by which *siḥr* became marginalized, paralleling the rise to prevalence of Sufi worldviews, see again Saif, “From *Ġāyat al-ḥakīm* to *Šams al-maʿārif*”). By contrast, I find “theurgy” to be a more promising candidate because, beyond its historical and descriptive connection to the Sufi cosmological understanding of ritual action, its normative assumptions not only capture the way Sufis authorized some methods of relating to the supernatural as virtuous, but also the particular ethical grounds on which they denigrated other ways of doing so (see e.g. previous note) – in a discursive move resembling what Jason Ānanda Josephson-Storm calls “exclusive similarity,” in *The Invention of Religion in Japan* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012), 29–38. Importantly, however, none of this is to say that the norms of the Sufi establishment, or one version thereof, went uncontested either. For example, as Gardiner (*passim*) has noted, the courtly scribal class (*ahl al-qalam*) saw the occult science of letters in general as a favorable alternative to the disciplines of organized Sufism, which would have reflected the real competition for power and prestige between these two groups as distinct estates in their society. The aloofness of this class from institutionalized Sufism is evident in Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, which extended to portraying the science of letters as a less demanding but equally effective alternative method of reaching the same goal as the Sufi path, as in the case of the Ottoman courtier and occultist ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 1454) examined in Cornell H. Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries,” in *Falnama: The Book of Omens*, ed. Massumeh Farhad and Serpil Bağcı (Washington, D.C.: Arthur M. Sackler Gallery, Smithsonian Institution, 2009), 231–244. Meanwhile, the marked proliferation of talismans and amuletic practices in later Shiʿi Iran, which Melvin-Koushki points out, was situated precisely after the eclipse of its Sufi orders, seeming to suggest a similar dy-

One reason this point seems to have largely escaped the attention of scholarship might be the way in which both traditions saw virtues exemplified in—and inaccessible without—specific symbols, ritual forms, and even supernatural beings whose particular character has no universally or immediately apparent connection to ethics as such. However, this feature of medieval Sufism is especially important to appreciating how a theurgic understanding of ritual, despite being apparently rooted in an arcane visionary cosmology inaccessible to a broad audience, could still extend to involve people from all walks of life, at least in theory. In particular, examining Kāshānī's vernacular writings will show us how this Sufi theurgic understanding of religious practice animated even his moralistic and didactic writings directed at a wider audience of non-initiates. In this context, it seems likely that Kāshānī's writings owe at least some of their widespread and enduring popularity to the way they promised even laypeople, in exchange for their efforts simply to be pious, observant Muslims, a measure of cosmic participation in God's emanation, which until that time had been part of the exclusive preserve and prestige of Sufis as an elite religious class.⁴⁵ At the same time, we will see how for Kāshānī this emanation of universal attributes of perfection, despite having their own substantive, independent existence, could not be encountered apart from its particular embodiments in holy people, both living and deceased – foremost among them the Prophet Muhammad, but after him also the Shi'i Imams. Here is where Kāshānī's writings afford us a possible glimpse of the kind of vernacular logics that attended the transformation of sectarian boundaries in Islam from their fluctuating premodern iterations into the relatively fixed forms they exhibit today.

namic playing out at the popular level. At the same time, however, highly prestigious Sufis themselves also became some of the most famous and influential purveyors of these methods, as in the case of Muhammad Ghawth (d. 1562) with his popular and widely circulated manual *The Five Gems* (*al-Jawāhir al-khamsa*), which even became an important source for the Tijāniyya, revivalist paragons of West African Sufi orthodoxy also steeped in various hidden sciences. Here, then, despite the detail and level of sophistication of its various occult *technai*, we still have to contend with an evaluation like Ernst's that even the practices Ghawth compiled in the *Jawāhir* were basically understood as forms of prayer. Carl Ernst, "Jawāher-e Kāmsa," in *Encyclopædia Iranica* (New York: Encyclopædia Iranica Foundation, 2008), 14:608–609.

⁴⁵ This is not to say that ordinary people did not have their own conceptions of relating to divine and unseen forces, only that Sufi discourses circumscribed this access. However, for a rare and remarkable account from the perspective of Islamic social history of the unseen as "a field of action potentially open to all," see Beatrice Forbes Manz, "Political Dynamics in the Realm of the Supernatural," in *Power, Politics and Religion in Timurid Iran* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 178–207, esp. 180–190.

5 Sufi Theurgy for All: Emanationist Ethics and Shi'ism in Kāshānī's Vernacular Treatises

The study of Kāshānī has focused largely on his systematic thought, especially as presented in his Arabic treatises.⁴⁶ At the same time, his function as the first successful popularizer of Ibn 'Arabī's teachings is well known, with his writings aimed at organizing and explaining their most difficult ideas to a readership of non-initiates or novices.⁴⁷ However, even these works presupposed a certain level of education or commitment to Sufi disciplines. I, on the other hand, am of the view that the existing scholarship has yet to appreciate the full range of the audience Kāshānī desired to reach, with some of his moralistic-didactic writings that survive in Persian restating the same emanationist ethics in even simpler and more accessible terms that could be understood and applied even by lay people. Especially with this prospect of a broader reception than scholarship has recognized, the particular mode of reasoning by which Kāshānī's emanationist ethics reenvisioned Shi'ism in terms of access to divine emanation rather than a particular theological or creedal position rises to the level of potentially general historical interest.⁴⁸

To make this case, I will point out the theurgic themes in two vernacular treatises of Kāshānī, one entitled *Tuḥfat al-ikhwān fī khaṣā'iṣ al-fityān* ("Gift for the Brethren on the Traits of Virtuous Youths"), and the other *Risālah-yi tashrīqāt* ("Treatise on Illuminations"). These works were for two audiences ostensibly very different in social standing, but equally "lay" by the standards of organized Sufism. The first exists in a Persian translation Kāshānī prepared of an Arabic manual he originally authored to guide edification of the fraternal organizations

⁴⁶ The only focused, full-length European language work on any aspect of Kāshānī's thought remains Lala, *Knowing God*. There also are a few important dissertations in Turkish to provide improved editions of Kāshānī's major works that also advance the study of his thought, with Necmettin Ergül, "Kaşani ve Hakâiku't-Te'vîl fî Dekâiki't-Tenzîl Adlı Eserinin I. Cildinin (Fâtîha – En'âm) Tahkik ve Tahriri" (PhD Thesis, Harran Üniversitesi, 2002), and Abdurrahim Alkış, "Abdurrezzâk Kâşânî'nin Şerhu Fusûsî'l-Hikem Adlı Eserinin Tahkik ve Tahlili" (PhD Thesis, Marmara Üniversitesi, 2008).

⁴⁷ James Winston Morris, "Ibn 'Arabi and His Interpreters Part II: Influences and Interpretations," *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 106/4 (1986): 733–756.

⁴⁸ Kāshānī's early handling in modern scholarship took him for Twelver Shi'i in a strict confessional sense, which was in line with the view of later premodern Shi'a scholars also known for their revisionism. For a critique of this view emphasizing Kāshānī's professed respect for the Sunni caliphs, see Lala, *Knowing God*, 22–23. Kāshānī's reverence for the Imams, however, was also more exceptional and contrary to standards of even his era's famously flexible Sunni orthodoxy than any scholarship has yet recognized, the focus of another study of mine currently under preparation. For a limited discussion see below, no. 66.

of *futuwwa* (lit. “young-manliness”).⁴⁹ Having come to form a central part of urban, and increasingly rural social life in the central Islamic lands of Iran, Iraq and Anatolia, the *futuwwa* societies functioned like lay religious brotherhoods, usually made up of guildsmen or craftspeople and led by a representative appointed from a Sufi order with ties to the caliphal or imperial court—most often in this setting, the Suhrawardiyya to which Kāshānī himself belonged.⁵⁰ Notably, however the leader of the *futuwwa* in Kāshānī’s formulation went from its figurehead in the Abbasid Caliph to the awaited Mahdi from Muhammad’s family, whom the Twelver Shi’a identify as the hidden Twelfth Imam.⁵¹ The second treatise is a digest of metaphysics, cosmology, Sufi ethics, and reflections on just kingship and the administration of the ideal state. Strikingly, Kāshānī explicitly labels this work as a summary of the “Rite of the Prophet’s Household” (*madhhab-i ahl-i bayt*), a term ordinarily claimed only by Twelver Shi’a. Kāshānī’s presentation, meanwhile, bears scant resemblance to Twelver theology or law, but recasts the term as a way for his readers to access God’s emanation of virtues through Muhammad and his descendants as a form of spiritual adoption into their family.⁵² Here, though the *Tashrīqāt* does not state the occasion or purpose of its composition, these latter themes of Sufi cosmology, genealogy, and Shi’ism were all major preoccupations of the newly Muslim Mongol military elite, making its intended

49 A much overlooked examination of this work, and its place in textual tradition and late medieval Islam’s religious landscape, was given in Abdülbaki Gölpınarlı, “İslam ve Türk İllerinde Futüvvet Teşkilatı ve Kaynakları,” *İstanbul Üniversitesi İktisat Fakültesi Mecmuası* 11/1–4 (1949–1950): 6–354. Some of its main themes are also surveyed in Seyyed Hossein Nasr, “Spiritual Chivalry,” in *Islamic Spirituality: Manifestations*, ed. idem (New York: The Crossroad Publishing Company, 1997), 304–318.

50 *Futuwwa* was a pre-Islamic ideal of chivalric masculinity also claimed by urban men’s societies, which developed relations with guilds in later centuries but were often, especially in their earliest iterations, not dissimilar to gangs. By providing a normative definition of *futuwwa* in line with their own ethics, Sufis were not only creatively engaging yet another pre-Islamic cultural tradition, but also seeking to discipline what was an otherwise frequently formidable social force by effectively admonishing these groups as to the nature of “real manhood.” For an overview of this complex socio-religious phenomenon, see Lloyd Ridgeon, *Morals and Mysticism in Persian Sufism* (London: Routledge, 2010).

51 Kāshānī, *Tuhfat al-ikhwān fi khaṣā’iṣ al-fityān*, in *Majmū’ah-yi rasā’il wa muṣannafāt*, 475, 530. Here, Kāshānī does not explicitly refer to Mahdi by name, but his invocation “peace be upon him,” would have struck his readers as referring to the Twelfth Imam. In his *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, at 127, however, Kāshānī discretely cites a Twelver Shi’i hadith on the Mahdi’s agnomen (*kunya*) which proves this identification. I analyze and contextualize this passage at length in another study currently under preparation.

52 Kāshānī, *Tashrīqāt*, in *Majmū’ah*, 320–325.

audience in one of the Ilkhanid emperors or members of their associated nobility all but certain.⁵³

What is remarkable about these treatises is that, despite one being authored for commoners, and the other for nobility, they are basically unanimous in their presentation of cosmology, ethics, and the theurgic light in which this places their practical prescriptions, as well as the centrality both ascribe to the members of Muhammad's family as special transmitters of divine emanation. In both, Kāshānī presents virtues or moral perfections as the substance of God's emanation to creation, differentiated reflections of His oneness that make up both the contents and *raison d'être* of religion. In the *Tuhfat*, his presentation of this schema is even organized around the Four Cardinal Virtues of antiquity, but re-envisioned as the primordial human nature, which is itself only a reflection of God's own attributes.⁵⁴ Not just formal religious practice, but all ethical conduct in turn becomes a means for acquiring or strengthening participation in the emanation of these perfections through a kind of sympathetic correspondence.⁵⁵ At the same time, the human body is an indispensable instrument for these perfections' realization in the world, marking the completion of the hierarchy of levels in cosmic existence through which the universal forms descend. Though human individuals begin their earthly life as the lowest, most restricted and most particular state of cosmic existence, by disciplining the soul to bring their actions into conformity with virtue, their very bodies reach a state of perfection that contains and conveys the totality of universal realities, without which these realities would remain unmanifest. In particular, the centrality of the body in Kāshānī's emanationist ethics is established by his connection of the cardinal virtue of justice (*'adālat*) with the

53 John E. Woods, "Timur's Genealogy," in *Intellectual Studies on Islam: Essays Written in Honor of Martin B. Dickson*, ed. Michel M. Mazzaoui and Vera B. Moreen (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1990), 85–101; İlker Evrim Binbaş, "Structure and Function of the 'Genealogical Tree' in Islamic Historiography," in *Horizons of the World: Festschrift for İsenbike Togan*, ed. İlker Evrim Binbaş (Istanbul: İthaki, 2011), 465–544; Judith Pfeiffer, "Confessional Ambiguity or Confessional Polarization?"

54 Temperance (*'iffat*), Courage (*shajā'at*), Wisdom (*ḥikmat*) and Justice (*'adālat*). "For the virtues, all of them, are the essential entailments of primordial human nature (*fiṭrat*)." Kāshānī, *Tuhfat al-Ikhwān fi khaṣā'is al-fityān*, in *Majmū'ah-yi rasā'il wa muṣannafāt*, 471.

55 "Shari'a is nothing but the form of justice in conduct between God and humanity," whereas "justice is nothing but the form of the Reality of Oneness in the world of multiplicity, so shari'a is the form and manifestation of justice." Kāshānī, *Tuhfat*, 478. The "form" (*ṣūrat*) of a reality here refers to both the appearance and conduit of its emanation at a lower level of reality, making conduct that either expresses shari'a more specifically or virtue more broadly the means of receiving the emanation of the One. For more discussion of how specific acts of worship and virtuous conduct attract emanation through sympathy by making the practitioner take the form of higher realities, see Schechter, "Nearness to the Real," 32–35.

cosmic principle of balance (*i'tidāl*) used to denote both the perfection of human faculties in virtue, and the adequacy of humoral constitution (*mizāj*) to its bodily receptacle.⁵⁶ Since both are manifestations of God's oneness (*waḥdat*) at their respective levels of cosmic reality, this makes disciplined, virtuous human bodies the visible forms or images of divine unity, both recipients of its perfections and their transmitters to others, according to the level of their participation, and the degree of their realization of the origin of all good, and all that is, in God.⁵⁷ With Muhammad and his descendants possessing the most supremely balanced constitutions and thus alone embodying virtue with absolute perfection, Kāshānī's teachings across both works readily support an attitude of Shi'a sympathy. However, these views have no clear sectarian bearing on Kāshānī's account of religious practice, which instead centers on particular modes of arranging all aspects of human conduct to correspond sympathetically with the emanations of virtue in his broader cosmological framework.

This immediate ethical purport of Kāshānī's overall schema is nicely encapsulated in an admonition to his readers in the *Tuhfat*. There he promises that whoever truly attains to even one of the virtues will "clearly recognize with spiritual perception" that it was in fact God who "deigned to emanate these perfections [to him] through the theophany of the light of His own attributes." In recognition of this fact, the aspirant:

will become lowly out of the utmost modesty and humility, and out of profuse gratitude for God's blessing, envisioning the grandeur and power of God most high, and seeing his own helplessness and wretchedness, realize his insignificance. And by the light of true guidance he will know that the soul is the origin of harm and wrongdoing and the source of filth and contamination, which are the preserve of contingency, and that the wickedness of moral ugliness, turbidity of soul, and baseness are but so many non-existent matters from the realm of contingency—whereas goodness, moral beauties (*maḥāsīn*), lights, and virtues are ontological matters (*umūr-i wujūdiyyah*) from the Presence of the All-Merciful.⁵⁸

Now, it would be easy to mistake Kāshānī's words here for an excerpt from a work for Sufi initiates describing a mystical or visionary state. However, Kāshānī here is in fact addressing a more general audience that has not embarked upon the spiritual journey to sainthood, but has rather only dedicated itself to the pursuit of

56 Kāshānī, *Risālah-yi mabda' wa ma'ād*, in *Majmū'ah*, 291.

57 Kāshānī, *Risālah-yi mabda' wa ma'ād*, 292. On the attachment of the "controlling spirit" that descends to the visible world to matter according to the form it conveys that was emanated from the Intellect, Kāshānī writes that "this form that appears outwardly is, in reality, the form of that spirit;" and at 297, "The soul is a luminous substance (. . .) separate from corporeal matter, the instrument by which it achieves perfection."

58 Kāshānī, *Tuhfat*, 506.

moral excellence whose achievement is its prerequisite, but which only a minority attain.⁵⁹ His extensive use of Sufi terminology notwithstanding, he is explicit that the path of *futuwwa* involves only “ethics and conduct” (*akhlāq wa mu‘āmalāt*) to the exclusion of higher visionary experiences of Sufism.⁶⁰ What he is doing in this passage, then, amounts to telling his audience that the very experience of striving for virtue, without any special religious qualification or added otherworldly vision, is itself none other than the experience of receiving God’s emanation.⁶¹ By this remarkable form of suggestion through creative extension of Sufi terminology, Kāshānī assured his lay readers that even their everyday struggles with their souls to behave virtuously were already part of the same theurgic quest that the Sufis are known for, only at a different level of the cosmic hierarchy.

Elsewhere, the theurgic nature of this moral quest is highlighted further still by the explicit role played by prophets and saints, not simply as pious predecessors or moral exemplars, but spiritually accessible supernatural beings and necessary intermediaries to God who act as conduits of His emanation. In one place, Kāshānī even explicitly instructs his readers to seek aid from the spirit of the Prophet Abraham as the “axis” (*quṭb*) of *futuwwa*, writing that:

for whomever has set foot on the path *futuwwa* or felt its call has found a trickle of the emanation of [Abraham] (. . .) to follow him and his path is obligatory for him, and to seek support from his sanctified soul and aid from his purified spirit is necessary until (. . .) a sympathy (*munāsabat*) with his soul is established, and through this sympathy he becomes prepared to receive the emanation of his perfection and a locus for the occurrence of some of his states.”⁶²

Here, Kāshānī explicitly applies the kind of cosmic sympathy common to Hermetic and Neoplatonic thought as well as Sufism to the practice of venerating de-

59 “The end of *futuwwa* can be the beginning of sainthood (. . .) The path of sainthood (. . .) ends with the annihilation of createdness in the Essence of Reality, while the path of *futuwwa* (. . .) ends with the purification of the primordial nature from the constraints of acquired dispositions.” Ibid., 472.

60 I.e. “path of sainthood” (*ṭarīqat-i walāyat*), which, in addition to “ethics and conduct” is made of “spiritual states, unveilings, sciences, and witnessings.” Kāshānī, *Tuhfat*, 472.

61 Before assuming that the terminology employed here is simply rhetorical window dressing, in his introduction to the Persian version of the *Tuhfat*, nb. how Kāshānī stresses to the reader that his translation, for those “Brethren of Purity and Lords of Fidelity” who “are not firm in their understanding of the Arabic tongue . . . came to abstain from augmentations and elaborations, so that, insofar as it leaves aside technical expressions and metaphors, and finds contentment with the habit of dervishhood over the raiments of kingship, it is shortened to the degree of what is necessary and essential, and is satisfied with matters of import and concern over curiosities about what is superfluous.” Kāshānī, *Tuhfat*, 467–468.

62 Kāshānī, *Tuhfat*, 476.

ceased holy people and seeking intercession or aid from their souls, whose efficacy he sees as contingent upon and continuous with striving personally to emulate their moral perfection and follow their exemplary conduct. This discussion is crucial for showing how theurgic and emanationist themes of Sufi doctrine gave a compelling rationalization for this practice frequently dismissed in modern scholarship as “popular,” while also harnessing it and directing it toward specifically ethical aims.⁶³ But even beyond this, it illustrates a broader ethical trend in Islam, where no account of what it means to be and do good is complete without the recognition of specific historical personalities remembered for embodying it perfectly. Kāshānī’s theurgic view of practice simply makes this logic of devotion exceptionally literal and explicit. That is, the pursuit of the good, as a kind of cosmic substance, becomes a metaphysical and cosmological impossibility without

⁶³ There is now a substantial body of historical literature on the veneration of saints and visitation of shrines in premodern Islam, but it has virtually in its entirety assumed that the practice of actually supplicating the deceased for aid was a “popular” practice proscribed by Islamic “orthodoxy.” Known by such terms as “mediation” (*tawassul*) or “seeking aid” (*istighātha*), it was and remains a much more widespread practice, and one until modern times far more universally accepted, than discussion in the secondary scholarship reflects. The first publication I know of dealing with primary sources that discuss the practice with approval is Jonathan Brack, *An Afterlife for the Khan: Muslims, Buddhists, and Sacred Kingship in Mongol Iran and Eurasia* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2023), who looks at the writings of the Jewish convert, physician and renowned vizier to the Muslim Mongol Il-Khans, Rashīd al-Dīn Faḡlullāh Hamadānī (d. 1318). Rashīd al-Dīn (also the father of Kāshānī’s patron) flatly states that the pious dead are freer to assist the living than they were when constrained to their bodies, but also retain a special connection to their place of burial. The conditions for approaching them for aid such as a sincere intention are similar to those for effective prayer to God (on which see Brack, *Afterlife*, 108). But this theory of Rashīd al-Dīn’s was not one of his more idiosyncratic, homespun ideas for an audience of Mongol fellow converts lacking a strict theological sensibility, for which he is well-known. Rather, none other than the major Sunni theologian Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī (d. 1210) gives the same explanation for the ability of the dead to aid the living, in his *Maṭālib al-‘āliya*, ed. Aḥmad Ḥijāzī, (Beirut: Dār al-Kitāb al-‘Arabi, 1987), 7:276. This is only one among many references to this practice from a wide range of normative Sunni sources, cited in a running list that Khalil Andani and Abullah Ansar have maintained as part of ongoing research into this neglected topic, “Ya Muhammad Madad: Sunni Scholars Who Permit Istighatha (Intercessory Prayer),” *Thinking Islam*, 21.12.2024 <https://www.thinkingislam.com/p/ya-muhammad-madad-sunni-scholars>. I have seen no indication in reviewing these and similar sources that Sufis like Kāshānī looked down on the supplication of saints for worldly aims in any way, but simply wished to impress upon their readers that if God was indeed more generous in responding to the prayers of his friends or those offered on their behalf, then seeking their aid (*madad*) for the purposes of increasing one’s morality and piety was, as in conventional prayer, superior to the pursuit of worldly goods. And, perhaps more to the point, if such powerful means for support in one’s struggle for ethical development existed, not to avail oneself of them could in practice only lead to failure.

knowing, loving and appealing to those who, because of their greater nearness to its Source, serve as its conduits – and on account of which no spiritual journey through the higher levels of reality is conceivable that is not also a process of continuous ethical refinement and increasing religious observance in the footsteps of these exemplars.

However, in the point of main historical interest from Kāshānī's thought, this theurgic role of holy people did not cease with exceptional individuals. Rather, in keeping with Kāshānī's cosmology, predisposition to virtue, and therefore to attracting an exceptional degree of divine emanation, was also a hereditary trait, shared first and foremost among the prophets and exemplified fully by Muhammad's supremely balanced (*mu'tadil*) constitution, a share of which he passed on to his descendants.⁶⁴ And while "outward" prophetic descent alone could neither substitute for becoming Muhammad's "inward" family through virtuous action nor excuse its contrary, Kāshānī nevertheless echoed the popular view in his society by celebrating in particular those who combined these two modes of relatedness to the Prophet, itself a recipe for the most widely accepted form of religious leadership at a local level and even charismatic authority in medieval Islam, and well into many modern contexts.⁶⁵ Kāshānī's "popular" audience would probably have encountered such sayyids as the liaisons of a given Sufi order with the guild-style organization of *futuwwa* in their local communities, whereas his courtly readers would have recognized the same figures as important recipients of imperial patronage, if not saintly intercessors capable of safeguarding their rule.⁶⁶ So if Kāshānī is at all as representative a figure of later Islamic religious

64 Kāshānī, *Tashrīqāt*, 324–325.

65 In the *Tuhfat*, Kāshānī affirms of the ideal teacher "that his family tree (*shajarah*) and descent (*nisbat*) be connected (*muttaṣil*) to the Prophet," at 477. In the *Tashrīqāt*, 330, he further underscores that, while "whoever has a sufficient share of [the perfection of] divine love has a connection to Muhammad by the heart and is his true family (*khawish-i yaqīnī*) . . . whoever is connected to him by outward descent (*nisbat*) has a strong preparedness to receive [his] perfections, in accordance with their sympathy in humoral disposition (*biḥ ḥasab-i munāsabat-i mizājī*). If he brings this potential to actuality, he combines spiritual and outward family, giving everything its due and becoming connected to him in every respect – and if not, he does the matter great injustice, for *whoever's works lag behind him, his ancestry will not hasten them!*" On the social position and treatment of descendants of the Prophet, see Kazuo Morimoto, ed., *Sayyids and Sharifs in Muslim Societies: The Living Links to the Prophet* (London: Routledge, 2012). As mentioned previously (no. 49) Kāshānī notably considered the true leader of these organizations to be the Mahdi from Muhammad's family, whom he deemed the "Seal of *Futuwwa*."

66 A nice example of the former is an early Ottoman promoter of *futuwwa*, Seyyid Hüseyin b. Gaybī (fl. mid 15th c.) who was himself a reader of Kāshānī. See Abdülbaki Gölpınarlı, "Şeyh Seyyid Gaybî Oğlu Şeyh Seyyid Hüseyin'in 'Fütüvvet-Name'si,'" *İstanbul Üniversitesi İktisat Fakültesi Mecmuası* 17/1–4 (1955): 27–72; Seyyid Hüseyin ibn Seyyid Gaybī, *Şerhu Hutbeti'l-beyân: İnce-*

culture as modern scholarship has increasingly come to contend, the way his cosmology made descendants of the Prophetic literal repositories of divine emanation might shed new light on the ease with which devotion to Muhammad's descendants so routinely cut across boundaries of language, culture and class—and more generally, serving as one illustration of how universal ideals have consistently found forms of embodiment in Islamic societies at once highly particular and deeply personal throughout their history.⁶⁷

Indeed, Kāshānī's time was one now generally known for its “confessional ambiguity,” when the boundaries between Sunni and Shi'a were more flexible or permeable than today, at least in their public expressions.⁶⁸ His treatment of Muhammad's family above all as sources of tangible divine emanation thus would have been particularly well-suited to this context that tended to make classically Shi'i figures the focus of a devotional culture open to all, rather than of polemical discourses. However, it is interesting that, in a striking manner felicitously parallel to the reabsorption of Kāshānī's account of independently existing universals into a more recognizable peripatetic formula with Mullā Ṣadrā, the confessional

leme-Metin, ed. Mehmet Saffet Sarıkaya (Isparta: Fakülte Kitabevi, 2004). For royal patronage of sayyids in the Mongol period, see Judith Pfeiffer, “Confessional Ambiguity vs. Confessional Polarization: Politics and the Negotiation of Religious Boundaries in the Ilkhanate,” in *Politics, Patronage and the Transmission of Knowledge in 13th–15th Century Tabriz* (Leiden: Brill, 2013), 129–163. On the supernatural properties of sayyids in religious culture, see Kazuo Morimoto, ed., “How to Behave toward Sayyids and Sharifs: A Trans-Sectarian Tradition of Dream Accounts,” in *Sayyids and Sharifs in Muslim Societies*, 15–36.

⁶⁷ It would be easy to be dismiss any such codification of a literal, hereditary aristocracy simply as reproducing and authorizing the continued entrenchment of particular asymmetries in power in a given society. But this would overlook, first, how a Sufi view like Kāshānī's sought to infuse the genealogical consciousness of his audience with a sense of ethical accountability that could otherwise have been absent, and moreover, how sayyids were only one class and interest group in a society marked by mutual heteronomy and diversified forms of power. Perhaps the most relevant context here is that in Kāshānī's world, while sayyids were frequently religious authorities as well as wealthy landholders, they did not hold dynastic political power on anything above an occasional local scale, and thus the kind of discourse he perpetuated of their innate virtue placed natural limits on the nature and scope of any imperial court's claims to authority—including Kāshānī's own sources of patronage. Royal envy of sayyids' charisma is especially clear in later, Timurid attempts to portray both Timur and Genghis Khan as descendants of 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib (and thus also Muhammad, through his daughter Fāṭima), by making the legendary “radiant being” who impregnated the foremother of Genghis, Alan-Qo'a, somehow from among 'Alī's progeny. See John E. Woods, “Timur's Genealogy,” 85–88.

⁶⁸ For the introduction of this term to Islamic Studies, see John E. Woods, *The Aqqyunlu: Clan, Confederation, Empire* (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1999), 3–4. However, for a revised look cautioning against its overuse in contexts of definite confessional difference, see now also Judith Pfeiffer, “Confessional Ambiguity or Confessional Polarization?”

fluidity of his emanationist ethics also ended in an outcome that similarly reaffirmed the impossibility, at least at the level of conventional human existence, of encountering the universal separate from its particular embodiments—in this case through adaptation to full-fledged Shi'i orthodoxy. For, amid all the emphasis Kāshānī places on descent from the Prophet generally and the special status of sayyids, it is only the line of Imams concluding with the hidden Mahdi that Kāshānī views as the full inheritors of Muhammad, including his spiritual essence, exceptional body, and the totality of his virtues, and who are thus inescapably the highest intermediaries after the Prophet's Spirit that make God's emanation available to the rest of creation.⁶⁹

At the same time, it appears to have been precisely by focusing on this substantive, emanationist dimension of the Imams' spiritual supremacy and basing it on a broadly accepted Sufi cosmology and ethics rather than polemical arguments, that Kāshānī came to play an early, previously unrecognized role in providing the kind of conceptual vocabulary that would eventually facilitate Shi'ism's acceptance in majority-Sunni Iran's wider religious culture.⁷⁰ For, when under Safavid rule two centuries later, Iran's largely sayyid-led Sufi orders of the kind Kāshānī championed were effectively replaced in their social role by a new Twelver Shi'i clergy (with many sayyids among them too), it is striking that the status of

69 See e.g. Kāshānī, "Tashrīqāt," 323–324. In English translation, there is a similarly comprehensive account, in fact somewhat more detailed, in Kāshānī, *A Sufi Commentary on the Qur'an. Volume 1*, 123–124. Again, Kāshānī does not give the Mahdi's name or enumerate the Imams before him, but this is clarified with former's identification as the Twelfth Imam in his *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ* (see no. 49). What is striking about these passages, however, is that they attribute to the Mahdi and other Imams perfections that are absent in pre-Islamic prophets (cf. Kāshānī, *Sufi Commentary*, 129), making them second only to Muhammad in standing – a view only acceptable in Shi'ism and completely anathema to all standards of Sunni theology, which maintains the superiority of all prophets to all saints without exception. I analyze and present these features of Kāshānī's thought for the first time in scholarship in another study currently under preparation.

70 This seemingly recalls the once widely-accepted characterization of Islam in Iran following the Mongol invasions as one of "imperceptible transition from Sunnism to Shi'ism," in the words of Alessandro Bausani, "Religion under the Mongols," in *The Cambridge History of Iran, Volume 5: The Saljuq and Mongol Periods*, ed. J. A. Boyle (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1968), 547. The most detailed such account was Marijan Molé, "Les Kubrawiyya entre Sunnisme & Shiisme aux huitième et neuvième siècles de l'hégire," *Revue des études islamiques* 29 (1961): 61–142. However, such views of a longue durée trend toward Shi'ism in medieval Iran have largely fallen out of fashion since Hamid Algar pointed out the teleology and essentialism that versions of this argument usually involved, in "Some Observations on Religion in Safavid Persia," *Iranian Studies* 7/1–2 (1974): 287–293. All the same, I am of the view that figures like Kāshānī compel us to revisit the issue, not as a foregone conclusion, but as an inquiry into concrete sources for the circulation of specifically Shi'i ideas and arguments in late medieval Iran's religious culture.

the Imams of the Shi'a themselves in Iran's religious landscape apparently did not undergo any meaningful change from the kind of role that Kāshānī originally envisioned for them. Accordingly, in the writings of one of Safavid Iran's earliest Twelver clerics, Ilāhī Ardabīlī (d. 1543), we find an overall view of the Imams closely matching Kāshānī's, where their primacy and exclusive authority are not a contradiction, but a consequence of the universality of their virtues and the perfection with which they embody them, as manifestations of the universal in the particular *par excellence*.⁷¹ In one passage in particular, we find an especially striking account of the Imams' supernatural function as objects of ethical emulation, theurgic appeal, and sources of virtue that Kāshānī could easily have worded himself. Here, at the heyday of Twelver Shi'ism's imposition as Iran's official religion, Ardabīlī would enjoin his readers to one of its core practices, sending blessings (*ṣalawāt*) upon the Prophet's family, in the following terms:

For knowledgeable followers and travelers possessed of awareness, it is their habit to be busy with the command of God, obligatory to be heeded, that after blessing His Prophetic Holiness, they set their tongues to blessing [the infallible Imams], *seek the emanation of perfections from their effusive inner reality*, and, adhering like a shadow to their illuminated essence amid the depths of the sea of uncertainty and waves of baseless doubts, partake in the light of the star of [the Prophet's saying] 'The People of my House are of the likeness of Noah's Ark – whoever embarks with them is saved.'⁷²

6 Conclusion

This article uses the writings of the major Mongol-era Sufi authority 'Abd al-Razzāq al-Kāshānī (d. 1329) to explore how the well-known shift in late-medieval Islamdom from rationalism and theology toward a Sufi blend of emanationist thought was not confined to intellectual history, but had potential ramifications across other areas of life in Islamic society as well. Drawing examples from Kāshānī and related figures, as well as their earlier Arabic sources in the Brethren

71 Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Ilāhī Ardabīlī, *Sharḥ Gulshan-i Rāz*, ed. Muḥammad-Riḍā Barzīgar Khāliqī (Tehran: Markaz-i Nashr-i Dānishgāhī, 1997), 33. Here, Ardabīlī ranks the spirits of Muḥammad and the Imams as the least conditioned of all created things, and categorically superior to whole ranks of other perfected humans including pre-Islamic prophets due to the totality of divine attributes they manifest being, in terms echoing Kāshānī, in a configuration of perfect balance (*i'tidāl*).

72 Kamāl al-Dīn Ḥusayn Ilāhī Ardabīlī, *Manhaj al-faṣāḥah fī sharḥ Nahj al-balāghah*, ed. Ilāhah Rūḥī Dil and 'Abdullāh Ghufrānī (Mashhad: Bunyād-i Pazhūhish-i Islām, 2011), 59–60 (emphasis mine).

of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā*) and even more distant Hellenistic background, I show how late medieval Sufis rationalized religious practice in publicly accessible terms that, for both historical and descriptive reasons, deserve classification as theurgy. At the same time, the importance of the ontological status of universals to this understanding of ritual that was ultimately embodied and included a range of “lay” practices illustrates the inseparability of vernacular and “high” religious conceptions in late medieval Islam. In particular, I show how Kāshānī’s prescriptions promised even lay Muslims some level of participation in the higher states of Sufi cosmology, primarily through the cultivation of virtues understood as emanations from God. At the same time, especially given his extensive influence and potential representativeness of his wider religious culture, I show how Kāshānī’s vision of practice makes the rise of Iranian Shi’ism out of the well-known confessional ambiguity of late medieval Islam a more ethically legible phenomenon, a mode of seeking theurgic participation in the divine emanation of universal virtues as manifest in the realm of particulars.

Here, Kāshānī’s theurgic model of Islamic practice and its underlying emanationist ethics first offer a new way to situate sectarian difference in late medieval Islam, a setting in which the Sunni-Shi’a divide is well known to have been more flexible or permeable than in more recent history. By variously viewing pre-Islamic prophets, Muhammad, and members of his family along with other holy people above all as sources of divine emanation to be accessed by a mode of piety that was equal parts ethical imitation and theurgic operation, the synthesis promulgated by Sufis like Kāshānī provided an idiom whose theoretical rudiments stood aloof from sectarian identities as such, but while also providing such identities with elaborate explanatory and performative means to authorize themselves. That is, for metaphysical and cosmological reasons, virtues here could not be accessed without recognizing their concrete embodiments in particular holy people, to whom differently configured patterns of devotion have variously constituted identification as Sunni or Shi’a throughout history. Thus, Kāshānī’s teachings also help us understand how such a broader, shared cosmology so apparently fluid and open to universality could still coalesce into expressions supporting specific sectarian identities and agendas that devolved in the last analysis on devotion to particular historical personalities. Here, though non-polemical and confessionally ambiguous himself, Kāshānī’s account of the Shi’i Imams’ ethical universality did not at all preclude the primacy or exclusivity of their particular modes of embodying it, and in fact entailed the logical interrelation of these two aspects of their existence. At the same time, Kāshānī’s teachings validated popular practices of devotion and tied them into the everyday efforts of laypeople simply to conduct themselves ethically, including even these minutiae of social life in a vibrant cosmology permeated by supernatural beings and divine forces.

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Esma Ünsal

Chapter 4

Continuity and Renewal: İsmail Hakki İzmirli's *Yeni 'Ilm-i Kelām*

1 Introduction

“The close relationship between novelty and continuity is usually difficult to identify, as it is often easier to categorize historical developments in a dichotomous way.”¹ This inherent challenge in recognizing the subtle interplay between tradition and innovation becomes particularly pronounced during periods of significant transformation. When societal, intellectual, or political landscapes shift, the natural inclination is often to perceive change as break from the past, rather than as an evolution. However, does renewal necessarily have to contradict continuity? This question lies at the heart of understanding how traditions endure and adapt. In some cases, it is precisely the attempt at renewal and the confrontation with the “other” – whether that be new ideas, different cultures, or evolving societal norms – that can contribute to preserving tradition and, thus, maintaining continuity. This seemingly paradoxical relationship suggests that innovation is not always a destroyer of the old but can, in fact, be at times its guardian. By engaging with new perspectives and integrating fresh insights, a tradition can rejuvenate itself, making it relevant and resilient in a changing world. Without such adaptive processes, traditions risk stagnation and eventual irrelevance.

This article aims to present İsmail Hakki İzmirli's (1869–1946) *Yeni 'Ilm-i Kelām*² (1920) as a compelling case study of this intricate dynamic. This work stands out as a unique and significant contribution in the intellectual landscape of the late Ottoman period. Often attributed to a reformed character, implying a radical departure from established theological thought, *Yeni 'Ilm-i Kelām* has historically been perceived as a testament to intellectual reformism. However, in my view, this interpretation might overlook a deeper, more nuanced intention. Instead, this article proposes that

1 M. Sait Özervarlı, “The Position of Philosophy in the Late Ottoman Educational Reforms,” in *Ways of Knowing Muslim Cultures and Societies*, eds. Bettina Gräf, Birgit Krawietz, and Schirin Amir-Moazami, (Leiden: Brill, 2018): 132–143, 132.

2 In this article, the spelling Kelām is used when referring to the Ottoman term, particularly in connection with İzmirli's work. When referring more generally to the theological discipline, the Arabic transliteration Kalām is employed. Both Ottoman Turkish and Arabic terms are transliterated in accordance with the International Journal of Middle East Studies (IJMES) transliteration system.

İzmirli's work could be more accurately considered as a deliberate and sophisticated attempt to maintain continuity within the Islamic intellectual tradition, achieved precisely through the strategic integration of innovation. By analyzing the arguments and methodology employed in *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām*, this research seeks to demonstrate how İzmirli, rather than abandoning tradition, sought to revitalize and secure its enduring relevance in the face of modern challenges, thereby offering an illustration of continuity preserved through carefully considered renewal.

2 The *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām* Movement

The *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām* Movement, a notable intellectual development in the late Ottoman era, encountered substantial difficulties in adapting to the rapid transformations of modernity and the Enlightenment. This movement aimed to restructure the science of Kalām, drawing on contributions from scholars across various regions. However, the 19th century highlighted to Islamic scholars that Aristotelian philosophy had lost its dominance in the West, marking a crucial turning point in philosophical history. Consequently, the Kalām, which had achieved a sophisticated integration with ancient philosophy, found itself outdated. The new intellectual adversaries for these scholars were materialism, positivism, and humanism. As modernist philosophy emerged as the latest intellectual frontier, it became imperative to revise both the subject matter and methodology of Kalām to align with it.³ The discussion about the status and legitimacy of religion and theology began with the pressing questions of modernity and the Enlightenment. During the late Ottoman period, theological literature was significantly influenced by materialist and positivist perspectives. These approaches led to a questioning of traditional religious and theological teachings, which were increasingly viewed as problematic and invalid in terms of their language, methods, and content. In this period, theologians aimed to comprehend and assess events using their own methods and viewpoints, in order to address emerging challenges effectively.⁴

Scholars from diverse regions, including modern-day Egypt, India, and the Ottoman Empire, subsequently pursued this endeavor. They produced works on

³ Ramazan Altıntaş and Ahmet Mekin Kandemir, eds., *Sabit ve Değişken Arasında Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām Hareketi*, (Istanbul: Rağbet Yayınları, 2022), 7.

⁴ Mahmut Ay, "Modernleşme Sürecinin Osmanlı Kelām Literatürüne Etkileri ve Yaratdığı Yapısal Sorunlar," in *Osmanlı'da 'İlm-i Kelām: Âlimler, Eserler, Meseleler*, eds. Osman Demir, Veynel Kaya, Kadir Gömbeyaz, U. Murat Kılavuz, (Istanbul: İsar Yayınları, 2016): 543–577, 543–544.

this topic, giving rise to a new discipline, new Kalām, or the science of Kalām.⁵ In the late Ottoman Empire's Turkish-speaking areas, the movement dedicated to reorganizing the science of Kalām was designated the *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām movement*,⁶ meaning *The New Science of Kalām*. This intellectual movement saw the emergence of various proposed solutions, categorized into three distinct positions regarding how to overcome societal challenges. The first position advocated for the assimilation of Western values as essential for societal modernization. The second prioritized indigenous values but recognized the necessity of adopting Western scientific and technological advancements. The third position, however, involved a complete rejection of all Western values and inventions by Muslims.⁷ Despite significant effort, the project of a new Kalām, initiated a century ago, remains unrealized. This ongoing challenge underscores its persistent relevance in contemporary theology.

3 İsmail Hakki İzmirli and his *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām*

İsmail Hakki İzmirli (1869–1946) was a key figure in the *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām* Movement, notably due to his influential work sharing the movement's exact name. Consistent with other intellectuals of his time, he reevaluated Islamic tradition in response to the demands of ongoing modernization.⁸ As M. Sait Özervarlı points out, “he served not just as a witness to this process, but also as one of its agents.”⁹ As a comprehensive agent of such politically and socially turbulent times, he created a considerable number of articles and books, and *Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām* could be considered his most important contribution. İzmirli's goal “was attempting to reconstruct Islamic philosophical theology and to produce a new *kalām* book that would bring together the traditional historical heritage of this discipline and the developments of modern thought.”¹⁰ He wrote this two-volume work on behalf of the Council for Islamic Research and Publications (Tedkikât ve Te'lifât-ı İslâmiyye Hey'eti).

5 Altıntaş/Kandemir, Sabit ve Değişken, 8.

6 M. Sait Özervarlı, “Yeni 'İlm-i Kelām,” *TDV İslâm Ansiklopedisi* (2013): 427–428, 427.

7 Çağfer Karadaş, “Kelam İlminde Dönemsel Gelişmeler ve Yen-i İlmi Kelam,” in *Sabit ve Değişken Arasında Yeni 'İlm-i Kelam Hareketi*, eds. Ramazan Altıntaş and Ahmet Mekin Kandemir, (Istanbul: Rağbet Yayınları, 2022): 15–43, 25.

8 M. Sait Özervarlı, “Alternative Approaches to Modernization in the Late Ottoman Period: İzmirli İsmail Hakki's Religious Thought against Materialist Scientism,” *International Journal of Middle East Studies* 39/1 (2007): 77.

9 Ibid., 79.

10 Özervarlı, *Alternative Approaches*, 77.

Western philosophy has also made its way to our country, as a result of which the Kelâm is increasingly regarded as inadequate, and this Kalâm must take on a new form in light of this new way of thinking. Because of this necessity, the Council for Islamic Research and Publications declared the writing of the *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm* indispensable.¹¹

The first volume of the work was printed in Istanbul between 1339–1341 AH (1920–1922) and the second volume between 1340–1343 AH (1921–1924), although he was never able to finish the second volume. *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm* was particularly influential in Turkey: after the reintroduction of religious sciences into academic teaching in the mid-twentieth century, it came to be regarded as a model for later works in kalâm theology; it became the subject of a 1979 doctoral dissertation by Sabri Hizmetli at Sorbonne University on the theological ideas of İsmail Hakkı İzmirli; it was republished in the modern Turkish (Latin) script in Ankara in 1981; and it has since been examined in further scholarly studies.¹² The first book contains an introduction and seven chapters, while the second covers an opening and four chapters.

In the first volume,¹³ the introduction (dibâce)¹⁴ summarizes İzmirli's attempts and his method. The first chapter is about religious precepts (aḥkām-ı şer'îyye),¹⁵ the second about the compilation of the Islamic sciences (ʿulūm-ı islāmîyyenin şüret-i tedvîni),¹⁶ the third about Islamic philosophers, Sufis, and the Batiniyya (fe-lâsife-i islāmîyye),¹⁷ the fourth about the Sunni fiqh and the development of the law schools (fiqh-i ehl-i sünnet),¹⁸ the fifth about the first (ontological) principles (mebādî-i evvel),¹⁹ the sixth about existence and essence (vücūd ve zāt)²⁰ and finally the seventh chapter about substance and spirit (madde ve rûḥ).²¹ The second volume²² opens with an introduction²³ where İzmirli presents compelling and irre-

11 İsmail Hakkı İzmirli, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm, I. Kitap* (İstanbul: Evkaf-ı İslâmiye Matbaası, 1339-1341 AH), 90. - translation Esma Ünsal.

12 Özervarlı, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm*, 428.

13 İzmirli, İsmail Hakkı: *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm, I. Kitap* (İstanbul: Evkaf-ı İslâmiye Matbaası, 1339-1341 AH / 1920-1922 CE).

14 İzmirli, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm I*, 2.

15 Ibid., 21.

16 Ibid., 71.

17 Ibid., 139.

18 Ibid., 182.

19 Ibid., 217.

20 Ibid., 253.

21 Ibid., 263.

22 İzmirli, İsmail Hakkı: *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm II. Kitap* (İstanbul: Matba-i Amire, 1340-1343 AH / 1922-1924 CE).

23 İzmirli, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm II*, 3.

futable proofs of God's existence. The initial chapter (zât-ı bârî)²⁴ then delves into these proofs, merging classical Islamic arguments with contemporary philosophical perspectives. Chapters two (şifât-ı bârî)²⁵ and three (şifât-ı şübûtiyye)²⁶ are dedicated to the Names and attributes of God, with the third chapter offering a more detailed exploration. The fourth and final chapter (ef'âl-ı bârî)²⁷ focuses on God's actions. In addition to the first section, which dealt with questions of divinity, İzmirli had envisaged – explicitly noted in the introduction – a second section devoted to prophethood, together with a concluding part; these, however, were never brought to completion.²⁸

This is the first book of the 20th century that attempts to renew a core discipline of Islamic studies.²⁹ A defining characteristic of the book is its focus on modern science and philosophy. It incorporates contemporary thought, physics, and chemistry, and references philosophers such as Immanuel Kant, René Descartes, and Nicolas Malebranche, alongside Islamic scholars of knowledge and nature. The author's familiarity with most of the thinkers cited in the book stems from secondary literature.³⁰ He emphasizes in the first volume that modern philosophy is largely inaccessible due to a scarcity of sources and translations. "The late entry of the New Philosophy into our country has not yet saved us from the period of imitation and translation, and today, the new philosophy has not yet taken a direction, has not yet been established and institutionalized."³¹

The issue at hand stems from conditions in the 19th century. During this period, there was no comprehensive Ottoman translation movement for European Enlightenment works. While some crucial works were read in their original languages, their translation only occurred after 1908, during the Second Constitutional Period. German Turkologist Christoph Herzog attributes this, among other factors, to a small market for printed materials and the suppression of non-conformist ideas from public dissemination. However, this situation changed with an increase in European language speakers and a growing market for Ottoman-Turkish printed matter. This shift allowed for public discussion of European Enlightenment ideas in the latter half of the 19th century. The limited number of translations of fundamental Enlightenment

²⁴ Ibid., 5.

²⁵ Ibid., 84.

²⁶ Ibid., 104.

²⁷ Ibid., 163.

²⁸ Özervarlı, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm*, 427.

²⁹ İzmirli, İsmail Hakkı, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam*, trans. Sabri Hizmetli (Ankara: Ankara Okulu Yayınları, 2018), 10.

³⁰ Özervarlı, *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm*, 428.

³¹ İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam I*, 147. – translation Esmâ Ünsal.

works also suggests a low level of interest in these ideas among Ottoman intellectuals. Furthermore, the fragmented nature of educational institutions is considered an impediment to further exploration of Enlightenment philosophy.³²

İzmirli and his contemporaries confronted existing prejudices against the European Enlightenment and its philosophy. They addressed issues concerning the West that predated their era, operating within a framework where previously, limited and largely unfavorable perspectives on the subject had been documented.³³ The book's unique essence and primary objective lie in initiating a theological discourse on Western philosophy for Turkish speakers. This aims to bridge a noticeable gap and foster a more profound comprehension of the subject.

4 İzmirli's Concept of a New Kalām

To properly understand İzmirli's concept of a new Kalām, it is essential to analyze his positionality within the Islamic sciences and their schools. In his book *Müstasvife Sözleri mi, Tasavvufun Zaferleri mi?: Hakkın Zaferleri* ("The words of the Şūfis, or the victory of mysticism? The victory of truth") İzmirli explains:

I only accept the words of all scholars with evidence. I value those words with contemplation (. . .). I listen to the words of the proponents and the opponents. I do not reject the opponents' words solely because of their disagreement, nor do I accept the words of the supporters solely because of their agreement. I am not absolutely on the side of any scholar. I do not take the words of any scholar like a revelation. I am not strongly on the side of Ibn İbn Taymiyya nor the side of al-Ghazālī. I am neither a Ḥanbalī nor an Ash'arī. I do not blindly follow the Şūfis or the Mutakallimūn. I am on the side of truth (. . .). Unless there is proof for a statement, I do not take it as my own. I write directly what I have claimed to be my own. Otherwise, I pass by just with the tradition (. . .). My loyalty is only to the religion of Islam. My path is only the best path, the path of Prophet Muḥammad. I will never accept to publicly reject a sect that works for the sake of truth and right, whether it is Salafiyya, the Mutakallimūn, the Şūfis, the philosophers, or any other sect (. . .). In matters of disagreement, I appreciate that each side has its justifications, and I recognize a certain truth in each sect from a particular perspective (. . .).³⁴

³² Christoph Herzog, "Aufklärung und Osmanisches Reich," in *Geschichte und Gesellschaft. Sonderheft* 23 (2010): 316.

³³ 17 Ibid., 310.

³⁴ Adnan Bülent Baloğlu, "İzmirli İsmail Hakkı'nın 'Yeni İlmi-i Kelam' Anlayışı," in *İzmirli İsmail Hakkı*, eds. Adnan Bülent Baloğlu and Mehmet Şeker, (Ankara: Türkiye Diyanet Vakfı yayınları, 1996): 93–107, 95. – translation Esma Ünsal.

İzmirli's approach to Kalām is unique in that he resists alignment with any particular school of thought. His primary concern is the pursuit of truth, not the defense of a specific ideology. He insists that the ideas of all Islamic scholars, regardless of their discipline, should be evaluated by the same criteria. This impartial stance, being equally distant from and close to all interpretations, leads İzmirli to describe his method as following “the path of the Prophet” and to declare his sole allegiance to “Islam.” This perspective is crucial for understanding his Kalām work, as such works typically categorize themselves within specific traditions and are characterized by defending their own theses against opposing schools. In his work, *Yeni İlm-i Kelām*, İzmirli's core approach diverges from merely representing or defending a particular school of thought, and he does not dwell on inter-madhab debates either. Instead, İzmirli's objective was to reinterpret Islamic values and principles through a Western lens, thereby integrating Islam with contemporary concepts and institutions.³⁵ “In other words, these people aimed to unite madrasa and maktab, east and west.”³⁶

İzmirli's choice of Kalām for his essential analysis of Western philosophy, over Islamic philosophy, raises a crucial question. He was a scholar who taught philosophy and its history at the Dārülfünûn, and he authored numerous works on both Islamic and modern philosophical thought.³⁷ İzmirli possessed expertise in both Islamic and modern philosophy. However, a closer examination of his definition of Islamic Philosophy reveals his clear preference for Kalām. He did not consider Islamic Philosophy to be genuinely *Islamic*, arguing that it did not directly stem from Islamic sources. For İzmirli, philosophy was understood as metaphysics, and Islamic philosophy as a blend of ancient Greek philosophy and Islamic theology, with the metaphysical component being dominant. He believed that true *Islamic* or *theological* philosophy was exclusively found within the field of Kalām.³⁸

İzmirli clearly distinguishes between Kalām and Islamic philosophy. He believes Islamic philosophy, by dealing with metaphysics independently of revelation, fails. In contrast, Kalām offers a path to metaphysics rooted in revelation, thereby developing an *Islamic* philosophy aligned with Islamic norms and knowledge. Having established İzmirli's theological stance and his differentiation between Kalām and Islamic philosophy, the next section will delve into his concept

³⁵ Ibid., 93.

³⁶ Ibid.

³⁷ Karadaş, *Kelam İlminde Dönemsel Gelişmeler*, 37–39.

³⁸ Mahir Alper, “İsmail Hakkı İzmirli'nin İslam Felsefesini Yorumu: İslam Felsefesi Tarihyazısına bir Örnek”, *İstanbul Üniversitesi İlahiyat Fakültesi Dergisi* 8 (2003): 115–158, 156.

of Kalām, specifically its definition, methodology, and objectives. İzmirli shows us two definitions of ‘ilm al-Kalām, similar to classic ones:

- 1 – The science of Kelām is a sublime science that deals with the nature and attributes of God and the states of creatures in this world and the hereafter based on Islamic norms. [. . .] 2 – The Kelām is a science that always strives with all its might to defend the foundations of faith by providing evidence and resolving doubts. Foundations of faith are based on the sources of religion, which is precisely why the Kalām (only) proves foundations of faith that are based on religious sources.³⁹

Kalām, as classically conceived, is a discipline dedicated to reflecting on the foundations of Islamic faith (‘aqīda).⁴⁰ İzmirli highlights its dual function: positively, it strengthens faith through arguments and proofs, and negatively, it refutes doubts and critiques other beliefs. This places Kalām in a dynamic tension, simultaneously defending one’s own faith and critically engaging with differing beliefs. To meet this challenge, Kalām employs a systematic approach, resolving doubts and reasoning through the combined application of reason and revelation.

All scientific methodologies are encompassed within Kelām: rational deduction, conceptual analysis, empirical observation, traditional authorities, and the Quran itself. Kelām does not rely solely on rationality or inspiration. It cannot be characterized as a purely rational or purely scriptural discipline. Inspiration is acknowledged as a legitimate source of knowledge only when prophets convey it.⁴¹

İzmirli highlights a critical aspect: Kalām science asserts itself as a *rational* justification of faith, uniquely grounded in *revelation*. İzmirli posits that reason and faith are not contradictory; instead, faith serves as a guide to reason rather than its adversary.⁴² Both instances are relevant for Kalām; no convincing argumentation can come from faith or reason alone.

This discipline aims not only to prove and defend the Islamic faith but, more importantly, to strengthen it. This strengthening of faith is crucial to achieving its ultimate goal: ensuring happiness in this world and the hereafter.⁴³ Through this conceptualization, İzmirli follows the well-known hierarchy of former Kalām scholars.⁴⁴ Because of its subject, method, and goal, Kalām deserves to be entitled as the “most honorable” discipline within Islamic sciences.

39 İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam* I, 3–4. – translation Esma Ünsal.

40 Richard M. Frank, “The Science of Kalam,” *Arabic Sciences and Philosophy* 2 (1992): 7.

41 İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam* I, 59. – translation Esma Ünsal.

42 İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam* I, 14. – translation Esma Ünsal.

43 İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam* I, 9. – translation Esma Ünsal.

44 Karadaş, *Kelam İlminde Dönemsel Gelişmeler*, 40.

The value and sublimity of a science are determined by the generality of its subject matter, the sublimity of its questions, the strength of its proofs, and the honorableness of its goal. Kelām is superior to all sciences in all these aspects. Its object is the ‘knowable’ (ma‘lūm), which expresses and encompasses everything, i.e., the most general object possible. Since the objects of Kelām include the essence and attributes of God, they are the most important objects. Since the proofs of Kelām are supported by religious scriptures and are therefore axiomatic, it is the discipline with the strongest proofs. And since its actual purpose is the happiness of man in this world and the hereafter, it also pursues the most honorable goal a scientific discipline can pursue. Thus, Kelām is undoubtedly the most sublime of all sciences.

İzmirli viewed Kalām as *ashraf al-‘ulūm*, the most noble of sciences. This perspective highlights Kalām’s role in rationally establishing and defending the fundamental principles of all other sciences. Beyond its scientific value, Kalām aims to fortify faith, thereby guiding individuals towards true happiness. This raises the question: what precisely constitutes the “newness” of this particular understanding?

5 The Renewal of Kalām

The Relevance, Subject, and Method of the new Kalām coincide with “classic Sunni” Kalām literature descriptions. To give one example, al-Jurjānī explains the status of Kalām in his *Sharḥ al-Mawāqif* as “therefore, the science of Kalām, in terms of all aspects of honor, is the most honorable of the sciences.”⁴⁵ Regarding the “character” of Kalām, there is no fundamental difference between the understanding of İzmirli and the Sunni Kalām tradition before him. Although the *Yeni İlm-i Kelām* movement is commonly interpreted as independent from any madhhab, İzmirli stays within the framework of the Māturīdiyya and Ash‘ariyya schools of thought.⁴⁶

The concept of “renewal” or “change” in Kalām does not originate from the discipline itself, but rather from external factors. As İzmirli states, “Kelām changes, based on its purpose, with the change of the enemies, the stubborn, and the people seeking enlightenment and renews itself according to the requirements of its time.”⁴⁷ What distinguishes the “new” Kalām is its focus on contemporary issues and its confrontation with new “enemies”.

⁴⁵ al-Jurjani, Ali ibn Mohammed, *Sharḥ al-Mawāqif. Mevākif Şerhi 1. Cilt*, trans. Ömer Türker (İstanbul: Türkiye Yazma Eserler Kurumu Başkanlığı, 2015), 151.

⁴⁶ Karadaş, Kelām İlminde Dönemsel Gelişmeler, 40.

⁴⁷ İzmirli, Yeni İlmi-i Kelām I, 10. – translation Esma Ünsal.

Although the new approaches introduced by its proponents, the “Yeni” (new) designation for this movement presents a problem because these thinkers remain rooted in tradition. While it’s impossible to generalize about all thinkers within this movement, Cağfer Karadağ suggests that their collective works can be viewed as a continuation of the *tecdid* and *İhyā’* movements. Similar to these movements, the Yeni ‘İlm-i Kelām movement can be traced back to socio-political circumstances (e.g., al-Ghazali). The confusion surrounding the term “Yeni” stems from a shift in its usage: historically, *tecdid* meant purifying the existing from excesses and reviving the origin (*yinelemek*), whereas later, influenced by Western colonization, the term came to signify a break with tradition and complete reconstruction (*yenilemek*).⁴⁸

Despite his work aligning with the Sunni Kalām tradition and lacking any reformist elements, he faced criticism from contemporaries like Hüseyin Kazım Kadri, solely for his engagement with modern philosophy.⁴⁹ For instance, Ahmed Nazif wrote an article in the journal *Sebilürreşād* (Straight Path) with the title “Yeni ‘İlm-i Kelām. Is there a need for Yeni ‘İlm-i Kelām? Or not?”⁵⁰ He argues that Islam does not require Western Philosophy and that a new Kalām discipline addressing this tradition is unnecessary. Instead, he emphasizes the need for a catechism (‘ilmihāl) rooted in the Quran and Sunna.⁵¹ İzmirli wrote a response to this article in the same journal defending his position.⁵² Such criticism may largely explain why İzmirli’s innovations and the “new Kalām movement” remain negatively associated with reform.

Various interpretations of İzmirli’s work exist, ranging from negative to positive. However, the term “new” in this context does not signify a radical overhaul of the Kalām discipline. Instead, it refers to a steadfast adherence to an established tradition, coupled with a bold willingness to engage with Western philosophy and the emerging questions it presents.

48 Karadağ, *Kelām İlminde Dönemsel Gelişmeler*, 35.

49 Adnan Bülent Baloğlu, “Sebilürreşād Dergisinde ‘Yeni İlm-i Kelām Tartışmaları,’” in *İzmirli İsmail Hakkı*, eds. Adnan Bülent Baloğlu and Mehmet Şeker, (Ankara: Türkiye Diyanet Vakfı yayınları, 1996): 265–312, 266.

50 Ahmed Nazif Dardağan-zâde, “Yeni İlm-i Kelām. Yeni İlm-i Kelâma Lüzûm Var mı? Yok mu?,” *Sebilürreşād* 22 (1923): 118–120.

51 Dardağan-zâde, *Yeni İlm-i Kelām*, 149.

52 İsmail Hakkı İzmirli, “Yeni İlm-i Kelām Hakkında. Sebilürreşād Ceride-i İslamiyyesine,” *Sebilürreşād* 22 (1923): 31–32.

6 Continuity Through Renewal

İzmirli critically engages with Western philosophy and scientific advancements, introducing these new concepts to a wider audience. Rather than shying away from confrontation, he embraces modern, largely unfamiliar Western ideas, seeking to integrate them fruitfully into theology. His confidence stems from his belief that modern science is in complete harmony with Islamic faith, and that no scientific achievement can ever supersede or undermine religion.

Since our religion encompasses all that is beautiful, it has no flaws. Looking for defects (in our religion) is a senseless, ignorant, and uninformed act. Flaws are only found in those who do not understand our religion, who cannot explain it, or those who understand it and still fight against it out of stubbornness. [. . .] Our religion is not an enemy of the positive sciences; on the contrary, it is their supporter. It (religion) is not resistant to nature, but resistance is part of its nature. Islam encompasses the knowledge of “that which has been sent down from God” and the understanding of “that which God has created,” i.e., the Book of Allah and the creatures of Allah.⁵³

In my opinion, the desideratum that İzmirli is following here is the desire to continue the metaphysical theology previously shaped by scholasticism. However, as described at the beginning, modern intellectuals realize that the customary metaphysical theology is being pushed away in the West. This is an unsettling realization. İzmirli and the scholars of his time dealt for the first time with a “post-metaphysical scientific world” and attempted to adopt. The change triggered in the West primarily by Kant but also other Enlightenment philosophers cannot simply be accepted or adopted. I think İzmirli saw the new Kalām as an innovative attempt to address modernization and its challenges, intending to shape this process without breaking the previous theological tradition. Kalām requires a renewal to survive and maintain its continuity. This intellectual undertaking by İzmirli represents a crucial pivot point, as it acknowledges the profound shifts occurring in Western thought while simultaneously seeking to preserve the intellectual heritage of Islamic theology. The post-metaphysical scientific world presented an unprecedented challenge, forcing a re-evaluation of established theological frameworks. İzmirli’s approach, therefore, was not merely an acceptance of external intellectual trends but a strategic re-engagement with the core tenets of Islamic scholasticism in light of new philosophical and scientific paradigms.

İzmirli’s work is an excellent example of the problematic dichotomy between continuity and innovation mentioned at the beginning. Especially in contexts that

53 İzmirli, *Yeni İlmi-i Kelam I*, 12–14. – translation Esma Ünsal.

disrupt the previous understanding of the world and science, change through renewal is intended to prevent a break with tradition. Here, we see how “renewal” is supposed to preserve continuity and not an attempt at radical reform. İzmirli was one of many intellectuals who tried to meet these challenges without abandoning their past and identity in this fast-paced period characterized by new knowledge and societal transformations amid modernization. In the Western tradition, we recognize caesuras in the history of ideas; perhaps İzmirli is understood as a scholar who sought to prevent such a rupture and strived for a “moderate” modernization. His dedication to a renewed Kalām underscores a profound understanding of the delicate balance required to navigate intellectual upheaval. This approach differentiates his efforts from those advocating for a complete break with tradition, positioning him instead as a thoughtful mediator between past and present. The concept of “moderate modernization” is key to understanding İzmirli’s intellectual project, highlighting his commitment to adapting and evolving theological thought while firmly grounding it in its historical and doctrinal roots. Paradoxically, by deliberately adopting innovation they reinforced the established theological narrative and protected it from forces that sought to undo it.

7 Significance for the Context of Islamic Theology in Germany

Even though İzmirli’s project to create a new Kalām remained unfinished and is often considered a failure, I view it as a crucial inspiration for contemporary Islamic theology in Germany. This discipline is relatively new within German universities, currently defining its identity and developing its profile. A significant challenge in this process is establishing a suitable dialogue between Islamic theology and modern philosophy. Fundamentally, İzmirli grappled with a question that remains highly relevant for Islamic theology today: how should we engage with a philosophy that is no longer perceived as ancient metaphysics? In his latest work, *Auch eine Geschichte der Philosophie*, Jürgen Habermas poses one of the most fundamental questions: “What can an appropriate understanding of the function of philosophy be today?”⁵⁴ Habermas attempts to reconstruct the genealogy of post-metaphysical thought; in other words, he tries to demonstrate the de-

⁵⁴ Jürgen Habermas, *Auch eine Geschichte der Philosophie I. Die okzidentale Konstellation von Glauben und Wissen*, (Berlin: Suhrkamp, 2020), 9.

velopment of modern philosophy that detached itself from its religious heritage but still refers to that heritage.⁵⁵ Philosophy is no longer seen as having the same synthesis with theology as it once did. This shift presented a challenge for İzmirli and his contemporaries. İzmirli's work, in fact, can be considered an early instance of engagement with post-metaphysical thought within the Ottoman Empire of the 20th century. The central question İzmirli grappled with remains a pertinent issue for Islamic theology in Germany today: How does Islamic Theology define its relationship to philosophy and position itself within a post-metaphysical context?

While Western philosophies are explored within German Islamic theology, a crucial aspect identified early by İzmirli is often overlooked: the potential for discourse between Islamic theology and modern philosophy. This discourse necessitates a clear understanding of the disciplines involved. Although Islamic philosophy may contribute to modern philosophy, a definitive distinction between Kalām, Islamic philosophy, and philosophy of religion remains elusive. İzmirli, among others, serves as a historical reference point for this issue. Therefore, it is imperative to critically examine, and if necessary, re-evaluate and redefine the objects and methods of contemporary Islamic theological disciplines.

8 Conclusion

This article has delved into the intricacies of the *Yeni İlm-i Kelām* movement, particularly focusing on the seminal work of İzmirli, which shares the same name. İzmirli's intellectual daring is evident in his direct confrontation with novel ideas emanating from the West, which had undeniably sparked considerable unrest and astonishment throughout the late Ottoman Empire. His proposed solution to the burgeoning influence of modern science and philosophy was the establishment of a new science of Kalām. This reimagined Kalām aimed to appropriate and integrate new knowledge and methodologies while robustly maintaining Kalām's foundational claims, defending religious faith, and systematically eliminating doubt through empirical and logical evidence. Consequently, İzmirli's work steadfastly pursued the objective of preserving the continuity of the Kalām tradition, not through rigid adherence to outdated paradigms, but through the inge-

⁵⁵ Thomas Schmidt, "Was heißt nachmetaphysisches Denken? Zum Verhältnis von Philosophie und Religion bei Jürgen Habermas", Karl-Jaspers-Gesellschaft e.V., 20.07.2025 <https://karl-jaspers-gesellschaft.de/?s=Was+hei%C3%9Ft+nachmetaphysisches+Denken%3F+Zum+Verh%C3%A4ltnis+von+Philosophie+und+Religion+bei+J%C3%BCrgen+Habermas>.

nious adoption of new methods and approaches. This could be succinctly encapsulated as continuity through renewal, a testament to his progressive vision.

Regrettably, historical realities confirm that neither İzmirli nor the broader *Yeni İlm-i Kelâm* movement were able to fully achieve their ambitious purpose. However, this observation should in no way diminish the profound value of İzmirli's contributions or his life's extensive work. On the contrary, he merits significant recognition for his intellectual courage in taking a proactive stand against the tide of scepticism and for his instrumental role in making complex Western philosophical concepts accessible to a wider audience within the Ottoman intellectual landscape. Nevertheless, the enduring and critical question of how to genuinely understand and apply Kalâm within the ever-evolving modern context persists, serving as a powerful legacy of İzmirli's pioneering efforts.

İlyas Çelebi addresses this issue in the Turkish context: "Today, there is a need for new studies on the definition of the science of kalâm, starting with its name, its subject, its aim, its method, its sources, and its models of knowledge and existence. A certain process must be experienced for these aspects to be realized."⁵⁶ The discourse surrounding Kalâm and its interplay with philosophy remains fraught with ambiguity, a condition particularly pronounced in both Turkish and German intellectual spheres. This ambiguity is not merely academic but has tangible implications, especially when viewed through the lens of issues raised in Jürgen Habermas' recent philosophical contributions. A pressing imperative for contemporary Islamic theology is to critically assess whether Kalâm can still maintain its relevance and intellectual vitality within a post-metaphysical landscape. Concurrently, it is crucial to meticulously delineate the precise modalities and frameworks through which a meaningful and productive dialogue between theology and modern philosophy can be initiated and sustained in the present era. A significant impediment to progress in this area appears to be a deep-seated reluctance to embrace substantial paradigm shifts and the organic development of new intellectual traditions. While there is a tacit acknowledgment of the inherent necessity for change, a genuine interrogation of the fundamental purpose and latent potential of Kalâm from its very foundational principles proves to be remarkably challenging. This hesitation, however, stands in stark contrast to the historical dynamism of intellectual traditions. As this article emphatically contends, far-reaching and transformative changes, alongside continuous evolutionary developments, are not merely desirable but absolutely essential

⁵⁶ İlyas Çelebi, "Modern Dönem Kelâm Çalışmalarının Temel Sorunları Üzerine," in *Modern Dönemde Dinî İlimlerin Temel Meseleleri. İlmi Toplantı*, (İstanbul: İSAM Yayınları, 2007): 73–104, 104.

to ensure the enduring sustainability and, more profoundly, the enrichment and flourishing of any intellectual tradition.

Consequently, the onus falls squarely upon theologians to confront this challenge. They are presented with a binary choice: either to passively accept the inherent shortcomings and limitations of past endeavors, thereby effectively disregarding the urgent need for intellectual clarity and renewed direction, or to actively honor the profound intellectual contributions of pioneering scholars such as İzmirlî. This latter path necessitates a courageous venture into fundamental transformations and radical alterations, a process that, while perhaps unsettling, is indispensable for the revitalization and future trajectory of Kalâm. This involves a profound re-evaluation of its methodological underpinnings, its epistemological claims, and its capacity to engage with the complex ethical, social, and existential questions that define the contemporary world. Only through such a deliberate and transformative engagement can Kalâm move beyond its current ambiguities and reclaim its rightful place in the ongoing dialogue between faith and reason.

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II Beyond Difference: Religion, Identity and Otherness in Modernity

Elisabeth Becker

Chapter 5

Beyond Simmel's Stranger: A Theory of Critical Strangerhood

"You neither heard it nor didn't hear it You neither saw it nor didn't see it It was inside of you, it was your voice But it was also outside, the voice of a stranger It was both a voice and it wasn't It reached you and departed from you It was the one arriving and departing It was neither heard nor was it silent Neither within nor without." –Zafer Şenocak.¹

1 Introduction

Otherness and difference, embodied in the figure that Georg Simmel² termed 'the Stranger', lie at the heart of the experiences of Jews and Muslims in modern Europe. In this chapter, I trace the figure and configurations of the Stranger in twentieth century Jewish critical thought, arguing that it can be brought to bear on current debates over both Jewish and Muslim belonging in modern European societies. Specifically, I develop a theory of critical strangerhood to signal the constructive and equally productive potentiality of this positionality, centering on the work of four twentieth/twenty-first century Jewish and Muslim authors who write in and about contemporary Europe from its margins as illustrative of this positionality.

I begin by outlining the work of sociologist Georg Simmel, political theorist Hannah Arendt, and sociologist Zygmunt Bauman on their theories of the concept of Strangerhood, which took shape through the reflection and inflection of these thinkers with the marginal Jewish positionality in Europe. All three drew from their lived experiences in the divided social terrain of European modernity, in which Jews were emancipated but still culturally set apart.³ At the same time as

1 Zafer Şenocak, "Three poems by Zafer Şenocak" (2021) trans. Kristin Dickinson in *Another Chicago Magazine*, 26.10.2024 <https://anotherchicagomagazine.net/2021/07/20/three-poems-by-zafer-se-nocak-translated-from-the-turkish-by-kristin-dickinson/>

2 Georg Simmel, "The Stranger." trans. Rosalie Mosse. *Baffler* 30 (2016): 176–179.

3 Hannah Arendt, "The Jew as pariah: A hidden tradition." *Jewish Social Studies* 6/2 (1944): 99–122.; Zygmunt Bauman, "Modernity and ambivalence." *Theory, Culture & Society* 7/2–3 (1990): 143–169.; Zygmunt Bauman, *Modernity and Ambivalence*. (Cambridge: Polity Press. 1991); Simmel, "The Stranger", 176–179.

exploring the Stranger as a position of embodied difference theorized to make sense of the Jewish experience in Europe, I argue that strangerhood can also be used to understand the contemporary Muslim experience in Europe. Strangerhood here connects the particular to the universal, emerging as a category of experience that entails both subjectivation and agency, i.e. one that can be enlivened to emancipate Europe's ethnoreligious minorities from their marginal positionalities and silenced histories.⁴ Empirically, I center on four twentieth/twenty-first century Jewish and Muslim authors—Stefan Zweig, Albert Memmi, Zafer Şenocak and Fatima Besnaci-Lancou—and through their respective bodies of work, four respective configurations of strangerhood: the Stranger in exile (Zweig), the colonial Stranger (Memmi), the post-war Stranger (Şenocak) and the postcolonial Stranger (Rahmani).

2 Strangerhood: A Jewish Social Positionality?

In his seminal essay, 'The Stranger', Simmel⁵ articulated the concept of the Stranger as modernity's seminal insider-outsider, claiming the 'classic example' of this figure to be the 'European Jew'. Through the figure of the Stranger, Simmel described the liminal positionality of those who are somewhat, somehow part of a society, while also enduringly set apart from it. The Stranger, Simmel argued, was perceived as not only liminal in space but also liminal in time: understood as temporary, that is present, even residing within, while never truly belonging to the society at hand. Born to two parents who had converted from Judaism to Christianity, Simmel occupied this position himself.⁶ At times referenced as a baptized Jew, of Jewish ethnicity or of Jewish ancestry, he rarely identified himself as a Jew, but he remained identified by others as a Jew, and therefore relegated to a marginal social position.⁷ To this day, numerous scholars reference Simmel as a Jewish sociologist.⁸

4 Jakob Egholm Feldt, "The future of the stranger: Jewish exemplarity and the social imagination," *Journal of Classical Sociology* 20 (3, 2020): 225–243.

5 Georg Simmel, "The Stranger," trans. Rosalie Mosse. *Baffler* 30 (2016): 176–179.

6 Jukka and Olli Pyyhtinen Gronow, "Georg Simmel," *Oxford Bibliographies*. 26.11.2024 <https://www.oxfordbibliographies.com/display/document/obo-9780199756384/obo-9780199756384-0180.xml?rskey=yLzS2y&result=1&q=Georg+Simmel#firstMatch>

7 Amos Elon, *The Pity of It All: A Portrait of Jews in Germany, 1743–1933* (London: Penguin, 2004); Efraim Podoksik, "The case for the historical Simmel." *Simmel Studies* 26/2 (2022): 59–77.; Albert Salomon, "Georg Simmel reconsidered," *International Journal of Politics, Culture and Society* 8/3 (1995): 361–378.

8 Carolyn A. Goldberg, "The Jewish stranger in Germany and America," In *The Stranger in Early Modern and Modern Jewish Tradition*, ed. by Christina Bartlett and Joachim Schlör, (Leiden: Brill,

Arendt⁹ also turned towards the liminal positionality of European Jews as Strangers in her controversial essay 'The Jew as Pariah: A Hidden Tradition'.¹⁰ Arendt begins this essay by describing Kafka's novel, *The Castle*. 'The Castle, the one novel in which Kafka discusses the Jewish problem, is the only one in which the hero is plainly a Jew; yet even there what characterizes him as such is not any typically Jewish trait, but the fact that he is involved in situations and perplexities distinctive of Jewish life,' she writes.¹¹ These situations and perplexities revolve around the novel's hero coming to terms with his positionality as 'the Jew-stranger in the castle',¹² one who is 'superfluous "unwanted and in everyone's way"'.¹³ In this same essay, Arendt describes two ideal types (in the Weberian sense) of European Jews: those who call for equal political rights while accepting that they are set apart (the conscious pariah)¹⁴ and those who seek to assimilate in the society at hand (the parvenu).¹⁵ While Arendt prefers the pariah over the parvenu, she also famously concludes that this differentiation, in terms of social relations, ultimately proves moot. Even the attempt to cast off a Jewish identity, through conversion to Christianity—a common part of the assimilatory project of the parvenu—proves fruitless.¹⁶ That is, Jews had been and would continue to be set apart from the mainstream: a reality that she herself experienced with the rise of Nazism, cast into life-long exile. Ultimately, Arendt concludes that all Jews are Strangers who remain together 'in the same boat, rowing desperately in the same angry sea'.¹⁷

In this now-famous essay, Arendt sought to document the destruction and trauma of her generation. With the great clarity of hindsight, she confronted the cleavages between Europe and its Jews, who had been (temporarily) accepted only when they cast off their Jewish identities, as individuals but never as a collective group: a status that did not—could not—endure once fascism took hold.

2021): 78–95.; Amos Morris-Reich, *The Quest for Jewish Assimilation in Modern Social Science* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2012).

9 Arendt, "The Jew as pariah: A hidden tradition," 99–122.

10 Of the same generation as Simmel, Max Weber (2010) first described Jews as a pariah people. Max Weber, *Ancient Judaism*. trans. Hans H. Gerth and Don Martindale (New York: Free Press, 2010).

11 Arendt, "The Jew as pariah: A hidden tradition," 99–122, 115.

12 Ibid., 122.

13 Ibid., 115 (quoting Franz Kafka).

14 Ibid., 113 (quoting Lazare).

15 Ibid., 121.

16 Amos Elon, *The Pity of It All: A Portrait of Jews in Germany, 1743–1933*. London: Penguin, 2004.

17 Arendt, "The Jew as pariah: A hidden tradition", 122.

Arendt's essay was thus very much of her time, and part of a far broader attempt to reconcile what had happened during the Holocaust with the sociocultural undercurrents of European life. Of the same generation as Arendt, the sociologist Zygmunt Bauman built on and further sharpened the notion of the Jew as Stranger, nested within his broader theorization of the dark sides of modernity (the violent ordering project of the modern state). Bauman defined the 'conceptual Jew' as the 'prototypical' 'ethnic-religious-cultural stranger' produced by modern European society, in which the individual became subsumed into a negative category of difference.¹⁸

While Simmel arguably introduced the category of the Stranger, with both Arendt and Bauman building on his conceptualization in order to make sense of a particular Jewish distinctiveness that endured in modernity, all at the same time pointed to a more universal position of alterity.¹⁹ Building out from the notion of the Jewish Stranger, I also move from the particular to the universal potential of this theoretical concept, considering the contemporary Muslim positionality in Europe as one of strangerhood. Numerous parallels can be made between the Muslim positionality in late twentieth to early twenty-first century Europe and the Jewish positionality in late nineteenth to early twentieth century Europe; both Jews and Muslims have been perceived as introducing unwelcome otherness into idealized Christian-centric visions of whose Europe is and what Europe should be. That is, just as questions of strangerhood were long bound up with the so-called Jewish Question dominating European public discourses on identity and belonging in modern Europe, they are today bound up with the so-called Muslim Question around which such discussions of identity and belonging now revolve.²⁰

¹⁸ Zygmunt Bauman, *Modernity and Ambivalence* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1991), 71, 85; Zygmunt Bauman, *Modernity and the Holocaust* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2001), 39.

¹⁹ Y. Michael Bodemann, "Von Berlin nach Chicago und weiter. Georg Simmel und die Reise seines 'Fremden'," *Berliner Journal für Soziologie* 8/1 (1998): 125–142.; Jakob Egholm Feldt, "The future of the stranger: Jewish exemplarity and the social imagination," *Journal of Classical Sociology* 20/3 (2020): 225–243.; Adam Sutcliffe, "The Stranger as self and other: Georg Simmel, Hermann Cohen, and the significance of Jewish difference," *Jewish Quarterly Review* 111/2 (2021): 300–303.

²⁰ Gil Anidjar, "On the European question." *Belgrade Journal of Media and Communications* 2/3 (2013): 37–50; Elisabeth Becker, *Mosques in the Metropolis: Incivility, Caste, and Contention in Europe* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2021); Anne Norton, *On the Muslim Question* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2013).

Europe's othering tendencies, if transformed in target and form, have been one of few constants amidst the upheavals of the last century.²¹ The experiences of Muslims and Jews thus cannot and should not be collapsed into a singular narrative of othering, but together—rather than fixate on the Jewish Question and/or Muslim Question—they can help us to reorient towards the Question of Europe, which is arguably the dominant question of our time.²² Such a reorientation, which reframes Muslims and Jews as co-Strangers of Europe, further presents an opportunity to move away from the dialogic relationships of Europe-Jew, Europe-Muslim or Muslim-Jew, to the trialogic relationship of Europe-Muslim-Jew.²³ And it guides us towards a reoriented theoretical perspective of Europe and its internal 'Others' as co-constitutive, their 'interarticulation' (a concept put forth by George Mosse): made by, against, through, and therefore always with one another.²⁴

21 While I argue that the so-called Muslim question has displaced the so-called Jewish question in terms of a primary reference point for hierarchies and exclusions, Jews and Muslims have also long been othered together. For instance, the blood purity laws of the Reconquista deemed both Jews and Muslims impure; and contemporary regulations, such as the 2012 circumcision ban in Germany (since reversed) targeted both Muslims and Jews. Thus, this replacement of the ultimate other in Europe has not been a linear or totalizing process (See Martínez, 2008; Amir-Moazami, 2016). María Elena Martínez, *Genealogical Fictions: Limpieza de Sangre, Religion, and Gender in Colonial Mexico*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2008. Shirin Amir-Moazami, "Investigating the secular body: The politics of the male circumcision debate in Germany." *ReOrient* 1/2 (2016): 147–170.

22 Elisabeth Becker, "Struggles for horizontal identification: Muslims, Jews, and the civil sphere in Germany," *Cultural Sociology* 17/1 (2023): 44–61.

23 Elisabeth Becker, "Another fateful triangle: Jews, Muslims, Europe." *Religions* 14 (2024): 1342; Muslim and Arab are often used in analogous ways in social and political campaigns of difference. In reality, these group categories and/or identities intersect and interact but are not one and the same. Albert Memmi's writings (2020) [see footnote 72], in particular, provide an opportunity to critically engage with this false collapsing of categories and identities. In her engagement with Memmi's work, Samia Hathroubi (in this volume) [see footnote 73] also draws attention to the triologue, here between the Jew-Arab-colonial France. Albert Memmi, *The Albert Memmi Reader*. eds. Jonathan Judaken and Michael Lejman (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2020). Samia Hathroubi, "Memmi's Arab-Jew notion and its mobilisation of a hybrid notion in France today." (in this volume)

24 Stefan P. Dudink, "Homosexuality, race, and the rhetoric of nationalism," *History of the Present: A Journal of Critical History* 1/2 (2011): 259–264, 260.

3 Critical Strangerhood: Writing Europe from the Margins

Max Weber understood Jews as a pariah people and Judaism as a ‘religion of suffering’ that placed Jews outside of history.²⁵ They were not, however, outside of history, but instead through such suffering, the Stranger positionality motivated them to act upon and shape history. In other words, while strangerhood was and is a position of marginality, it is not only one of subjectification. It is equally one of agency. As Bauman powerfully asserts: ‘the Stranger rebels.’²⁶

What I term ‘critical strangerhood’ is one instantiation of this agency. Critical strangerhood is a form of self-articulation that resists both marginality in the present and an absence from history: creating a ‘third space’ between full inclusion and full exclusion, which is ‘a space of possibility – a space of critique, of poetry, of reflection, of debate.’²⁷ As I will showcase in the following four examples of authors, the experience of being Strangers became the jumping off point for the critical writings of both Muslims and Jews in contemporary Europe. Just as Simmel, Arendt and Bauman used the particular experience of European Jews to theorize the Stranger as at once befitting the Jews and as a more universal category of social differentiation, these authors have animated their particular experiences as part of the more universal experience of violence and exclusion in twentieth to twenty-first century Europe: experiences of exile and colonialism, as well as post-war rebuilding and postcolonial reconfiguration through pressures from the margins.

In the following section, I engage with the work of these authors in chronological order, beginning with the experience of strangerhood in exile from Europe during the Holocaust and its aftermath (vis-à-vis Zweig) to the experience of colonial strangerhood (vis-à-vis Memmi) and strangerhood in the wake of both of these violent projects (vis-à-vis Şenocak, in terms of postwar strangerhood and Fatima Besnaci-Lancou, in terms of postcolonial strangerhood). Through the voices inscribed in the (semi)autobiographical texts of these four authors, I trace the conceptualization of strangerhood across a century of rupture and renewal, while honing in on the implications of a theory critical strangerhood for history, identity and, ultimately, the enduring interdependence of Europe and its others.

²⁵ Max Weber, *The Sociology of Religion*. trans. Ephraim Fischoff (London: Methuen, 1966), 111.

²⁶ Bauman, “Modernity and ambivalence,” 143–169, 145.

²⁷ Gilane Tawadros, “The revolution stripped bare,” *Nka: Journal of Contemporary African Art* 22–23 (2008): 60–79, 67.

3.1 Stefan Zweig and Homelessness: The Stranger of Exile

Born in Vienna in 1881, Stefan Zweig rose as a celebrated literary figure first in early-twentieth century Austria and then on a global scale. Zweig's writing took many forms: fiction and nonfiction, plays, journalism and historical biographies, including that of Marie Antoinette.²⁸ He turned his pen on himself, writing his own autobiography, *The World of Yesterday: Memoirs of a European*, after being cast out of Vienna in 1937: migrating first to London, then briefly to New York City and finally resettling with his wife in Petrópolis, Brazil.²⁹ In *The World of Yesterday*, Zweig traced the parallel downfalls of Europe and his own life. Interweaving historical shifts with autobiography, Zweig wrote of the grief that consumed him as he faced the destruction of the whole world he had known. His sense of strangerhood deepened when linked to the experience of exile in particular, and to the loss not only of his motherland but also the dignity of his mother tongue. 'My literary work, in the language in which I wrote it, has been burnt to ashes in the country where my books made millions of readers their friends. So I belong nowhere now, I am a stranger or at the most a guest everywhere. Even the true home of my heart's desire, Europe, is lost to me after twice tearing itself suicidally to pieces in fratricidal wars.'³⁰

As a German Jewish poet of the same generation, Nelly Sachs³¹ wrote in a poem, 'A stranger always has / his homeland in his arms / like an orphan / for whom he may be seeking nothing / but a grave'. With his homeland metaphorically in his arms, Zweig sought, but could not find peace, neither in the bustling New York City metropolis nor the small mountain town of Petrópolis, where he committed suicide on 22 February, 1942. In the letter that he wrote to accompany his death, he described his 'homeless wandering' following immense loss: 'the world of my own language having disappeared for me and my spiritual home, Europe, having destroyed itself'.³²

28 Leon Botstein, "Stefan Zweig and the illusion of the Jewish European." *Jewish Social Studies* 44/1 (1982): 63–84.

29 Stefan Zweig, *The World of Yesterday: Memoirs of a European*. trans. Anthea Bell (London: Pushkin Press, 2011); Stefan Zweig and Lotte Zweig, *Stefan and Lotte Zweig's South American Letters: New York, Argentina and Brazil, 1940–42*. ed. David J. Davis and Oliver Marshall (London: Continuum, 2010).

30 Stefan Zweig, *The World of Yesterday: Memoirs of a European*. trans. Anthea Bell (London: Pushkin Press, 2011), 18.

31 Nelly Sachs, *Flight and Metamorphosis: Poems – A Bilingual Edition*. trans. Joshua Weiner and Lynn B. Parshall (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2022), 95.

32 Leo Spitzer, *Lives in Between: Assimilation and Marginality in Austria, Brazil, West Africa, 1780–1945* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 171–172.

Since his death, Zweig has been portrayed by literary theorists as a nostalgic scribe of German-speaking Europe in its ‘German-Jewish epoch’, although Jews had in fact faced great discrimination before the unspeakable violence that consumed their lives under the Nazi project of expansion and annihilation.³³ Zweig had always been part of Europe’s margins, but he had—as a celebrated author—also been partially, temporarily included within its core. It was in exile from the Europe he had known, helped to grow, and grown to love that Zweig recognized his own strangerhood, as a Jew, in a devastating way. He wrote from exile of the parallel threads that tied him both to Europe and to Jewishness, longing for the former while refusing to distance himself from the latter. ‘If Judaism is a tragedy, let’s live with it,’³⁴ he implored, connecting his own ultimate rootlessness to the historical tragedy of the Jewish people, as ‘a community of outcasts driven out again and again since the exile from Egypt.’³⁵ And yet in his late writings, Zweig also identified the productive potentiality of this positionality, writing that ‘the homeless, more than anyone, are free in a new way.’³⁶ And he similarly identified his own particular ‘duty to bear witness’ through his writings, a form of sight into a buried past that far outlasted his premature death.³⁷ Today, these writings provide what Walter Benjamin described as a ‘window-mirror’, the ability to see into and also reflect that extended era of exile: the Strangers of Europe cast out past its geographical margins, stuck in an ‘unhealable rift’ of enduring longing and the unfilled desires of finding home in exile.³⁸

3.2 Albert Memmi and the Tear: The Colonial Stranger

Albert Memmi’s career as an author was rooted not in a position of exile, but another in-between. In the colonial context, he occupied an uncertain and unsettled

33 Steven Beller, “The World of Yesterday revisited: Nostalgia, memory, and the Jews of fin-de-siècle Vienna,” *Jewish Social Studies* 2/2 (1996): 37–53.; Amos Elon, *The Pity of It All: A Portrait of Jews in Germany, 1743–1933*, (London: Penguin, 2004).

34 Ofer Aderet, “Trove of letters spotlights Stefan Zweig’s take on Judaism, Zionism and writing,” *Haaretz*, 26.11.2024 <https://www.haaretz.com/jewish/2016-11-16/ty-article/.premium/trove-of-letters-spotlights-stefan-zweigs-take-on-judaism-zionism-and-writing/0000017f-dc0c-df62-a9ff-dcdfec780000>

35 Zweig, *The World of Yesterday*, 454.

36 *Ibid.*, 17.

37 *Ibid.*, 21.

38 Walter Benjamin, *The Arcades Project*. trans. Howard Eiland and Kevin McLaughlin (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1999), 542 [R3, 1]; Edward Said, *Reflections on Exile and Other Essays* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002), 173.

place between Tunis and Paris. Born in Tunis to a Jewish Italian father and a Jewish Berber mother on December 15, 1920, Memmi termed himself an 'Arab Jew', invoking an experience of double strangerhood (of the colonized Arab within a colonial regime and as the minority Jew within a majority Muslim society).³⁹ And yet in his first-person writings, Memmi also articulated this double strangerhood as imbuing him with a critical sharpness, the capacity to understand more than others, those who belonged more easily, around him: whether in Tunisia or later in France. 'I was sort of a half-breed of colonization, understanding everyone because I belonged completely to no one', he writes.⁴⁰ Memmi reflects on this positionality in *Portrait of a Jew*, his autobiographical work published in 1962, in which he grappled with the cleavages of identities and categories as North African societies confronted colonization with force, seeking to reconstruct themselves on their own grounds.⁴¹

That Memmi spent his childhood on the edge of the Jewish ghetto, on a dead-end street, is symbolically potent and pertinent for a person defined by edges and in-betweenness. It is this position on the fringe, part of society while set apart from its center, from which Memmi came to speak and to prolifically write. Continuity in ruptures, home-ness in movement, empowerment in the margins: all of these seeming paradoxes that emerge throughout Memmi's writings encapsulate the experience of the Stranger in modern Europe. This at-once emotional and physical in-betweenness is embodied in published images of Memmi in his Parisian living room, outfitted in Tunisian fabrics, cushions and objects.⁴² Although he lived his adulthood in Paris, Tunis played an enduring role in Memmi's work, as backdrop to his self-reconfigurations: whether in explicit or implicit autobiographical form (the later most pronounced in his novel, *The Pillar of Salt*, published in 1955; in it, the protagonist is called to negate himself as Jew, Arab and African in his striving to become French, but finds himself unable to do so as he confronts his layered past).⁴³

In *The Colonizer and the Colonized*, arguably his most famous text, Memmi⁴⁴ illuminates the necessary translation of his individual experience—'I simply

39 Janice Hayes, "Circumcising Zionism, queering diaspora: Reviving Albert Memmi's penis" *Wasafiri* 22/1 (2007): 6–11.

40 Albert Memmi, *The Albert Memmi Reader*. eds. Jonathan Judaken and Michael Lejman (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2020), 12.

41 Albert Memmi, *Portrait of a Jew*. trans. Elisabeth Abbott. Lexington, MA: Plunkett Lake Press [1962] 2013.

42 See Sam Roberts, "Albert Memmi, a 'Jewish Arab' intellectual, dies at 99," *The New York Times*, 07.01.2025 <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/10/books/albert-memmi-a-jewish-arab-intellectual-dies-at-99.html>

43 Albert Memmi, *The Pillar of Salt*. trans. Edouard Roditi (Boston: Beacon Press [1955] 1992).

44 Albert Memmi, *The Colonizer and the Colonized*. trans. Howard Greenfeld (London: Earthscan, [1957] 2003), 5, 12.

wanted to understand the colonial relationship to which I was bound'—into a far more collective one—'so many different persons saw themselves in this portrait that it became impossible to pretend that it was mine alone, or only that of colonized Tunisians, or even North Africans'. He (like Simmel, Arendt and Bauman too) thus begins from the particular and extends his writings outwards, seeking to theorize a more universal understanding. Memmi writes, 'I have hardly ever made any books that weren't born out of experience, of a lived experience. I start from experience and from there I try to theorize'.⁴⁵ Although made and constrained by the colonial order into which he was born (told, for instance, that his desire to study philosophy was but a 'colonial hope'), Memmi⁴⁶ powerfully—if painfully—attempts to transcend the boundaries of the colonial world, as well as the boundaries within the colonized world as an Arab Jew. Jonathan Judaken⁴⁷ argues that Memmi has no choice but to at once embody, and therefore speak/write from his perspective of multiplicity. And Guy Dugas⁴⁸ echoes this fate, by describing Memmi as 'writer of the tear': the experience of being attached and detached, part of—and yet torn from—the whole.

For the colonial Stranger, it is impossible to find wholeness, a settled self, in the midst of so many painful and purposeful divisions. Like Arendt, Memmi traces the responses of the Stranger to lasting, if partial, exclusions (for himself, as the colonized Arab Jew) as multiple: and also as dynamic, through the process of assimilation-rejection-revolt. He argues⁴⁹ that at first, the colonized attempts to become like the colonizer, assimilating through 'internal convulsions and contortions' (akin to Arendt's parvenu). 'Many Jews would, if they could, tear out their souls—that soul which, they are told, is irremediably bad', he writes.⁵⁰ And yet assimilation ultimately proves impossible: with the colonial project founded upon enduring hierarchies and marginalities, a so-called 'core' and periphery, a division between the civilized European and the uncivilized non-European (or rather, the grey-making partial/peripheral Europeans, Strangers as colonial subjects). Of the colonized, Memmi concludes, 'The major impossibility is not negating one's existence, for he soon discovers that, even if he agrees to everything, he would not be saved. In order to be assimilated, it is not enough to leave one's group, but one must enter another;

⁴⁵ Albert Memmi, *Le Juif et l'Autre*, (Paris: Editions Nartillat, 1995).

⁴⁶ Memmi, *The Colonizer and the Colonized*, 4.

⁴⁷ Jonathan Judaken, "Introduction," in *The Albert Memmi Reader*, ed. Jonathan Judaken and Michael Lejman, (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2020): xv–xliv.

⁴⁸ Guy Dugas, *Albert Memmi: Écrivain de la déchirure* (Sherbrooke, Quebec: Éditions Naaman, 1984).

⁴⁹ Memmi, *The Colonizer and the Colonized*, 166.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 166.

now he meets with the colonizer's rejection.⁵¹ The colonized are left with no choice, just as Arendt's pariah, but to recognize their incapacity to ever fully belong. And yet Memmi takes this one step further than Arendt, as he argues that the colonized must finally revolt. Still, the interdependence of the Stranger and those who estrange him remains, as even in attempts to cast off the colonial order, 'The colonized's self-assertion, born out of a protest, continues to define itself in relation to it. In the midst of revolt, the colonized continues to think, feel and live against and, therefore, in relation to the colonizer and colonization.'⁵² The interarticulation of the colonial Stranger and Europe proves inescapable for all.⁵³

3.3 Zafer Şenocak and the Hyphen: The Postwar Stranger

Zafer Şenocak speaks in his extensive writings to his experience as the child of a 'guestworker' from Turkey who migrated to Germany, and to the experience of an entire generation of post-war Strangers in Europe. Born in Ankara in 1961, Şenocak moved with his parents to Bavaria in 1970, for his father's work in the post-war guestworker program.⁵⁴ After World War II, workers like his father and tens of thousands of others were called to Germany to literally rebuild its shattered infrastructure.⁵⁵ In his writings that span fiction, non-fiction and poetry, Şenocak—a leading figure of the 'Turkish turn in German literature'⁵⁶—rose as one of the first known proponents of hyphenated Turkish-German identities: connective rather than fragmented, fractured or torn. He also became perhaps the first writer who identifies, in the place of bilateral Jewish-German or Muslim-German

⁵¹ Ibid., 168.

⁵² Memmi, *The Colonizer and the Colonized*, 183.

⁵³ Dudink, "Homosexuality, race, and the rhetoric of nationalism," 260.

⁵⁴ Tom Cheesman, "Ş/ß: Zafer Şenocak and the civilization of clashes," In *Zafer Şenocak*, eds. Tom Cheesman and Karin E. Yeşilada, 144–158 (Cardiff: University of Wales Press, 2003); Donna N. Coury, "Enlightenment fundamentalism: Zafer Şenocak, Navid Kermani, and multiculturalism in Germany Today," *Edinburgh German Yearbook*, vol 7: *Ethical Approaches in Contemporary German-Language Literature and Culture*, eds. Emily Jeremiah and Frauke Matthes (Rochester, NY: Camden House, 2013); Ernest Gellner, "Das Verhältnis zwischen Heiligem und Profanem muss immer wieder mit Spannung aufgeladen werden": *Islam in Texten von Zafer Şenocak*. In *Islam in der deutschen und türkischen Literatur*, eds. Klaus von Stosch and Matthias Hofmann (Paderborn: Ferdinand Schöningh, 2012): 153–173.

⁵⁵ Stephen Castles, "Guestworkers in Europe: A resurrection?" *International Migration Review* 40/4 (2006): 741–766.

⁵⁶ Leslie A. Adelson, "The Turkish turn in contemporary German literature and memory work," *The Germanic Review: Literature, Culture, Theory* 77/4 (2002): 326–338, 326.

relationality, a trilateral relationship between Muslims, Jews and Germany. (This is different from Memmi's own trialogue, of the Jew-Arab-African, but similarly moves from dualistic to triangulated struggles over identity and belonging). In his celebrated 1998 novel *Gefährliche Verwandtschaft* (Dangerous Relatives),⁵⁷ Şenocak introduces a protagonist who embodies this 'trialogue' of German, Jewish and Turkish identities. The biography of this novel's protagonist-cum-narrator, Sascha, introduces layered ambiguities in terms of both the German present and its past, unsettling assumed social boundaries by crafting a (fictional and yet timely) conversation between Germans, Muslims, and Jews in Germany present and past. Like Memmi, Şenocak highlights how plurality begins not on the communal level, but instead within the individual. And yet in other ways, his work can be juxtaposed to that of Memmi (as 'writer of the tear'), as he focuses on cohesion and uniting, by rethinking identities' intersections and overlaps: the spaces not of opening but enmeshment that create new forms. For example, Şenocak writes of the translator as speaking a third language and thereby occupying a third space, making new meaning through the very act of translation itself.

Şenocak's rethinking does not, however, entail coherence. Rather he embraces the uncertain, incoherent, ambiguous: the Stranger. Unlike Arendt, he sees the Stranger as neither necessarily pariah or parvenu, but instead as an innovative, if discomfiting, in-between. 'Integration in our times is a highly contradictory, complicated process', he writes.⁵⁸ 'It creates people with multiple identities, people with fractures in their biographies that can no longer be categorized through a fixation on some unambiguous idea'. Şenocak himself is one of these very people, and describes in beautiful prose how this biographical dynamism affects all of his senses. He reflects, for instance, on the taste of milk and Milka chocolate bars after he arrives in Munich, juxtaposed with the fresh cow milk of his early childhood in Turkey.⁵⁹ Unlike Zweig, Şenocak does not lose but instead recognizes both the multi-locality and the dynamism in his experiences of home. His notion of 'Heimat' is more than a fixed site; it is one transported in his life across the borders that fail to contain him, and that he is not afraid to cross.

Like Zweig and Memmi, Şenocak speaks to a particular generation of Strangers and a particular experience of strangerhood: the experience of post-war strangerhood among those objectified and externalized as labor from European nations after World War II. His father was part of the generational wave from Turkey that literally

57 Zafer Şenocak, *Gefährliche Verwandtschaft* (Berlin: Babel, 1998).

58 Zafer Şenocak, "Fragments of memory: Excerpts from Zafer Şenocak's *Zugenentfernung*," trans. Jill Nicholl and Mark Schwalm, *Transit* 8 (1). 27.11.2023 <https://transit.berkeley.edu/2012/nicholl-schwalm/#>

59 Şenocak, "Fragments of memory: Excerpts from Zafer Şenocak's *Zugenentfernung*,"

rebuilt the grounds of Germany, and yet never entirely belonged to this rebirthed old country, whose railways they laid like veins across a shattered world (the same 'world of yesterday' that had cast Stefan Zweig out).⁶⁰ Still, like Memmi, Şenocak moves from the particular to the general in order to communicate this experience of strangerhood, that is from the autobiographical to the broader social world. In his poem, which is the epithet of this article, "That Which Befell You Neither Occurred Nor Didn't Occur", Şenocak captures the universal experience of the Stranger as 'neither within nor without', inside but also outside, always arriving and departing, 'neither heard nor silent'.⁶¹ 'To wrestle out of silence', Şenocak replies to an interviewer who asks him about the task of a novelist.⁶² Himself rooted in the multicultural and multilingual experience of being Turkish-German, Şenocak exposes a shared longing to belong both to the present and to the history of Europe. He explores this longing for more intimate connections to persons and also place through, for instance, a series of essays (*Das Fremde, das in jedem wohnt*, *The Stranger that Lives in Everyone*). In one, "Empty Archives—Lost Letters", he delves into the depths of his mother's memory, and expunges her neighbors' unwillingness to share their personal histories.⁶³ What Şenocak calls for across his writings is, ultimately, a more inclusive and hyphenated approach to memory: one that begins with accepting plural personal memories ('the stranger that lives in everyone'), memories from the margins that lay the pathways, those veins that lead to the beating heart of a more inclusive present.

3.4 Fatima Besnaci-Lancou and Polyphonic History: The Postcolonial Stranger

Zafer Şenocak's project of creating a more inclusive memory and thereby history is one echoed in both writing and action by the so-called *Filles de harkis* (daugh-

⁶⁰ Ernest Gellner, "Das Verhältnis zwischen Heiligem und Profanem muss immer wieder mit Spannung aufgeladen werden: Islam in Texten von Zafer Şenocak." in *Islam in der deutschen und türkischen Literatur*, eds. Klaus von Stosch and Matthias Hofmann, (Paderborn: Ferdinand Schöningh, 2012): 153–173; Stefan Zweig, *The World of Yesterday: Memoirs of a European*. trans. Anthea Bell (London: Pushkin Press, 2011).

⁶¹ Zafer Şenocak, "Three poems by Zafer Şenocak," trans. Kristin Dickinson, *Another Chicago Magazine*. 6.11.2024 <https://anotherchicagomagazine.net/2021/07/20/three-poems-by-zafer-senocak-translated-from-the-turkish-by-kristin-dickinson/>

⁶² Elaine Sun, "Imagining the other side of things: Zafer Şenocak and hidden archives," *Multicultural Germany Project*. 7.1.2025 <https://mcp.berkeley.edu/2021/04/16/imagining-the-other-side-of-things-zafer-senocak-and-hidden-archives/>

⁶³ Zafer Şenocak, *Das Fremde, das in jedem wohnt: Wie Unterschiede unsere Gesellschaft zusammenhalten* (Bielefeld: edition werkstatt, 2018).

ters of the Harkis) in France. This handful of authors, most notably Fatima Besnaci-Lancou, Dalia Kerchouche, Hadjila Kemoum and Zahia Rahmani, have come to embody the strangerhood of postcolonialism. Their written projects were born as concerted attempts at unsilencing the histories of their fathers, and also creating an inclusive national memory culture, in which Algerian Muslims who had fought alongside the French Republican soldiers during the Algerian War became recognized as part of France, rather than stigmatized Others.⁶⁴ Their written projects were integrated into broader social and political configurations, with Besnaci-Lancou co-founding the *association harkis et droits de l'Homme* (Association of Harkis and Human Rights) with Kemoum, another of the Harkis' daughters in 2004.⁶⁵ As part of this organization, Besnaci-Lancou wrote and disseminated *Le manifeste pour la ré-appropriation des mémoires confisquées* (The Manifesto for the Recuperation of Confiscated Memories)⁶⁶ presented in the French Parliament in 2004, calling for a dissolution of 'simplistic qualities' in the way that experiences and roles during the Algerian War of Decolonization had been publicly coded, resulting in the relegation of the Harkis to the societal margins. While working to reconstruct a more inclusive France after the war, Besnaci-Lancou asserted in this manifesto: 'We need to reweave the fabric of this confiscated memory of this obscured lineage', rejecting the 'fragmented narrative', demanding in its place a full, defragmented understanding of history that would require the cooperation of France and Algeria. In so doing, she pointed to the burdens of exile shared by Harkis and others who migrated from Algeria to France, the weight of such a burden having crushed Stefan Zweig.

Coinciding with the period of decolonization, which stretched from 1954–1962, Besnaci-Lancou's story as a postcolonial Stranger begins with her birth in 1954, in Sidi Ghiles, Algeria and is equally punctuated by her family's move to France in 1962. When the Harkis, including her father, fled to France in the early 1960s, they were held in so-called 'reception estates', and denied French citizenship: referenced and treated as refugees, who could not move freely in French society.⁶⁷ Harkis who eventually settled in France largely turned away from and/or hid their personal histories, exposed only through biographical accounts shared with (and later inter-

64 Géraldine Enjelvin and Nada Korac-Kakabadse, "France and the memories of "Others": The case of the Harkis," *History & Memory* 24/1 (2012): 152–177.

65 Enjelvin, Korac-Kakabadse, "France and the memories of "Others," 152–177.

66 Fatima Besnaci-Lancou, *Le manifeste pour la ré-appropriation des mémoires confisquées*, 25.1.2025 <https://associationahdh.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/08/529c1-le-manifeste-for-the-reappropriation-of-confiscated-memories.pdf>

67 Claire Eldridge, *From Empire to Exile: History and Memory Within the Pied-noir and Harki Communities, 1962–2012* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2016).

rogated by) their families. Besnaci-Lancou was one of the four daughters of Harkis' who rose as mainstream authors in France, with her writing project focused on confronting, documenting and contesting the stigma that colored her father's life. Her work connects back to Zweig's notion of a duty to bear witness, while also building upon it, as one of the 'architects of Harki memory'.⁶⁸ As Memmi wrote, 'The most serious blow suffered by the colonized is being removed from history and from the community'.⁶⁹ The daughters of the Harkis, Besnaci-Lancou included, identified their personal duty as that of constructing a more honest and inclusive history, beginning from their autobiographies and moving outward from there (again, from the particular to the universal): re-emplacing their fathers, and thereby not just themselves but so many other Others, in the collective memory of France. Their acts of writing became acts to re-present, that is both represent and again make present the complicated histories of France's colonial project and its lasting human—but also, often, inhumane—aftermath. In so doing, the Harkis' daughters chartered a path to a more inclusive history, a 'polyphonic' version of history.⁷⁰ They did so specifically by writing autobiographical-historical books that complexified their fathers' roles in history. This led to an unsilencing and equally to an unsettling: calling into question the easy and equally false sociocultural boundaries between the colony and the 'mother' metropolis. It led to a reconfiguration of both spatial and imagined exclusions present and past.

The project of the Harkis' daughters is one of speaking not only of, but also for their fathers. In her text *Fille de harki* (Daughter of a Harki),⁷¹ Besnaci-Lancou exposes her father's lack of language to describe his experience of indignity and shame. This juxtaposes with the post-war experience of Şenocak, who speaks a third tongue, as the translator and inhabitant of two language-worlds, as well as the third that extends between them. 'They did not speak, but were spoken to' writes Géraldine Enjelvin⁷² of the Harkis, who were often called the 'generation of silence' in France, a name notably also given to those exiles like Zweig, who

68 Lana J. Sims, "Rethinking France's "memory wars": Harki collective memories, 2003–2010." *French Politics, Culture and Society* 34/3 (2016): 83–104, 86.

69 Albert Memmi, *The Colonizer and the Colonized*. trans. Howard Greenfeld (London: Earthscan, [1957] 2003), 135.

70 Enjelvin, Korac-Kakabadse, "France and the memories of "Others", ", 152.

71 Fatima Besnaci-Lancou, *Fille de harki: "Le bouleversant témoignage d'une enfant de la guerre d'Algérie"* (Paris: Atelier, 2005).

72 Géraldine Enjelvin, "The Harki identity: a product of marginalisation and resistance to symbolic violence?" *National Identities* 8/2 (2006): 113–127, 118.

fled Europe during the Holocaust.⁷³ Similar to the post-war Stranger, the post-colonial Stranger here attempts to heal the tears experienced in the colonial era: to overcome neat dichotomies (in this case of ‘traitor/hero’), replacing these dualities with a more complex web of relations articulated through the voices of the silenced’s children. Here another triangle of relations emerges, that of the father-daughter-state. Besnaci-Lancou’s work, *Daughter of a Harki*, in particular, has been referenced as a ‘collecto-biography’, that is in conversation and a piece of the larger body of publications by Harkis’ daughters who rose as authors and public figures contesting the divisive erasures of recent French history that stretched across and thereby effected generations.⁷⁴ It is part of a larger collection of work that makes up a ‘harkeological quest’ for a polyphonic version of history, in which the Harkis’ experiences could be recognized equally as integrated and integral parts of contemporary France.⁷⁵

4 Conclusion

While these four types of strangerhood diverge, the authors at the center of this article also share a great deal with one another. Witnessing is a trope that runs through the works of all four authors, linked by their concerns for memory and for history, including their responsibility to narrate—whether in autobiographical or semi-fictional accounts—the social crises of their times. All are also aware of the tension between opening and closure, and between insider and outsider. All suggest a kind of hyphenation, of being both/and, rather than either/or. All reside and write from the societal margins. All are, ultimately, critical Strangers who occupy a kind of third space between full inclusion and full exclusion from the European societies from and about which they write. ‘It is always through language that you build your world and inhabit it,’ (*C’est toujours par la langue que l’on construit son monde et qu’on l’habite*) explains Zahia Rahmani, one the Harkis

73 Enjelvin, “The Harki identity,” 118; Kata Moser, “Breaking the silence or using it to speak? An exploration of silence as a literary device in four Harki narratives,” *French Cultural Sociology* 24 (1, 2013): 44–62.

74 Nicola Sutherland, “Harki autobiographies or collecto-biographies? Mothers speak through their daughters,” *Romance Studies* 24/3 (2006): 193–201.

75 Susan Ireland, “Moving beyond the legacies of war in second-generation Harki narratives,” in *Post-Migratory Cultures in Postcolonial France*, ed. by Katharina Kleppinger and Lise Reeck, (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2018): 112–128, p. 123.; Bohdan Stepanov, “The implicated subject: colonial atrocity, harki identity, and an ontology of the in-between,” *Violence: An International Journal* 4 (1–2, 2023): 30–47, 44.

daughters, in a interview with Philippe Guillibert for *Vacarme*.⁷⁶ 'If I say "la main" (afus) or "étranger" (abrrani), it's not just words that come to me, it's a world that I conjure up. There is a politics of language that is relative to the possibility of its exercise in the social space' (*Si je dis « la main » (afus) ou « étranger » (abrrani), ce ne sont pas seulement des mots qui viennent, c'est un monde que je convoque. Il y a une politique de la langue qui est relative à la possibilité de son exercice dans l'espace social*). Rahmani continues by describing the idealistic potentiality of 'writing as righting'.⁷⁷

Whether or not writing makes 'right', writing makes known. Writing confronts through exposure, creating lasting narratives that unsilence. The Stranger as author may be discomfiting and unsettling, but, as Arendt argued, the goal should not be to make the Stranger like 'us'.⁷⁸ Both Levinas and Buber echo that 'to make the stranger familiar is somehow to do violence to the otherness of the other'.⁷⁹ All assert that the Stranger must be recognized, known and dignified on their own terms.

This notion of respecting the integrity and the illuminating potentiality of the Stranger is in fact deeply rooted in both Jewish and Islamic religious thought. Jewish religious thought posits that the Stranger should be met with openness and empathy, rather than exclusion and violence. As written in Exodus 22:21, "You shall not wrong a stranger or oppress him, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt." Of the same generation as Simmel, the Jewish philosopher and theologian Hermann Cohen explicitly linked theological references regarding the Stranger in the Talmud to the role or purpose of the Jews in the messianic project of humanity.⁸⁰ He thus moved from the Stranger as an uncomfortable and discomfiting positionality to the Stranger as signaling an ethical responsibility or imperative. Adam Sutcliffe writes that, 'For Simmel, the stranger was an analytical model for understanding the Jewish self; but for Cohen, the stranger was an alien figure, in loving response to whom Jews most profoundly

76 Philippe Guillibert, "Paradis perdus: Entretien avec Zahia Rahmani," *Vacarme*. 7.11.2025). <https://vacarme.org/article3237.html>

77 Philippe Guillibert, "Paradis perdus: Entretien avec Zahia Rahmani," *Vacarme*. 7.11.2025). <https://vacarme.org/article3237.html>

78 Phillip Hansen, "Hannah Arendt and bearing with strangers," *Contemporary Political Theory* 3/1 (2004): 3–22.

79 Lisbeth Lipari, "Listening for the other: Ethical implications of the Buber-Levinas encounter," *Communication Theory* 14/2 (2004): 122–141, 138.

80 Hermann Cohen, *Religion of Reason: Out of the Sources of Judaism*. trans. Simon Kaplan (New York: Frederick Ungar, 1972).

inhabited their ethical responsibility and mission'.⁸¹ For Cohen, it was the embrace of the Stranger, both in legal protections and compassion that sat at the heart of the Jewish experience in regard to justice.⁸² Jewish religious thought thus also speaks to the chameleonic nature of this positionality, one not essential to any group or identity, but rather held by different groups—in association with different identities—across different places and times. The figure of the Stranger is equally present in Muslim thought. In his work on Al-Ghazali, Ebrahim Moosa, contemporary scholar of Islamic thought, writes of the unique knowledge-producing capacity of the Stranger who inhabits the literal and/or cultural threshold space (*dihliz*),⁸³ 'that experience allows one to see things—to view things in a way that a domesticated or complacent gaze may fail to observe'. That is, the Stranger positionality endows the subject with a kind of critical gaze that clarifies; as Bauman writes, 'always on the outside even when inside, examining the familiar as if it was a foreign object of study, asking questions no one else asked, questioning the unquestionable and challenging the unchallengeable'.⁸⁴

The critical Stranger, in the herein orchestrated, triangulated conversation between Jewish authors, Muslim authors and Europe, becomes not only in-between, transcending boundaries and order but also intermediary, able to speak—in both literal and figurative languages—across multiple sociocultural entities: at once creative maker and inhabitant of a third space. These incarnations of what I theorize as 'critical strangerhood' are particularly vital at a time of democratic erosion and fragmentation, with rising far-right wing movements across Europe and beyond. In a recent essay on European democracy, Şenocak himself reflected: 'The test of European democracies is yet to come. It is, of course, important to prevent social and economic distortions. But there is more at stake. It is about the human image, about our self-perception and about the perception of strangers.'⁸⁵

The test of European democracies is yet to come but also very much bound up with the past, that which came and went, albeit not without leaving its marks,

⁸¹ Adam Sutcliffe, "The Stranger as self and other: Georg Simmel, Hermann Cohen, and the significance of Jewish difference," *Jewish Quarterly Review* 111/2 (2021): 300–303, 303.

⁸² Cohen, *Religion of Reason: Out of the Sources of Judaism*.

⁸³ Ebrahim Moosa, *Ghazālī and the Poetics of Imagination* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2005), 279.

⁸⁴ Zygmunt Bauman, *Modernity and the Holocaust* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2001), 53.

⁸⁵ Zafer Şenocak, "The hour of assembly," trans. Olivia Arter and Elaine Sun. *Transit* 13/1 (2021a): 87–89, 88.

its many scars. The question of Europe is undeniably tied to the Jewish question that so long captured the imaginaries of the continent, resulting in absolute catastrophe, and equally tied to the Muslim question that has become a scapegoat for both the faults and fears of modernity. Reading these four authors brings to the fore how the Strangers of Europe—Muslim, Jewish, in exile, under colonialism, in post-war and post-colonial societies—contest contemporary inequities and marginality not only in topic, but equally in hybrid written forms. Biography bleeds into fiction, poetry is used to re-inscribe the margins into history. The critical Stranger creates a productive, constructive discomfort in calling for the present and the past together to be thought, written and read differently.

Here relationality comes to the fore. For Buber, all real living is meeting; for Arendt, politics takes place in the public realm. And in the writings of these four authors (and arguably many others), one encounters not only relationality but also the interarticulation of Europe and its critical Strangers, including authors, but also others.⁸⁶ All reflect upon and reconstruct what and whose Europe is from the margins, rather than accepting predetermined cultural boundaries emplaced by those in power, at the societal core. It is not that their positions are necessarily horizontal, as cultural inequalities persist; but still they expose the interdependence of Europe and its Strangers, whose histories and future trajectories cannot be unbound from one another. The linearity of time and the fixidity of place do not dissolve but instead show their Janus faces: that they exist at once here and there, now and then ('then' as both future and past). There is thus a dynamism to their experiences which is very much part of the larger diasporic experiences which all have faced. Diaspora, as Stuart Hall argues,⁸⁷ is 'less about origins than trajectories'. These four authors turn their attention towards these trajectories, as they struggle to overcome violent pasts. In the case of Zweig this leads to devastation, as he realizes his own incapacity to belong in the post-Holocaust world, an eternal homelessness that he cannot withstand. Memmi remains always torn—attached to Tunis and Paris, Tunisia and France, Europe and Africa, Arabness and Jewishness, and the colonial order itself. Şenocak's trajectory entails hyphenation, not a tear but an attempt at fusion: a both/and (although, as Samia Hathroubi⁸⁸ has argued, the hyphen does not necessarily com-

⁸⁶ Dudink, "Homosexuality, race, and the rhetoric of nationalism," 260.

⁸⁷ Henry Louis Gates Jr., "Introduction," *The Fateful Triangle: Race, Ethnicity, Nation*, ed. Kobena Mercer (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2017), xvi.

⁸⁸ Samia Hathroubi, "Memmi's Arab-Jew notion and its mobilisation of a hybrid notion in France today." Working paper, presented at Forum for Jewish-Muslim Theology and Thought Inaugural Conference, "Cultures of Continuity: Jewish-Muslim Conversations on a Contested Ideal." Humboldt University, October 24–26, 2023.

plete, but may also conceal or overlook other identities). And finally, Besnaci-Lancou brings such unity in the present through a recognition, speaking, and completing of memory.

What can we find within the bounds of the books, in which these Strangers write—as they live—between and beyond the lines that have been drawn for them? And what can we as social theorists learn from their critical, creative acts, of wrestling their stories—the stories of Europe’s Strangers writ large, which are also part of the larger story of Europe—out of silence? The agency of the strangerhood positionality that was long overlooked can be attended to through the conceptualization of critical strangerhood, that is the ability to critique and shape society from the margins. Here we see otherness not as singular or stagnant, but multiple and moving—both with the tides of history, and also how such ‘Strangers’ agentively reshape collective memory. As Mary Douglas famously wrote, there is ‘energy in the margins’,⁸⁹ in this occupation and skilled articulation of a third space.

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⁸⁹ Mary Douglas, *Purity and Danger: An Analysis of Concepts of Pollution and Taboo* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2002), 141.

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Samia Hathroubi

Chapter 6

Memmi's notion of the Arab-Jew and the mobilisation of notions of hybridity

1 Introduction: Encountering Albert Memmi

During my research in Paris in 2019, I delved into the experiences of French Jewish students of Maghrebi descent who were undertaking studies in the Arabic language. It was within the framework of this particular study that I first encountered the compelling concept of the “Arab-Jew.” This pivotal idea was initially discovered in a footnote within Ella Shohat’s seminal work, *Colonialité et Ruptures*,¹ a collection of her insightful writings on Arab Jewish figures. Shohat’s book, originally penned in English and subsequently translated into French, meticulously explored the lives and identities of Jewish Arab individuals and, notably, traced the intellectual lineage and origin of the term “Arab-Jew” back to the influential Tunisian-French intellectual and writer Albert Memmi.

This initial academic encounter with Memmi’s intellectual legacy was later enriched by a personal experience. I had the distinct opportunity to engage in a profound discussion about Memmi with a Tunisian Jewish friend named Moché. This conversation took place in the vibrant city center of Tunis, amidst the bustling atmosphere of the Tunisian capital. At the time of our discussion, Moché was deeply immersed in reading Memmi’s renowned novel, *The Pillar of Salt*,² in preparation for a conference that was commemorating the centenary of Memmi’s birth. This serendipitous encounter, encompassing both the engaging conversation with Moché and the tangible presence of Memmi’s literary work, profoundly piqued my curiosity and further ignited my interest in the intricate and multifaceted identity of the “Arab-Jew”.

¹ Ella Shohat, *Colonialité et Ruptures: écrits sur les figures juives arabes*, trad. Joëlle Marelli (Montréal: Lux éditeur, 2021), 13.

² Albert Memmi, *The Pillar of Salt* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1992).

2 Memmi, a Writer of Identity, Colonialism and Conflicting Legacies

“Albert Memmi defies categorization. Jew and Arab, Tunisian and French, African and European, born poor and yet privileged, Jewish and staunchly secular, Zionist and critical of Israel, a leftist who highlighted the blindness of progressives, a prophet of national liberation whose viewpoint was internationalist, a socialist and anticolonialist who underlined the shortcomings of third-world postcolonial regimes, Albert Memmi has always challenged ‘fixed identities and easy binaries.’”³ Born in Tunis in 1920, under the French protectorate, Albert Memmi came from a disadvantaged Jewish background, residing in the Hara,⁴ the traditional Jewish quarter. His mother, an illiterate Jewish Berber, and his father, a saddler, provided him with a humble upbringing. Memmi died in Paris in 2019, having lived a life across geographical and cultural divides. His identity was a tapestry of interwoven threads: French, Tunisian, and Jewish. This multiplicity was further mirrored in his intellectual pursuits, as he transcended disciplinary boundaries to become a recognized sociologist, novelist, and philosopher. Initially, his personal, intellectual, and social trajectory appeared to be marked by a sense of disjunction and separation. However, in public discourse, Memmi frequently articulated his experience of occupying a nuanced middle ground, residing in a space of profound overlap. He saw himself as both Jew and Arab, a product of colonization who nonetheless embraced the language of the colonizer, and a self-made figure who achieved a newly acquired “bourgeois” status as a university professor and accomplished writer at the very heart of the colonial metropole, Paris.

Albert Memmi’s extensive body of work has garnered considerable academic attention. Scholars have delved into his explorations of identity, the intricate dynamics of colonialism, and his unique positionality as both a witness to and an active participant in the transformative eras of colonialism and postcolonialism. His writings offer invaluable insights into the complexities of cultural hybridity, the psychological impact of domination, and the ongoing struggles for liberation and self-definition.

As early as 1984, Guy Degas referred to Memmi as ‘the writer of heartbreak’.⁵ Anne Decout, Claude Hagège and Jean-Claude Zarka have published numerous ar-

3 Albert Memmi, *The Albert Memmi Reader* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2021).

4 The term ‘h’ara’, which means neighborhood, is used in Tunisia to designate the Jewish quarter of the city. It is the equivalent of the Moroccan ‘mallah’.

5 Guy Degas, *Albert Memmi: écrivain de la déchirure* (Sherbrooke, Québec: Éditions Naaman, 1984).

ticles, often in literary journals, that highlight the conflicts and separation Memmi experienced due to his adoption of the French language.⁶ These articles also focus on his alter ego, Alexandre Mordechai Bennilouche, the protagonist of his acclaimed work, *The Pillar of Salt*.⁷ Memmi illustrates through his alter ego a journey of physical and symbolic shifts. This trajectory moves between the traditional Jewish world of Tunis and the secular environment of the École Israélite Universelle where he pursued his studies. It also encompasses a linguistic transition from Judeo-Arabic to French, and a societal navigation through the complexities of French colonizers, colonized Arab Muslims, and Jews. As Gastaut highlights, Memmi's theoretical contributions, particularly his essays,⁸ establish him as a crucial witness and participant who sheds light on the "clarity, complexity, and vicissitudes of the colonial and postcolonial times."⁹

Albert Memmi's powerful role as a witness, and indeed a living embodiment, of the experiences of Tunisian Jews is undeniable. His personal journey and writings illuminate the complex destiny of this community, particularly within the framework of the colonial empire and its profound aftermath.

Scholarly interpretations of Memmi's significance, however, reveal a fascinating duality. Hagège and Zarca, in their seminal article, leverage Memmi's example to bolster their thesis regarding the critical influence of cultural dynamics on the trajectory of Tunisian Jews.¹⁰ They highlight the pivotal role of adopting French and the impact of educational institutions like the Alliance Israélite Universelle, both before and after the establishment of the French protectorate in Tunisia. For them, Memmi's journey is "A highly significant intellectual journey: transcending an elusive position through the writer and sociologist Albert Memmi's choice of universality." This perspective emphasizes a movement towards a broader, more universal intellectual space, suggesting a successful navigation of identity through his embrace of a global literary and sociological perspective.

6 Mathieu Decout, "Albert Memmi: Portrait de l'écrivain colonisé en statue de sel," *Revue d'histoire littéraire de la France* 114/4 (2014): 897–909; Claude Hagège et Bernard Zarca, « Les Juifs et la France en Tunisie, » *Le Mouvement social* 197/4 (2001): 9–28

7 Albert Memmi, *La statue de sel* (Paris: Éditions Gallimard, 1953).

8 Albert Memmi, *Portrait d'un juif* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1962); *L'Homme dominé* (le colonisé, le Juif, le Noir, la Femme, le domestique) (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1968); *Juifs et Arabes* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1974); *La Dépendance* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1979); *Ce que je crois* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1985); *Le Racisme* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1994); *Le Portrait du décolonisé* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 2004).

9 Yvan Gastaut, "Albert Memmi, un regard postcolonial," in *Ruptures postcoloniales: Les nouveaux visages de la société française*, ed. Achille Mbembe (Paris: La Découverte, 2010): 88–95.

10 Claude Hagège and B. Zarca, "Les Juifs et la France en Tunisie," *Le mouvement social* 197/4 (2001): 9–28.

Conversely, other prominent scholars such as Haïm Saadoun¹¹ and Georges Bensoussan¹² offer a different portrayal of Memmi. While acknowledging his privileged position as a witness to the tumultuous events in Tunisia, they contend that his experience represents not transcendence, but rather a profound sense of division and separation. Bensoussan, for instance, views Memmi as an archetypal figure illustrating an inescapable rupture between Jewish and Muslim communities. This interpretation underscores the deep-seated divisions that emerged from the colonial encounter and its legacy, casting Memmi's narrative as a testament to fragmentation rather than unification.

The existing literature on Memmi, therefore, compellingly exposes the inherent ambiguity in understanding the continuity and rupture within the experience of the Arab-Jew. His life and work serve as a crucial lens through which to examine the intricate interplay of cultural adaptation, historical trauma, and evolving identities, ultimately reflecting the multifaceted and often contradictory realities of Jewish life in the Arab world during a period of immense historical transformation.

3 Memmi, An Arab-Jew: A New Reading and Reception of Memmi's Work

This book chapter delves into the profound significance and enduring legacy of Albert Memmi, a distinguished Jewish Tunisian-French author, whose groundbreaking concept of the "Arab-Jew" first emerged in his seminal 1974 work, *Juifs et Arabes*.¹³ Memmi's pioneering ideas critically challenge prevailing frameworks of conflict and presumed divisions between Jews and Muslims, offering a nuanced perspective that resonates with contemporary scholarship.¹⁴

11 Haïm Saadoun, "Nouvelle lecture de La Statue de sel d'Albert Memmi," *Revue d'Histoire de la Shoah* 205 (2016): 561–70.

12 Georges Bensoussan, *Les Juifs du monde arabe: La question interdite* (Paris: Odile Jacob, 2017).

13 Albert Memmi, *Juifs et arabes* (Paris: Gallimard, 1974), 49.

14 Maud S. Mandel, *Muslims and Jews in France: History of a Conflict* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014);

Ethan B. Katz, *The Burdens of Brotherhood: Jews and Muslims from North Africa to France* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2015); Samuel S. Everett and B. Gidley, "Getting away from the noise: Jewish-Muslim interactions and narratives in E1/Barbès," *Francospheres* 7 (2018), 173–196; Samuel S. Everett, Ben Gidley, eds, *Jews and Muslims in Europe: Between Discourse and Experience* (Leiden: Brill, 2022): 1–22.

By meticulously exploring Memmi's deeply personal experiences and rigorously examining the inherent interconnectedness of the categories "Arab" and "Jew", this analysis demonstrates how a newly-engaged readership has actively mobilized his concepts and writings. This mobilization has had a transformative effect, effectively blurring the boundaries of identification for many individuals. Simultaneously, Memmi's work directly confronts and challenges the dominant discourses prevalent in postcolonial France, particularly the "taken-for-granted doxa animosity"¹⁵ between Jews and Muslims and the problematic conflation of the categories "Arab" and "Muslim." This exploration has particular relevance for the third generation of French Jews of Tunisian or Maghrebi descent, who are increasingly asserting multiple identities and actively engaging in crucial conversations about their multifaceted postcolonial heritage.

Through a focused examination of the notion of the Arab-Jew, this article specifically aims to investigate the profound interconnectedness of the categories "Arab" and "Jew." In contemporary times, these categories have, regrettably, become perceived as contradictory, showcasing a lack comprehending nuance, as in the case of the often-misunderstood relationship between "Muslim" and "Jew." The compelling figure of the Arab-Jew, understood as a hybrid identity, furnishes a vital critical framework for contemplating and analytically dissecting the possibilities of historical and cultural continuities. In this article, I argue that the figure of the Arab-Jew, as conceptualized and embodied by Albert Memmi, serves as a powerful instrument to blur and fundamentally question the rigid boundaries that define processes of identification, racialization, and symbolic divisions between Jews and Arab-Muslims in France today. This nuanced perspective offers a crucial lens through which to understand and potentially reconcile complex identity formations in a postcolonial context.

To support this argumentation, I will draw upon Ella Shohat's¹⁶ insightful concept of the hyphenated and hybrid figure, specifically focusing on the "Arab-Jew." Shohat posits that this figure transcends a mere empirical classification, emerging instead as a profoundly critical category. It encapsulates a co-constitutive cultural past, serving not only as a tangible historical reminder but also as a powerful symbol pregnant with imaginative potentialities for the future. The very existence of this hyphenated figure directly challenges the prevailing political climate, in which the categories of "Jew" and "Arab" have been rendered mutually exclusive. This di-

15 Ella Shohat, "On Orientalist Genealogies: The Split Arab/Jew Figure Revisited," in *The Edinburgh Companion to the Postcolonial Middle East*, eds. Anna Ball and Karim Mattar (Édimbourg: Edinburgh University Press, 2019), 118–159.

16 E. Shohat, *Taboo memories, diasporic voices* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2006); E. Shohat, "The split Arab/Jew figure revisited," *Patterns of Prejudice* 54:1–2 (2020): 46–70.

visive framework, as Shohat eloquently argues, has given rise to what she terms an “ontological oxymoron”, a conceptual impossibility rooted in a manufactured binary. By foregrounding the “Arab-Jew”, Shohat calls into question the present reality and its deeply problematic, separating framework, thereby emphasizing the urgent need to transcend these rigid boundaries and to explore alternative narratives that genuinely reflect the richness and complexity of other lived experiences.

This article and its contribution concerning Albert Memmi’s work are situated within a broader and vibrant area of scholarship that meticulously examines the notion of hybridity. Prominent figures in this field include Stuart Hall,¹⁷ Paul Gilroy, and Homi Bhabha,¹⁸ whose theoretical frameworks have significantly shaped our understanding of cultural mixing and identity formation. As John Hutnyk judiciously reminds us in his article, the concept of hybridity is “often used in the context of diasporic populations as a process of cultural mixing in which the diasporic newcomers adopt aspects of the host culture and rework, reform and reconfigure them in the production of a new hybrid culture or ‘hybrid identities’”.¹⁹ This understanding is crucial for appreciating the nuanced ways in which cultural elements interact and transform within diverse communities.

Within the specific context of our argument, the hybridity inherent in the notion of the “Arab-Jew” as employed by Memmi and strategically mobilized by the diverse “ecosystem of individualities” analyzed in this article, must be understood as a “disruptive and productive category” (Bhabha 1994). This recognition is important because it simultaneously allows us to discern profound continuities within Memmi’s expansive body of work and, more significantly, it acts as a catalytic force. It actively opens up a *third way*, a path capable of attenuating the increasingly rigid process of separation between “Arabness” and “Jewishness” within the contemporary French political and social landscape. This *third way* offers a crucial alternative to the prevailing binary.

What Memmi uniquely contributes to this discourse is a profound fusion of autobiographical and intellectual perspectives. The individual cases highlighted in this article are not merely theoretical constructs; they are deeply informed by Memmi’s own lived experiences. This personal engagement enables him to critically interrogate the complex processes of de-racialization, as well as the multifaceted dynamics of identification and self-identification within contemporary

17 Stuart Hall, “The Work of Representation,” in *Representation: Cultural Representation and Signifying Practices*, ed. Stuart Hall (London: Sage, 1997): 13–58.

18 Paul Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic: Modernity and Double Consciousness* (London: Routledge, 1993); Homi K. Bhabha, *The Location of Culture* (London: Routledge, 1994); Stuart Hall, *The Fateful Triangle: Race, Ethnicity, Nation* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2017).

19 John Hutnyk, “Hybridity,” *Ethnic and Racial Studies* 28/1 (2005): 81.

French Jewry. His work thus becomes a powerful testament to the intricate interplay between personal narrative and broader socio-political realities.

By embodying this unresolved figure—a figure that resists easy categorization and challenges fixed notions of identity—this concept offers a transformative approach. It provides a means of transcending the dominant hegemonic framework, which often imposes restrictive categories and limits intellectual inquiry. More importantly, it opens up avenues for exploring alternative perspectives on how to think, analyze, and ultimately understand both the “Arab” and the “Jewish” in France. This transcends simplistic binaries, fostering a more nuanced and holistic comprehension of these complex identities within the French context.

Viewing Memmi within the broader framework of “cultures of continuities” represents a thought-provoking and innovative approach. By proposing that Memmi represents a culture of continuity, we actively challenge the prevailing paradigm of ruptures and separations that has largely dominated the existing scientific literature concerning his work. Memmi’s powerful voice serves not only as a poignant reminder of the historical presence and contributions of Jewish voices within the Arab/Muslim world but also stands as a compelling testament to a specific historical experience. This experience, once perhaps marginalized or overlooked, is now being actively reclaimed by a third generation of French Jews, particularly those of Tunisian or broader Maghrebi descent. These individuals are deeply and passionately engaged in reconnecting with their Arab heritage, in essence, reclaiming an “Arabness” that was either suppressed or forgotten. These endeavors are far from isolated acts; they collectively form a vibrant constellation of both formal and informal groups. Their strategic mobilization of Memmi, his extensive body of work, and his enduring power as a figure of cultural representation is not merely an academic exercise but is deeply embedded within a broader sociopolitical milieu both present and past.

4 Reviving Albert Memmi: Exploring Transnational Enthusiasm in Art, Literature, and Activism

This comprehensive study delves into the enduring relevance of Albert Memmi’s intellectual legacy, drawing upon a dual analytical framework. Firstly, it undertakes a meticulous examination of scholarly literature dedicated to Memmi’s extensive oeuvre, tracing the evolution of academic engagement with his intellectual and literary insights. Secondly, it explores a rich tapestry of contemporary

artistic, literary, and activist expressions, which collectively signify a powerful resurgence of interest in his foundational work.

My research has analyzed a diverse array of materials situated within the transnational artistic, literary, and activist landscape. This corpus spans various media, from compelling podcasts that re-contextualize his ideas for new audiences, to influential books and critically acclaimed films that grapple with the complexities of his thought. This burgeoning engagement is particularly salient among individuals of Jewish heritage born or raised in France, whose familial roots extend to Tunisia. For these individuals, whose grandparents or parents experienced life in Tunisia, Memmi's work offers a profound lens through which to understand enduring questions of identity, belonging, and colonialism.

Crucially, these multifaceted endeavors are not isolated phenomena. Instead, they converge to form a vibrant constellation of both formal and informal groups. The collective mobilization of Memmi's intellectual contributions, and his conceptual frameworks, is not merely an academic exercise; it is an integral component of a broader sociopolitical strategy. This approach aims to re-engage with and re-interpret Memmi's ideas in a contemporary context, fostering new dialogues and informing ongoing struggles for justice and recognition. This renewed engagement highlights the timeless resonance of Memmi's critique of colonialism and his explorations of the complexities of the colonized and colonizer, offering valuable frameworks for understanding today's societal challenges while also informing emancipatory practices.

4.1 A Persistent Tension: Disruptions and Consistencies in Memmi's Life and Work

Albert Memmi's life and literary works are deeply entwined, a connection he himself acknowledged by stating, "I have practically never written books that do not stem from an experience, a lived experience. I start from the experience and from there I try to theorize."²⁰ This highlights the importance of his personal experiences as foundational to his theoretical contributions, making his life a crucial aspect of scholarly analysis. Memmi also believed that thinkers should always begin with the particular before approaching the universal, emphasizing the importance of understanding one's own condition to comprehend and empathize with others. This approach is exemplified in his book *Portrait of a Jew*,²¹ titled in

²⁰ Albert Memmi, *Le Juif et l'Autre*, (éditions Nartillat: Paris, 1995), 63.

²¹ Albert Memmi, *Portrait of a Jew*, trans. Elisabeth Abbott (The Orion Press, New York, 1962).

the singular rather than plural. Memmi's semi-biographical work, *Pillar of Salt*, a work of autofiction, clearly demonstrates the overlap between his life and that of the narrator, Alexander Mordechai Benillouche. Critics have extensively discussed the significance of the three names of this literary alter ego. Each name carries profound meaning, representing a complex dimension of Memmi's identity. Joëlle Strike, in her doctoral thesis on Albert Memmi, notes that "Mordekhai" reflects his Jewish identity and the ghetto, "Alexandre" symbolizes the admired Western world, and "Benillouche" not only signifies his Jewish heritage but also evokes indigenous origins.²² Strike further states that of these three names, "Mordekhai" brought him the most shame, leading him to actively distance himself from it and adopt the Western name of Alexandre to assimilate into French society. This analysis underscores the intricate relationship between Memmi's personal experiences, his literary creations, and the multifaceted identities explored in *Pillar of Salt*.

Considering continuity in Memmi's personal journey and work may initially appear challenging, as ruptures are recurrent patterns. The following excerpt from *Le Portrait du colonisé* encapsulates this pattern of rupture:

"If I was undeniably a native, as they used to say, as close as possible to the Muslim, by the unbearable misery of our poor, by the mother tongue (my own mother never learnt French), by the sensibility and manners, the taste for the same music and perfumes, by an almost identical cuisine, I tried passionately to identify myself with the French. In a great impulse that carried me towards the West, which seemed to me the paragon of all true civilisation and culture, I first cheerfully turned my back on the East, irrevocably chose the French language, dressed in Italian and adopted with delight even the tics of the Europeans. In which, moreover, I was trying to fulfill one of the ambitions of every colonised person, before he goes into revolt."²³

Memmi's work is often understood through the lens of rupture, particularly in relation to the long-established Jewish communities of North Africa. This rupture was driven by several factors: colonial modernity, the influence of the Alliance Israélite Universelle, the adoption of French language and culture, and the decolonization process, which included Arab-Muslim national exclusivism in Tunisia and the Arab-Israeli War. *The Pillar of Salt* symbolically illustrates this break, with its narrator and main character opting to emigrate to Argentina instead of France. In *Les Juifs de la Tunisie*, Memmi writes, "We are the longest memory of

22 Joëlle Strike, *Autobiographie et autographie dans l'œuvre d'Albert Memmi*, DLitt thesis (Pretoria: University of Pretoria, 2000), 35.

23 Albert Memmi and Jean-Paul Sartre, *Portrait du colonisé. Précédé du Portrait du colonisateur* (Paris: Buchet/Chastel, 1957), 51.

the Maghreb.”²⁴ However, he laments the decline of the Jewish communities in North Africa, with only a few elderly individuals remaining, praying as they await death.²⁵

4.2 The Internal Rupture within Albert Memmi's Work and its Conflicting Legacies

Memmi's body of work reveals an internal inconsistency due to conflicting perspectives. Initially, he was celebrated as the author of *Colonized* in 1962, often mentioned alongside of prominent figures like Fanon and Aimé Césaire.²⁶ However, his later works²⁷ led to his exclusion from post-colonial literature. In these books, Memmi advocates for a national solution as the sole viable option and strongly defends Israel. This divergence from his earlier position was further emphasized by *Portrait of the Decolonized* in 2004, which alienated a large portion of his original audience.²⁸ Critics have frequently accused Memmi of presenting a “jaded doxa shaped by contemporary stereotypes of Arab nations and of African and North African immigrants in France.”

Gil Hochberg's insightful article, “An Anti-Colonial Zionist Remembering Albert Memmi”,²⁹ illuminates the profound fissures and paradoxical legacies embedded within Albert Memmi's extensive body of work. Hochberg contends that there are, in essence, two distinct Memmis. The first is the celebrated anti-colonial theorist, author of the seminal text *The Colonizer and the Colonized*,³⁰ and the novelist behind *La statue du sel*, a politically acute portrayal of the escalating tensions inherent to colonial rule. This Memmi is widely recognized for his incisive critique of oppressive power structures. The second Memmi, however,

²⁴ Albert Memmi, *Les Juifs de la Tunisie*, (Editions du Scribe: Paris, 1989), 160.

²⁵ Ibid., 175.

²⁶ Frantz Fanon, *Les Damnés de la Terre* (Paris: François Maspero, 1961); Aimé Césaire, *Discours sur le colonialisme* (Paris: Présence Africaine, 1950).

²⁷ Albert Memmi, *La Libération du Juif* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1975); Albert Memmi, *Le Portrait du Juif* (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 2004).

²⁸ Patricia Crowley, “Albert Memmi: The Conflict of Legacies,” in *Postcolonial Thought in the French-speaking World*, ed. Charles Forsdick and David Murphy (Liverpool, 2009; online edn, Liverpool Scholarship Online, 20 June 2013)

²⁹ Gil Hochberg, “An Anti-Colonial Zionist? Remembering Albert Memmi,” *Mondoweiss*, 2020, <https://mondoweiss.net/2020/06/an-anti-colonial-zionist-remembering-albert-memmi/> accessed 12/2023.

³⁰ Albert Memmi, *Decolonization and the Decolonized*, trans. Robert Bononno (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2006).

emerges in his later writings, where Hochberg identifies a notable failure to adequately address the multifaceted plight of the Arab Jew within the specific context of French colonialism. This later Memmi, according to Hochberg, appears as an uncritical proponent of Zionism, notably without thoroughly scrutinizing its own colonial dimensions. This analytical distinction by Hochberg not only highlights the evolution of Memmi's thought but also underscores the enduring complexities and contradictions that can arise within a single intellectual trajectory, particularly when confronting the multifaceted challenges of identity, belonging, and liberation in a post-colonial world.

Guy Degas, one of the most influential and perceptive commentators on Memmi's literary oeuvre, eloquently encapsulated Memmi's essence by describing him as "the writer of the tear."³¹ This evocative metaphor resonates deeply because a tear does not signify outright separation. Much like a piece of torn fabric, which, despite its rupture, remains a single, continuous entity rather than two distinct fragments, Memmi's work, despite its internal tensions, maintains a profound coherence. This concept of tension serves as a crucial bridge to understanding Memmi's ambivalent relationship between continuities and discontinuities throughout his writing career.

Indeed, a thorough examination of Memmi's prodigious output, commencing with *The Salt Statue*, reveals that despite residing for the vast majority of his adult life in the vibrant intellectual hub of Paris, he never once ceased to engage with, and indeed, draw profound inspiration from Tunisia, his literary breeding ground. Tunisia, therefore, was not merely a historical setting but a continuous wellspring of inspiration, a literary touchstone for the Memmi living in Paris. This enduring connection is evident in his subsequent works. For instance, *Le Désert*, published in 1977,³² meticulously reconstructs the mythical figure of the wandering ancestor, Al Mammi, thereby delving into themes of displacement, heritage, and the search for roots. Similarly, *Le Pharaon*, released in 1988,³³ offers a nuanced and often poignant portrayal of the intricate processes of decolonization through the experiences of its protagonist, Armand Gozlan, a Tunisian archaeologist of Jewish origin. Gozlan's complex journey unfolds as he initially champions the cause of the colonized, only to subsequently discover himself an outsider, alienated and even menaced, within a newly independent society that has become foreign and hostile to his identity and aspirations.

³¹ Guy Degas, *Albert Memmi: Écrivain de la déchirure* (Sherbrooke: Éditions Naaman, 1984).

³² Albert Memmi, *Le Désert ou La Vie et les aventures de Jubair Ouali El-Mammi* (Paris: Gallimard, 1977), 191.

³³ Albert Memmi, *Le Pharaon* (Paris: Julliard, 1988), 376.

Furthermore, a profound exploration of the pervasive ambivalence surrounding Memmi's native country can be discerned within the very fabric of his novelistic creations. This rich internal hermeneutics, therefore, compels us to turn our attention directly to Memmi himself for further illumination. In a remarkably candid reflection in 1987, Memmi himself acknowledged that his books could indeed be interpreted through the lens of heartbreak and conflict. Yet, he also posited that they could be viewed as profound and deliberate attempts to grapple with, and ultimately to resolve, these very heartbreaks and conflicts. This self-awareness highlights the intensely personal and often therapeutic dimension of his writing.

A powerful illustration of this internal struggle and the complexities of identity is found in his seminal work, *Les juifs de Tunisie*, mentioned earlier in the text.³⁴ In this poignant passage, Memmi recounts a deeply resonant question posed by his own daughter upon her return from school: "What am I, Daddy? Jewish, Arab, French, Tunisian?"³⁵ This singular question, laden with existential weight, is in essence a collective question that encapsulates the intricate and often overlapping layers of all of these identities. In a world increasingly defined by hybridity and intersecting cultures, taking a comprehensive inventory of who we truly are becomes not merely an academic exercise but a prerequisite for genuine self-recognition and, just as crucially, for the recognition and understanding of future generations. In this pivotal context, Memmi's extensive body of work serves as an invaluable mirror, offering richly textured narratives that reflect the myriad complexities of identity formation and the enduring human imperative for profound self-understanding. As the author himself so succinctly articulated in 1987: "It is true that my books can be read in terms of heartbreak and conflict, but they can also be read as an attempt to resolve these heartbreaks and conflicts."³⁶ This statement not only summarizes the essence of his literary project but also invites readers to engage with his work as a profound dialogue on the human condition in a world shaped by colonialism, decolonization, and the ongoing search for belonging.

³⁴ Albert Memmi, *Les Juifs de Tunisie: portraits et témoignages* (Paris: Gallimard, 1975).

³⁵ *Ibid.*, 162.

³⁶ Heller-Goldenburg, Lucette, "À bâtons rompus avec Albert Memmi, à Cologne le 19 mai 1987," *Cahier d'études maghrébines* 3 (1991): 97.

4.3 New Aesthetics and Politics of the Self : *The Emergence of Albert Memmi within the Fragile Transnational Diaspora*

Inspired by Albert Memmi, particularly his work *Pillar of Salt*, as a significant voice for Jews in Muslim contexts, this presentation introduces three individuals whose journeys and creations exemplify a nascent, yet delicate, transnational diaspora. This constellation of individuals and informal groups spans Paris, Tunis, and Israel, with each person aware of and drawing inspiration from the others' work.

The first example is Illana Weizmann, a 39-year-old Parisian-born who currently lives in Tel Aviv. Over the past decade, Weizmann has evolved politically, becoming a prominent advocate for feminism, combating antisemitism, and aligning with the left. Her recent book, *les Juifs, des blancs pas comme les autres* (currently only available in French), heavily references Albert Memmi's *Portrait d'un juif* and *Libération d'un juif*. Like Memmi, Weizmann emphasizes lived experiences, aiming to position antisemitism at the forefront of the anti-racist struggle in France, alongside of other racially marginalized groups, particularly Muslims, who are frequently mentioned. The book challenges the exclusion of Jews from anti-racist discourse, which often stems from the idea that Jews are assimilated into the dominant "white" social and cultural group. Weizmann, born Attali into an Algerian Jewish family, grounds her entire work in the concept of racial categorization. Interestingly, this argumentative approach leads her to echo the sentiments of a Tunisian Jewish individual born in the Hara, thereby forging a historical, geographical, colonial, and intellectual link that allows her to claim a non-white, postcolonial identity. On page 201 she writes:

"In this book, I aim to show the similarities between Jews and Muslims in terms of alienating racialization, but they also exist in a positive mode. In the case of Sephardic Jews, for example, we can speak of a common Arabness. I listened to a four-hour podcast by Jewish Arab Cléo Cohen, *Comment je me suis réconciliée avec mes identités* (How I reconciled with my identities), in which she works to repair, reconstitute and reappropriate the Arab legacy of North African Jewish identities. Ever since I was very young, I've lived as a Jew and an Arab."³⁷

This redefinition of the "symbolic boundaries"³⁸ between these two groups serves a political purpose for Weizman. Thus she writes on the following page: "The similarities in the processes of racialization of Jews and Muslims, as well as the cul-

³⁷ Illana Weizman, *Des Blancs comme les autres? Les Juifs, angle mort de l'antiracisme* (Paris : Stock, 2022), 201.

³⁸ Michèle Lamont and Virág Molnár, "The Study of Boundaries in the Social Sciences," *Annual Review of Sociology* 28/1 (2002): 167–95.

tural proximities, should imply only cooperation and solicitude.”³⁹ Weizmann’s work entails a reclaiming of her Arab identity, serving as a means to transcend the prevailing narrative of hostility between Jews and Muslims and contributing not only to reconciliation but also a political stance. She aims to approach the anti-Semitic struggle from the point of view of the position of Jews within the militant field. Weizmann critiques the perception of Jews as “white” in anti-racist movements, aiming to situate French Jews alongside of other “racialized” groups like Muslim and Black individuals, as elaborated in the final chapter of her book. Weizmann thus reclaims her Arab identity to challenge the dominant narrative of Jewish-Muslim animosity. In an interview, she explains, “Albert Memmi is a cornerstone when it comes to the lived Jewish experience. When I read *Portrait d’un juif* (published in 1962), I feel like I see myself in the mirror. I couldn’t have written it, but he tells my story.”⁴⁰ Like Memmi, Weizman advocates for a universalism that embraces particularisms and differences. This contrasts with the view that immigrant communities in France should integrate at the expense of their unique identities.⁴¹

Cleo Cohen, a filmmaker, explores dual identity in her works “Que Dieu te protège” and “Juive-Arabe”.⁴² Her documentaries feature interviews with her Tunisian and Algerian grandparents about their heritage. Cohen also produced a four-hour series for France Culture, focusing on encounters among her Parisian peers. The first episode, “C’est où chez nous”, captures a Shabbat dinner conversation with Collectif des Juifves VNR,⁴³ a queer anti-racist and feminist collective. Members discuss their experiences with French, Arab, and Jewish identities. Some noted how Arabic, their grandparents’ and parents’ language, became associated with the ethno-religious category of Muslims. One member commented:

“Initially, I conflated Arab and Muslim identities, leading to a profound realization: ‘I can be Jewish-Arab.’ It was a revelation.” These discussions highlighted the struggles of having their position acknowledged in postcolonial France. “White people don’t understand. You’re either Arab or you’re a Jew.” The inter-

39 Weizmann, *Des Blancs comme les autres? Les Juifs, angle mort de l’antiracisme*, 202.

40 Illana Weizman, “Tous les racismes proviennent d’une même essence, qu’on soit Juif, Musulman ou Noir”, interview par Hélène Berkaoui, *Bondy Blog*, 11 octobre 2022, <https://www.bondyblog.fr/opinions/interview/illana-weizman-tous-les-racismes-proviennent-dune-meme-essence-quon-soit-juif-musulman-ou-noir/>

41 Crowley, “Albert Memmi: The Conflict of Legacies,” 127.

42 Cléo Cohen, *Juive-Arabe, comment je me suis réconciliée avec mes identités*, série documentaire, France Culture, 2022, <https://www.radiofrance.fr/franceculture/podcasts/serie-juive-arabe-comment-je-me-suis-reconciliee-avec-mes-identites> (accessed 28 June 2023)

43 Collectif des Juifves VNR, *Facebook*, <https://www.facebook.com/pages/category/community/Collectif-des-Juifves-VNR-113605736750990/> (accessed 28 June 2023)

views reveal how participants questioned the blurred lines between Arabs/the Arabic language and Muslims. And the possibility of being Jewish-Arab sparked a dialogue about the perception of Jews as white in postcolonial France. One participant even stated: "Speaking Arabic in the 80s was *hchouma* shameful (. . .). I've internalized the colonialist rhetoric. It's painful when people tell us we're white."⁴⁴

4.4 Uncovering Personal and Familial Narratives

My final example is Margaux Fitoussi, a Franco-American of Tunisian Jewish descent. She created the 2017 documentary *Hara*, in which she interviews Albert Memmi. Having lived in Tunisia, she is currently pursuing a doctoral degree in anthropology at Columbia University. In an interview discussing the significance of the ghetto, Fitoussi described her project as an attempt to fill narrative gaps and voids in personal history.

"What happens when stories are not told, when people have been uprooted for one reason or another, when we no longer know nor remember what came before? The film juxtaposes images of Tunis's historic Jewish quarter with Albert Memmi's writings and a 2016 interview with him.

Making *El Hara* provoked questions I would have never otherwise thought to ask my family. Screening a rough cut for my grandfather in 2016 (he died within weeks of Memmi in 2020) evoked stories I had never before heard, including that he used to pray in the synagogue that appears at the end of the film. It was an entry point into memories he'd long thought forgotten. What I am left with is the knowledge that within the larger story of the *Hara* are thousands of individual stories of people like my grandfather. Each story, like each wave, resembles but never mimics that which came before and that which will come after."⁴⁵

The above quote powerfully illustrates the enduring and multifaceted impact of Albert Memmi's intellectual contributions, particularly on the formation and recclamation of personal and familial identities within a broader historical and cul-

⁴⁴ This is a transcription of an excerpt Cléo Cohen, *Juive-Arabe, comment je me suis réconciliée avec mes identités*, série documentaire, France Culture, 2022, <https://www.radiofrance.fr/franceculture/podcasts/serie-juive-arabe-comment-je-me-suis-reconciliee-avec-mes-identites> (accessed June 2023)

⁴⁵ Claudia Camarda, A. K. Sharick, and K. G. Trostel, eds., *The Venice Ghetto: A Memory Space That Travels* (Amherst, MA: University of Massachusetts Press, 2022).

tural context. The creation of the documentary *El Hara* by Fitoussi⁴⁶ serves as a compelling case study, demonstrating how Memmi's profound insights can act as a catalyst for deep introspection and intergenerational dialogue.

Fitoussi's journey in producing *El Hara* was not merely a technical undertaking but a deeply personal one, sparking a cascade of essential questions about her own lineage and the collective memory of her community. This creative process facilitated a pivotal moment when she screened the film for her grandfather. This act transcended a simple viewing; it became an intimate space for revelation, unlocking a trove of previously unshared narratives. A particularly striking example is his connection to the synagogue that appears at the film's conclusion—a detail that had seemingly faded into the recesses of time. The documentary, therefore, functioned as a powerful mnemonic device, reactivating by bringing to the forefront memories her grandfather had long considered lost or inaccessible. This example illuminates the therapeutic and reconstructive potential of art and storytelling in confronting and revitalizing dormant historical consciousness.

Beyond the individual narrative, the quote above meticulously underscores the profound significance of each personal story within the expansive tapestry of the Hara. It articulates a crucial concept: while individual experiences within the Hara may share common threads and resonate with collective memories, each narrative remains inherently unique and irreplaceable. It is a nuanced echo, never a perfect replication, of what has transpired before or what will unfold in the future. This notion profoundly enriches our understanding of the Hara's collective experience, revealing a remarkable depth and complexity. It speaks to the myriad individual lives that have been shaped by its history, each contributing a distinct hue to the vibrant mosaic of its past. This emphasizes that collective identity is not a monolithic entity but rather a dynamic interplay of countless singular voices, each possessing its own particular perspective.

In essence, the quote eloquently demonstrates how Memmi's seminal work, coupled with the meticulous exploration of the Hara, provides an invaluable entry point for individuals to forge meaningful connections with their heritage. It offers a pathway to unearth forgotten memories, to piece together fragments of a shared past, and ultimately, to gain a more profound and nuanced understanding of their family's distinct and vital place within a grander historical narrative. This exemplifies Memmi's enduring and pervasive legacy: his ability to consistently spark introspection, to cultivate and foster essential intergenerational dialogue, and to champion the preservation of individual stories. These personal narratives

46 Fitoussi, Margaux, and Mo Scarpelli, dirs., *El Hara*. France/Tunisia/USA: Rake Films, 2017. 16 min. French and Arabic with English subtitles. <https://vimeo.com/ondemand/elhara>

together contribute to the rich and intricate tapestry of cultural memory, ensuring that the past remains a living and evolving entity, continually informing and enriching the present.

Memmi is a vital point of reference in the memorial landscape of Tunisian or Algerian Jews for this nascent group, which extends beyond the three figures mentioned. As an Arab Jew who views himself as a catalyst for wider dialogues, Memmi completes the voids in their individual mappings and aids their pursuit of reconciliation or political objectives.

For Fitoussi and Cohen the creative process contributes to a process of remembering and re-memory (Toni Morisson 2019).⁴⁷ To Weizmann, Memmi's works and the mobilisation of this intellectual as a patron figure support a political claim in the context of the de-racialisation of Jews in France in anti-racist struggles and movements. We must thus consider this constellation of individual positionalities within the broader social, political and artistic contexts. Indeed, in recent years France has had two major exhibitions, with extensive media coverage, one on Arab Jews at the Institut du Monde Arabe,⁴⁸ inaugurated by the President of the French Republic, and a second, one curated by same the historian Benjamin Stora, at the Musée National de l'Immigration about Jews and Muslims from colonial France to the present day.⁴⁹ This sociocultural climate has probably also contributed to the emergence of specific processes of remembrance.

These processes further resonate beyond the nation-state with a global movement of rehabilitation and re-appropriation of Arab or Amazigh identity among descendants of Jews from the Middle East and North Africa. The Maghrebi re-identification among Jewish descendants of the Maghrib is discussed in a volume *Jewish-Muslim Interactions*,⁵⁰ which highlights the growing cultural expression of Israeli artists who, through cultural performance, reclaim the use of dialectal Arabic and a Maghrebi affiliation. In the French context, in that special issue, I my-

47 The notion of 'rememory' is borrowed from Toni Morrison. It emerged as a key term that referred to communal memories of the African American past. In a posthumous essay, Morrison refers to it as "recollecting and remembering as in reassembling the members of the body, the family, the population of the past." A. Z. Kovács, "Body Marks of the Past in Toni Morrison's 'A Mercy and Home'," *Metacritic Journal for Comparative Studies and Theory* 7, no. 1 (2021): 69.

48 Institut du Monde Arabe, "Juifs d'Orient," *Institut du Monde Arabe*, accessed on 17 December 2023, <https://www.imarabe.org/fr/expositions/juifs-d-orient>

49 Musée national de l'histoire de l'immigration, "Juifs et musulmans de la France coloniale à nos jours," *Musée national de l'histoire de l'immigration*, consulté le 17 décembre 2023, <https://www.histoire-immigration.fr/programmation/expositions/juifs-et-musulmans-de-la-france-coloniale-a-nos-jours>

50 Everett S. and Rebekah Vince, eds., *Jewish-Muslim Interactions: Performing Cultures between North Africa and France* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2020).

self examined the activities of two associations for culture and language learning that are emerging in this field.

4.5 Legacies and Recognition: Albert Memmi and Gisèle Halimi in Tunisian Society

Exploring the creative processes of the three trajectories mentioned above led me to address a question that has been at the forefront of my mind. What legacies do we claim, and why? In exploring the legacies of Memmi, I came across another Tunisian-Jewish figure: Gisèle Halimi (1927- 2020) a major anticolonialist and feminist figure who was a lawyer.⁵¹ A striking contrast emerges between the two. While Tunisia has remained largely silent on the death of Albert Memmi, with no commemoration or symbolic gestures, streets in Tunis have been named after Halimi. Halimi garnered recognition and appreciation while Memmi, despite his significant contributions as a writer and thinker, has not received the same level of acknowledgment. This observation has raised concerns and prompted further investigation into the reception and responses to their work. Sophie Bessis, a researcher who herself is a Franco-Tunisian Jew and resides between Tunis and Paris, has contemplated this issue and penned a brief analysis on the subject. She suggests that their respective positions on Israel and Palestine may offer an explanation for the contrasting reactions. Halimi, an anti-colonialist figure and advocate for the Palestinian cause, consistently rejected Israel, while Memmi held a more complex and dynamic position throughout his life.⁵² However, it is crucial to note that this is only one aspect of the complex narrative that warrants deeper exploration. As Bessis aptly argues, for individuals from the southern shore of the Mediterranean reading Memmi's works entails introspection and an examination of one's relationship with the Other.⁵³ It necessitates delving into buried memories that may be uncomfortable to confront.

⁵¹ Library of Congress, "Gisèle Halimi," *Library of Congress*, accessed September 15, 2025, <https://guides.loc.gov/feminism-french-women-history/famous/gisele-halimi>

⁵² Sophie Bessis, "Deux destins judéo-tunisiens, Gisèle Halimi et Albert Memmi," *Expressions maghrébines* 20/2 (2021): 39–46.

⁵³ Ibid.

5 Conclusion

Albert Memmi's intellectual legacy, when examined through the lens of "cultures of continuities", offers a powerful counter-narrative to the prevailing academic emphasis on ruptures and separations. His oeuvre, deeply rooted in the complexities of his personal journey, serves as a vital bridge between seemingly disparate Jewish and Arab identities. This unique positioning makes his work a profound testament to a historical experience that is now being actively reclaimed and reinterpreted by a new generation of French Jews of Tunisian or broader Maghrebi descent.

However, Memmi's contributions are not without their inherent tensions and conflicting legacies. While he was initially lauded as a pioneering anti-colonial writer, his later embrace of Zionism and his somewhat problematic portrayal of North African Muslim descendants in a postcolonial framework have undeniably generated significant criticism. These shifts alienated a segment of his initial readership and led to complex debates within intellectual and activist circles.

Despite these critical points of contention, the enduring relevance of Memmi's work remains undeniable. It continues to ignite interest and enthusiasm across a diverse spectrum of artistic, literary, and activist communities. The very complexities that have generated critique do not, in fact, diminish the profound and lasting impact of his ideas. As evidenced by the fresh interpretations offered by contemporary intellectuals and artists, Memmi's personal journey—his relentless exploration of identity, the intricate dynamics of colonialism, and the multifaceted challenges of postcolonialism—continues to resonate deeply with individuals who are prepared to engage in nuanced and often challenging conversations about their shared postcolonial heritage.

At its core, the significance of Memmi's work lies in its contribution to a broader, more profound discussion about the interplay between continuities and ruptures within cultural and historical narratives. There are two pivotal concepts that emerge from his work, which I propose as key takeaways: Firstly, the "hyphen" itself—often perceived as a simple connector—actually conceals a multitude of meanings, hidden histories, and a diverse array of actors whose contributions are often overlooked. Secondly, it is crucial to acknowledge that the processes of rupture and continuity are neither static over time nor solely dictated by external forces. Instead, they are profoundly shaped by the active agency of individuals and the transformative power of cultural and artistic movements. These movements possess the remarkable capacity to reawaken dormant histories, thereby forging continuities even in places where, at first glance, only ruptures appear to exist.

When considering the title “Jewish-Muslim Conversations”, one might instinctively envision a straightforward dialogical relationship—a two-way exchange. Yet, in reality, this often manifests as a more intricate triangular dynamic. Beneath the deceptively simple hyphen of “Jewish-Muslim” lie the interwoven and often conflicting forces that shaped Memmi’s experiences. These include the pervasive influence of coloniality, the profound impact of the French language as a medium of both expression and imposition, and the somewhat abstract and often ideological universalism espoused by the French Enlightenment. It is only through a meticulous and comprehensive examination of these interconnected factors that we can begin to unravel the intricate tapestry of legacies, the moments of rupture, and the persistent threads of continuity that define this complex historical and cultural landscape.⁵⁴

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⁵⁴ I began writing and thinking about this article in late 2022 and early 2023. I presented it during the seminar in Berlin in the last quarter of 2023. By the time the volume is published in 2025, the biographical trajectories of the artists I cite, as well as the geopolitical situation, have changed radically. It is this sense of rupture that I attempted to explore in an article published here:

Hathroubi, Samia. “Logbook of a Researcher in Sociology in Times of Crisis: Investigating Jews and Muslims after the 7th of October and the Following Days.” *European Journal of Cultural Studies* 28, no. 1 (2025): 121–129.

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Elad Lapidot

Chapter 7

Knowing People

Discontinuities in Modern Jewish Political Epistemology

1 Introduction

This chapter offers a reflection on the continuities and discontinuities between the modern project of knowledge, paradigmatically represented by academic knowledge, and the modern project of Judaism.

By “project of knowledge” I mean self-conscious, conceptualized, articulated, organized and institutionalized activities for the purpose of knowledge production. One of the central figures of a project of knowledge is the school or the academy. My research focuses on diverse contemporary understandings of academic knowledge and their connection to Judaism. More specifically, I’m interested in the interrelation between the self-understanding or self-knowledge of the modern academic knowledge project (often termed “epistemology”) and its knowledge of the Jewish project. This interrelation appears most clearly in the self-conception of the academic knowledge of Judaism, the academic Jewish studies, i.e. as the interrelation between how it understands itself and how it understands its object.

I state from the outset, in a nutshell, the basic tensions and stakes that I perceive in this interrelation. The most crucial point is the status given by academic knowledge to knowledge in Judaism itself, that is to Jewish knowledge. It seems to be an uncontroversial statement that knowledge as a project, i.e. organized knowledge, plays a central role in the main historical forms of Jewish being and practice. In some forms, Jewish being itself appears as a collective project of knowledge, called *torah* or *talmud*. In this context, the concept of “Jewish Studies” reveals its ambivalence: the “Jewish” may designate not only the subject-matter of a basically non-Jewish project of knowledge, but also the form of knowledge itself. From this perspective, the encounter between modern academic knowledge and Jewish knowledge carries the potential of conflict – at the very least of discontinuity.

This is, first, an epistemological conflict, namely a tension not just between different inventories or states of knowledge and information, but between different projects of knowledge, different epistemologies, i.e. different basic conceptions of what it is at all “to know” and the different principles and practices of knowledge that follow therefrom. This is what I refer to as “projects” of knowledge. Foucault used the term “episteme”. So the encounter between modern aca-

demic knowledge and Judaism *qua* knowledge, between academic Jewish studies and Jewish Jewish studies, potentially generates a tension between two different epistemes, i.e. an epistemological tension.

Second, and on the other hand, the academic project of knowledge itself is a collective project, or even more: a project of collective. This applies to the very idea of the school. It explicitly applies to the institution of the *universitas magistrorum et scholarium*, the community of teachers and students, modernly known as the “university”. The university is the knowledge project *qua* a project of collective, it constitutes a collective form of life organized around knowledge, so to speak a “city of knowers”. As such, the university stands in *political* relations and tensions vis-à-vis other projects and models of collective existence, such as the Church and more prominently in late modernity, the State. Similarly, the encounter between the modern university and the Jewish collective project(s) potentially generates a political tension.

Combined, the epistemological and the political converge into one basic epistemo-political tension, a tension of political epistemology, which concerns the question of the relations between knowledge and collective existence: What ways are there for intersubjective practice and performance of knowledge? What ways are there for epistemic constitution of communal or collective existence? What is the relation between the modern academic and the modern Jewish epistemo-political models?

What I want to focus on in the following is the ways in which this epistemo-political tension has been negotiated and resolved by different modern projects of academic studies of Judaism. As said above, I will look at how the negotiations and resolutions of this tension between the academic project and the Jewish project are articulated in the relation between how the academic project understands and constructs (“knows”) itself and how it understands and constructs its Jewish object of knowledge. In other words, I will try to perform an epistemo-political analysis of the self-conception of academic Jewish studies.

I will point at four different models of academic Jewish studies, in four modern projects of academy, which I think are central for the above question: the German University’s *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, the Hebrew University’s *khokhmat yisrael*, the American University’s *Cultural Jewish Studies* and the Lithuanian *yeshiva*’s project of *torah*. For each of these models I will try to suggest a basic conceptual articulation, based on a representative discourse by one or more of its historical founders. Obviously, these are only initial, general reflections, offered by way of hermeneutics, which await further discussion, examination, differentiation, support or – refutation.

2 The German University's *Wissenschaft des Judentums*

The first model I would like to consider is that of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*. This German concept, translatable (with difficulty) as the ‘Science of Judaism,’ designates a specific project of academic Jewish studies in the modern German University in the early 19th century. It is this project that the common contemporary narrative of academic Jewish studies in the university, as I will show below, relates to as its historical and epistemological origin. The very fact of this genealogical narrative is significant. One could trace the genealogy of the 19th century *Wissenschaft of Judentum* from earlier phenomena and conceptions of the study of Judaism in early modern and medieval universities, mostly in various Christian theological contexts.¹ In the present reflection, which is dedicated to modern and contemporary Jewish Studies, I wish to work with the common narrative of *Wissenschaft des Judentums* in its original sense, precisely as a significant genealogical narrative, with constitutive consequences for later models, even as they criticize and negate it. It is in this sense that the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* may be considered as the foundational project of modern university Jewish studies.

This initial narrative awareness also determines the choice of textual source for the discourse analysis. The archive of Jewish Studies suggests as the earlier manifesto of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* Immanuel Wolf's (later Immanuel Wohlwill) “Über den Begriff einer Wissenschaft des Judenthums” [“On the Concept of a Science of Judaism”], which opened the first issue of the *Zeitschrift für die Wissenschaft des Judenthums* [Journal for the Science of Judaism] in 1822.² Wolf's text is no doubt one of the earliest articulate expressions of the self-understanding of the then new epistemic project and emergent collective: the *Ver-ein für Cultur und Wissenschaft der Juden* [Association for Culture and Science of the Jews], which published the journal, and was founded in Berlin in 1819. In other words, Wolf's text is – conceptually – the expression of an already existing epistemo-political configuration. The text I wish to analyse here is an earlier text, preceding both the journal and the association. It does not even yet speak of Wis-

1 See for instance Giuseppe Veltri and Gerold Necker, eds., *Gottes Sprache in der philologischen Werkstatt. Hebraistik vom 15. bis 19. Jahrhundert*, (Leiden: Brill, 2004).

2 Immanuel Wolf, „Über den Begriff einer Wissenschaft des Judenthums,“ *Zeitschrift für die Wissenschaft des Judenthums* (1822): 1–24. Wolf's text was presented and analyzed as the basic text of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* and of contemporary academic studies of Judaism, for instance, by Christoph Schulte, „Über den Begriff einer Wissenschaft des Judentums. Die ursprüngliche Konzeption der Wissenschaft des Judentums und ihre Aktualität nach 175 Jahren.“ *Aschkenas* 7.2 (1997): 277–302.

senschaft des Judentums. Rather, it lays the conceptual foundations for the intellectual configuration that will merit that name.

The text in question was published in 1818 by Dr. Leopold Zunz, the founding father of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, under the humble title *Etwas über die rabbinische Literatur*, “Something on the rabbinic Literature.”³ This title indicates that the significance of the text resides less in what exactly is to be said “on” its object (“something”), and more in the identification and designation of this object itself, in its very objectification. In other words, this text performs the foundational act of constituting the object of the future Science of Judaism, i.e. of constituting Judaism as an object of science.

The objectification is carried out by the concept of “literature.” “Literature” is a specific way of designating knowledge. Zunz’s scientific project of knowledge, from its inception, identifies its object as being itself knowledge. The concept “literature,” however, unlike the concept “science” for instance, abstracts from any epistemic specificity of the concerned knowledge and identifies it by the sole fact of its textual media. In the concept “literature,” the objectification of Jewish knowledge is carried out by way of de-epistemization, that is, by denying this knowledge any epistemic specificity.

The knowledge in Zunz’s title is, however, not unspecific, undetermined knowledge. It is characterized as “rabbinic.” The term “rabbi” seems to designate a specific type of paradigmatic knowledge agent, a specific kind of – literally – *magister*, a master of knowledge, ‘teacher’ or ‘scholar.’ “Rabbinic” would consequently be an epistemic designation of the “literature” in question, identifying a specific form or kind of knowledge, a specific *episteme*. It is this notion, however, that Zunz rejects. This rejection constitutes the crucial conceptual operation of this seminal text. The concept “rabbinic” is brought in the title precisely because it is understood to designate a specific kind of knowledge, namely in order to invoke this understanding – not for the purpose of confirming it, but for the purpose of dismissing it. Zunz’s lays his foundation through a profound act of negation. This act is so subversive that it is only explicitly stated in a footnote on the first page of the text. This footnote could be read as the basic motto for Zunz’s new Science: “basically the title rabbi, which courtesy grants to everyone, has less meaning than doctor.”⁴

This is not an act of simple negation, but of substitution. The “rabbi” forfeits the epistemic agency in favor of another knowledge agent, the university “doc-

³ Leopold Zunz, „*Etwas über die rabbinische Literatur* (1818),“ in *Gesammelte Schriften*, vol. 1., ed. Leopold Zunz (Berlin: Gerschel, 1875), 1–31.

⁴ Zunz, *Etwas*, 1.

tor”, which becomes the new paradigm for Zunz, who three years later will himself become a *Dr. phil.* The substitution of the epistemic agent signifies the substitution of the epistemic agency, that is the episteme that is operative in Zunz’s knowledge project. The episteme that is the object of Zunz’s knowledge has been de-epistemized, neutralized as: “literature.” Its “rabbinic” specificity too was denied epistemic force. The further determination of this literature, its characterization, classification, articulation, and also interpretation and comprehension, namely the actual “knowing” of this literature must take place in and through a different episteme: the one whose agent is the “doctor,” that is modern German science.

Consequently, what Zunz now proposes to do and actually starts doing in his inaugural essay, what he calls the “preliminary literary works” for turning the “Literature” in question into an object of knowledge, is to subject it to the entire set of knowledge categories of modern German science. This literature should be understood, he writes, as theology, mythology, religion, jurisprudence, state science, ethics, moral, astronomy, geography, mathematics, technology, industry, art, history, language, poetry and philosophy. Insofar as it constitutes knowledge, furthermore, insofar as it is at all knowable, the object of Zunz’s new science must fall under one or more of these categories.

The object itself, however, is not designated by any of these categories. In fact, having established that the “literature” to be studied by his new science has *no* epistemological specificity of its own, in the same famous footnote Zunz suggests designating it, instead of by the misleading “rabbinic literature,” by a new concept: “Jewish Literature.” This is the moment where the “Jewish” appears in the new science. Its function is negative: the concept “Jewish” is intended to neutralize any epistemological specificity, that is with relevance to modern science. “Jewish” is introduced so to speak as a category of non-knowledge: it designates something that does constitute knowledge (“literature”), but does not have its own epistemic agency, lacks its own epistemology and may be known only through foreign categories. This is the significance of constituting “the Jewish” or “Judaism” as an object of science: “The entire literature of the Jews, in its broadest scope, will be handled here as **an object of research**, without concerning ourselves of whether its content should or may also be a **norm for our own judgments**.”⁵

This is the epistemological drama behind Immanuel Wolf’s almost tautological sounding statement four years later that the “Science of Judaism” aims at

5 Zunz, *Etwas*, 5; emphases in the original.

turning Judaism into “an object of science”.⁶ This means facilitating the initial representation of Jewish knowledge within the sole medium and in the exclusive categories of modern German science. This is also the basis for all later statements, such as Martin Buber’s in 1901, that “in the strict methodical sense, there cannot be valid Jewish science”.⁷ This epistemology may still be identified and characterized in current German academic Jewish studies as follows: “none of its methods or disciplines is ‘Jewish’. Rather, the Science of Judaism integrates a plurality of methods, questions and knowledge of other sciences. (. . .) It is *one* science due to its object, in all its phenomena: Judaism. (. . .) Also in *Jüdischen Studien*, Jewish Studies or *Judaistik*, ‘Jewish’ is not an attribute of the studies themselves, but of their object field”.⁸

I wish to point at the profound political significance that this epistemological configuration has in Zunz’s foundational project. The negation and substitution that underlie the epistemic construction of “Judaism” as the object of science are also at work in the closely related construction of the Jewish collective, the ‘Jews.’ This construction is carried out in the form of narrative construction, i.e. of historiography. Zunz posits the beginning of his text and narrative in “the flourishing period of the old Hebrews,” namely in the Bible. What follows is a story of irreversible decline. The “Jewish literature” that is to become the object of his science is described as “the later products of the Hebrew nation,” which has “fallen from its political as well as intellectual height.” Jewish knowledge would be a form of degeneration, solely supported by “foreign culture.” The modern rise of “European” literature, says Zunz, has brought about the final demise of Jewish literature. The epistemic negation of Judaism is thus enacted in a historical narrative of the Jewish collective, which temporally leads to and defines, pre-determines Zunz’s present moment itself: “In our time,” he writes, Jews turn to German language and culture and “carry the modern Hebrew literature to the grave.”⁹ Zunz’s Judaism is an already dead Judaism that is presently being buried by the Jews themselves, the Jews of the present.

It is in this “burial ritual,” as Gershom Scholem will later call it,¹⁰ that science has a historical role to play, Zunz explains: “Science emerges and demands an

⁶ Wolf, “Über den Begriff,”: 1.

⁷ Martin Buber, “Jüdische Wissenschaft,” *Die Welt: Zentralorgan der Zionistischen Bewegung* 41 (1901): 1.

⁸ Schulte, “Über den Begriff,” 302 – translation Elad Lapidot.

⁹ Zunz, *Etwas*, 10.

¹⁰ Gershom Scholem, “From Reflections on *khokhmat yisrael*” (1940), in *dvarim bego*, (Tel Aviv: Am Oved, 1975), 385–403 [in Hebrew, translation Elad Lapidot].

account [*verlangt Rechenschaft*] from the time that **ended**.”¹¹ What is the epistemo-political significance of this “account”? To answer this it is essential to recall that the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* project was not just embedded, but claimed to play an active and critical role in the political processes concerning the situation of the Jews in the German and Prussian states. Zunz explicitly links his nascent science project to the “civic existence” of the Jews. This link could be on some level understood along the lines of so to speak improving the situations of the Jew, namely providing knowledge and information – “account” – both to the state authorities and to Jews themselves on how to best negotiate the integration of the Jews in the State, the new era of the German Jews. One can also detect an apologetic tendency, namely the desire to prove that “Judaism deserved emancipation.”¹² Zunz’s own later writing and activities provide ample basis for such understanding.¹³

It seems to me, however, that Zunz’s operation has a deeper dimension. The “account” science is called to provide on Judaism, that is on the Jewish literature that “ended,” is to substitute the account of Judaism on itself, that is Jewish self-knowledge, self-consciousness. Judaism once buried, Science of Judaism is to become the new self-consciousness of Jews – not just to improve them but to *be* them. Zunz’s *Wissenschaft des Judentums* aspires not just to objectively “know about” Jews, but constitutes itself as the modern Jewish collective project, or the modern collective project that is Judaism. The inaugural act of conversion is performed by Zunz himself, in the short self-reflexive preface to his foundational text. In it, Zunz explains the identity of the “we,” in whose name and voice his text speaks, who repeatedly claim the Science of Judaism as “our science.” “[I]n doctrinary matters”, Dr. Zunz write, “[the author] chooses the humble **we**, by blending in the entire battalion of representatives, who campaign for the silent science.”¹⁴

Who is “science”? Of what epistemo-political project is “*Wissenschaft*” the name? This is a crucial and difficult question, with implications for the entire project of modernity. Constitutive for the entire discourse of “science” is its universal claim. The agent of science is humanity. The question about the epistemo-

11 Zunz, *Etwas*, 10.

12 Christian Wiese, *Challenging Colonial Discourse Jewish Studies and Protestant Theology in Wilhelmine Germany* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2005), 5.

13 Leopold Zunz, *Die gottesdienstlichen Vorträge der Juden, historisch entwickelt. Ein Beitrag zur Alterthumskunde und biblischen Kritik, zur Literatur- und Religionsgeschichte* (Berlin: G.Reimer, 1832), iii; Ludwig Geiger, „Zunz im Umgang mit Behörden und Hochgestellten“, *Monatsschrift für Geschichte und Wissenschaft des Judentums* 60 (1916): 330–370.

14 Zunz, *Etwas*, 11.

political project of science requires further discussion of the notions of universalism and the human, and of the specific universal idea that the *Wissenschaft* has of the human being. At this point, I will only refer to the particular historic situation of Zunz's science project. The immediate answer to the question concerning the identity of the collective, institutionalized framework to which it subscribes, so it seems to me, can be no other than the German state university, namely the knowledge project of the German state. This is the episteme and discourse adopted by Zunz. In this perspective, all of the future institutions – associations, seminaries, *Hochschule* – of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* would be *epistemologically* already institutions of the German state university, ultimately aspiring to what Zunz himself sought to achieve from the King of Prussia, namely to become also *institutionally* a part of the German state.¹⁵ “Science of Judaism” would be the epistemic name of converting the Jewish collective project into the modern project of the German state.

3 *Khokhmat Yisrael* and the Hebrew University

The first counter-model to the German University's *Wissenschaft des Judentums* I would like to look at is the project of *khokhmat yisrael*, the “Wisdom of Israel,” in the Hebrew University. My focus is Gershom Scholem's 1940 essay, “Reflections on *khokhmat yisrael*.” This text is not as fundamental to the concept or the practical execution of *khokhmat yisrael*—neither in its ideas nor in its institutional impact—as Zunz's work was for *Wissenschaft des Judentums*. I say this from Scholem's own viewpoint. His text understands itself as “reflections” on its object, *khokhmat yisrael*, which accordingly would already exist. Scholem's “Reflections” have become canonic as a historical self-critique of modern university Jewish studies, looking back, as to a point of origin, on the German *Wissenschaft des Judentums*. This act of reflection, that is of rethinking, revisiting, returning back from a distance to the point of departure, constitutes the basic operation of Scholem's science as historical, not just in the sense of looking *at* or even being *in* history, but as making history.

This fundamental understanding of science as an agent, perhaps the agent of history, what I perceive as an explicitly epistemo-political conception of science, is clearly expressed by the very concept of *khokhmat yisrael*. In contrast to Zunz's German science of Hebrew literature, חכמת ישראל is spoken in the language of *yisrael* itself, spoken *by yisrael*. Indeed the “Wisdom of Israel” is clearly not just the-

15 Letters brought in Geiger, „Zunz im Umgang mit Behörden und Hochgestellten,” 337.

oretical knowledge *about* Israel or Judaism, but the existential knowledge, the “wisdom” that belongs *to* and sustains the collective Israel. The political agent Israel is also the epistemic agent, the subject of *khokmat yisrael*. Inversely, *khokmat yisrael* would be the epistemic designation of the historical, political collective of Israel.

Scholem’s “Reflections” begin by directly invoking an existing and already operative espiemo-political discourse, tying together knowledge project and collective project, namely the Zionist “great vision” of the Hebrew University in Jerusalem.¹⁶ The invoked vision articulates the historical-political narrative of the messianic redemption of *yisrael* in epistemic terms, that is in discourse of knowledge.¹⁷ The redeemed subject is not *yisrael*, rather the vision speaks of “the redemption of *khokmat yisrael*.” It is *khokmat yisrael* who “returns” from exile to its land and to its tongue. The “new building,” a clear reference to the rebuilt temple, is portrayed as “the house of wisdom and science,” “the house of *khokmat yisrael*,” which emerges in the concrete and already existing shape of “the Institute for the Sciences of Judaism on Mount Scopus as the first seed of the Hebrew University.”¹⁸ The Hebrew University was founded in 1925 and in 1940, when Scholem is writing his reflections, he is a professor at the Hebrew University’s Institute for Sciences of Judaism [המכון למדעי היהדות], so to speak a “priest” of the new temple of *khokmat yisrael*. The terminological difference between the “Jewish Studies,” where Scholem held office, and *khokmat yisrael*, which he was contemplating, measures the distance between vision and reality, which his “Reflections” establish and attempt to bridge.¹⁹

Like Zunz, Scholem too positions his own intervention as the present moment, the “now” of the narrative he is constructing. In contrast to Zunz’s history of Jewish knowledge’s decline, Scholem, as aforesaid, tells a story of its redemption. His own present position in the story, however, Professor for Sciences of Judaism, Scholem identifies in relation to Zunz’s position (“reflection”), and, simi-

16 On the history of the idea of the Hebrew University, see Israel Kolatt, “The Idea of the Hebrew University in the Jewish National Movement” in *The History of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem. Origins and Beginnings*, ed. Shaul Katz and Michael Heyd (Jerusalem: The Hebrew University Magnes Press, 2000), 3–75.

17 A foundational articulation of this vision can be read, for instance, in the inaugural speeches of Hayim Nahman Bialik and Rav Abraham Isaac Kook at the opening ceremony of the Hebrew University in 1925, Katz & Heyd *The History of the Hebrew University*, 311–362.

18 Gershom Scholem, “From Reflections,” 390.

19 As Daniel R. Schwartz (“From Rabbinical Seminaries to the Institute of Jewish Studies”, Katz & Heyd *The History of the Hebrew University*, 457–476) shows, the Hebrew University’s Institute for Jewish Studies was and still is much more a Zunzian historical-philological *Wissenschaft* project than the “house of wisdom” in Scholem’s national-messianic vision.

larly to Zunz, as a *negative* moment. But this negation is of a more complex, dialectic nature. The term Scholem is using to designate the dialectical configuration defining his moment in history is *Ikvata de-Meshicha* [עקבתא דמשיחא], “the footstep [or the trace] of messiah.” In the “wisdom of Israel,” this term designates the time when the messiah nears, but such that his nearing presence first takes effect and is observable and felt in the growing acuteness of his absence. *Ikvata de-Meshicha* is the moment when, just before redemption, bad gets worse.²⁰ It can be understood as the time of destruction of the destructive world order itself, from which redemption is sought, in preparation of the construction of the new, positive world order. *Ikvata de-Meshicha* is thus a complex time of transition, which contains three negative moments: the negativity of the unredeemed world, the destruction of this world and the negation of this destruction for the sake of reconstruction. In this process of redeeming Jewish knowledge, the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* and *khokhmat yisrael* execute different moments.

The modern epistemic figure of *Ikvata de-Meshicha* in Scholem’s discourse, that is the figure of messianic presence in modern knowledge, so it seems to me, is “historical critique.” In other words, like Zunz, Scholem too identifies the future of Jewish knowledge in modern science. More specifically, he finds it exactly where he believes Zunz himself found it, namely in German romanticism. It is in the “historical critique” of German romanticism that Scholem perceives the dialectics of “the footsteps of Messiah”: the dual tendency of destruction and conversion, what he calls the “contradiction.”²¹ For formal, positive logic “contradiction” is the mark of the untrue statement. For dialectic, in contrast, contradiction marks movement, development, that is the growth of true idea into true reality, into history. The historical truth that Scholem identifies as the *telos* of romantic “historical critique,” that is the messianic end where all epistemic contradictions are reconciled, is the fulfillment of science in national politics – “the construction of a nation.”²²

The “nation” is the end of knowledge. Nation-building is also the ultimate meaning of the modern project for redeeming Jewish knowledge through historical critique, the project that Scholem calls *khokhmat yisrael*. It is in this framework that his historical critique of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* should be understood. Scholem acknowledges that the founders of the Science of Judaism, people like Zunz, Steinschneider and Geiger, correctly appropriated German romantic historicism by developing the productive contradiction of “pure science”

²⁰ For the term *ikvot meshikha* see TB Sota 49a; for the eschatological meaning and fantasy associated with this concept, see TB Sanhedrin 97a-b.

²¹ Gershom Scholem, “From Reflections,” 396.

²² Ibid., 403.

with a “political role” and by applying it to Jewish knowledge. However, he says, “[t]heir historical conscienceless did not permit its owners the positive use of their method, and so the romantic science and its methods appear in their work as a frightening burial ritual.”²³ As I showed, the notion of “burial” was used by Zunz himself. This image of a death ritual now becomes central in Scholem’s narrative. This expert of mysticism speaks of the “demonic” nature of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, whose historical philology laid down Jewish knowledge in “literature,” in rows of books like rows of graves.²⁴ Scholem further identifies the epistemo-political meaning of this act of “liquidation” as “historical suicide”: “The Jew wishes to liberate himself from himself and the Science of Judaism is for him a burial ritual and liberation from the burden that lies on him.”²⁵ In other words, the grave of *khokhmat yisrael* is the collective grave of *yisrael* itself. This is what I referred to, in my analysis of Zunz, as the act of “substitution”, that is the *Aufhebung* of Jewish-being in German-being.

Scholem’s depiction is very bleak. His judgment of *Wissenschaft des Judentums* sounds categorically damning, when he describes it, for instance, as the “cancer in the living body of *khokhmat yisrael*.”²⁶ We should not, however, forget the historical dialectics that frames his entire narrative. The messianic operation of “historical critique,” to which Scholem himself subscribes, inherently and necessarily contains a moment of negation, namely the destruction of the unredeemed world. In both Scholem’s and Zunz’s narratives, which on this point converge, this is the world of Jewish knowledge before the advent of science. It is a world outside life, outside history, a world of “spirits” or “ghosts.”²⁷ The redemption of these spirits requires ending the state of their ghostly existence. In this sense, the destruction effected by the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* is necessary. The problem for Scholem is that this destruction is conceived and executed as *pure* destruction, as “liquidation”: redeeming the spirit of Jewish knowledge by letting it die, by giving it a “proper burial.”

As I argued and Scholem now confirms, this epistemic and political negation of Judaism by the Science of Judaism was guided and pre-determined by its fundamental commitment to the project of the German University, and ultimately of the German State. Writing in the Hebrew University in Jerusalem, Scholem has a different perspective. The ultimate goal of academic Jewish studies is not objectifying and disempowering Jewish knowledge in order to make room for modern

²³ Ibid., 389.

²⁴ Gershom Scholem, “From Reflections,” 392.

²⁵ Ibid., 391.

²⁶ Ibid., 401.

²⁷ Ibid., 390.

non-Jewish science as the new epistemic agent, the goal is not Science of Judaism. Rather, the goal is to redeem the Jewish agent itself by redeeming *khokhmat yisrael*. The first negative moment of destruction was necessary, but now – and this is precisely Scholem's own big “now” – comes the moment where “historical critique” of Jewish knowledge can use “both sides,” namely both the destructive and the constructive. Construction does not just replace destruction. Rather, they are two moments in the same historical project. The constructive moment is a counter-operation to the destructive one. Scholem's *khokhmat yisrael* counters the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*. Their contradiction is dialectical. Scholem thus formulates the constructive operation of the Wisdom of Israel in a dialectical relation to the destructive operation of the Science of Judaism, namely as negation of negation, as the “liquidation of the liquidation” [היסול ההיסול],²⁸ which is an act of historical “reflection.”

The redemption of Jewish knowledge in the Hebrew University, as Scholem envisions it, is not a redemption by proper burial, but, on the contrary, by bringing back to life – by “revival” or “renaissance” [תחייה]. Since for Scholem the entire *telos* of science is the “construction of a nation,” he directly identifies the renaissance of *khokhmat yisrael* with the Jewish “national renaissance,” with Zionism.²⁹ National revival, the political restoration of the Jewish collective as sovereign, fulfills the idea of science, by allowing it:

to see from the inside, to go from the center to the periphery without reticence and without falsification! To rebuild the entire structure of science in light of the historical experience of the Jew who dwells inside his people and who has no other concerns but seeing the problems, the events and the ideas according to the truth of their being, in the framework of their historical function in the nation.³⁰

The redeemed *khokhmat yisrael* is the historic return of the collective self-consciousness of the Jewish people mediated by “historical critique.” As in the German University, in the Hebrew University too the epistemo-political redemption of Jewish knowledge is modern science – only here it is not understood as redemption *from* but as redemption *of* Jewishness.

²⁸ Gershom Scholem, “From Reflections,” 399.

²⁹ *Ibid.*, 400.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, 399.

4 Jewish Cultural Studies and the American University

I want to examine a third discourse within modern academic Jewish studies: the project of Jewish Cultural Studies in the American University. I see this as a second counter-model to the German University's *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, and also, it seems to me, as a response to the Hebrew University's *khokhmat yisrael*. This is the most recent paradigm I will examine in this paper and in many respects, it is still evolving. For this reason, it is harder to determine and evaluate the exact scope and paradigmatic nature of this project, as well as its epistemological goals and prospects. The task is all the more complex for me, since I believe my own research, including this paper, belongs to the same present moment, the epistemological and political “now” that also defines *Jewish Cultural Studies*. This is why my critical reflection on this discourse is almost self-reflective.

I wish to characterize the broader horizon of the “now”. *Jewish Cultural Studies* is a paradigm, a growing tendency in university Jewish studies in the last three decades, and is no longer only objectifying and subjecting Jewish knowledge to modern scientific episteme, but identifying in Jewish knowledge resources for *critique* of modern university episteme. This can be termed re-activation or re-epistemization of Judaism. It is interesting to note, however, that these critical attempts themselves are mostly inspired and theoretically determined by developments in the epistemological self-critique of modern and contemporary university discourse, first and foremost in the Anglo-American academy. They characteristically proceed as applications of general theories on the specific field of Jewish Studies. Thus, drawing on postcolonial discourse, scholars have identified in the rise of Jewish Studies, beyond the motif of objectification and subjugation of Judaism to German science, which I underlined, also a moment of “resistance and disruption,”³¹ such as “the endeavor to contest the anti-pluralist hegemony of Protestant culture”.³² *Jewish Cultural Studies* is a contemporary programmatic attempt to realize this potential of epistemological resistance. One of its seminal manifestos was authored by Jonathan Boyarin and Daniel Boyarin, as an introduction to

31 Susannah Heschel, “Jewish Studies as counterhistory,” in *Insider/Outsider. American Jews and Multiculturalism*, eds. David Biale, Michael Galchinsky and Susannah Heschel (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1998), 101–115, 102.

32 Wiese, *Challenging Colonial Discourse*, 25; more recently see Willi Goetschel and Ato Quayson, “Introduction: Jewish Studies and Postcolonialism”, *Cambridge Journal of Postcolonial Literary Inquiry*, 3.1 (January 2016): 1–9.

the 1997 collective volume *Jews and Other Differences: The New Jewish Cultural Studies*.³³ It is the conceptual articulation offered in this text that I will now examine.

The Boyarins' introduction is titled "So What's New?" In the "New" Jewish Cultural Studies, what's new is neither Jewish nor Jewish Studies, but Cultural Studies. Cultural Studies are a general development in modern academic episteme, of which "Jewish" Cultural Studies would be a specific application. The Boyarins refer here in the first place to the work of Raymond Williams, the British founder of cultural studies, as well as to research directions such as reflexive anthropology, women studies and feminist theory. The Boyarins understand the novelty in all these academic directions not just in the indifferent sense of 'it has never been done before', but more precisely as a "response" to the "crisis" of modern West and "liberal academy," that is as self-critical historical reflection of the university episteme.

To understand this critique, that is the nature of the crisis and the response, I quote here the central statement of the Boyarins' manifest, which formulates the goal and basic vision of the new *Cultural Jewish Studies*:

Jewish culture as part of the world of differences to be valued and enhanced by research in the university, together with the differences of other groups hanging unto cultural resources similarly at risk of being consumed by a liberal universalist ethos.³⁴

The crisis of liberal academy lies in the elimination of differences by liberal universalism. This should not be too quickly understood as plain anti-universalism, since the crisis generated by universalism is described here in general, universal terms. There seems to be a difference within universalism – different universalisms. The liberal kind of universalism is consuming, eliminatory, destructive. It seems to me that, at least with respect to academic Jewish studies, the notion of destructive universalism can be referred to the foundational negative operation of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* that both Zunz and Scholem designated as "burial," and that I described as de-epistemization of Jewish knowledge and its substitution by modern science. It remains a question, as I underlined above,

33 Jonathan Boyarin and Daniel Boyarin, eds., *Jews and Other Differences: The New Jewish Cultural Studies* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1997). Another way of understanding this project is as "Critical Jewish Studies," see Elad Lapidot, "Angelos Novus, a Midrash: Critical Jewish Studies and the University to Come" in *Critical Jewish Studies Now*, eds. Re'ee Hagay and Itamar Hartian (Cham: Springer, forthcoming), through a reading of Jonathan Boyarin, *Storm from Paradise. The Politics of Jewish Memory* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1992).

34 Boyarin and Boyarin, *Jews and Other Differences*, xi.

whether this elimination was carried out for the benefit of universalism or for the benefit of the German state.

The response of Cultural Studies to the destructive universalism of academic studies lies in “what’s new” in these studies, namely their notion of “culture.” In other words, the fundamental epistemological operation carried out by Cultural Studies is the perception of their object of study as “culture.” To understand the basic thrust of this concept, I refer to the definition of Raymond Williams himself, the founder of Cultural Studies, who explained the precise sense of his use: “Where culture meant a state or habit of the mind, or the body of intellectual and moral activities, it means now, also, a whole of life.”³⁵ In other words, Cultural Study’s concept of “culture” posits a difference between “intellectual and moral activities” as belonging to the sphere of the “mind,” what in epistemic terms we can call “knowledge” in the narrow sense, and “the whole of life,” which would thus include more than that, that is something beyond mind and intellect, beyond or different than knowledge. This means that the academic, scientific category of “culture” generates an epistemological difference between science itself (as intellectual activity), and its other, the non-intellectual object of science: life.

It is interesting to note that “culture” thus produces a similar effect of de-epistemization of the scientific object to the one produced by the category “literature.” “Literature,” however, is a de-epistemized concept of knowledge itself and therefore promotes, as I showed above, its subjugation to the scientific episteme and the substitution of the epistemic agent. “Culture,” on the other hand, designates the otherness of knowledge itself, in which knowledge is embedded, that is “the whole of life.” It accordingly generates a distance, an estrangement between science and its object. Indeed, the fundamental function of the concept of “culture” is to establish “difference.” Difference, “a world of differences,” is the proposed antidote to liberal, eliminatory universalism. As the Boyarins write: “difference can heal.”³⁶

This is why the project of the “New Jewish Cultural Studies” could also be titled “Jews and Other Differences.” This title can be read as the epistemo-political vision of the academic Jewish studies in the form of Jewish Cultural Studies: “Jewish culture as part of the world of differences to be valued and enhanced by research in the university”.³⁷ University Jewish studies are to enhance Judaism as different. What is the meaning of this project? There is here, it seems to me, ambivalence. Both the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* and *khokhmat yisrael* may be

³⁵ Raymond Williams, *Culture and Society* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1960), xvi-xvii.

³⁶ Boyarin and Boyarin, *Jews and Other Differences*, xiii.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, xi.

said to advance precisely this – Judaism as different. In Zunz's discourse this difference is generated through the medium of history: Judaism is deferred to the past. In Scholem's discourse the difference lies in Jewish national identity. How is the cultural difference – different? In epistemo-political terms, it seems to run the risk of leading to the same result of neutralizing the "different" Jewish knowledge from even potentially being the agent of the collective project of modern academic knowledge itself. In other words, orienting university research to respect and enhance the difference and otherness of Jewish and other systems of knowledge, as "different cultures," may operate as a new mechanism for disempowering all those differences and consequently rendering absolute the episteme of "university research" itself, this time under the flag of the American University and the eschatology of the United States.

We can get a better sense of this difficulty if we ask what is "Jewish" in academic Jewish studies, from the perspective of Jewish Cultural Studies. The Boyarins' text offers two answers. The first answer is formulated as a critique of what they call the "politics of Jewish identity in the American academy."³⁸ Since Jewish Studies programs are often funded by Jewish communities, the programs tend to focus on the enhancement of Jewish identity. Against this Jewish politics of knowledge, the Boyarins point out how academic programs of other "particulars," that is the "Other Differences," such as Latino, African American, gay and lesbian studies, "tend to be broadly tied to demands of affirmative action and diversification as a general mandate for universities at the end of the twentieth century."³⁹ In other words, the Jewish difference as *per se* different, as a particular "identity," must cede before the non-Jewish "general mandate" of the university. The potential risk here is that Cultural Jewish Studies would work to relativize Jewish knowledge in relation to the absolute position of "universities at the end of the twentieth century."

But the Boyarins also provide a second answer to the question about the Jewishness of Cultural Jewish Studies. They do recognize a general horizon, a universal claim in Jewish "culture" itself, namely the vision of *tikkun olam*, of "repairing the world."⁴⁰ This universalism would not be that of the modern liberal universalist ethos. In other words, alienating Judaism from modern academic knowledge, through the concept of "culture," also opens the possibility of acknowledging the proper agency as well as the proper action, the proper "world," of Jewish knowledge. There may be a Jewish epistemo-political project that is universal but *differ-*

³⁸ Boyarin and Boyarin, *Jews and Other Differences*, viii.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, xi.

⁴⁰ *Ibid.*, vii.

ent than the project of modern science promoted in such modern academies, for instance, as the German and the Hebrew state universities.

In the Boyarin manifesto the idea of this potential Jewish difference operates mainly negatively, by generating resistance to the historical narrative espoused both by Zunz and Scholem, that is of Western modernity as the redemption of Judaism. The Boyarins put in question, more specifically, post-WWII Jewish historiography that has developed this narrative by conceiving of the Holocaust and the State of Israel as the Jewish “return to history.” They critically refer to this operation as the “devaluation of Jewish difference in exile.”⁴¹ Although they only refer to post-WWII historiography, it seems to me that in fact what they call into question is the foundational operation of modern academic Jewish studies, which is, as I showed above, the negation of what Zunz referred to as “the later products of the Hebrew nation” that has “fallen from its political as well as intellectual height,” namely “rabbinic literature.”⁴² The epistemo-political paradigm shift suggested by the New Cultural Jewish Studies comes to light negatively, through the Boyarins’ critical description of the foundational negative paradigm: “pre-modern, Post-Exilic Jewish experience as being primarily of antiquarian or philological interest, rather than critical resources for the necessary refashioning of Jewishness in the present.”⁴³ The new paradigm would be the opposite of that.

This formulation opens a horizon of questions, most importantly for the present epistemo-political investigation: What kind of “critique” and critique of what exactly does pre-modern, Post-Exilic Jewish experience or knowledge has to offer? More precisely, to what purpose, to what end, would the revaluation of Jewish difference in exile work? In what way would it not only serve Jewishness and difference as such, but also, perhaps *eo ipso*, *tikkun olam*? Doesn’t designating the different Jewish knowledge as “pre-modern” run the risk of reproducing the hegemonic narrative of modernity as redemption of the Jews? Wouldn’t the acknowledgement of a proper Jewish epistemo-political vision as in fact *alternative*, and not just different than the presently hegemonic one, require redeeming it from the past by looking for it within modernity itself? What about modern exilic Jewish knowledge as alternative to university Jewish studies themselves? Is there a modern rabbinic epistemo-political project of academic Jewish studies?

This is what I would like to suggest now, in the last part of this paper.

⁴¹ Boyarin and Boyarin, *Jews and Other Differences*, viii.

⁴² *Ibid.*, viii.

⁴³ *Ibid.*, viii.

5 Torah in the Lithuanian yeshiva

The last project I would like to look at is that of torah study in the Lithuanian yeshiva. It is not trivial or at least not very common to consider this project as a modern model of academic Jewish studies, especially not in the university discourse. As the analysis of all first three models of university discourse has shown, at least historically, one constitutive act of Jewish studies in the modern university has been the negation, by burial, redemption or alienation, of the traditional rabbinic knowledge project, to which the Lithuanian yeshiva subscribes. The extent to which the world of Lithuanian yeshivot is intimately linked to the object of this negation is perhaps indicated by the relative absence of this world from university Jewish studies. Decisively a modern Jewish phenomenon, it has received very little attention from research of modern Judaism, compared to such phenomena as Jewish mysticism, Hassidism, *Haskala*, Zionism and of course *Wissenschaft des Judentums* itself.⁴⁴ Research of rabbinic knowledge tends to focus on the past: on early rabbinic literature in late antiquity or Middle Ages. The contemporaneity, the presence of the Lithuanian yeshivot is for university Jewish studies somehow *unheimlich*, an otherness that is too close.⁴⁵

Indeed, the fact is that the world of Lithuanian yeshivot, also in its own self-understanding, is *par excellence* a modern project of academic Jewish studies, in the most precise sense of these words. It is both conceptually and institutionally an organized project of Jewish knowledge, with its own model of academy, namely the yeshiva. It is modern – not just chronologically, as a phenomenon that happened to emerge in the early 19th century, at the same time and parallel to phenomena of modernity, but in direct relation to these phenomena and as an integral part of them. The Lithuanian yeshiva is still currently the central and defining project of many agents of Jewish knowledge, learners, teachers and scholars, who are committed to the rabbinic episteme. Moreover, it is constitutive to the very nature of many contemporary communities as communities. In this

44 For this insight, as for many others in this section, I am indebted to Oded Schechter. Among most recent research: Shaul Stampfer, *Lithuanian Yeshivas of the Nineteenth Century*, (The Littman Library of Jewish Civilization, 2014); Shlomo Tikochinski, *Lamdanut, Mussar ve-Elitizm* [Scholarship, Moral and Elitism], (Jerusalem: Merkaz Shazar, 2016); Immanuel Etkes, *The Gaon of Vilna: The Man and His Image* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2002); Immanuel Etkes and Shlomo Tikochinski, eds., *The Yeshivot of Lithuania – Memories* (Jerusalem: Merkaz Shazar, 2004); Eliyahu Stern, *The Genius: Elijah of Vilna and the Making of Modern Judaism* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013); Shai Wozner, *Legal Thinking in the Lithuanian Yeshivoth. The Heritage and Work of Rabbi Shimon Shkop* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 2016).

45 For this sense of *unheimlich*, see Martin Heidegger, *Sein und Zeit*. Gesamtausgabe, Band 2 (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klostermann, 1977), 244–253.

sense, it functions as a political project, often with a much more significant political impact than that of a state university. Its profoundly exilic nature speaks in the title “Lithuanian,” which, similarly to the Babylonian character of the *Talmud Bavli*, even when it referred to an existing geographical nexus, has no expressed identification with the political project of sovereign Lithuania, like, say, the Vilnius University does.

My attempt here is to reflect on the *talmud torah* (torah study) project of the Lithuanian yeshiva as a modern model of Jewish epistemo-politics. As demonstrated, the fundamental disconnect between university Jewish studies discourse and rabbinic knowledge necessitates, more than in the analysis of other discursive configurations, a heightened awareness of the act and significance of translation when attempting to bridge this gap. The text I will read in what follows is the *Nefesh Ha-Chaim* by Chaim ben Yitzchok of Volozhin, better known as Rabbi Chaim of Volozhin (1749-1821). Rabbi Chaim was a prominent disciple of the Vilna Gaon and in 1802 founded a yeshiva that has become the model of all Lithuanian academies, the “mother of yeshivot,” the Etz Chaim Yeshiva in Volozhin, then a part of the Russian Empire.⁴⁶ *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, the “Soul of Life” or the “Living Soul,” was probably written in R. Chaim’s later years,⁴⁷ and first published posthumously, by his son, in 1823, five years after Zunz’s “Etwas über rabbinische Literatur.” Rabbi Chaim’s book, which Samuel Mirsky described as “holding both his soul and the soul of his yeshiva as one,” is, according to Norman Lamm, “the theoretical basis of the great yeshivot in 19th century Lithuania.”⁴⁸

The book begins by laying down its epistemological foundations. Man’s being created *bezelem*, in the “image” of God, R. Chaim writes, means that man is “the partner of the creator.”⁴⁹ This is precisely the meaning of the book’s title, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, the Living Soul: the human being as “the force and living soul of innumerable upper and lower worlds.”⁵⁰ R. Chaim, referring in his text to sources from all periods and genres of rabbinic literature, with especially numerous references to the book of Zohar, posits an epistemology that is conceptually akin to the ones developed during these same years not so far away from Volozhin,

46 On the founding see: Stampfer, *Lithuanian Yeshivas*, 29–60.

47 Norman Lamm, *Torah Lishmah: Torah for Torah’s Sake: In the Works of Rabbi Hayyim of Volozhin and His Contemporaries* (Jerusalem: Ktav, 1989), 39–40; Etkes, *The Gaon*, 186.

48 Lamm, *Torah Lishmah*, 38, including the Mirsky quote.

49 R. Chaim Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim* (Vilnius: 1837 [1823¹]) [in Hebrew], 57. The following quotes will refer to page numbers of the 1837 edition. All translations are mine. For a recent edition and translation see Avinoam Fraenkel, *Nefesh HaTzimtzum. Rabbi Chaim Volozhin’s Nefesh HaChaim with Translation and Commentary* (Jerusalem/New York: Urim, 2015).

50 Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 19.

namely by Kant in Königsberg, and by the post-Kantian German idealism in Jena and Berlin, which grant central, constitutive status and power to the human agent within the order of things. Like the German philosophers, the Volozhiner rabbi too places the center of human agency in the human mind, what he calls “soul.” Man’s constitutive function requires that he “raise the purity of his thought and intention and turn it upwards for repairing and purifying the holy worlds.”⁵¹

Unlike Kant and more similarly to Hegel, R. Chaim’s understanding of constitutive human agency is not purely epistemological, that is not just limited to cognition – to what we know – but is also ontological, namely concerns the very being of the world. The most important consequence of this difference is the engagement of epistemology, not in metaphysics, but in history: the agency of human knowledge determines and is incarnated by specific figures and phenomena of the human, that is as historical existence. If for Hegel the paradigmatic or accomplished historical figure of the human mind in history was German philosophy itself, R. Chaim identifies another historical agent – *yisrael*.⁵² Within the discourse of Jewish studies, it is critical at this point to note that, in line with the tradition of talmudic literature, R. Chaim’s text does not mention even once the words “Jewish” or “Jews.” As I showed, the *Wissenschaft des Judentums* foundational operation of de-epistemizing its object consisted for Zunz precisely in re-baptizing it “Jewish.” There is here a constitutive moment, which is crucial for the present epistemo-political reflection.⁵³

Yisrael is for R. Chaim the name of the collective manifestation of the human “living soul” in the created world. This is “the secret of the higher root of the collective [כללות] of the souls of *yisrael* together,”⁵⁴ the “assembly” or “collective of *yisrael*” [כנסת ישראל].⁵⁵ The collective of *yisrael* is not understood as a particular nation or culture, whose knowledge would ultimately be self-knowledge, “identity,” but as the very embodiment of human knowledge agency in history. The specificity, the “secret” of this collective, so to speak, is founded in its universal, cosmic knowledge. Correspondingly, this knowledge itself appears in concrete

⁵¹ Ibid., 44.

⁵² Ibid., 20.

⁵³ For a view on what seems to me as an early Paulinian act of founding the “Jewish”, see Elad Lapidot, “Du, der du mit Buchstaben und Beschneidung ein Gesetzesübertreter bist”. Paulus und die Grundlegung des Judentums.” in *Täter und Opfer. Verbrechen und Stigma im europäischen-jüdischen Kontext*, eds. Claudia Simone Dorchain and Tommaso Speccher (Würzburg: Königshausen & Neumann, 2014), 19–41.

⁵⁴ Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 16.

⁵⁵ Ibid., 66.

phenomena within world history, intimately related to the historical constitution of *yisrael*. According to R. Chaim's narrative, the founding father of *yisrael*, "the patriarchs and all of the first righteous," literally embodied the "living" knowledge "through their understanding, in the purity of their mind."⁵⁶ It is through Moses that this knowledge was "brought . . . down to earth,"⁵⁷ namely received a worldly corporeal presence and became a given, *data*, namely *torah*. *Nefesh Chaim* identifies the accomplishment of this epistemic givenness in what Zunz referred to rather as "the later products of the Hebrew nation," after it has "fallen from its political as well as intellectual height," namely in the foundational "rabbinic literature", the Talmud. The accomplished imperative of human ontological agency, the "living soul," is accordingly articulated by R. Chaim in the following terms: "since the holy Talmud was sealed, we should only keep and perform all that is written in the holy torah in writing and orally."⁵⁸ This project he calls עסק התורה, the 'concern with' or 'engagement in' the torah, which brings to mind the original Latin meaning of *studere* – to dedicate oneself to something, direct one's efforts and attention to it.

The universal, cosmological ontology that determines the epistemo-political project of *yisrael*, that is the understanding of *yisrael's* collective torah project as the "living soul" of the world, is described by R. Chaim in very strong terms. He makes an analogy between the human soul that is connected to the human body through eating and drinking, "and without them [the soul] shall separate and leave the body," to the creator's connection to its created world through "the engagement in the torah and the deeds of *mitzvot* [commandments] and work of prayer by the special people [עם סגולה]." Without *yisrael's* torah activity, he writes, "He, blessed be He, would have removed himself, blessed be He, from [the worlds], and instantly they would all return to naught and nothing."⁵⁹ What makes the *yisrael* collective "special" or "holy people" [עם הקדוש],⁶⁰ is thus its cosmic role: "the world is impossible without *yisrael*" [א"א לעולם בלא ישראל] (53).

It is within this narrative, this history that R. Chaim positions his own moment, his "Now". Like all foundational moments, the Volozhiner's too is a one of crisis, of rupture, of break. This crisis he describes in epistemo-political terms, namely as referring to the situation of the collective knowledge project of *yisrael*. Similarly to Zunz, R. Chaim too frames his moment of crisis as the lowest point in a long history of decline: "it has been many days in *yisrael* that the engagement

⁵⁶ Ibid., 44.

⁵⁷ Ibid., 45.

⁵⁸ Ibid., 46.

⁵⁹ Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 53.

⁶⁰ Ibid., 56.

in the holy *torah* has been in decline from one generation to the other. And now in the present generations, in our many sins, it has declined considerably, and lies in the shadow of the lowest level.”⁶¹ It should be well noted, that the described epistemic crisis does not simply lie in the dwindling of *torah* study, in the disappearance or lack of knowledge. Rather, the gravity of the moment resides in the *substitution*, i.e. *perversion* of the *torah* knowledge project through a different project and concept of knowledge: “Now they are many days without a teacher [מורה], and the way of each person is as he sees fit to follow the inclination of his understanding [ללכת אחרי נטיית שכלו].”⁶² The *torah*, the collectively given knowledge, is substituted by individual reason. The latter is so far from being a simple absence of knowledge, that it even presents itself in its own specific givenness, in the literature of “fear/reverence and morality” [ספרי יראה ומוסר], which replaces the “written and oral holy *torah*”, i.e. the *talmud*, first and for most the three constituents of the Talmudic page: *gmara*, *rashi* and *tosfot* [גפ"ת].⁶³

The most obvious and immediate concrete historical figure, in which R. Chaim could have identified this epistemic crisis, is the rise of Hassidic movements.⁶⁴ However, it seems to me that the tension he describes, between *torah* and reason (שכל), is just as constitutive for the contemporary *Haskala*, the Jewish “enlightenment,” and the enlightenment movement *tout court*. Asserting reason against tradition is in many respects the epistemic essence of the emancipatory self-assertion of modernity itself, whose advent R. Chaim’s words reflect. Interestingly, the turn from *torah* to purity of thought may draw from the Volozhiner’s own historical narrative a messianic, redemptive character of *return*, that is to the pre-Mosaic times of the “the patriarchs and all of the first righteous.” As said above, R. Chaim recognizes the liminal, critical essence of this modern event, but he sees it as a moment not of redemption but of the greatest catastrophe. Without *torah* the world will “return to naught and nothing”. If there is any messianism in *Nefesh Ha-*

61 Ibid., 93.

62 Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 69.

63 Ibid., 93.

64 There seems to be no dispute in the research about localizing the *Nefesh Ha-Chaim* in the context of the Hassidut. Much disputed is, however, the precise nature of this relation. One opinion considers R. Chaim’s book as basically a polemic against Hassidut, e.g. Etkes, whose entire chapter on R. Chaim is called “The Reaction of R. Chaim of Volozhin to the Hassidut”, pp. 164–222. Lamm, on the other hand, understands the critique of Hassidut in the book as only “indirect,” the main purpose being the presentation of R. Chaim’s own vision, see Lamm p. 62. Interestingly, Lamm refers to – and dismisses as “unserious” – a third reading of *Nefesh Ha-Chaim* as actually pro-Hassidic or crypto-Hassidic, see p. 58–59. My own reading agrees with Lamm that the text is in no way an “attack”, much the less “slandorous writing” against the Hassidut. I do however recognize the critical element in the text as vital to its historic gesture.

Chaim, and this is not at all the character of the text, then it would designate rather the time of *Ikveta de-Meshicha*, the horrors before the coming.

It is against this threatening cosmic catastrophe that R. Chaim of Volozhin presents his conception of *torah* learning in Part IV of his *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, which reads as the constitutive epistemic-political tractate for the Lithuanian academic Jewish studies project. This chapter presents itself almost as an independent treatise on “the measure of the obligation to engage in the *torah*, on any man in *yisrael* day and night.”⁶⁵ R. Chaim focuses the entire discussion on the fundamental question of epistemology, namely the question about the essence of knowledge. He formulates this question as referring to the exact meaning of the rabbinic expression תורה לשמה, *torah li-shma*, literally *torah* ‘for her name’, meaning *torah* for ‘her’ or ‘its’ sake.⁶⁶ This expression is a basic concept of rabbinic epistemology, since it constitutes reflective knowledge defining the proper relation or approach to be taken towards knowledge itself. More precisely, it determines the *telos* or purpose of knowledge: one should engage in the *torah* “for its sake”. The question is for the sake of what exactly. R. Chaim points out that the current crisis resides in the prevailing understanding – “as most of the world now believes”⁶⁷ – that “*torah* for its sake” means engaging in the *torah* with a specific “intention” (כוונה) and “devotion” (דבקות).⁶⁸ He is not so much concerned with defining the exact object of this claimed devotion, which is something like “the attachment of your thought to your creator,”⁶⁹ i.e. devotion to God. The main point for R. Chaim is rather that the idea of “devotion” as condition for engagement in *torah* means that the engagement in *torah* becomes secondary and subordinate to one’s engagement in one’s own thought. Given, objective knowledge becomes the – ultimately redundant – means for subjective self-affirmation. *Torah* becomes *khokhmat yisrael*.

Against this understanding, R. Chaim (following R. Asher ben Jehiel, the *Rosh*) interprets *torah li-shma* as *torah* for the sake of *torah* itself: “for the sake of knowing and understanding and learning and thinking [לפילול] and not for scorning and boasting.”⁷⁰ In other words, the engagement in the *torah* is not just a means to an end, but is the *telos*. To explain this, R. Chaim offers a radical knowledge ontology, which is based on the given, corporeal nature of knowledge as *torah*. The *torah* is

⁶⁵ Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 93.

⁶⁶ See mAbot 6, 1.

⁶⁷ Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 94.

⁶⁸ Ibid., 87.

⁶⁹ Ibid.

⁷⁰ Ibid., 95. I am reminded of Paul’s words in the *Epistle to the Romans* against the Jew who “boasts in the law” (Rom. 2:23).

given as words. These words are God's words, "[a]nd He, blessed be He, and his word are one."⁷¹ This means that God and *torah* are one [קב"ה ואורייתא חד].⁷² *Torah* is not just a vehicle to get closer to God, it is God. The ultimate attachment to God therefore lies in no further transcending intention but in the most concrete engagement in the words of the *torah*: "any word that [the learner] lets out of his mouth is the very words that so to speak come out also from His mouth, blessed be He, at the very same time."⁷³ While learning *torah* the learner unites with the world creator and becomes the "living soul" of the world.⁷⁴ However, and this is decisive, the existence of the world does not, or does not only depend on *torah* learning in the sense that *torah* is cause, pre-condition or means for the existence of the world. The *torah* does not exist for the sake of the world. On the contrary, *torah* and *torah* learning is the purpose of the world: "it is through the engagement in the holy *torah* that his intention, blessed be He, in the creation is fulfilled, because it was only for the sake of the *torah*, that *yisrael* engage in it."⁷⁵ In the Lithuanian academy, Jewish studies are the purpose of creation.

To conclude my reading of the *Nefesh Ha-Chaim* I will point at the political implications of R. Chaim's epistemology, namely its understanding of the collective project "*yisrael*". As said above, *yisrael* is the agent of *torah*, the collective that engages in *torah*. The *torah* project of knowledge is thus ontologically constitutive for *yisrael*, which ontology is expressed by R. Chaim in the concise formulation: "the Holy, blessed be He, the *torah* and *yisrael* are all one" [קב"ה ואורייתא וישראל כולה חד].⁷⁶ This means that the very existence and "givenness" of the collective *yisrael* is immediately attached to the givenness of the *torah*. The historic event that tied the political constitution of *yisrael* and the *torah* giving is Mount Sinai. Based on a *midrash* from the Zohar (Khukat 178b), R. Chaim interprets Sinai not as a past event, but as the present epistemico-political paradigm of *torah* studies: "whoever engages in *torah* is like they stand every day on Mount Sinai to receive *torah*, as it was said 'this day you became a people'."⁷⁷ *Torah* study constitutes *yisrael*. This means that the collective project of *torah* studies, the *torah*

71 Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 97.

72 Ibid., 99

73 Ibid.

74 "[T]he entire life and existence of all of the worlds is only through the breath of our mouths and our study of [the *torah*]. And the truth is without any doubt that if the world, from one end to the other, had been, heaven forbid, even for one instant devoid of our engagement in and contemplation of the *torah*, instantly all of the upper and lower worlds would have been destroyed and become naught and *tohu*, heaven forbid" (Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 100).

75 Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 102.

76 Ibid.

77 Volozhin, *Nefesh Ha-Chaim*, 103.

academy, the Lithuanian *yeshiva*, does not, like the modern university, serve the state, but is itself the paradigm of the Jewish *polis*, the “state” of *yisrael*.

6 Conclusion

I sought to demonstrate the centrality of the interrelations – continuities and discontinuities – between the epistemic and the political in the modern project of academic Jewish studies. Especially important for me was to show the foundational rupture between the modern scientific and the Jewish episteme, a rupture generated by the act of knowing. In this sense, the central tension of my reflection is between the first three models, the university, and the fourth one, the *yeshiva*. Writing within a university context and discourse, the challenge is how to negotiate this tension, this gap between Jewish studies and torah studies. The stakes, both risks and chances, of this challenge, I think, are today just as much political as they are epistemological.

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Chapter 8

“Don’t Settle for the Visible”: The Hidden and Revealed in an Istanbul Cabaret

1 Introduction

The Turkish Netflix hit, *The Club* (2021–2023), opens with the sounds of pigeons cooing. The birds are housed on a rooftop coop overlooking a stunning minareted silhouette of Istanbul. A young woman stands on the roof, picks up a revolver and fires it, causing the frightened birds to take flight. She leaves after securing the cage door—an act that foreshadows her own eventual confinement for the murder she has just committed. The gunshot, as we later learn, was aimed at the man who had impregnated her. But the murder was not a “crime of passion” in the conventional sense. It rather had to do with the fact that he had betrayed her family which led to their downfall. Years later, inside a prison a group of women celebrate the radio announcement of an amnesty for prisoners convicted for non-political crimes. The young woman from the rooftop is one of the inmates. She stands apart, lights candles, covers her eyes and quietly recites the Hebrew benedictions welcoming Shabbat. The opening scene introduces the leitmotifs of the show – love, betrayal and reprisal woven together with Jewish ritual. All this makes for an unprecedentedly bold and perhaps better put provocative show on Turkish TV.

A period narrative set in mid 1950s Istanbul against a backdrop of Turkey’s ever-expanding statism, *The Club* revolves around relations romantic or otherwise between Jews and Muslims through the life journey of Matilda Asseo after her release from prison while she works in a center city nightclub. Another central character is her daughter Raşel, who had no knowledge of her mother’s existence until the day she was released from prison. Somewhat reluctantly Matilda builds her relationship with Raşel. She maintains a friendship with the provocative musical artist Selim, and tries to survive under a cruel supervisor, Çelebi. Raşel, meanwhile navigates a relationship with the suave yet distant taxi driver İsmet. The script of *The Club* is a fictionalized version of the lives of the parents and grandparents of Rana Denizler, a Turkish TV writer. It ran for two seasons. In the second season, Raşel’s daughter, the young Rana becomes a main character, and eventually the storyteller through whose eyes we see the story.

The Club offers some striking departures from mainstream Turkish TV. It is the first Turkish series to feature a sympathetic Jewish main character; to incor-

porate Ladino—particularly striking given the early republic’s insistence on the exclusivity of Turkish as a medium of public discourse; and to depict the devastating impact of the 1942 Wealth Tax and the violence of the 1955 anti-Greek pogrom. With its richly layered storytelling and evocative historical setting, *The Club* captivated audiences across the globe, both Jewish and not, ranking as one of Netflix’s most-watched non-English language series.¹ This resonance speaks to the show’s narrative power and to its exploration of themes that traverse cultural, religious and temporal boundaries.

2 Premise

Matilda is the daughter of a once well-to-do Jewish family impoverished through a harsh tax on non-Muslims issued in 1942. Those who didn’t disclose possessions and whose assets were discovered were punished by internment in labor camps. Matilda’s father had been hiding money to help Jewish refugees. These funds, kept in a wall safe in the family’s dining room, were revealed by Matilda to her lover, a non-Jewish employee of her father’s, who then disclosed it to a state assessor. Matilda’s father and brother were arrested and sent to a work camp where the father died. Matilda avenged her lover’s betrayal – hence the opening scene of the show. It’s a doubly complex act which will come back to haunt her later since he is also the man who had impregnated her. So, she doesn’t just murder a lover, but with equally severe consequences to her future well-being, he’s also the father of her daughter. Upon her release Matilda first meets with the community elder with whom she had entrusted her infant daughter, Raşel, at the beginning of her incarceration. He reveals that given Matilda’s background as an unwed mother and convicted murderer he could not arrange an adoption for the girl and so he had no choice other than to place her in an orphanage. Now a teenager, the daughter rejects her mother’s overtures to build a relationship. Prone to trouble, Raşel is attracted to İsmet, a suave taxi driver and a bit of a bad boy. Herself a bad girl she needs help to counter the charges she faces for breaking into an Istanbul cabaret. She had done so on behalf of a friend whose I.D. was locked away by the nightclub’s manager. The man catches Raşel in the act and Matilda applies for a job at the cabaret hoping to bail Raşel out. There she befriends Selim, a so far unsuccessful singer. Matilda watches his audition and is

¹ Aytac Kara, 16.11.2021. “*Kulüp* ilk haftasında Netflix’in en çok izlenen dizilerinin arasına girdi.” (*Kulüp* is among the most watched series on Netflix on its first week) *Ranini tv*, ranini.tv <http://www.ranini.tv/haber/46090/1/kulup-ilk-haftasinda-netflixin-en-cok-izlenen-dizilerinin-arasina-gi>.

mesmerized. Matilda befriends some of the other employees and shields the vulnerable young women from the abuse of the Club’s manager, Çelebi. The man appears at this point in the story as a villain. Later, we learn that his apparent evil side stems from thwarted passion. He had long been in love with Matilda and years earlier he tried and failed to protect her from her duplicitous lover.

The plot’s antagonism—Us vs Them—hinges on Jews and Muslims inhabiting discrete universes. They may work together, even sleep together as lovers, but for the most part the line separating them remains intact and at least in the early episodes, they do not intermarry. As one female character warns Raşel concerning her Muslim love interest, Muslim men will date non-Muslim women, but they only marry Muslim women. Yet, the love affairs in the series prove otherwise. Raşel’s Jewish husband is simply too tame to hold much appeal for her. Both mother and daughter end up not just with non-Jewish men as partners but with aggressive and tormented men. However, by the end of the series they are quite domesticated. They are also heroized, helping save the Club and its members, including their families.

3 Setting

The story of *The Club* replicates the birth of modern Turkey as a post Ottoman state. The series also shows the demise of a cosmopolitan metropolis which, traditionally, did not require its myriad ethnic groups to forgo links to each of their communities.² Jews have been a part of the city’s fabric ever since its inception as a Byzantine and then Ottoman metropolis. Following the Jewish expulsion from Spain in the late 15th century, the city served as a place of refuge for Iberian Jews and witnessed the encounters and ultimate blending of Romaniot, Sephardim, Karaites from the east and then Ashkenazim from Central and Eastern Europe. Some of their traces are still evident in the names of synagogues and sometimes in the names of the city’s districts and monuments.

One illustration of Istanbul’s waning cultural and social complexity in the post-Ottoman state is the decline of the once largely Jewish area in which the series takes place, Galata. Traditionally a Levantine quarter, architecturally dominated by a tower built by the Genoese during the Byzantine Empire, Galata sits at the crossroads between the port and foreign embassies. A commercial and residential neighborhood, the area largely served the non-Muslim segments of the

2 Zeynep Çelik, *The Remaking of Istanbul: Portrait of an Ottoman City in the Nineteenth Century* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1986).

city. From the mid nineteenth century onwards, as the Jewish impact on the city became more pronounced, upwardly mobile Jewish families abandoned the older Jewish quarters of Hasköy and Eminönü in favor of the more modern and affluent neighborhoods of Pera and Galata. An example of the increasing impact of Jews on the city is the Camondo family. Becoming extraordinarily wealthy as bankers, the family rose to prominence as financiers to the sultan. They were also agents and patrons of change in Istanbul, and protectors of Near Eastern Jews alongside the Montefiores and Rothschilds.³ The buildings sponsored by the family or that housed its members are among the most spectacular in the old commercial districts of the city. Besides the grand buildings, one of their lasting achievements is the Beaux Arts Camondo Stairs, still one of the most impressive monuments in Istanbul. Although today very few Jews live in Galata, the aura of its Jewish past lingers. There are many former synagogues in the area, and some are still in use. The largest houses the museum of the Jews of Turkey. Heading south and close to the Galata Tower is the imposing Ashkenazi Synagogue commissioned by Austrian Jews in 1900. Though with greatly diminished numbers in terms of worshippers, the synagogue is still in use and is featured in the show.

4 Difficult History

The demise of the empire presented a new political situation with relations between Muslims, Jews and other minorities in Turkey – in a sense the backstory of the show. As narrative *The Club* is unprecedented in its focus on this “difficult history” of the Republic. It is the first TV series to feature use, and in parts extensive use, of Ladino – an important consideration given the new state’s insistence on the exclusivity of Turkish as a public language; it was one of the first to show the devastating impact of the Wealth Tax; and one of the first to show the horrors of the 1955 pogrom against Greeks. At the expense of temporal accuracy, the show includes these two events in its storyline, punctuating the beginning and the climax of the first season, and we can assume reflecting the liberal politics of the show’s creators.

Turkey’s parliament unanimously passed the Wealth Tax Law on November 11, 1942. The stated aim of the levy was to raise money for armaments should Turkey become embroiled in war, but it was also intended to level the economic disparities

³ Nora Şeni, “The Camondos and their Imprint on the 19th-Century Istanbul,” *International Journal of Middle Eastern Studies* 26 (1994): 663–675; Aron Rodrigue, ed., *Ottoman and Turkish Jewry: Community and Leadership* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1992).

between Muslim and other citizens of the state. After January 1943, anyone who failed to pay the levy would be sent to a labor camp in the eastern provinces. The tariff had repercussions beyond the unfair monetary imposition. It became an underlying cause of Jewish unease within the republic and the impetus to emigrate despite the absence of the kind of public antisemitism that manifested itself elsewhere in the Islamic world during this period. At the same time, it is important to note that Turkey remained neutral during World War II and hosted a number of Jews fleeing Nazi occupied Europe.⁴ Despite some public recognition of the ills of the levy, its damage has never been fully acknowledged.⁵

The first season of *The Club* ends with the 1955 pogrom against Istanbul’s once prominent Greek community. It was prompted by false rumors of an attack on Atatürk’s home in Thessaloniki which incited a mob to take revenge by attacking mixed ethnic neighborhoods of Istanbul. Many lives were lost, and a good deal of property destroyed. The show suggests that the event was not a popular or spontaneous outbreak but was orchestrated by state provocateurs who preached the need to protect the Turkish nation from non-Muslims whose wealth is like “a poke in the eye” to ‘real’ that is, Muslim Turks. The great tragedy of the pogrom is that it delivered a *coup de grace* to an important dimension of Istanbul’s Euro-cosmopolitanism, forcing many non-Muslims, especially Armenians and Greeks to leave. Though not directed at them, Jews suffered collateral damage to property. Uncertain of their future many chose to emigrate. Those who stayed tried to make themselves less visible. The show’s political critique is sharpest in its depiction of the 6–7 September pogrom, presented as state-enabled plunder. The state assessor, who justifies his extortion of Matilda’s father by invoking memories of the Allied occupation and minority collaboration, is revealed to be one of the instigators of the pogrom. Similarly, İsmet’s (Raşel’s love interest) father stokes the flames of ethnic violence and participates in the looting, even

4 Scholarship on the Wealth Tax and its aftermath has steadily grown, alongside increasing public acknowledgment of its injustices. The damage of the tax has increasingly been voiced in public media, too. *Salkım Hanım’ın Taneleri* (*Mrs Salkım’s Diamonds*) a 1990 novel by Yılmaz Karakoyunlu, depicts the tax’s impact through Jewish characters. When it was adapted into a film in 1999 under the same title, the characters were changed to Armenians, as the Jewish community declined to cooperate with the production or grant access to communal spaces. See Rifat N. Bali, “Geniş Toplum Bizleri Yeterince Tanımıyor”: Türk Yahudi Toplumu ve “Türkiye Sahnesi”nde Temsil Edilme Halleri (*The Public Does Not Know Us Sufficiently”: Turkish Jews and the State of Representation in Turkey*). (Istanbul: Libra, 2022).

5 A motion was offered by Garo Paylan, MP, for parliamentary inquiry in November 2021. It was not passed.

turning on his own son when the son tries to protect a victim of the mob. These moments suggest correctly that the ethnic hostility in the early Republic was not toward religion, but toward minority wealth and visibility.

5 Love

At its core, *The Club* explores identities in motion: names, selves, and pasts withheld and then unexpectedly disclosed. Love, in this context, is not redemptive or a means of escape but a crucible through which the characters undergo trial and transformation, offering the possibility of transcendence. Perhaps nowhere is this transcendence more apparent and surprising than in the gravitas of the relationships that eventually develop between Raşel and Matilda, between İsmet and Raşel, between Rana (Raşel's daughter) and her initially absent father İsmet and between Matilda and Çelebi. These relationships carry the emotional weight of the show, transforming it from entertainment to deeply moving drama. Interestingly, probably because of a national culture of secularism the interethnic, inter-religious dimension of those relationships is never explored, leading us to ask whether it is a lost opportunity or just a safe way to skirt around a subject.

The main interethnic love affair is between Matilda and Çelebi, another truly enigmatic character in the story. We see him at first as a corrupt and even villainous manager with a side hustle in women, liquor trafficking and skimming off the top of employees' salaries. Matilda protects others from the abuse of the club's manager. When Matilda tries to observe Shabbat while working in the Club and asks to leave before evening on Friday, Çelebi refuses. Apparently, it's not because of ignorance or antisemitism—he knows what Shabbat is and even uses the word. It's just his apathy. He is equally dismissive of Hacı's request to observe Friday prayers at the mosque. Later, however, Çelebi is revealed to have been a secret admirer of Matilda. He even tried to save her from the treachery of her lover. His efforts were thwarted when the man discovered a letter Çelebi had written to Matilda. At the end of the first season Çelebi acts as Matilda and Raşel's savior when the two were trapped outside the Club's bolted doors during the anti-Greek pogrom. The rest of the staff were immobilized through fear and unwilling to unbolt the door. Only Çelebi was able to act. The transition from abuser to rescuer and would-be lover happens unexpectedly. This abrupt transformation seems improbable except within the series' Jewish symbolic economy of Purim. Behind the mask hides a true self. As we learn by the end of the first Season, Çelebi's cruelty masks his thwarted passion for Matilda, revealing the transformative power of deep love – something we believe to be a Sufi overlay in what is ostensi-

bly a Jewish story. Here what tips us off perhaps is the meaning of Çelebi’s name. In Sufi usage it designates a descendant of Rumi.⁶ An unusual name for a man in twentieth century Istanbul, Çelebi has also been used as an adjective that denotes refinement and good manners—at best an oxymoron for the character in the first season. In the second season he becomes true to the name.

The second interethnic love affair is between Raşel, Matilda’s daughter, and İsmet, a heart throb whose one true love seems to be the taxi he drives. An ambiguous character and a ladies’ man with surprising talents (he speaks English well and is even courted by a beautiful staff member from the US embassy). Although he despises his truly despicable father, who is a bad husband and father, İsmet, too, is an absent husband adrift in his taxi rather than present for the birth of his child with Raşel. İsmet’s relationship with Raşel never bridges a cultural divide. When they were first courting, Raşel introduces herself as Aysel, Islamicizing her name. Later in the episode she reveals her identity to İsmet, and he inexplicably slaps her, throws her out of the taxi and leaves her on the outskirts of the city. They eventually reconcile, yet İsmet insists on calling her by her Islamic name Aysel. Despite this name, she doesn’t become Muslim in a cultural sense and certainly not in a religious sense. Indeed, their relationship seems to be in tandem with the secular values of the Republic. This is one element that is in keeping with the story of Denizer’s parents. Interestingly, her father, contrary to his portrayal in the early part of the series was a much more involved parent, open to the world and even well read.

Regarding the depiction of interethnicity, Orhan, the elegant, enigmatic and aristocratic owner of the Club merits a note. Orhan shows good business acumen and even daring in booking an innovative and transgressive male frontman for his nightclub. Aside from Salim, Orhan is the least macho of the show’s men, and the only main character who is not in a relationship. He is dominated by his mother, who maintains a secret shrine to the Virgin Mary in their home, revealing a secret Greek background. As the narrative progresses Orhan’s identity, including his Greek name, Niko, becomes clear and is an object of manipulation by the state assessor who exerts pressure on him to Turkify the club by releasing all non-Muslim employees. Orhan does so without protest. Interestingly, the dismissal does not include Matilda. Indeed, no mention is made of her in the discussion of who will be let go. It’s not that Orhan believes in Turkification but he’s too weak and wracked by fear not to: he needs to maintain his cover and now lives in fear of being outed as Greek. In a secular state religion is a private matter. In

⁶ Mehmet İpşirli, “Çelebi”, TDV İslâm Ansiklopedisi, 11.06.2025 <https://islamansiklopedisi.org.tr/celebi>.

the context of Turkish and Greek antagonisms following the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire, however, ethnic background takes on a different significance.

6 Music

Music is not just the show's background; it informs its shape and content, speaking to its emotional and intellectual depth. After all, the series is called *The Club*. As noted earlier, love, both thwarted and transformative, is the leitmotif of the show. In understanding both music is fundamental. Music points to a mode of cognition directly connected to affect and, we believe relates especially to Sufi sensibilities. The musical choices in the series, featuring an array of songs, from Harry Belafonte's "Matilda" to recent compositions by the acclaimed pianist and composer Fazıl Say, to Sephardi *romansas* performed by Turkish Israeli singer Yasmin Levy, and the focus on Selim's performances, highlight the cultural complexity of the period. Ladino songs introduce a polyphonic world, revealing Turkish inflections and multiple traditions across the Mediterranean. For the uninitiated Turkish listener, Ladino songs create ambivalence: the melody is familiar, but the language is not. The songs present another instance where Ladino seeps through the narrative and provides a means of entry albeit subliminally into the Jewish world. Matilda, returning home from the Club, hears a beloved Sephardi ballad, "Yo era Ninya" played in a courtyard in Galata. The lyrics translate as "I was once a rich girl," reflecting Matilda's own plight. In this scene she has a conversation with Hacı, a young, sweet, fellow worker, who recently arrived from Anatolia to look for work. Hacı is also captivated by the music and tells Matilda that it is reminiscent of the lullabies his grandmother sang to him – a comment about commonality. Or perhaps it's a hint about a link that was more substantial hundreds of years ago and since forgotten. Matilda reveals that the song belongs to a people who came to Turkey 400 years ago from Spain and that she is one of them. "Like me, too," Hacı adds, emphasizing the shared experience of migration and homesickness that music both heals and exacerbates.

Selim's performances make the show as much musical entertainment as drama. We first see Selim as an unsuccessful singer, too transgressive as a male lead with his Euro-American song repertoire and a performance style that feels like a jazz era diva, and we see him literally kicked out of one club which we assume is just one of many. The Club becomes his breakout opportunity. To convince Niko / Orhan to employ him as a musical frontman, Selim refers to the show he puts on as a bridge between East and West, the old and the new. He bonds with Matilda when he auditions in *the Club* as a frontman. Selim and Mat-

ilda’s family-like bonding speaks to the transgressive nature of both. Selim’s homosexuality is never mentioned despite the inferences in his mannerisms and especially in the provocative lyrics of his songs, overshadowed by the performance, especially its choreography. Selim’s songs have been composed by renowned Turkish musicians; The title song “Yıldızlara” (to the stars) is composed by singer and songwriter Kenan Doğulu. “Masal” (Wonder Tale) is composed by the Turkish pop diva and lyricist Sezen Aksu. All songs speak about defiance, daring/courage, self-fashioning, forgiveness, new beginnings, through celestial imagery that ranges from flying to rainbows, stars, angels, butterflies – the ultimate image of metamorphosis. Lyrics connote Sufi ideas on the transformative power of intense love. Given Rumi’s background and transgressive friendship with Shems, the overlap may not be accidental. Sufism is somewhat unique in Islam because it prioritizes music; Rumi’s *Masnavi* starts by asking the reader to listen to the sound of the reed flute, complaining about the pain of separation from the beloved.⁷ *Masnavi* makes melody part of cognition and love the crux of being. These themes will resurface as we conclude our analysis of the series.

7 Jewish Presence

Promenading through her neighborhood, Matilda is immersed in various languages including Turkish, Greek and surprisingly Ladino. The use of the latter and the effort expended in language training for the non-Jewish cast add considerably to the show’s feel of authenticity. The use of Ladino also evokes what has disappeared from the soundscape of the city. Republican Turkey encouraged its citizens to become fully Turkish by secularizing and forgoing their other codes of communication, especially the use of minority languages. These policies, accompanied by a new historical thesis that bypassed the Ottoman past, aimed to sever the remaining ties with an Islamic heritage to facilitate Westernization. Jews abided by this transformation.⁸ With the language policies of the Republic, Turkish increasingly replaced Ladino as the Jews’ mother tongue. Yet, adherence to Ladino, albeit in a highly attenuated form, preserved a unique speech community within what had once been a multilingual archipelago.

7 Jalal al-din Rumi, *The Masnavi* (Oxford University Press, 2008).

8 Jewish fervor for Turkification went far. The advocate of language reform, Moise Kohen Tekinalp, encouraged the Jews to Turkify their names and prayers, through what he called the Ten Commandments for Turkish Jewry in his work on state building, *Türkleştirme* (Turkification, 1928). See Bali, *Bir Türkleştirme Serüveni 1923–1945* (A Journey of Turkification 1923–1945).

The series might in part be understood in dialogue with the recent cultural trend that offers Jewish legacy as part of the cultural capital of the city. In contrast to a history of a desire for invisibility, Turkey's contemporary Jewish community now opts for the opposite. The community's positive reception of *The Club* speaks to that.⁹ The show promotes Turkey's official discourse that associates the Jewish presence in Turkey with the migration of Jews following their expulsion from the Iberian Peninsula. From the Turkish perspective, the uninterrupted presence of a Jewish community is testimony to Turkish tolerance and stands in contrast to the history of Jews in Christian Europe. Nor should there be anything surprising about this. Unlike Greeks and Armenians, Jews posed no threat to the Turkish Republic. Jews never had a desire to join their settlement to an area where they might be a majority even when in recent times there arose a powerful Jewish state nearby. The idea of tolerance was not just a Turkish narrative but a Jewish one as well. Ottoman Jews suffered from Christian, not Muslim persecution. And the periodic blood libels they experienced in the region were leveled against them not by Muslims but by Christian Greeks. The conclusion of the show, and the protagonist's decision to stay in Turkey despite witnessing mass violence, albeit not against Jews, is further testimony to the same allegiance.¹⁰

A somehow ambiguous Jewish figure in the series is the Jewish elder. We see an older Jewish man at the beginning—whom Matilda goes to ask for the necessary papers so she can make move to Israel. He raises the issue of her daughter whom she has not yet seen and insists that she must do so. Their conversations have an affectionate parent/child quality to them. We are given no direct evidence of his status. He does not have a beard, he does not wear clerical attire, nor even a kippah. His office—lined with books—indicates that he is learned. His name is David.

We see the same man at the Purim celebration, greeting Matilda in the synagogue's courtyard. His role is probably best understood as that of a community elder rather than a religious authority. When Matilda wants to emigrate to Israel

9 Rıfat N. Bali, "Geniş Toplum Bizleri Yeterince Tanımıyor": *Türk Yahudi Toplumu ve "Türkiye Sahnesi"nde Temsil Edilme Halleri* ("The Public Does Not Know Us Sufficiently": *Turkish Jews and the State of Representation in Turkey*). (İstanbul: Libra, 2022).

10 The bond between the Ottoman and later Republican Turkey and their Jewish citizens has been challenged by many. See, in particular: Rıfat N. Bali, *Bir Türkleştirme Serüveni 1923–145* [*A Journey of Turkification 1923–1945*], (İstanbul: İletişim, 2000), *Les Relations entre Turcs et Juifs Dans La Turquie Moderne* [*The relations between Jews and Muslims in Modern Turkey*] (İstanbul: Isis Press, 2005); *The Varlık Vergisi Affair: A Study on its Legacy* (İstanbul: Isis Press, 2001). Julia Philips Cohen *Becoming Ottomans: Sephardi Jews and Imperial Citizenship in Modern Era* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014). Marcy Brink-Danan, *Jewish Life in Twenty-First Century Turkey: the Other Side of Tolerance* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2013).

in the beginning of the series, he insists that the journey across the Mediterranean has ended. It is true that the Jewish women in the series consider moving to Israel, and Raşel does so, but the move proves only temporary, and she soon enough returns to Turkey. Strangely, the show offers no explanation for the return; instead, it reinforces the idea of Turkey as home and refuge. He also voices the idea of Turkey as Jewish home.

8 Jewish Rituals

The Club privileges secularity and does not go against Turkish sensibility about religion especially in this earlier period of the republic. That said, Jewish ritual frames the narrative particularly of the first season. Jews in this series are not portrayed as deracinated or as distant from their religious traditions. Matilda’s religious observance is one of many elements in the story that estranges in a quasi-Brechtian way our understanding of modern Turkey and its citizenry. As noted, Matilda observes Shabbat in prison, albeit through reciting blessings and lighting candles – ostensibly nothing more. A full day of rest would probably not have been possible even if that were how she had customarily observed shabbat. Here, she does so alone without any of her fellow inmates joining in or even expressing curiosity. She is alone but she does not look forlorn. This scene sets up the series as a Jewish story and as we will indicate later, not exclusively so. It also presents an image that will be invoked in the first season’s powerful finale.

In the series Islam is almost absent—no mosques, no imams, no calls to prayer nor even prophylactic phrases in everyday speech; statism seems to have replaced religion. Despite the prominence of Jewish rituals, it is not until the end of the second season, at Matilda’s funeral, that we see any clergy explicitly presented. Until then, religious authority remains largely symbolic and understated. Similarly, there is no representation of the rituals connected to the more austere holy days, like the new year’s days of worship nor is there even a family Passover seder. Indeed, Shabbat is portrayed simply by Friday night candle lighting and sometimes a family meal. We do see Matilda in synagogue from time to time but not worshipping. Nor are Jewish commensural rules and traditions referred to and contrasted with those of non-Jews. Matilda attends a Purim celebration, but we learn nothing about the holiday, the series features Purim with some creative liberties. Matilda attends celebrations where children parade with lanterns – a colorful but religiously inaccurate depiction of Purim (the lanterns are used on Simhat Torah not Purim). While the festivities include communal dining in the synagogue courtyard, they notably omit the ritual reading of the Megillah (the

Scroll of Esther) – a central religious component of the holiday alongside the customary feasting and revelry. Yet, it's a holy day which we believe is a key symbol of the series; it has the leitmotif of the hidden self and of female agency: Hadas/ Esther is the archetype for Matilda. It is Esther who tips off the Persian king of Haman's evil intent and makes possible the rescue of Jews and the wreaking of vengeance on their oppressors. In *The Club*, Matilda inflicts vengeance by killing her family's betrayer. The story of Purim highlights female agency. Purim is about inversions, up and down, inside and outside and as noted, the hidden self—unknown motives and unlikely transformations. Purim helps explain some of the show's inconsistencies regarding characters and why villains so inexplicably transform into helpers. Rana Denizer, the scriptwriter whose family history provides the basis of the show, mentions Purim as the holiday that encapsulates the life philosophy of her father İsmet, who approached all people without prejudice. Apparently, this is why the holiday is foregrounded in the story.¹¹

Beyond retribution, Purim embodies carnivalesque reversals of fortune that permeate the series. Matilda begins the series as a privileged daughter from a wealthy family, is then incarcerated, and eventually released to become a basement laundress, and ultimately the backstage manager of a nightclub; Selim's transformation is from a rejected performer deemed too transgressive to a national radio celebrity; and Çelebi's concealed desire for Matilda, revealed late in the series when he is a heroic rather than a villainous character and achieves his ambition to bond with Matilda. These transformations reflect Purim's essence of hidden identities and unexpected revelations. Indeed, Matilda becomes determined to uncover Çelebi's true nature. She seeks out Haymi, her father's former business manager, who now resides opposite the synagogue on the island of Büyükkada – a place for retreat for wealthier members of Istanbul's Jewish community. Their conversation unfolds during the Purim festivities, creating a symbolic backdrop for revelations. Haymi imparts the holiday's deeper significance: "You must know what Purim is, Matilda. It is the holiday of contradictions. The revealing of that which has been hidden. On this night we drink until we are no longer able to separate good from evil so that we aren't prejudiced against anyone." He concludes by bridging Jewish tradition with Sufi philosophy: "Just like Rumi said, do not settle for the visible. This is the same." This powerful synthesis of Jewish observance and Islamic mysticism encapsulates the series' exploration of Turkey's cultural syncretism – where seemingly disparate traditions may

11 Selin Kandioti, February 2, 2022. "Ailemin hikâyesini anneannemin Şabat 'Sofra'larında öğrendim" (I found out about my family history on Shabbat tables). *Şalom*. [salom.com.tr https://www.salom.com.tr/haber/121164/ailemin-hikayesini-anneannemin-sabat-sofralarinda-ogrendim](https://www.salom.com.tr/haber/121164/ailemin-hikayesini-anneannemin-sabat-sofralarinda-ogrendim).

sometimes reveal profound parallels and points of connection beneath apparent differences. Interestingly, these arcs of change invite a reading not just through Jewish but also Sufi poetics. Both traditions employ the idea of the hidden and revealed, but Sufism carries a Jewish story of Purim’s masquerade to another level by offering the possibility of transcendence through intense love. Haymi’s revelation occurs while the community is engaging in a feast complete with alcohol—the latter a violation of Islamic rules of commensalism.

9 The Ark

The focal point of the show, *the Club*, is what we now refer to, following Mary Louise Pratt, as a contact zone. It is a place in which people of different backgrounds come together and interact even if only temporarily.¹² Indeed, Selim makes the argument to Niko the Club’s owner and his employer that other cabarets cater either to Muslims or to Europeans and through his repertoire they could appeal to both. That coming together takes on a particularly dramatic, almost biblical dimension in the final scene of the first season when the night club acts as a sanctuary from the primordial-like storm raging outside, while a frenzied mob attacks anyone whom they think might be Greek. Symbolically the Club became like a biblical ark responsible for the preservation and renewal of all life (Matilda’s daughter Raşel even gives birth inside it). Raşel’s baby represents a mediation of two presumed antinomies – Jew and Muslim. The final scene shows many of those who work in The Club sheltering behind bolted doors while the storm rages outside. They share a communal meal, the table lit by candles – a beautiful replication of the opening scene of the series when Matilda, also incarcerated, celebrates Shabbat by lighting candles. In that scene she did so alone. In this she is joined by her fellow workers, a panoply of the city’s population. So, what begins as an ethnic story about singularity ends as a national allegory of coming together and ecumenism. Interestingly, its key symbols are Jewish – the Ark, the lighting of candles, the tranquility and well-being that Shabbat signifies. The Club has become an ark, preserving humankind in the face of a deluge of racial, ethnic and gender hatred that left unchecked threatens to destroy us all.

The story of the Deluge is shared by all the Abrahamic religions, yet it harks back to previous traditions as well. The story exists in *the Epic of Gilgamesh* through the story of Utnapishtim, as the man given immortality after having sur-

12 Mary L. Pratt, *Imperial Eyes: Travel Writing and Transculturation* (London: Routledge, 2008), 9.

vived the Deluge in an ark.¹³ *The Epic of Gilgamesh* was composed well before the emergence of Judaism. In the Hebrew Bible, Noah precedes Abraham and his descendants whom Jews consider tribal progenitors. In rabbinic reckoning Noah was not a Jew. But he is considered to have been someone who uniquely walked with God and was a righteous man: he was not an idolator, did not engage in immoral acts, respected life and did not kill or steal. In Islam, Noah is one of the five prophets of strong will, alongside Abraham, Moses, Jesus, and Mohammad. Noah preached to a group of unbelievers for years, and when they did not respond, the deluge came forth. In *the Quran* Noah's wife and one of his sons were not among the believers and washed away in the flood.¹⁴ The trials and tribulations of Noah vary in Judaic and Islamic traditions, yet they point to a similar experience of surviving catastrophe, to rupture, and the belief in human continuity. It's within this framework that the writers of this series can conceive of a Turkey in which the divide that separates Muslim, Christian and Jew are nothing more than different ways to express the same basic belief in a divine presence and the life affirming value of righteousness and hospitality. It should also be noted that the Ark has a special significance for Turkish Jews. Sephardic ancestors fled the Iberian Peninsula, according to legend, on boats that were sent to fetch them by the Ottoman Sultan. The legend underlines the basis of Jewish loyalty to the Ottoman rulers and to their successor the Turkish state as well. Indeed, more than a few local synagogues celebrate this in their interior design, most notably the very striking ark, or Teva of the Ahrida Synagogue in Balat, one of the older Jewish neighborhoods of Istanbul.

10 Conclusions

The Club's great significance is the courage to critique state policies in as public a medium as international television and acknowledge the mistreatment of others—ethnic, religious, women and even obliquely represented gender minorities. A show about one family and the end of one aspect of Istanbul's cosmopolitanism works as an allegory for the nation's future. *The Club* is not a show about two religions in conflict; despite some ethnic tensions there is no obvious antagonism between Judaism and Islam.

¹³ Andrew George *The Babylonian Gilgamesh Epic, Volume 1*. (Oxford University Press, 2003). pp. 70, 152–155.

¹⁴ Ömer Faruk Harman, "Nûh", TDV İslâm Ansiklopedisi, 19.06.2025, <https://islamansiklopedisi.org.tr/nuh>.

At the beginning of the essay, we mentioned the caged pigeons on the rooftop where Matilda shoots and kills her lover. The leitmotif here is passion, misdirected or inverted through betrayal. Pigeons – as doves – also evoke the story of Noah. In Turkish and in Hebrew there is only one word, *güvercin* in Turkish, and *yonah* in Hebrew, to denote both pigeon and dove. Moreover, birds also have strong symbolic resonance in Sufi poetry, particularly in Farid ud-Din Attar’s the 12th century Iranian mystical epic *The Conference of the Birds*, in which a flock of birds sets out seeking truth and determined to find a leader, the legendary Simurgh.¹⁵ The thirty birds that complete the journey to Simurgh’s abode find out that they themselves are Simurgh. There seems to be some of this in the story of *The Club* and certainly in Matilda’s trajectory, thereby suggesting a Sufi text hidden and intermingled within a Jewish story. Like in Sufi thinking, intense love and journey have transformative power. Hence many of the characters in the series break through their previous inability to connect and fundamentally alter their selves. Imagine that, rather than at war with each other, Islam and Judaism are bound to one another through transformative love.

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III Dialogical Theology and the “Co-production” of Thought

Ephraim Meir

Chapter 9

Dialogical Theology and its Relevance for Jewish-Muslim Relations

Asher Biemann and Ufuk Topkara's Forum for Jewish-Muslim Theology and Thought advances an innovative approach to the Muslim and Jewish traditions and promotes the interaction between Muslims and Jews. With this article and playing on the private names of the instigators of the new Forum, I would like to express my wish that the new horizon, *ufuk*, may give all of us joy and happiness, *osher*.

1 Identity and Belonging

We are all embedded in concrete situations; we act and think out of specific traditions. Yet, the word 'identity' has become problematic. Identities quickly become fixed and rigid. They are frequently formed on the negative background of others. A parochial, narrow, and constrictive 'we' is contrasted with the outgroup, 'they.' The word 'identity' must be problematized.

In addition, and parallel to the word identity, the word 'belonging' easily becomes problematic. In our more and more culturally diverse societies, there are multiple forms of belonging. We belong to our own group to one degree or another and we also belong to the world, in which different groups exist. Belonging always denotes belonging to a particular group, but also to the world as such. Too much emphasis on particularity leads to parochialism. Too much accent on a cosmopolitical belonging to all neglects one's always concrete embedment in specific cultures and groups. The word 'identity' and the word 'belonging' seem to be ambiguous.

In our times, we witness the ascendance of political leaders who promise to take care of the interests of the own group at the expense of other groups. They lead a troublesome identity politics that promote the own by excluding the other. Discrimination, humiliation, non-recognition, indifference and even hatred are the result of such a disastrous politics. This dreadful situation is well known in many regions in the world.

Identity politics is gaining field all over the globe. Happily, we witness countercultures that swim against the tide by advancing a dialogical identity. A few

examples will suffice. The Kenyan philosopher John Mbiti pointedly formulated his view on the relational I with the sentence “I am because we are.” This is part of the African Ubuntu culture. Buddhist culture hails the interconnectedness by deconstructing identity through *an-atma*, the non-self. The Vietnamese monk Thich Nhat Hanh conceived ‘being’ as “inter-being.”¹ For the Jewish dialogical philosopher Martin Buber “I require a You to become.”² Playing upon the initial phrase of the Hebrew Bible he writes: “In the beginning is relation.”³ For the French-Jewish philosopher Emmanuel Levinas the I is summoned by the other: “The word *I* means *here I am*, answering for everything and for everyone.”⁴ The list of dialogical thinkers in various cultures could be easily expanded.

If we listen carefully to the narrative of the other in agenda-less presence, we could learn how she lives and thinks. We could celebrate the plurality of world-views and contribute to the shaping of dialogical persons and societies. Casting aside suspicion and prejudices, we open ourselves to the interconnectedness of all. This opens the horizon, *ufuk*, of a “new we.”

Dialogue creates a shared and common world, a world of the ‘and.’ It is more about attitudes than about contents, more about deeds than about words, more focused on the doable than upon the knowable. In dialogue as in-betweenness, one transcends one’s own self in orientation to the other, and this in turn allows us to discover the alterity in ourselves. We do not live in parallel worlds, one alongside the other, neither are we merely a part of a whole. Dialogue strives to create unity without dissolving singularity.

The creation of a relational I and, more broadly, of a dialogical society contests a static identity and surprises a closed identity with alterity. The lofty reality of dialogue creates an ‘in-between’ space with interaction between people and concrete involvement with others. In dialogue, one makes the other present. It is not only about allowing others to be different, but to recognize them in their otherness that cannot be absorbed in sameness. At the same time, one does not leave the other in his or her otherness; one engages in communicating and shaping a common world. In dialogue, one celebrates plurality and promotes the other, who becomes visible. Looking positively at religious others and at their specific contri-

1 Thich Nhat Hanh, *Interbeing. Fourteen Guidelines for Engaged Buddhism* (Berkeley, CA: Parallax, 1998).

2 Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, translated by Walter Kaufmann, (New York: Charles Scribner’s Sons, 1970): 62.

3 Buber, *I and Thou*, 69.

4 Emmanuel Levinas, *Otherwise than Being or Beyond Essence*, translated by Alphonso Lingis, (Boston, Dordrecht, London: Kluwer, 1991): 114.

bution to human culture influences their reality and future. In what is known as the Pygmalion effect, expectations affect the behaviour of others.

2 Interreligious Dialogue

In this perspective, interreligious dialogue receives its relevance and vitality. To my mind, interreligious dialogue has foremost an eminent ethical dimension. The religious other asks to be respected and listened to: she demands that one approaches her story in a non-judgmental way and without preconceived ideas.

Interreligious dialogue is not easy. Religious exclusivists are more concerned with the survival, corroboration, and expansion of their own group than with communicating with religious others. In their radical dissimulation, they feel superior, belittle or blatantly discriminate others. In their splendid isolation, exclusivists forget alterity. On the other edge of the spectrum, cosmopolitical people may forget specificities. In radical assimilation, their particularity and that of others get lost in an all-absorbing unity.

The task is, therefore, to go beyond radical dissimulation and radical assimilation in what I call ‘trans-difference,’ in which one respects differences and shares a common world. In ‘trans-difference,’ one communicates not despite differences, but thanks to them. People belong to different worlds, but they also belong to the larger world. Since we live in *one* world, communication is a lofty human possibility. Shaping one’s identity takes place in the own group as well as in relation with other groups. Interrelatedness goes against identity politics and works with mutual acceptance and promotion. In this perspective, interreligious dialogue has the potential of healing religious rivalry and clashing cultures. In interreligious dialogue, one receives the gift of the other’s otherness and becomes different to oneself. The aim of interreligious dialogue is to create bonds with religious others. One does not have to be an academic specialist of religions or a formal representative of an institutionalized religion to engage in interreligious dialogue. Each of us is a unique human being, who belongs to a particular religious narrative, with her own life experience and position. However, we are also in contact with religious and non-religious others. John Donne’s utterance “No man is an island” was made concrete by Abraham Joshua Heschel who claimed that: “No religion is an island.”⁵

5 Abraham Joshua Heschel, “No Religion Is an Island,” *Union Seminary Quarterly Review* 21/2 (1966): 117–134; reprinted in Harold Kasimow and Byron L. Scherwin (eds.), *No Religion Is an Island: Abraham Joshua Heschel and Interreligious Dialogue*, (New York: Orbis Books 1991), 3–22

3 Human Rights

The quality of our God-talk depends on the way it contributes to respect for human rights and for the dignity of every human being. Beyond an academic elitist theology, ordinary people have their God-talk. In this way, theology is democratized, brought out of the academic ivory tower and linked to the concrete problems of the world. In a theology that has human rights at its center, the Transcendent is approachable in the realization of justice and equality and in loving relationships. People belonging to different religions may become engaged in the implementation of cross-bordering human values.

A few years ago, I described Judaism in my book “Old-New Jewish Humanism” as a specific kind of humanism.⁶ Can we come to an ethical interpretation of Judaism and Islam, of *halakha* and *sharia*? The medieval scholar Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya writes the following beautiful sentences: “Sharia is all about wisdom and achieving people’s welfare in this life and the afterlife. It is all about justice, mercy, wisdom and good. Thus, any ruling that replaces justice with injustice, mercy with its opposite, common good with mischief, or wisdom with nonsense, is a ruling that does not belong to the Sharia, even if it is claimed to be so according to some interpretation.”⁷ *Taqwa*, traditionally conceived as Muslim ‘piety,’ manifested in food restrictions, prayer or alms giving, may be reimagined as God-awareness, potentially present in all human beings. Such a God-awareness is immediately linked to the cultivation of attention to and compassion for other human beings. For Mouhanad Khorchide, not rituals, but rather the ability to participate in the other’s joy and suffering, to care and to forgive, constitute service of God.⁸ Rituals with their spiritual and ethical dimension are a means to become more loving and merciful: they are important in as far as they stimulate a human being to accomplish her *fitra*, her ontological condition or orientation to a loving and merciful God and her participation in God’s life.⁹ The peaceful development of the human being and her loving relationship to others should be at the heart of every religion. Rediscovering the humanistic core in Judaism and Islam allows

and in Susannah Heschel (ed.), *Moral Grandeur and Spiritual Audacity: Essays by Abraham Joshua Heschel*, (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1996), 235–250.

6 Ephraim Meir, *Old-New Jewish Humanism* (Interfaith Dialogues for Love and Peace), (Tel-Aviv: Idra, 2018).

7 Mustafa Akyol, *Reopening Muslim Minds. A Return to Reason, Freedom and Tolerance*, (New York: St. Martin’s Essentials, 2021), 85.

8 Mouhanad Korchide, *Islam ist Barmherzigkeit. Grundzüge einer modernen Religion*, (Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 2016), 102–103, 114–115.

9 Korchide, *Islam ist Barmherzigkeit*, 97, 103–108, 198.

for criticism on the way our religions function in society and shows us the relevance of our religions in the contemporary world. Religious inwardness should be expressed in reverence of the human being, in the continuous battle against human suffering and humiliation, in marching together for the cause of the disadvantaged and in support of civil rights.

An innovative approach to our religions could, of course, focus on classical foundational texts and look for positive utterances about the religious other in a humanistic, dialogical hermeneutics.¹⁰ Yet, just as in the case of the words identity and belonging, religious texts are frequently ambiguous. They function in specific historical and geographical contexts which have radically changed in the course of time. What is decisive is not the number of positive utterances in biblical verses or in *suras* of the Qur'an. Decisive is how past religious utterances function in present-day cultural, economic, social, and political contexts. Texts are important; the relationship to texts in *midrashim*, *drashot* and *tafsir* are even more important.

Holy Scriptures are for the development of human beings. Khorchide has contributed to spelling out a humanistic Qur'an hermeneutics.¹¹ The underlying image of God is not the furious, punishing God, who commands humans, but a God who loves and is merciful as a mother for her child and who wants the development and liberation of the human being. The Qur'an is not about master/slave but about a loving relationship between the human being and God. Poetically, he writes: The Qur'an is a "letter of love" (*Liebesbrief*).¹² Similar to Khorchide, I see Torah as the letter of love which the beloved reads again and again to become worthy of the love of her lover. The more she reads this letter as an expression of love, the more she wants to love and become worthy of his love. Torah, as the Qur'an, is there for us, human beings. This implies a dialogical hermeneutics, in which responsibility and human dignity are central.

A theology of human rights should not merely focus upon texts; it should discuss lived religiosity in its relevance for society.¹³ Othering of the others has led to estrangement; deep listening to their narrative leads to diminishing hatred and

¹⁰ Micha Brumlik deems that the interreligious dialogue between Muslims and Jews could start by focusing on the theological attitudes in the foundational texts. He also refers to Al Andalus that showed the possibility of a Jewish-Muslim coexistence. Elisa Klapheck, Micha Brumlik and Susannah Heschel, *Judentum. Islam. Ein neues Dialogszenario* (Machloket Streitschriften 6), (Berlin and Leipzig: Hentrich & Hentrich, 2022), 48.

¹¹ Korchide, *Islam ist Barmherzigkeit*, 159–196.

¹² *Ibid.*, 168.

¹³ Susannah Heschel starts the interreligious dialogue between Muslims and Jews from the lived religion and points to the common ground between the parties. *Ibid.*, 51–69.

conflict and preparing the way for a more peaceful coexistence. What is at stake is shaping a dialogical identity that cannot be conceived without the relation to others and without common concern for the future or the creation of a 'new we.' Can we become partners, who care for democracy, freedom, equality, and other human rights, with and beyond our religious affiliations?

In interreligious dialogue one trusts the religious other in order to develop a new consciousness of the interdependence of all religions, in view of a more peaceful society. The underlying idea is that if religions are not for the world, they remain perhaps high and magnificent trees, but without bearing fruit. Religions are not there to serve themselves. They are for the human beings, not vice versa. They have a soteriological function. In a genuine, transformational, and trustful dialogue, emphasis is upon the moral quality present in the various responses to the inconceivable Reality.

I argue that interreligious dialogue is an eminent ethical reality. In interreligious dialogue as in any dialogue, the primordial aim is not to 'know' the other. Situating the other, understanding her in her historical, social, economic, and cultural context, does not come first. Meeting the other requires foremost an ethical mindset. Knowing, comparing, experiencing, and situating are secondary. Moreover, ethical orthopraxis is more important than correct orthodox thoughts: to be righteous is more important than having the right faith. In acknowledging the religious other, one testifies to the Divine. With all our specificities and differences, we are not condemned to live in separated and unconnected worlds and to see others negatively. A real interreligious dialogue offers alternatives.

4 Dialogical Theology

Dialogical theology is a theology that has dialogue as its goal and method. It also conducts a dialogue with the secular world and its values. It is based upon dialogue and reflects on it.¹⁴ Dialogue implies respect for differences and going beyond this in communication. It maintains separateness and develops one's relational capacities. The ethical call of the other implies an ethical or dialogical hermeneutics of the religious sources.

¹⁴ Ephraim Meir, *Dialogical Thought and Identity. Trans-Different Religiosity in Present Day Societies*, (Berlin and Jerusalem: De Gruyter and Mages, 2013); Ephraim Meir, *Interreligious Theology. Its Value and Mooring in Modern Jewish Philosophy*, (Berlin and Jerusalem: De Gruyter and Mages, 2015).

In dialogical theology as in religious and non-religious dialogues, “trans-difference” is crucial. “Trans-difference” avoids the absolutization of differences as in post-modernity as well as the absolutization of sameness as in modernity. It avoids the pitfall of an otherness that is not approachable and of a sameness that annexes and functionalizes the other, reducing her to the same. Interreligious theology is about the self and the other, about boundaries and crossing boundaries, about celebrating one’s specificity and becoming inspired by others. Boundaries mark different spiritual homes. At the same time, these boundaries are relative: loving one’s home does not exclude involvement with others in the broader world. Jews may invite Muslims in their home, Muslims may visit the homes of Jews. Jews and Muslims may live together in one country, in one town, in one street and in one home. Exchange and cooperation replace isolated entities and create coexistence in a pluralist society. Most importantly, in a trans-different religious dialogue, one’s uniqueness lies in the ethical link to the other.

As John Dunne has pointedly described, one may pass over to another way of life, to another religion and come back with new insights to one’s own religion.¹⁵ Interreligious encounters require imagining. They presuppose a religious conviviality that challenges the usual rift between religious groups. In an interreligious theology, based upon interreligious meetings and dialogues, one’s own religion is only one collective experience in the mosaic of religious experiences that all testify to the Transcendent. Interreligious theology as the theology of dialogue with dialogical means contains a sustained reflection on a multiplicity of approaches to the Transcendent. In such a theology, one learns from religious others. One is also critical of others, but most of all of oneself in a healthy self-criticism.

5 Revisiting and Reimagining Traditions

The inaugural conference of the Forum for Jewish-Muslim Theology and Thought has been on continuity, discontinuity and re-continuity, on connection, disconnection and reconnection. I deem that the success of interreligious dialogue depends upon the preservation of traditions as well of their renovation and transformation. Traditions are different reactions to the Divine, and as such, they are a mixture of human and divine elements. One tends to think that traditions are a fixed, archaic body of behaviors and opinions. The truth is that they are constantly evolving; they are not a mere repetition of the past, but a challenge for the present and the future. Traditions may become violent and oppressive power-

15 John S. Dunne, *The Way of All the Earth*, (New York: Macmillan, 1972), ix.

structures. In an innovative approach to traditions, proposed by the Forum, one becomes conscious of problematic passages in religious sources and develops positive attitudes towards religious others. An interreligious theology reflects on interreligious dialogue as a meeting place and offers a critical reflection on religious traditions. It works with concepts from different traditions to reimagine them in a post-traditional epoch. Not a re-traditionalization, but a reinvention of tradition will make religions relevant again for today's society.

The Forum actively seeks to engage in creating new narratives and discourses, emphasizing simultaneously a continuation of the religious intellectual heritage. More particularly it seeks to develop contemporary Islamic theology and thought as an important emerging field of research. The Forum focuses upon the question how Islamic theology and thought could be brought into systematic engagement with modern discourses. It is believed that Jewish thought offers possibilities to advance Islamic thought. To my view, both Jewish and Islamic thought flourish and blossom in discussion with modern and contemporary discourses. Both are challenged to rediscover uniting and humanizing forces. The Jewish-Muslim dialogue could sharpen self-criticism and lead to reviewing and reshaping identities. Interaction with each other leads to the discovery of alterity in ourselves. In the interreligious meeting, differences are appreciated, but we are also called to be interconnected. No religion is autarkic; all religions are part of the greater human community. Dialogical or pluralized theology leaves polemics behind and turns to the religious other. The dialogical turn in theology, which we witness today, brings about a new kind of religiosity, in which openness to the other and interrelatedness are central.

Seven years ago, I met in Princeton Martin Nguyen, the son of Vietnamese refugees and a professor of religious studies at Fairfield University, Connecticut. Nguyen just published his book *Modern Muslim Theology*, in which he develops a narrative theology of the Muslim tradition. He creatively shows how tradition is continually developing. He brings a parallel between *al-ka'ba* and tradition. *Al ka'ba* functions as an allegory for tradition. Just as *al ka'ba* is a sacred source and reflects at the same time a human history, tradition is both of God and humanity. *Al ka'ba* is *axis mundi* and orients towards God. Yet, *al ka'ba* can be made into its opposite, set on fire and witness bloodshed. Nguyen deems that just as *al ka'ba* changes, tradition depends upon all the generations. The Black Stone can be taken away and be returned. God's house must be made whole again.¹⁶

¹⁶ Martin Nguyen, *Modern Muslim Theology: Engaging God and the World with Faith and Imagination*, (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield, 2018), 49, 57–58.

I deem that Nguyen's thoughts on the Muslim tradition can be applied to other religious traditions, which are all a mixture of divine and human elements. As expressions of human culture, traditions have a Janus-face: they may contribute to dialogue and interconnectedness, they also may be exclusivist, inhuman and violent. They may lead away from God in violent negation of others. They also may be near to God in nearness to others. The restoration of the sacred space between human beings, their interdependence and positive interaction, testify to the divine presence. To bring this about, one must admit that traditions are not an aim in themselves. They are necessary but cannot be absolutized. They are the way of human beings to connect with the Transcendent. Various traditions connect with the Divine, but they are not the divine source itself; they are only a response to it.

The goal of traditions is, therefore, to bring about a dialogue between the Divine and the human, which is realized in interhuman connectivity. Traditions should respect the divine space that is the place where people interact in a dialogical way. The ethical quality of religions depends upon their contribution to the world which is characterized by plurality. Each specific tradition is a possible enrichment for religious others. Instead of excessive sympathy for the own people and antipathy towards other religious groups, we will have to preserve, restructure, reinvent and reimagine our traditions to make them relevant in the world of today.

6 Fanaticism

The famous sociologist of religion, Peter Berger, was acutely aware of fanatic elements within the religions. In a review of my book *Interreligious Theology*, Peter Berger mildly and humorously criticizes my work in pointing to the duty to say "no" to certain religious manifestations: "I don't think I would want to enter into dialogue with whatever degenerate imams legitimate the hell on earth being instituted by ISIS in the areas it controls in Iraq and Syria. Or suppose there still survived the cult of human sacrifice which existed in Mesoamerica in pre-Colombian times. Imagine, say, that a delegation of Aztec theologians were welcomed on an interreligious conference at the World Council of Churches in Geneva: 'Thank you very much for coming to this conference. We are greatly looking forward to hear-

ing your paper explaining why the gods have to be fed by the blood of sacrificial victims (. . .).”¹⁷

I agree with Berger that there are limits to the interreligious dialogue. Several attitudes may make dialogue impossible. One of them is a violent reading of sacred Scriptures and the lack of their contextualization. Another impediment lies in exclusivist absolute truth claims in the approach to religious others.

In 2002, the famous Israeli writer Amos Oz talked in Germany about fanaticism that “lies in uncompromising righteousness.”¹⁸ For him, “conformity and uniformity, the urge to belong and the desire to make everyone else belong” is the most widely spread form of fanaticism.¹⁹ It is worth to quote a somewhat longer passage of his speech, entitled “How to Cure a Fanatic”:

“No man is an island, said John Donne, but I humbly dare to add to this: no man and no woman is an island, but every one of us is a peninsula, half attached to the mainland, half facing the ocean; half connected to family and friends and culture and tradition and country and nation and sex and language and many other ties. And the other half wants to be left alone to face the ocean. I think we ought to be allowed to remain peninsulas. Every social and political system which turns each of us into a Darwinian island and the rest of humankind into an enemy or a rival is a monster. But at the same time every social and political and ideological system which wants to turn each of us into no more than a molecule of the mainland is also a monstrosity. The condition of peninsula is the proper human condition. That’s what we are and that’s what we deserve to remain. So, in a sense, in every house, in every family, in every human connection, in every human connection we actually have a relationship between a number of peninsulas and we better remember this before we try to shape each other and turn each other around and make the next person turn our way while he or she actually needs to face the ocean for a while. And this is true of social groups and of cultures and of civilizations and of nations and, yes, of Israelis and Palestinians. Not one of them is an island and not one of them can completely mingle with the other. Those two peninsulas should be related and at the same time left on their own. I know it is an unusual message in these days of violence and anger and revenge and fundamentalism and fanaticism and racism, all of which are loose in the Middle East and elsewhere. A sense of humor, the ability to image the other, the capacity to recognize the peninsular quality of every one of us may be at least a partial defense against the fanatic gene which we all contain.”²⁰

17 Peter Berger, “Interreligious Theology. Its Value and Mooring in Modern Jewish Philosophy,” *The American Interest*, 6.9.2025 <https://www.the-american-interest.com/2017/01/11/a-jewish-take-on-pluralism/>

18 Amos Oz, *How to Cure a Fanatic. Israel and Palestine: Between Right and Right*, (London: Vintage Books, 2012), 57.

19 Ibid., 61.

20 Ibid., 79–81.

The words of Amos Oz on peninsulas, attached to the mainland and facing the ocean as well as his attention to the unabsorbable particular and the universal echo with my notion of “trans-difference”.

7 Competencies to Develop

Finally, I would like to point to the importance of the development of a few competencies that we could acquire to engage in successful interreligious dialogues.

A first competency to practice is *to be present* to the religious other, without preconceived ideas. Pure presence diminishes one’s bias towards the other and invites her to be fully present and ready to communicate. It comes before any knowledge and experience. Presence comes before content. The context of intersubjective meeting and not the objective content of the partners in dialogue is primordial. Recognition precedes cognition. To be present before others may result in extending hospitality to others or becoming a guest in the other’s home. In hospitality, the fear for the other is replaced by welcoming her in her concrete, embodied existence. A second competency to acquire is the *readiness to learn*. Being in contact with religious others could enrich us and open up unexpected horizons.

Humility is a third component in a successful interreligious encounter. Confronted with religious others, one may become conscious that one’s own viewpoint is only one viewpoint in the colorful mosaic of approaches to the Ultimate Reality. To think that one has the best religion or to shape one’s own religious identity on the negative background of other religions in a kind of “religiodicee” must be unlearned. The Divine is approached from different viewpoints which have all their own legitimacy. This necessarily entails the adoption of a multiperspectivism: one’s own religion is only one way in the mosaic of ways to transcend reality. Religions have different ways in approaching the unobtainable and indescribable Transcendence. Humility in religious matters implies that we recognize and value religious others. Religions are, in Zen Buddhist parlance, only the “fingers” that point to the moon, or in Muslim parlance, God is “greater” (*akbar*).

A fourth characteristic of a fruitful interreligious dialogue, closely related to the preceding one, lies in the *abandonment of absolute truth claims*. In dialogue, one recognizes and appreciates that religious others have their own way to the Ultimate Reality. This implies that one gives up superiority claims. In a positive approach to religious others, one values their specific religious worldview along with their peculiar representations and images of the Divine. The dialogical turn

in religious study and practice is incompatible with absolute truth claims. Respecting the religious other is not enough. What is needed is a positive evaluation of religious plurality. Nobody has a monopoly on holiness or salvation. Is election reserved for Jews or are all elected? Are only Muslims enjoying heavenly paradise? Is the sense of wonder not present in different religious traditions? In light of a qualitative interreligious dialogue, there is no superior or only true path to salvation. Many distinctive ways lead to salvation. All are asked to develop compassion and love and to promote life in all its forms.

Religions participate in the divine Truth, which they cannot ultimately reach. In what is called a negative theology, it is denied that one can possess knowledge about God's essence. Such a theology is to be found, for example, in Maimonides's *Guide of the Perplexed*. People who pretend to completely 'know' God are fanatics. The apophatic tradition avoids any identity between human knowledge and divine truth. The infinite is not reducible to the finite; the ultimate is unconceivable, beyond our perceptions of it. In this sense, idolatry can be redefined as the confusion between religion and God. God is the Truth, we participate in it through our relative truths. Significantly, Psalm 85:12a reads: "Truth will sprout from the earth" (*'emet mi-'erets titsmah*). Truth does not come from heaven; it sprouts from the earth. The *midrash* Bereshit Rabba 8:1 tells us that when God decided to create the human, there was a dispute among the angels in heaven: The angel of loving-kindness was in favor; the human was charitable. The angel of truth was against; the human was full of falsehood. The angel of righteousness agreed that the human would be created, but the angel of peace objected. God took truth and threw it to the earth, as is said: "Truth will sprout from the earth." I infer from this *midrash* that human beings seek truth, which will "sprout from the earth," in ongoing dialogue with others. This makes our own truth relative; it is not heavenly Truth. Truth grows between people in interconnection that brings peace. Absolute truth claims hurt a peaceful relation to other religions. Truth is born in dialogue: not just in tolerating others, but in entering into dialogue with them. One realizes the truth when searching for a meaningful life and for cross-bordering values.

A widespread opinion maintains that truth is more elevated than peace; one is ready to give up peace for the sake of truth. Many think that truth comes first, and that peace must retreat. However, the Jewish tradition supports a different opinion. In Zecharya's prophetic vision (Zach. 8:16.19), truth and peace belong together and in Ps. 85:11 lovingkindness and truth meet (*hesed ve-'emet nifgashu*). The aim of truth is to bring peace, and peace conditions the search for truth. Interreligious dialogue presupposes that one is not in the sole possession of truth and that one's own religion is not superior to another.

Finally, *translating* is characteristic for a good interreligious dialogue. When we meet the religious other, we necessarily translate. In dialogue, we listen to the other's narrative and allow her words to penetrate our world. In dialogue, we translate our own world in terms of the other and the other's world in our own words. This eminently dialogic act is possible since we live in *one* world.

Engaging in interreligious encounters is a difficult task. The pitfalls are many. Jews and Muslims will have to respectfully listen to each other's narrative. This may be sometimes strange and surprising. Yet, we do not have to leave each other alone. The religious other should not remain totally other. Meeting her always opens new horizons. Our religious others call upon us to be included in a shared, common world. I hope that, also after the inaugural conference of the Forum for Jewish and Muslim Theology and Thought, the Forum will continue to open for us new horizons that lead to interrelatedness, cooperation, and coexistence.

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Tuğrul Kurt

Chapter 10

The Interdependency of Jews and Muslims in Medieval Intellectual History: Muslim Impact on Saadia Gaon (d. 942) and his Reception

1 Introduction

Saadia Gaon, or Sa'īd b. Yūsuf al-Fayyūmī as known in Islamic sources, stands as a pivotal figure in Jewish Philosophy. He is highly regarded for his significant historical contributions, particularly his advocacy for a unique understanding, his opposition to criticisms, and his distinctive perspective on the interplay between reason and revelation. His life and extensive works have been thoroughly examined to ascertain his profound influence on the trajectory of Jewish faith.¹ Saadia Gaon's extensive writings span various fields. While some of his works have been preserved in their entirety, others exist only in fragments or are known through references by his contemporaries and later scholars.² Saadia Gaon's philosophical contributions include his understanding of knowledge, which he believed progresses from the concrete to the abstract. He posited that knowledge begins with a concrete characteristic and gradually acquires an abstract quality through scientific pursuits. The ultimate abstract form of knowledge, achieved through various stages of activity, represents the highest level of human understanding. Furthermore, Saadia Gaon refuted the idea of the physical universe being created from an eternal spiritual entity. He presented logical arguments to defend the concept of creation from nothing, significantly contributing to his philosophical stance against creation from a non-physical entity.³

Saadia Gaon was born and raised in a region where Islam was dominant. He was fluent in both Arabic and Hebrew, using them effectively in his daily life and academic pursuits. Recognized as an authority in religious and literary studies, his extensive works covered diverse fields. He served as a juridical source for

1 Ömer Faruk Harman, "Feyyūmī, Sa'īd b. Yūsuf," in Türkiye Diyanet Vakfı İslâm Ansiklopedisi, vol. 12 (İstanbul: TDV Yayınları, 1995), 517–519.

2 Ibid., 518.

3 Ali Satılmış, "Temel Eserleri Özelinde Saadya Gaon ile Kadi Abdulcebbar'ın 'Adalet Prensipli' Bağlamında Bir Mukayesesi," Kocaali İlahiyat Dergisi (2020): 113–114.

Jewish jurisprudence and established foundational paths for future scholars.⁴ The most significant period of Judeo-Arabic scholarship in medieval intellectual history is marked by two leading figures whose intellectual pursuits profoundly impacted their contemporaries and later generations. Among many scholarly figures, Saadia Gaon stands out as a pivotal individual who not only initiated the classical Judeo-Arabic tradition but also significantly shaped its development across various Jewish and general academic fields.⁵ Moses Maimonides (1138-1204) built upon the foundational work of Saadia Gaon, elevating Judeo-Arabic thought to new heights. Maimonides, particularly through his meticulously crafted Hebrew Law Codex, stands as a prime example of classical Judeo-Arabic culture's pinnacle. This enduring text remains vital for Jewish scholarship, demonstrating the lasting impact and importance of both scholars in intellectual history.⁶

Saadia Gaon stands as a powerful symbol of the rich interplay between Judeo-Arabic traditions in the medieval period. While Maimonides is often seen as the pinnacle of Judeo-Arabic cultural fusion, it was Saadia Gaon who paved the way. He was the first Jewish scholar to profoundly engage with Arabic intellectual customs. Among his many significant contributions, his meticulous translation of the Pentateuch into Arabic was particularly noteworthy, even drawing comments from scholars like Abraham Ibn Ezra.⁷ In his exegesis on Genesis 2:11, Ibn Ezra delves into Saadia Gaon's seemingly unconventional choice to translate even geographical and specific names. He surmises that Saadia Gaon's intent might have been to craft his translation in the vernacular and script of the Ishmaelites – indicating a potential audience that extended beyond the Jewish community to include Muslims.⁸ This interpretation is further emphasized by Ibn Ezra's poignant reference to the Arabic script as opposed to Hebrew.

Saadia meticulously explores various philosophical perspectives, often without explicitly naming their originators. His critiques reveal a profound understanding of classical Greek philosophy, including the Sophists and Skeptics, as well as the dualistic tenets of Manichaeism and Zoroastrianism, and certain aspects of Indian philosophy. Saadia aims to refute these ideas primarily through rational arguments, supplemented by scriptural evidence. A notable example is

⁴ Muhammed Ali Bağır, *Dinler Tarihi Açısından Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı, Eserleri ve Yahudi İnanç Tarihiine Etkisi*, (PhD diss., Erciyes Üniversitesi, Kayseri, 2014): V.

⁵ Joshua L. Blau, "The Linguistic Character of Saadia Gaon's Translation of the Pentateuch," *Oriens* 36 (2001): 1.

⁶ *Ibid.*

⁷ *Ibid.*, 70.

⁸ *Ibid.*

his forceful rejection of the dualistic claim that two separate creators eternally and infinitely brought all entities into being.⁹ He refutes this idea using several counterarguments, employing logical reasoning and rational arguments. Saadia's deep grasp of specific theories is clear from his examples. He specifically challenges Aristotle's assertion of an infinite celestial realm, offering four logical explanations to demonstrate its shortcomings.¹⁰ Saadia's extensive understanding of the topic, coupled with his apparent grasp of fields like astronomy and mathematics, is evident in these explanations. Following his analysis, he asserts that *creatio ex nihilo* (creation out of nothing) is the only acceptable theory of creation. This conclusion stems from his rational assessment of prevailing creation theories, where he finds all others, except for *creatio ex nihilo*, to be irrational and unsustainable.¹¹

In 931 CE, Saadia Gaon undertook a literal Arabic translation of the *Sefer Yetzirah*¹² and provided an extensive commentary.¹³ To prevent further misinterpretations and alterations, Saadia included the Hebrew text he possessed. He structured *Sefer Yetzirah* into eight sections, with the first four reclassified into seven paragraphs each. The subsequent four sections were viewed as expansions and repetitions of the initial four, leading him to summarize them. Saadia's work also featured an Arabic introduction, similar to those of Muslim scholars of his era, which began with praises and acknowledged the traditional attribution of *Sefer Yetzirah* to Abraham. He additionally emphasized that philosophers globally had sought to unravel the mysteries of the universe's creation.¹⁴ He assessed and rejected the cosmological theories presented by the Dahriyya,¹⁵ without naming them, and subsequently evaluated the creation theory proposed by the author of

9 Bağır, *Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı*, 150.

10 For the theological and philosophical arguments of Saadia Gaon, see Bağır, *Ibid.*, 118–260.

11 Bağır, *Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı*, 166.

12 *Sefer Yetzirah*, with Saadia Gaon's commentary, Sefaria, https://www.sefaria.org/Sefer_Yetzirah.1.1?lang=bi&with=Saadia%20Gaon&lang2=bi (last accessed August 26, 2025).

13 Alfred P. Hayman, *Sefer Yesira: The Book of Creation: History and Tradition, Translation, and Commentary*, (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2004), 22.

14 Bağır, *Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı*, 95.

15 In the context of the term “dahr”, which is associated with the concept of “absolute time”, Dahriyya is a materialist perspective that asserts the absence of a creator for the universe and all existence, advocating that everything is eternal (Hinrich Biesterfeldt, “Reflection: ‘Eternalists’ and ‘Materialists’ in Islam: A Note on the “Dahriyya,” in *Eternity: A History*, Oxford Philosophical Concepts, ed. Yitzhak Y. Melamed (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016)). It denies the existence of a governing and all-powerful creator. According to this view, the universe has always existed without a beginning. It postulates that all existence is subject to continuous motion and development by absolute time. Saadia primarily emphasizes the “Dahriyya” view that “we only accept the truth of knowledge obtained through our senses.” (Bağır, *Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı*, 95).

Sefer Yetzirah, emphasizing the significance of letters and numbers in the process of creation.¹⁶ Saadia's main goal, according to various scholars, was to refute existing mythical and mystical interpretations of the text. He emphasized its philosophical significance within Rabbinic Judaism, also exploring God's ten sacred names and the Ten Commandments.¹⁷ Conversely, other experts hypothesize that the text's enduring relevance and its profound insights into cosmogony and the nature of creation were compelling reasons for Saadia to offer his commentary.¹⁸

Miriam Goldstein's research sheds light on the challenges faced by early Arabic translations of Jewish and Christian scriptures.¹⁹ She notes that while fragments of Christian Arabic Bible translations from the ninth century exist, the translations were likely completed by the late eighth century.²⁰ Multiple Judeo-Arabic Bible translations from the early ninth century have been discovered, indicating a flourishing tradition. Although the specific intellectual environment surrounding their creation by Jewish scholars is not fully understood, these translations were part of a larger literary output. This included complementary works such as glossaries, Bible commentaries, texts on Jewish commandments, and grammars of Biblical Hebrew. However, the limited preservation of ninth-century compositions makes it difficult to ascertain the precise connections between these various works. Miriam Goldstein emphasizes Saadia Gaon's crucial contribution to establishing Arabic as a legitimate language for religious scholarship and Bible translation.²¹ Saadia's translation, initially celebrated as groundbreaking, was later found to build upon earlier ninth-century translations, while also introducing innovative methods. His work is best understood as a reformative response to both external and internal pressures, rather than merely an attempt to fill a void in translation efforts.

The case of Saadia Gaon illustrates that the relationship between Jewish and Islamic intellectual traditions is far from a simple narrative of one-sided influence. Saadia Gaon meticulously integrated Muslim concepts, particularly Qur'ānic terminologies, but not through mere imitation. Instead, he infused these terms with fresh dimensions, grounding them in his unique Jewish intellectual and

16 Bağır, *Saadia Gaon'un Hayatı*, 95.

17 Haggai Ben-Shammai, "Saadya's Goal in His Commentary on *Sefer Yezira*," in *A Straight Path: Studies in Medieval Philosophy and Culture: Essays in Honor of Arthur Hyman*, ed. Shlomo Pines and Yirmiyahu Yovel (Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 1988), 9.

18 Raphael Jospe, "Early Philosophical Commentaries on the *Sefer Yetzirah*: Some Comments," *Revue des Études Juives* 149/ 3–4 (1990): 375.

19 Miriam Goldstein, "Saadya's Tafsīr in Light of Muslim Polemic Against Ninth-Century Arabic Bible Translation," *Jerusalem Studies in Arabic and Islam* 36 (2009): 173–199.

20 Ibid. 173.

21 Ibid.

theological framework. His assimilation of Qur'ānic terminologies was a process of reinterpretation, re-contextualization, and often rejuvenation, offering both Jewish and Muslim audiences' new perspectives on shared religious concepts.

Consequently, intellectual influence flowed in both directions. Several Muslim scholars subsequently incorporated conceptual frameworks introduced by Saadia Gaon. This reflects a genuine intellectual exchange, where ideas were not merely borrowed, but enriched, expanded upon, and then re-integrated into their originating traditions. This continuous loop of intellectual exchange highlights a deeper narrative of mutual respect, shared learning, and collaborative knowledge production. It stands as a testament to the dynamic interplay between two major religious traditions, characterized not only by coexistence but by co-evolution and symbiosis. As evidenced by Saadia Gaon's contributions, this complex relationship defies any oversimplified portrayal of mere influence, inviting us instead to recognize and appreciate the nuanced encounters that have shaped both traditions.

Religious texts and their interpretations reveal a rich tapestry of diverse cultural and religious currents. Over centuries, these currents have intertwined, demonstrating their profound interconnections and confluences.²² At the core of these intricate relationships lies the principle of interdependency, which goes beyond a simple transfer or assimilation of individual cultural or religious elements. It signifies a deep, mutual reliance and influence.

In this context, the distinction between “influence” and “encounter” is crucial. “Influence” often implies a one-sided interaction where one culture or religion significantly shapes another. In these dynamic, specific elements, practices, or ideas might be adopted from the dominant culture, with the subordinate culture or religion having little to no reciprocal impact. This indicates a hierarchical relationship, characterized by a giver-receiver dynamic.

Conversely, an “encounter” denotes a mutual and often symmetrical coming together of cultures or religions. In such encounters, both parties can exert equitable influence on each other. These interactions foster the emergence of new forms and practices that embody the distinct characteristics of both involved parties, suggesting a relationship founded on equality, mutual respect, and shared enrichment.

In the intricate tapestry of Jewish intellectual and cultural heritage during the medieval epoch, Saadia Gaon's translation of the Torah occupies a position of paramount significance. This translation, far from being a mere scholarly en-

²² Douglas Pratt, “Christian Encounters with Islam: An Historical Precursor,” in *Christian Engagement with Islam*, ed. David Thomas and Douglas Pratt (Leiden: Brill, 2017), 3–23.

deavor, encapsulates the nuanced interplay of Jewish and Muslim societies, reflecting an era of interaction that wasn't solely defined by its polemics or geopolitical skirmishes. Contextualized within this broader historical framework, Saadia Gaon's *Tafsir* stands out not merely as a religious document, but as an embodiment of the multifaceted Jewish-Muslim relational dynamics of the time. Examining Saadia Gaon's work, one cannot confine its relevance to its linguistic attributes alone, albeit their importance is undeniable. The translation, in its profundity and depth, secures a salient position in the annals of Jewish intellectual thought, shedding light on broader socio-religious paradigms and the synthesis of varied cultural influences:

Saadia's Arabic translation of the Bible is of importance for the history of civilization; itself a product of the Arabization of a large portion of Judaism, it served for centuries as a potent factor in the impregnation of the Jewish spirit with Arabic culture (. . .).²³

The commendation of Saadia Gaon by Maimonides, as cited by Henry Malter (1921) in his seminal work, "Saadia Gaon: His Life and Works," is both revealing and profound.²⁴ Although Maimonides and Saadia Gaon held divergent views on various theological and philosophical matters, Maimonides' acknowledgment of Saadia's pivotal role is a testament to the latter's undeniable influence and impact on Jewish scholarship. Maimonides' statement underscores the importance of Saadia's work in preserving and elucidating the Torah for the Jewish community. To say that "were it not for Saadia, the Torah would almost have disappeared from the midst of Israel"²⁵ is a reverberating endorsement. It recognizes Saadia's efforts in clarifying ambiguous portions of the Torah, fortifying its weakened segments, and disseminating its teachings both orally and in writing.

Maimonides, a towering figure in Jewish philosophy and Torah scholarship, lauded Saadia, underscoring the vital role of scholarly collaboration and mutual respect despite disagreements. Malter's inclusion of this quote highlights the interconnected legacies of these two scholars. It serves as a reminder of the dynamic nature of religious scholarship, where vibrant debate, disagreement, and profound mutual respect collectively foster a deeper, more nuanced comprehension of sacred texts and traditions.

David M. Freidenreich in his insightful analysis, offers a pertinent comparison which underscores the stature of Saadia Gaon's *tafsir* in the Jewish scholarly tradition. He elucidates: "Saadia's *Tafsir* plays a role analogous to Onkelos' more

²³ Henry Malter, *Saadia Gaon – His Life and Works* (Philadelphia: The Jewish Publication Society of America, 1921), 279.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 279.

²⁵ Robert Gordis, "Rabbi Saadia Gaon," *The American Jewish Year Book* 44 (1942): 72.

renowned Aramaic Targum of the Torah, standing as an authoritative translation that garners widespread study in religious circles, often juxtaposed with the Hebrew original.”²⁶ Freidenreich highlights the intrinsic authority of Saadia Gaon’s *tafsīr* by comparing it to Onkelos’ Targum, presenting it as more than a mere translation. This comparison suggests the *tafsīr*’s widespread recognition and popularity, extending beyond elite scholarship into religious circles. Its educational power is underscored by its frequent use alongside the original Hebrew text, fostering a rich, symbiotic interpretative dynamic. Furthermore, the very creation of a *tafsīr* for the Torah, a term and tradition rooted in Islamic exegesis, exemplifies Saadia Gaon’s effort to integrate Jewish and Muslim intellectual discourse in the medieval era. This cultural synthesis, as implied by Freidenreich’s analysis, testifies to the vibrant interfaith dialogues and exchanges of the period.

Therefore, when analyzing the complex relationships between Jewish and Muslim intellectual traditions in the Middle Ages, particularly through the works and reception of Saadia Gaon, it becomes crucial to determine whether these interactions were more akin to influences or encounters. This distinction will provide deeper insights into the nature of these exchanges, the power dynamics involved, and their subsequent impact on the evolution of both traditions.

This discourse will explore the multifaceted influences of Islamic thought on Saadia Gaon’s works, as elucidated by Freidenreich. The analysis will be structured into distinct sections for comprehensive understanding. First, I will examine Saadia Gaon’s deliberate choice of “*tafsīr*” as a *terminus technicus* for his work, demonstrating his conscious reference to the rich tradition of Muslim exegesis. Subsequently, the focus will shift to his use of geographically-connotated terms of Islamic origin to describe biblical locales. This section will critically explore the implications of such linguistic choices, highlighting the intricate interplay between language, culture, and exegesis. Moreover, I will delve into conceptual assimilation, unraveling instances where Saadia Gaon borrowed not only etymological elements but also incorporated specific narrative elements and motifs from Islamic sources, thereby enriching his theological discourse.

Finally, I will transition to the reception of Saadia Gaon’s ideas by Muslim scholars during the medieval period. To maintain scope, I will concentrate on a singular illustrative example, acknowledging the expansive and nuanced nature of his intellectual legacy’s reception in diverse contexts and among various scholars.

26 David M. Freidenreich, “The Use of Islamic Sources in Saadiah Gaon’s ‘Tafsīr’ of the Torah,” *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 93, 3/4 (2003): 353.

2 Islamic Terms in Saadia's Tafsīr

Reconstructing the inherent linguistic features of Saadia's Pentateuch translation is very important in philological study. Saadia's explanations of the Oral Torah laid the groundwork for Rabbanite theological discussion among scholars from Iraq, North Africa, and, to a lesser extent, Andalusia.²⁷ Analyzing this work offers a crucial perspective on Saadia's linguistic subtleties, illuminating the style of a key figure in Judeo-Arabic culture. It also clarifies the linguistic structure of a translation that became an influential interpretation of the Torah, widely adopted in scholarly and liturgical contexts, highlighting its immense influence within the Judeo-Arabic community.

A thorough understanding of its complex linguistic system is essential to grasp its individual parts. Each component's function is deeply connected to the work's overall linguistic framework. A single linguistic feature can take on a completely different meaning when placed in a different system. Therefore, the detailed interaction between individual linguistic elements and their broader structure requires careful examination.

To fully comprehend the linguistic makeup of post-classical Arabic, similar texts must be exhaustively studied. This approach will lead to a richer and more nuanced appreciation of how the language evolved and its dynamic nature.²⁸ This assertion gains even more weight when one discerns the unmistakable imprints of Islamic thought and references from the Qur'ān in Saadia Gaon's translation. Freidenreich mentions, that the telling instance can be found in the translation of the term "red heifer" (*parah adumah*).²⁹ The "red heifer" holds a distinctive place in Jewish literature due to its enigmatic nature and its role in ritual purification.³⁰ It is among the most mysterious mitzvahs (commandments) in the Torah, specifically detailed in the Torah portion (*parashat*) of Chukat, where the laws pertaining to it are outlined. According to Numeri 19:2, the Torah states that this statute was commanded by the Lord to the children of Israel. The interpretation of these laws involves meticulous requirements. The red heifer must be entirely, "perfectly red",³¹ with even the presence of two black hairs rendering it invalid. Addi-

²⁷ Herman, *Prophetic Authority*, 271

²⁸ Blau, *Linguistic Character*, 3.

²⁹ Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 387–388.

³⁰ Joseph L. Blau, "The Red Heifer: A Biblical Purification Rite in Rabbinic Literature," *Numen* 14/1 (1967): 70–80; Albert I. Baumgarten, "The Paradox of the Red Heifer," *Vetus Testamentum* 43/4 (1993): 442.

³¹ *Mishneh Tora, Red Heifer* 1.2, Sefaria, https://www.sefaria.org/Mishneh_Torah%2C_Red_Heifer.1.2?lang=bi&with=all&lang2=en (last accessed August 26, 2025).

tionally, it must not have been subjected to any form of labor or work during its lifetime. Even having a yoke placed on its back or mating would disqualify it as a candidate. When a suitable red heifer was identified, and there was a need for more purifying ash water, a ceremonial process was initiated.³² The cow was ritually slaughtered and burned on a pyre, accompanied by a cedar branch, a hyssop sprig, and crimson wool.³³ The ashes resulting from the burning process were then mixed with carefully guarded water drawn from the Shiloach spring.³⁴

In the rite for the purification of צרעה the cedar, hyssop, and crimson material also have a functional role within the rite—beyond any symbolic sense they might carry they nevertheless serve practically as a sprinkling agent for the mixture of blood and water (Lev 14.6–7, 51–52).³⁵

Individuals who had come into contact with the deceased would undergo a purification process involving sprinkling with the ash water on the third and seventh days following their defilement.³⁶ On the seventh day, they would immerse themselves in a mikvah (ritual bath), and by that night, they would return to a state of ritual purity.³⁷ It is important to note that, in the absence of a Temple in Jerusalem, the rituals associated with the red heifer, as well as many other laws related to ritual purity, are no longer applicable. These practices are reserved for a future messianic era when they are expected to be reinstated.

Saadia Gaon's translation of the term "red heifer" (*parah adumah*) in Jewish literature exhibits a noteworthy convergence of Jewish and Islamic intellectual legacies. The Qur'anic account, specifically in Q 2:69, describes the heifer as a "yel-

32 *Mishnayot Parah* (Source Sheet no. 134617), Sefaria, <https://www.sefaria.org/sheets/134617?lang=bi> (last accessed August 26, 2025) and *Britannica*, s.v. "red heifer," Encyclopaedia Britannica, <https://www.britannica.com/topic/red-heifer> (last accessed August 26, 2025).

33 *Mishnayot Parah* (Source Sheet no. 134617), Sefaria, <https://www.sefaria.org/sheets/134617?lang=bi> (last accessed August 26, 2025) and H. Birenboim, "Tevul Yom and the Red Heifer: Pharisaic and Sadducean Halakah," *Dead Sea Discoveries* 16/2 (2009): 254–273.

34 "Red" is an effective defence against demonic spirits in primitive belief while the burning of the red

cow along with other cathartic agents, the cedar, scarlet, and hyssop, is a pagan ritual of magic only loosely affiliated with the Israelite sacrificial cult." Joel Richard Humann, *The Ceremony of the Red Heifer: Its Purpose and Function in Narrative Context* (PhD diss., Durham University, 2011): 23.

35 Humann, *The Ceremony of the Red Heifer*, 132.

36 Stephen Newman, "Understanding the Mystery of the Red Heifer Ritual," *Jewish Bible Quarterly* 43/2 (2015): 93–96.

37 Susan Grossman, "Mikveh and the Sanctity of Being Created Human," in *Hakol Kol Yaakov: A Festschrift in Honor of Rabbi Dr. Jacob J. Schachter*, ed. J. David Bleich (Leiden: Brill, 2021), 67–88.

low cow” (*baqara şafrā*), deviating from the conventional descriptor.³⁸ Saadia Gaon, intriguingly, embraces this Qur’ānic terminology in his rendition, signifying the interwoven influences of both traditions. This narrative in the Qur’ān intertwines elements from the books of Numeri 19 and Deuteronomy 21 while also incorporating elements from rabbinic commentary. For instance, the debate over the age and color homogeneity of the red heifer, with rabbinic tradition disqualifying it for having even two hairs of a different color, finds a place in the Qur’ānic account. While the Qur’ānic account in Q 2:69³⁹ alludes to it as the “yellow heifer/cow” (*baqara şafrā*), diverging from the traditional descriptor, Saadia Gaon intriguingly adopts this Qur’ānic terminology in his rendition.⁴⁰ From a comparative and historically critical perspective, it is noteworthy that the descriptions of the color of the cow in both the Book of Numeri “red heifer” and the Qur’ān, using the term “*şafrā*,” may not necessarily be distinct from one another. This linguistic parallelism raises intriguing questions about the interpretation and influence of these texts.

Gabriel Said Reynolds highlights in “The Qur’ān and the Bible,” that the Qur’ānic passage (Q 2:67–71) where the Israelites hesitate to follow the command to slaughter a cow, contrasting it with their eager worship of the golden calf.⁴¹ This contrast in the Qur’ān reflects debates found in the Mishnah Parah regarding the cow’s age, purity, and precise color. Interestingly, in verse Q 2:69, the Qur’ān em-

³⁸ For more information see Ali Aghaei, “The Morphology of the Narrative Exegesis of the Qur’ān: The Case of the Cow of the Banū Isrā’īl (Q 2:67–74),” in *Reading the Bible in Islamic Context: Qur’anic Conversations*, ed. Daniel J. Crowther, Shirin Shafaie, Ida Glaser, and Shabbir Akhtar (Abingdon: Routledge, 2017), 167–194.

³⁹ “They said: Pray for us unto thy Lord that He make clear to us of what colour she is. (Moses) answered: Lo! He saith: Verily she is a yellow cow. Bright is her colour, gladdening beholders.” *Edition of the Qur’ān (al-Qur’ān al-karīm)*, Cairo 1924, Image, Unicode Text, Latin Transcription, digital edition by Michael Marx in collaboration with Tobias J. Jocham et al., Corpus Coranicum, <https://corpuscoranicum.de/en/verse-navigator/sura/2/verse/69/print> (last accessed August 26, 2025).

⁴⁰ Joshua L. Blau, “Was Saadia Gaon’s Arabic Translation of the Pentateuch Meant for Muslims Too?” in *Modern Jewish Scholarship in Hungary: The ‘Science of Judaism’ between East and West*, ed. Tamás Turán and Carsten Wilke (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2016), 70.

⁴¹ “The Qur’ān (vv. 67, 71) here has the Israelites resist the command (cf. Num 19:1–3) to slay a cow, whereas they eagerly performed the unholy rite of worshipping another cow: the golden calf. The Qur’ān’s emphasis on the Israelites’ uncertainty about exactly what sort of cow is called for reflects debates in Mishnah Parah over the age of the cow, its purity, and its precise color (in v. 69 the Qur’ān uses a word, *şafrā*, that today is understood to mean “yellow”, but its original sense might be closer to “red”, the Hb. word in Numbers means lit. “blood-colored.” Gabriel Said Reynolds, *The Qur’ān and the Bible: Text and Commentary* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2018), 52.

plays the term *ṣafrā'*, which is commonly understood today as “yellow.” However, its original sense might lean closer to “red,” aligning with the Hebrew word in Numbers, which means “blood-colored.”⁴² It is proposed that Saadia should have had the ability to distinguish between the yellow and red colors in Arabic.⁴³ Freidenreich suggests that Saadia’s biblical translation was influenced by the Qur’ānic narrative.⁴⁴ He cites Joseph Qaṭīḥ’s⁴⁵ argument that Saadia interpreted *ṣafrā'* as the naturally occurring yellowish-brown color of cows, as a blood-like red would be considered unnatural.⁴⁶ Saadia seemingly assumed that biblical commands pertained only to naturally occurring phenomena. Freidenreich suggests that Saadia’s choice of the Arabic term may have been influenced by how Muslims understood it in the Qur’ān, placing it on a spectrum between yellowness and blackness.⁴⁷ However, Saadia’s intended understanding might have leaned towards black, although this interpretation contradicts the Mishnaic requirement that even two black hairs would render the cow unfit. According to Abdulla Galadri, Saadia might have perceived *ṣafrā'* as brown.⁴⁸

This comparison underscores the intricate interplay between linguistic elements and their interpretations in these texts, shedding light on Saadia’s translational choices and the broader cultural influences of the Qur’ān on his work. Saadia Gaon’s engagement with Islamic terminologies and concepts is manifest in several dimensions of his work, providing a window into the intricate interplay of Judeo-Islamic scholarship during the medieval period. One salient instance lies in his choice of nomenclature for his translation of the Torah. Rather than employing the more direct and expected terms such as *tawrāt* or *tarjama*, Saadia Gaon intriguingly opts for *tafsīr*. This term, rooted deeply within the Islamic exegetical tradition, signifies more than a mere translation. Its usage suggests an interpretative and exegetical endeavor, hinting that Saadia Gaon’s rendition was not envisioned as a mere verbatim transference from Hebrew to Judeo-Arabic. Instead, it carried layers of meaning, interpretation, and possibly even commentary, aimed at rendering the text more comprehensible and relevant to its Judeo-Arabic readership.

42 Reynolds, *The Qur’ān and the Bible*, 52.

43 Abdulla Galadari, “The Red Cow: The Qur’ān and the Midrash,” in *Emerging Horizons: 21st Century Approaches to the Study of Midrash*, ed. W. David Nelson and Rivka Ulmer (Piscataway, NJ: Gorgias Press, 2021), 22.

44 Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 387–393.

45 Joseph Qaṭīḥ, *Tirgum ha-Tafsir shel Rav Se’adiah Ga’on* (Jerusalem, 1984; repr. in *Torat Hayyim*, Jerusalem, 1986).

46 Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 389.

47 Galadri, *The Red Cow*, 22.

48 Ibid.

This deliberate terminological choice underscores Saadia Gaon's profound appreciation for, and incorporation of, the broader cultural and intellectual milieu in which he operated. His willingness to embrace *tafsīr* not merely as a term, but as a methodological approach, highlights the depth of the cross-cultural currents that shaped his scholarship. This article will focus on a few key examples to avoid being overly broad. Nevertheless, these examples will highlight Saadia Gaon's significant contributions to Jewish-Muslim intellectual exchange during the medieval period.

3 *The Terminus Technicus “tafsīr”*

Tafsīr, an Islamic scholarly discipline, represents the nexus where divine revelation and human interpretation intersect. Derived from the Arabic root *f-s-r*, the term essentially conveys the process of unveiling or deciphering the depths of meaning enshrined within the Qur'ān.⁴⁹ By definition, the “Qur'ān is not only a much-recited sacred text; it is ‘the reciting’ (*al-qurmān*). Specially, it is God’s ‘reciting’, his verbatim speech, his eternal, uncreated Word.”⁵⁰ Its interpretation requires a discipline, *tafsīr*, which has emerged as one of the most significant academic pursuits within Islamic studies. This concept of “unveiling” is deeply rooted in the verb *fassara*, meaning elucidation or clarification. Additionally, the realm of Qur'ānic interpretation is multifaceted and far from being monolithic. It is intricately layered with terms such as *ta'wīl*, which frequently intertwines with *tafsīr*. Though scholars might occasionally use these terms interchangeably, they indeed carry unique semantic nuances. In her analysis, Nimet Şeker articulates that the foundation of classical Sunni interpretation, as presented through the theoretical contributions of select scholars, sets the stage for analyzing the tension between textual coherence and the context of revelation.⁵¹ This interpretive theory is characterized by a dichotomous approach to the subject matter. By reconstructing discussions surrounding the hermeneutical terms *tafsīr* and *ta'wīl*, one can trace the underpinnings of this hermeneutic process and the associated methodological inquiries. *Tafsīr* typically gravitates towards explanation, provid-

49 Abdulhamit Birişik, “Tefsir,” in *TDV İslâm Ansiklopedisi*, vol. 40 (İstanbul: İslâm Araştırmaları Merkezi, 2011), 281–290.

50 William A. Graham and Navid Kermani, “Recitation and Aesthetic Reception,” in *The Cambridge Companion to the Qur'ān*, ed. Jane Dammen MacAuliffe (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006), 115.

51 Nimet Seker, *Der Koran als Rede und Text: Hermeneutik sunnitischer Koranexegeten zwischen Textkohärenz und Offenbarungskontext* (Berlin: EB Verlag, 2019), 133.

ing clarifications on the apparent meanings, while *ta'wīl* delves deeper into allegorical interpretations.

Linguistic expositions further expand upon the richness of the term *tafsīr* by alluding to its potential association with *sefr*.⁵² This connection magnifies the essence of *tafsīr* as an act of revelation, an endeavor to dispel obscurity and bring forth clarity. Thus, *tafsīr* serves as a beacon, illuminating the Qur'ānic text for its readers. But the domain of *tafsīr* is not solely a linguistic exercise. It represents a synthesis of multifaceted knowledge. Scholars adept in *tafsīr* routinely draw from linguistic disciplines like *ṣarf* (morphology) and *naḥw* (syntax).⁵³ Yet, their expositions are equally informed by other Qur'ānic sciences, hadith, historical contexts, principles of logic, and Islamic jurisprudential norms. This interdisciplinary approach underpins the holistic objective of *tafsīr*: discerning and elucidating the divine intent enshrined in the Qur'ān. The early Islamic era, graced by the presence of the Prophet Muḥammad and his Companions, bore witness to numerous allegorical elucidations of the Qur'ān.

Given the nuanced significance of the term *tafsīr* within the Islamic context, where it holds an esteemed position and serves as a primary tool for elucidating the Qur'ān, the decision by Saadia Gaon to utilize this very term for his translation of the Torah is deeply intriguing. At its core, the act of translation inherently entails a process of interpretation. As the semantic boundaries of languages rarely align perfectly, the act of carrying meaning from one language into another invariably introduces a dimension of interpretive judgment. During the 12th century, a period characterized by a rich tapestry of interfaith dialogue and scholarly debates, Abraham Ibn Ezra emerged as a prominent commentator.⁵⁴ This era witnessed the cross-pollination of ideas, often facilitated by the act of translation and interpretation. Freidenreich's account highlights Ibn Ezra's critical perspective on Saadia's translational strategies.⁵⁵ Ibn Ezra often cited Saadia's interpretations, though sometimes critically, and notably voiced skepticism. His suggestion that Saadia's insights might have come from "dreams" implies not only that Saadia's sources could be fanciful but also raises questions about the validity of his interpretations. The comment on Saadia's translation of the Torah "in the language of Ishmael"⁵⁶ encapsulates the broader sociocultural dynamics of the period. Given the dominant stature of Arabic, associated with the Ishmae-

52 Birişik, *Tefsir*, 281–290.

53 Birişik, *Tefsir*, 281–290.

54 Hermann Greive, *Studien zum jüdischen Neuplatonismus: Die Religionsphilosophie des Abraham ibn Ezra*, *Studia Judaica* 7 (Berlin/New York: De Gruyter, 1973).

55 Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 358.

56 Ibid.

lites (Muslims), Saadia's choice might be viewed as a pragmatic endeavor to make the Torah accessible and relevant in a primarily Arab milieu. Freidenreich's insights illuminate the intricate interplay between translation, religious identity, and scholarly discourse in the 12th century. The dynamic tension between innovation and tradition, particularly evident in the debate surrounding Saadia's *tafsīr*, highlights the complex cultural negotiations characteristic of this era.

In the Arabic lexicon, *tafsīr* signifies "explanation" or "interpretation," thus underscoring the intertwined nature of translation and interpretation. Saadia Gaon's choice to employ the term *tafsīr* for his Torah translation, therefore, provides a window into his perceived role as an interpreter and not merely as a translator. This choice may reflect a conscious effort to bridge the rich interpretive traditions of Islam with Jewish scriptural studies. By doing so, he not only facilitates a linguistic transition but also engages in a deeper, more profound dialogue between two major monotheistic religions. Such a decision also highlights the permeability and fluidity of religious, cultural, and linguistic boundaries during the period. It underscores the interconnectedness of the Abrahamic faiths and their shared history of intellectual and theological exchanges.⁵⁷ Saadia Gaon's use of *tafsīr*, a term deeply rooted in Islamic exegesis, for his Judaic enterprise, therefore, stands as a testament to the intricate tapestry of religious scholarship in the medieval period.

It is essential to underscore that Saadia Gaon, in translating the Torah into Judeo-Arabic and designating it as a *tafsīr*, might not have intended to engage a Muslim readership. Had that been his objective, a direct translation into Arabic would have been the logical choice. Given that Muslims of the era were largely unfamiliar with Hebrew or its script, Saadia's choice strongly suggests a primary focus on a Jewish audience. This perspective finds further validation in Saadia's own articulation. In the preamble to his *tafsīr*, Saadia elucidates his motivations, stating that he embarked on this project in response to a request for a straightforward rendition of the Torah. This version was intended to be devoid of linguistic intricacies, devoid of polemics against heretics, and free from the intricacies of rational or traditional law. Instead, Saadia aimed for a crystalline conveyance of the Torah's text and its core meanings. This self-stated objective underscores his

57 Sidney H. Griffith, *The Bible in Arabic: The Scriptures of the 'People of the Book' in the Language of Islam* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2013), 4. Griffith highlights how the translation of the Bible into Arabic reflects the shared intellectual and theological world of Jews, Christians, and Muslims. While Griffith discusses this in the context of scriptural translation, his observation underscores more broadly the interconnectedness of the Abrahamic traditions.

commitment to rendering a transparent and accessible interpretation for his Jewish contemporaries.⁵⁸

In the broader context of translation studies, this alignment between translation and interpretation reinforces the idea that every translation is, in essence, a recontextualization. It is an endeavor that goes beyond the mere transference of words, delving into the realm of meaning, culture, and context. Saadia Gaon's choice, in this light, encapsulates the broader complexities and responsibilities inherent in the act of translating sacred texts.

4 Geographical Places

One of the standout features of his work is the association of Torah's geographical places with Islamic sacred sites. By equating names like "Mesha" with Mecca and "Sephar" with Medina, Saadia bridged two religious worlds, offering readers a unique perspective that rooted the sacred texts in a shared sacred geography. Genesis 10:30, often referred to as the "Table of Nations," details the descendants of Noah and offers a genealogical account of how various ethnicities and regions were populated after the flood. In this context, the names "Mesha" and "Sephar" are given as geographical markers delineating the range of settlements of Joktan's descendants, a significant figure in the lineage of Shem. Saadia Gaon's interpretation of Genesis 10:30 serves as a fascinating nexus between ancient Judaic narratives and the Islamic context of his era. The Table of Nations in Genesis provides an intricate account of post-flood lineages, mapping out the origins and migrations of various groups descended from Noah. Within this rich textual landscape, Saadia's decision to align the terms "Mesha" and "Sephar" with Mecca and Medina, respectively, is highly noteworthy. Saadia's interpretation transcends mere linguistic translation, serving as a deliberate cultural and theological link. By connecting Mecca and Medina, pivotal sites in Islam, with ancient Jewish traditions through his reading, he achieves two goals: he makes Jewish scripture more accessible and pertinent to his contemporaries, and he underscores the common origins and interconnected pasts of Judaism and Islam. Saadia's approach can also be seen as a nuanced form of interfaith dialogue. By integrating foundational Islamic landmarks within a Judaic narrative, he underscores a commonality and shared reverence between the two religions. Living as a Jewish scholar in an Islamic environment, Saadia's perspective was undeniably shaped by the religious and cultural crosscurrents around him. His association of Mecca and Medina

58 Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 358–359.

with the genealogies of Genesis can be interpreted as a gesture towards mutual recognition and respect between the two faith communities.

Saadia Gaon's intriguing association of the Biblical terms "Mesha" and "Sephar" with the Islamic holy cities of Mecca and Medina respectively highlights the complex interplay between religious interpretation and cultural context. While this interpretation could be seen as an attempt to align with the prevalent Islamic influences of his time, it's important to consider that this connection might not be unique to him. A broader understanding potentially existed during his era, suggesting that the Bible in this passage might indeed be referencing Mecca and Medina.

In Genesis 10, which is also known as the Table of Nations, the focus is on the genealogy of nations descended from Noah's sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth. Amid this genealogy, there's a segment detailing the descendants of Joktan, the great-great-grandson of Shem. The text specifies their dwelling to be "from Mesha as you go toward Sephar, the mountain of the East."⁵⁹ Based on geographical and historical analysis, as Richard Davidson mentions, "Mesha can be associated with Mesene, located at the northwest end of the Persian Gulf."⁶⁰ Conversely, Sephar might correspond to Dofar or the ancient Saprappa referenced by Ptolemy and Pliny.⁶¹ Interestingly, there's a significant mountain near Dofar, which aligns with the biblical "mountain of the East." Given this context, Saadia Gaon's interpretation is intriguing. Why would he link Mesha to Mecca and Sephar to Medina? An explanation could be found when examining the broader biblical and historical contexts. Abraham's descendants through Ishmael, including twelve tribes, predominantly settled in the Arabian Peninsula. Notably, at least six of these tribes are referenced in cuneiform inscriptions from the northern region of the peninsula.⁶² The Ishmaelites, as described in Genesis 25:18, settled from Havilah to Shur, indicating an extensive territory that reaches near Egypt and stretches toward Assyria. The biblical narrative also denotes amicable ties between the Ishmaelites and Israel, with several intersections of their histories and mutual associations. Saadia Gaon's interpretative translation of the phrase "fi tariq hajar al-hijaz"/ "the way to Shur" in Genesis 16:7 with a possible allusion to the Kaaba in Mecca, raises intriguing questions about the motivations behind his choices. This interpretation suggests that Saadia Gaon was not merely engaging in eisegesis, but rather he might have been drawing upon an interpretative tradition

⁵⁹ Genesis 10:30

⁶⁰ Richard Davidson, "The Children of the East," *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* 14/1 (2018): 49.

⁶¹ Ibid.

⁶² Ibid.

that recognized deeper connections between biblical narratives and the emerging significance of places like Mecca and Medina, especially within the context of the Islamic tradition. Saadia's decision to identify Mesha as Mecca and Sephar as Medina in Genesis 10:26–30 is particularly noteworthy. It seems that his goal was to bridge early Semitic history with later religious and cultural developments in the Arabian Peninsula. By doing so, he aimed to harmonize Jewish traditions with the geographical and spiritual realities of his time, emphasizing the interconnected destinies of the children of Abraham. While Saadia's approach is generally consistent, there are instances, like his translation of Shur, where his decisions appear creative and inconsistent. In the case of Shur, he translates it differently in various verses, and one notable instance is his rendering of it as "hajr al-hijaz" in Gen 16:7. This translation suggests a connection to the Black Rock of the Kaaba in Mecca, influenced by Islamic traditions.

However, as Freidenreich points out, manuscript variations in this specific translation raise questions about Saadia's original intent. While some manuscripts align with the interpretation of Mecca, others differ. Saadia's commentary on this verse does not provide clarity on this matter. Still, it is reasonable to consider that Saadia's choice to refer to the Hijaz region in his *tafsīr* was deliberate, given his willingness to associate Mecca and Medina with biblical locations in other verses. The motivations behind Saadia's willingness to incorporate Islamic references into his interpretations remain a subject of scholarly debate. While the influence of the Islamic cultural environment cannot be dismissed, it is crucial to note that Saadia was exposed to various Islamic traditions and did not reference all of them. His choices may be better understood by examining other instances in his *tafsīr* where he appears to modify biblical texts based on parallel passages in the Qur'ān.

Saadia Gaon's interpretations and translations, particularly those that resonate with Islamic traditions, reveal the intricate influence of religious, cultural, and geographical elements on his scholarship. His decisions reflect a scholar who actively sought to bridge diverse traditions in his pursuit of clarifying the Torah's meaning. Freidenreich's research illuminates these complex facets of Saadia's work, encouraging further exploration and analysis within the broader context of Jewish-Islamic interactions. Therefore, Saadia Gaon's decision to link Mesha with Mecca and Sephar with Medina is not arbitrary. Instead, it stems from a profound understanding of the biblical narrative, an acknowledgment of historical realities, and potentially a desire to foster a shared sense of Abrahamic heritage.

5 Conceptual Influences: Becoming Like Angels

Saadia Gaon's translation of the Torah has been a subject of scholarly exploration, revealing intriguing connections between his work and the Qur'ān. Polliack and Freidenreich have made significant contributions in recognizing Saadia's utilization of Qur'ānic passages in his Torah translations, particularly evident in his interpretation of Genesis 3:3–5. This analysis delves into Saadia's translation choices and potential influences, shedding light on the complexities of his work, with a particular focus on insights drawn from the commentaries of Polliack and Freidenreich. These scholars' contributions form a foundational basis for understanding the nuanced relationship between Saadia Gaon's Torah translation and the Qur'ān, and I will further expand upon their findings in this examination.

One striking example of Qur'ānic influence in Saadia's translation is his handling of the dialogue between the devil and Adam and his wife (Eve- in Islamic literature *Ḥawā*) in the Garden of Eden. Genesis 3:3–5 contains a crucial dialogue between God, Adam, Eve, and the serpent, where God warns them about the forbidden fruit, the serpent contradicts God's words, and eventually persuades Adam and Eve to eat from the tree. In Saadia Gaon's translation of this dialogue, one can observe elements reminiscent of Qur'ānic language. He introduces the phrase "Like God, you know good and evil" (*wa takūnāni ka-llāhi 'ariftū al-ḥayr wa al-šarr*) and "You become like angels who know good and evil" (*ka-l-malāika 'ariftū al-ḥayr wa al-šarr*). Notably, Saadia's use of "angels" here corresponds to the Qur'ānic expression "*takūnā mala-kayni*" (you become like angels). However, it is essential to recognize that the Hebrew version of this passage doesn't necessarily have to associate humans with God. The phrase in question, וְהָיִיתֶם כְּמַלְאָכִים יָדְעֵי טוֹב וָרָע, can be interpreted in two ways: "Like God, you know good and evil" and "Like Divine Beings, you know good and evil." The ambiguity in the Hebrew text allows for both interpretations, and it's worth noting that Saadia's choice to use "angels" might be influenced by his exposure to Qur'ānic language and concepts.⁶³ This demonstrates the complexities of translation and interpretation, where the choice of words can significantly impact the understanding of a text, especially when navigating between different religious and linguistic contexts.

⁶³ "Then Satan whispered to them that he might manifest unto them that which was hidden from them of their shame, and he said: Your Lord forbade you from this tree only lest ye should become angels or become of the immortals." Q 7:20. *Edition of the Qur'ān (al-Qur'ān al-karīm)*, Cairo 1924, Image, Unicode Text, Latin Transcription, digital edition by Michael Marx in collaboration with Tobias J. Jocham et al., Corpus Coranicum, <https://corpuscoranicum.de/en/verse-navigators/sura/7/verse/20/print> (last accessed August 26, 2025).

Freidenreich points out that this translation creates a parallel with Qur'ānic language found in Q 7:20, where Satan tempts Adam and Eve with the idea that by eating from the tree, they will become like angels or among the immortal. Several possibilities arise when considering the motivations behind Saadia's translation choices in Genesis 3:5. One hypothesis is that Saadia might have been influenced by the Qur'ānic understanding of the Garden of Eden story, where the promise of becoming like angels or immortal beings is central. However, this raises questions about Saadia's willingness to incorporate Qur'ānic influences into his translation and whether such influences were prevalent in his cultural environment. Another possibility, according to Freidenreich, is that Saadia drew from the Aramaic Targum Pseudo-Jonathan, a translation of the Torah that predates his work.⁶⁴ This Targum translates the relevant portion of Genesis 3:5 as “*wa-tehewon ka-malakhin ravrevin*,” which closely resembles Saadia's translation. While Pseudo-Jonathan's version combines elements of earlier Targum Onkelos and later interpretations like Saadia's, it introduces the notion of becoming “like great angels”.⁶⁵

Since Saadia didn't explicitly explain his translation choices, scholars need to consider several factors. His interpretations diverged from traditional rabbinic views, incorporating creative linguistic selections and aligning with Qur'ānic language. This suggests a complex interplay with various textual traditions.

6 The Reception of Saadia Gaon's Thoughts

When examining the concepts Saadia Gaon adopted from the Muslim context, particularly the Qur'ān, a crucial question emerges: Did these ideas exist in Muslim sources before or after him? A detailed analysis reveals notable similarities, though it remains uncertain whether these parallels are solely due to Saadia Gaon's influence or reflect the intellectual *Zeitgeist*. For example, Ibn Abi Ḥātim's (d. 327/938) exegetical work on Q 7:20 contains the following passage:

And on the authority of Ibn Abbas: Unless you are two angels, or you are one of the immortals. He said: It means two angels, you will be like Him. Meaning: Like God, the Mighty and Sublime.⁶⁶

⁶⁴ Freidenreich, *The Use of Islamic Sources*, 378.

⁶⁵ Ibid.

⁶⁶ Abū Muḥammad 'Abd ar-Raḥmān b. Muḥammad b. Idris ar-Rāzī (Ibn Abi Ḥātim), *Tafsīr*, ed. As'ad Muḥammad al-Ṭayyib, vol. 5 (Mecca: Maktabat al-Bāz, 1999), 1450.

Notably, Ibn Abī Hātim was a contemporary of Saadia Gaon, making it challenging to definitively establish direct influence. However, a different scenario emerges with the case of Ibrāhīm b. ʿUmar b. Ḥasan al-Biqāʾī (809–85 AH/1407–80 CE), a late Mamluk scholar who wrote a Qurʾān commentary. In his commentary, he employed the Hebrew Bible to interpret biblical material found in the Qurʾān. His *tafsīr* can be likened to “an Islamic Diatessaron,” where he created a “Harmony of the Four Gospels.”⁶⁷ Using Bible verses, Jewish, and Christian sources to explain Qurʾānic verses was not a new or previously unknown method of Qurʾānic exegesis. The genre of *isrāʾīliyyāt*, which consists of narratives and traditions from Jewish and Christian sources, has long been recognized as one of the essential sources for Qurʾānic exegetes.⁶⁸ However, what sets al-Biqāʾī apart as unique is his decision to incorporate direct quotations from the Hebrew Bible and the Gospels, relying on their official Arabic translations, when interpreting Qurʾānic verses related to biblical material.⁶⁹ This distinctive approach marks a departure from more traditional methods of exegesis and underscores al-Biqāʾī’s innovative engagement with these texts shedding light on Qurʾānic passages. This approach reflects a significant engagement with both Islamic and Judeo-Christian sources and suggests a broader intellectual trend during his time.

Ibrāhīm al-Biqāʾī’s work warrants further study to understand the extent of cross-cultural and inter-religious influences in the intellectual climate of his era. This underscores the challenge of tracing the origins and spread of ideas across diverse religious and cultural contexts, making it an ongoing area of academic inquiry. Notably, al-Biqāʾī’s use of Biblical sources often met with disapproval from his contemporaries, a testament to his fervent commitment to such references. We are informed that, “When al-Biqāʾī came to the half of his commentary, he started to receive appreciation and criticism from various sections. The objections generally focused on the quotations from the Bible and the broad handling of the relationship.”⁷⁰ What he did after these criticisms is particularly interesting, and I want to share it here: “After that, the author took a break from writing

67 Walid Saleh and Kevin Casey, “An Islamic Diatessaron: Al-Biqāʾī’s Harmony of the Four Gospels,” in *Translating the Bible into Arabic: Historical, Text-Critical and Literary Aspects*, ed. Sara Binay and Stefan Leder, (Würzburg: Ergon, 2012), 85–116.

68 Tuğrul Kurt, “Die isrāʾīliyyāt – Rekonstruktion oder Biblisierung des Korans? Versuch einer Analyse der Funktion und Nutzung der jüdisch-christlichen Überlieferungen in der islamischen Exegesetradition,” *Frankfurter Zeitschrift für Islamisch-Theologische Studien* 5 (2020): 183–196.

69 “he decided to quote the Hebrew Bible and the Gospels, in their official Arabic translation, when interpreting Bible-related material in the Qurʾān”. Walid Saleh, *In Defense of the Bible: A Critical Edition and an Introduction to al-Biqāʾī’s Bible Treatise* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2008), 1

70 Necati Kara, “NAZMÜ’D-DÜRER,” in *TDV İslâm Ansiklopedisi*, vol. 32 (İstanbul: TDV Yayınları, 2006), 463–464.

his work and wrote two works (*al-aqwāl al-qawīma* and *Maṣā'id an-naẓar*) on the permissibility of the transfer from the Bible and the necessity of the science of relations⁷¹

It is evident that al-Biqā'ī draws on the work of Saadia Gaon in his translation and interpretation of the Qur'ānic text. In his writings, al-Biqā'ī mentions that he compared his version with that of some Jewish rabbis who held Saadia Gaon's translation in high regard. These rabbis considered Saadia Gaon's translation to be the best, especially if he himself had been the reader. However, al-Biqā'ī asserts that his own version is not only closer to the actual Hebrew wording but also reflects a higher level of proficiency in Arabic compared to Saadia's translation.⁷²

This assertion by al-Biqā'ī suggests a clear influence of Saadia Gaon's work on his own approach to Qur'ānic interpretation. By comparing his translation with that of Saadia Gaon, al-Biqā'ī positions himself as a scholar who seeks to improve upon the previous translation by bringing it closer to the original Hebrew and enhancing the linguistic aspects of the Arabic text. Furthermore, al-Biqā'ī's reference to a specific Qur'ānic verse (Q 15:29) underscores his commitment to demonstrating the superiority of his version over Saadia Gaon's. Al-Biqā'ī discusses the significance of Idrīs (Enoch) in Islamic tradition and how his narrative relates to Jewish and Christian accounts. Enoch is portrayed as a notable prophet and as the ancestor of Noah. Al-Biqā'ī underscores Enoch's status as a recipient of divine revelations and his role in delivering crucial messages to the people. Enoch's elevated position is symbolized by his being raised to a high station, possibly the paradise or the fourth heaven, in alignment with the Islamic tradition of the Prophet Muhammad's Night Journey.⁷³ Al-Biqā'ī also highlights the influence of Jewish and Christian traditions on the depiction of Enoch. He notes that the story of Enoch and its interpretation were already present in Jewish and Christian sources before they became part of Islamic narratives. Furthermore, the author references an ancient version of the Torah's translation, shedding light on Enoch's life and his pleasing status in the eyes of Allah, ultimately leading to his being taken by Allah. In addition to the passage mentioned earlier, al-Biqā'ī also directly refers to Saadia Gaon at other points in his work. In another, ancient version of the Torah, al-Biqā'ī conducted a comparative analysis with the input of some renowned Jewish scholars. This comparison was based on the translation by Saadia Gaon in terms of its intended meaning. Saadia Gaon served as the reader, and the

71 Ibid.

72 Ibrāhīm b. 'Umar b. Ḥasan al-Biqā'ī, *Naẓm ad-durar fī tanāsib al-āyāt wa-s-suwar*, vol.1 (Cairo: Dār al-Kutub al-Islāmī, 1984), 279.

73 Ibid.

text reads as follows: The entire lifespan of Henoah spanned three hundred and sixty-five years.

In another version of the Torah, which is very ancient, I compared it with some distinguished Jewish scholars, based on the translation by Saʿīd al-Fayyūmī in meaning. He was the reader, and it reads: ‘The entire life of Henoah was three hundred and sixty-five years. Then Henoah was pleasing to Allah, so he vanished because Allah had taken him away.’⁷⁴

Then Henoah found favor with Allah, and thus, he disappeared because Allah had taken him away. This reference to Saadia Gaon’s translation underscores the significance of his influence and the impact of his work on subsequent interpretations of biblical and Qur’ānic texts.

7 Conclusion

Saadia Gaon’s thought and its reception within Jewish and Islamic intellectual traditions reveal a multifaceted and nuanced relationship. His incorporation of Islamic concepts, particularly Qur’ānic terminologies, was not a simple absorption but a masterful reinterpretation. Saadia imbued these concepts with a unique Jewish perspective, creating new avenues for understanding shared religious ideas for both Jewish and Muslim audiences.

The influence was not unidirectional. Muslim scholars later integrated Saadia Gaon’s conceptual frameworks into their own work, demonstrating a reciprocal exchange. This dynamic intellectual relationship was characterized by mutual respect, shared learning, and collaborative knowledge production. This intricate interplay challenges oversimplified notions of influence, highlighting instead the nuanced encounters that shaped both traditions. It underscores the coevolution and symbiosis between Jewish and Islamic intellectual traditions, characterized by a deep mutual dependence.

Saadia Gaon’s work demonstrates that the relationship between his thought and Islamic ideas was more than mere influence; it was a profound interplay of diverse cultural and religious currents. This highlights a principle of interdependency, signifying a reciprocal exchange where both Jewish and Muslim societies contributed equitably.

A testament to this intricate relationship during the medieval period is Saadia Gaon’s translation of the Torah into Judeo-Arabic. This endeavor transcended simple linguistic translation, reflecting a deep engagement with the socio-

⁷⁴ Ibid., 216.

religious dynamics of the time. His choice of the term “*tafsīr*” for his translation further underscores his commitment to an interpretative and exegetical approach, revealing the significant cross-cultural influences on his scholarship.

Saadia Gaon’s intricate engagement with Islamic concepts and terminologies exemplifies the rich intellectual exchange between Jewish and Muslim traditions. This interaction defies simple categorization, highlighting the complex dynamics that shaped both faiths. The enduring impact of Saadia’s work is evident in its reception by scholars like Ibrāhīm al-Biqā’ī, demonstrating his lasting influence on subsequent interpretations of biblical and Qur’ānic texts.

The development of religious methods, texts, and motifs during the medieval period was not a one-way street, but a complex and interdependent interplay. Saadia Gaon stands as a pivotal figure in illustrating this dynamic. It is crucial to distinguish between “influence,” which implies a one-sided impact, and “encounter,” signifying a symmetrical and mutual confluence of cultures or religions. Saadia Gaon’s legacy embodies the latter, where Jewish and Islamic traditions actively enriched each other’s intellectual landscapes. This interdependence underscores the vibrant collaboration, shared learning, and mutual respect that characterized the Middle Ages. His enduring significance invites further exploration into the profound exchanges that shaped the religious and cultural heritage of both traditions.

In essence, Saadia Gaon’s engagement with Islamic concepts and the reception of his work within both Jewish and Islamic traditions underscore the intricate interplay of ideas, cross-cultural influences, and nuanced encounters that contributed to their intellectual development. His legacy serves as a testament to the dynamic and symbiotic relationship between Jewish and Islamic thought during the medieval period, warranting continued exploration and analysis in this fascinating field of study.

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Chapter 11

“Reciprocal Illumination”

A Quasi-Midrashic Orientation for Inter-Theological Inquiry

1 Introduction

Among the perturbing issues in the study of a tradition’s continuity is the matter of interfaith relations generally and inter-*theological* study more particularly. That is, the study of *theos*, *cosmos*, *anthros*, and their relations. What do our traditions tell us about these? The historical evidence is mixed with, for instance, Maimonides drawing productively on the medieval Arabic Muslim philosophers such as al-Fārābī, ibn Sīnā, and ibn Bājja and with early modern Reformed Covenantal theologians drawing heavily on the Hebrew Bible and study with rabbis. On the other hand are centuries of forced disputations imposed on Jewish communities by anti-Judaistic Christian clerics and anti-Judaistic readings of the Hebrew Bible by highly trained, nineteenth-century exegetes such as Julius Wellhausen and Adolf von Harnack.

Each possibility, positive and prejudicial, relies on assumptions about its own and other traditions and on the approaches to interfaith study that follow from those assumptions. This chapter proposes an approach to inter-theological scholarship, “reciprocal illumination,” with the aim of furthering productive exchange characterized by curiosity, interest in new perspectives, and mutual respect for the differences among traditions. It will focus on Jewish-Christian exchange. Importantly, the chapter suggests that a wide range of inter-theological exchanges—from the ubiquitous, cultural adaptations of ideas from one tradition to another to more formal inter-theological study—fall within the continuity of Jewish tradition and experience since the amoraic period.

2 Antecedents of “Reciprocal Illumination” in the Jewish Experience

To begin, somewhat cheekily, with ubiquitous religio-cultural adaptation, one might think of the re-working of Egyptian YVH worship (fourteenth to twelfth

century BCE¹) into the Israelite tetragrammaton and theology (tenth century BCE). Or one may think of Daniel Boyarin's work² and the *Jewish Annotated New Testament*³ on early Christian re-interpretation of Jewish theology, texts, and practices—two of western civilization's most significant instances of inter-theological exchange. As noted by the many authors in *The Ways That Never Parted: Jews and Christians in Late Antiquity and the Early Middle Ages*, Jewish-Christian exchange was robust into the beginning of the medieval period.⁴ One cannot read the gemara without recognizing the influences of Persian, Hellenistic, Christian, and neo-Platonist thought. *Entangled Histories: Knowledge, Authority, and Jewish Culture in the Thirteenth Century* tells a similarly complex story of the high Middle Ages.⁵

In describing this sort of ubiquitous cultural exchange—at times explicit, at times indirect, and at times unacknowledged—Katharina Heyden and David Nirenberg use the term co-production. “Not only at their origins,” they write, “but at every instant of their existence, including present and future, many and varied Muslim, Jewish, and Christian communities are forming, re-forming, and transforming themselves by interacting with, thinking about, and imagining each other” at times irenically and at times conflictually.⁶ Heyden and Nirenberg unpack one example in which, to argue for the importance of its ideas, a Qur'anic passage co-produces itself with the Talmud tractate *b. Shabbat* 88a (on the Sinai narrative), which itself was a co-production with (and against) the Pauline view that Judaism enslaves one to the law while Christianity allows for freedom.⁷ Galit Hasan-Rokem similarly investigates the “intertextuality of Leviticus Rabbah with New Testament texts” by looking at co-appearing stories of women in exchange

1 James Dunn and John William Rogerson, *Eerdmans Commentary on the Bible* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2003), 3.

2 Daniel Boyarin, *The Jewish Gospels: The Story of the Jewish Christ* (New York: The New Press, 2013).

3 Amy-Jill Levine and Marc Zvi Brettler, *The Jewish Annotated New Testament 2nd Edition* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2017).

4 Adam H. Becker and Annette Yoshiko Reed, eds., *The Ways That Never Parted: Jews and Christians in Late Antiquity and the Early Middle Ages* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2007); see also Israel Yaakov Yuval, *Two Nations in Your Womb: Perceptions of Jews and Christians in Late Antiquity and the Middle Ages*, trans. Barbara Harshav and Jonathan Chipman (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008).

5 Elisheva Baumgarten, Ruth Mazo Karras, and Katelyn Mesler, eds., *Entangled Histories: Knowledge, Authority, and Jewish Culture in the Thirteenth Century* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2016).

6 Katharina Heyden and David Nirenberg, “Co-Produced Religions: Judaism, Christianity, and Islam,” *Harvard Theological Review* 118/1 (2025): 159-180, quote from 160-161.

7 *Ibid.*, 163-164.

with religious authorities.⁸ In these and other examples, faith traditions differ from and rework each other as they articulate their own positions.

In the modern era, Jewish interest in inter-theological inquiry has been more explicit even with the wariness of a historically oppressive Christianity. Nineteenth-century scholars such as Henrich Graetz, Samuel Hirsch, and Abraham Geiger in Germany, Claude Montefiore in the UK, and in the US with Felix Adler, Emil Hirsch, Kaufmann Kohler, and Isaac Mayer Wise were in part seeking to integrate Jewish communities into the surrounding societies and in part inaugurating serious engagement among modern philosophy, Jesus’ moral vision, and modern Judaism. Geiger and his contemporary Samuel Hirsch (*Die Religionsphilosophie der Juden*, *The Religious Philosophy of the Jews*), for instance, understood Judaism’s global dispersal through Hegel’s notion of Spirit working through world history. Geiger writes, Judaism “was itself to journey into the world with all its members according to the entire form of life which it had taken. The call of the spirit directing history went out to Judaism.”⁹ Monotheism and the moral code are the universal aspect of Judaism, which is tasked with bringing these universals to the world in engagement with it.

Geiger understood Christianity and Islam as heirs to this universal aspect. More unusually, Sigismund Stern held that, to engage others about these universal verities, Judaism should become a Jewish church—not in the sense of adopting Christian doctrine but in the sense of becoming an official corporate body with certain civil powers to contribute to society overall. “Judaism, therefore, must create its own church within which its own life can take shape and enter into the lives of states and nations that are the carriers of the present development. It must exit the fragmentation of its present existence and shape itself into a coherent, living and organic whole.”¹⁰ To be clear about what he means by “enter into the lives of states and nations,” Stern continues:

“there is no law for us that could prevent us from living and acting in the most intimate communion with our Christian brothers, no doctrine that might make us think of the work of those who profess a different faith as lesser than our own, no rule that demands of us to seclude or separate ourselves from the members of other religions (. . .). *Judaism should not just permit its adherents this activity but demand it as a religious duty.*”¹¹

8 Galit Hasan-Rokem, “Building the Gate, or Neighbors Make Good Fences,” in *Tales of the Neighborhood: Jewish Narrative Dialogues in Late Antiquity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2003), 55–85.

9 Abraham Geiger, *Judaism and Its History* (New York: Bloch Publishing Company, 1911), 212.

10 Samuel Kessler and George Kohler, *Modern Jewish Theology: The First One Hundred Years, 1835–1935* (Philadelphia: The Jewish Publication Society, 2023), 130, 131.

11 Kessler and Kohler, *Modern Jewish Theology*, 135–136, emphasis mine.

In the US, the 1885 Pittsburg Platform put it this way: “We recognize in every religion an attempt to grasp the infinite, and in every mode, source or book of revelation, held sacred in any religious system, the conscious indwelling of God in man.”¹² With this understanding of God working through all religions, the platform continues, “Christianity and Islam being daughter religions of Judaism, we appreciate their providential mission to aid in the spreading of monotheistic and moral truth . . . we *extend the hand of fellowship* to all who cooperate with us in the *establishment of the reign of truth and righteousness* among men.”¹³ Advancing the point at the 1893 World’s Parliament of Religions in Cincinnati, Emil Hirsch identified Judaism as one of the “three great religions” and declared that “race and nationality can not circumscribe the fellowship of the larger communion of the faithful, a communion destined to embrace in one covenant all the children of men.”¹⁴ Hirsch then links “the fellowship of the larger communion of the faithful” to the long tradition of Judaism since the rabbis: “The church universal must have the Pentecostal gift of the many flaming tongues in it, as the rabbis say was the case at Sinai”¹⁵ Infused by Judaism as by other religions, this communion “will then as now lift man above his weaknesses by reminding him of his responsibilities. The goal before us is Paradise.”¹⁶

These nineteenth-century efforts evince a Judaism drawing on its distinct resources in exchange, in “dialectic,” or in “entanglement” with its milieu, as Judaism has done throughout history. Scholarly works on these efforts include those by Paul Mendes-Flohr, Ruth HaCohen, Moshe Idel, and David Ruderman.¹⁷ Amir

12 Michael Meyer, and W. Gunther Plaut, eds., *The Reform Judaism Reader: Insights from the Central Conference of American Rabbis* (Philadelphia: The Jewish Publication Society, 2000), 198.

13 Ibid., 199, emphasis mine.

14 Emil G. Hirsch, “Elements of Universal Religion,” in *Judaism at the World’s Parliament of Religions* (Cincinnati: Union of American Hebrew Congregations, 1894), 386–390, quote from 386–387.

15 Indeed, the rabbis permit most prayers to be said in many languages (except Aramaic)-even those rabbis who prefer that certain prayers be said in Hebrew, see for instance, Maimonides, *Mishneh Torah*, *Hilchot Berachot* 1:6,

וכל הברכות בלשון נאמרו בכל לשון והוא שיאמר קעין שתקנו חכמים. ואם שנה את המטבע הואיל והקביר אפיקה ומלכות נענין הברכה אפילו בלשון חל יצא:

“All the blessings may be recited in any language, provided one recites [a translation of] the text ordained by the Sages. [A person who] changes that text fulfills his obligation nonetheless - since he mentioned God’s name, His sovereignty, and the subject of the blessing - although he did so in a ordinary language.”

16 Hirsch, “Elements of Universal Religion,” 388.

17 Ruth HaCohen, “Between Noise and Harmony: The Oratorical Moment in the Musical Entanglements of Jews and Christians,” *Critical Inquiry* 32/2 (2006): 250–277; Moshe Idel, “Transfers of Categories: The German-Jewish Experience and Beyond,” in *The German-Jewish Experience Revis-*

Engel writes that, while drawing on their respective resources, traditions productively “spill over the boundaries set by institutions to create more complex, less restricted worldviews.”¹⁸ This is a story not of siloed development but rather of distinct traditions in complex relation, give-and-take, and often co-constitution. In his study of such thinkers as Gershom Scholem, Ernst Mueller, Martin Buber, and Meir Wiener, Engel finds that their exploration of Kabbalah and Hasidism:

“(. . .) created a basis for thinking about a combined Jewish and Christian religiosity. They did so *knowingly*, using well-established cultural forms for their purposes. Judaism, Christianity, and German-language culture did not just influence each other; they also, at times, merged into greater, more complicated, and more capacious worldviews, encompassing elements from all three.”¹⁹

In his analysis, Engel describes the enrichment of traditions in exploration with others while Heyden and Nirenberg describe several oppositional encounters. However, in all, the exchange is inextricable from the evolution of Jewish thought and its methodology, if you will, and it has continued into the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. The English translation of Joseph Klausner’s *Jesus of Nazareth: His Life, Times, and Teaching* (first written in Hebrew) was published in 1925,²⁰ Samuel Sandmel’s *We Jews and Jesus: Exploring Theological Differences for Mutual Understanding*, in 1965.²¹ Stephen Wise, Susannah Heschel, *The Journal of Ecumenical Studies*, and edited volumes such as *Jesus through Jewish Eyes*²² and *The Jewish Annotated New Testament* have all furthered this exploration. We may add the work of Byron Sherwin, Shaul Magid, Daniel Matt, Irving Greenberg, and Zalman Schachter-Shalomi on the Jewish messianism of Jesus and on “the use

ited, eds., Steven E. Aschheim and Vivian Liska (Berlin: De Gruyter/Brill, 2015), 15–44; Paul Mendes-Flohr, *German Jews: A Dual Identity* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1999); David Ruderman, *Early Modern Jewry: A New Cultural History* (Princeton: Princeton University Press 2010).

18 Amir Engel, “Jewish–Christian Religiosity: A Study in Twentieth-Century Central European History,” *Modern Intellectual History* 20 (2023): 764–784, quote from 766.

19 Ibid, 767, emphasis mine.

20 Joseph Klausner, *Jesus of Nazareth: His Life, Times, and Teaching*, trans. Herbert Danby (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2020).

21 Samuel Sandmel, *We Jews and Jesus: Exploring Theological Differences for Mutual Understanding* (Woodstock, SkyLight VT: SkyLight Paths, 2006).

22 Beatrice Bruteau, ed., *Jesus through Jewish Eyes: Rabbis and Scholars Engage an Ancient Brother in a New Conversation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2001).

and adaptation of the Jewish mystical tradition as a template for the Jewish Jesus.²³ Martin Buber called Jesus “a great brother.”²⁴

Organizations like the Council on Centers of Jewish-Christian Relations have documented Jewish-Christian dialogue and collaboration since the end of the Second World War.²⁵ The Vatican’s 1965 *Nostra Aetate* was critical in fostering this dialogue, stating:

“Since the spiritual patrimony common to Christians and Jews is thus so great, this sacred synod wants to foster and recommend that mutual understanding and respect which is the fruit, above all, of biblical and theological studies as well as of fraternal dialogues (. . .) what happened in His passion cannot be charged against all the Jews, without distinction, then alive, nor against the Jews of today (. . .). Furthermore, in the rejection of every persecution against any man, the Church, mindful of the patrimony she shares with the Jews (. . .) decries hatred, persecutions, displays of anti-Semitism, directed against Jews at any time and by anyone.”²⁶

The Dabru Emet response, signed by over 220 rabbis and intellectuals from all branches of Judaism and published in *The New York Times* in 2000, furthered the possibility of interfaith dialogue in noting eight areas of commonality among Jews and Christians: (i) Jews and Christians worship the same God, (ii) Jews and Christians seek authority from the same book, (iii) Christians can respect the claim of the Jews on the land of Israel, (iv) Jews and Christians together accept the moral principles of the Pentateuch, (v) Nazism was not a Christian phenomenon, (vi) The humanly irreconcilable difference between Jews and Christians will not be settled until God redeems the entire world as promised in Scripture . . . Neither Jew nor Christian should be pressed into affirming the teaching of the other community, (vii) A new relationship between Jews and Christians will not

23 Shaul Magid, *American Post-Judaism: Identity and Renewal in a Postethnic Society* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2013), 148; see also, Irving (Yitz) Greenberg, *For the Sake of Heaven and Earth: The New Encounter Between Judaism and Christianity* (Philadelphia: The Jewish Publication Society, 2004); Daniel Matt, “Yeshua the Hasid,” in *Jesus through Jewish Eyes*, ed. Beatrice Bruteau (MaryKnoll: Orbis Books, 2001), 74–80; Zalman Schachter-Shalomi and Arthur Green, “Thinking through the Metaphors of Deep Ecumenicism: A Dialogue,” *Spectrum* 3/2 (Summer/Fall 2007); Byron Sherwin, “Who Do You Say That I Am (Mark 8:29): A New Jewish View of Jesus,” in *Jesus through Jewish Eyes*, ed. Beatrice Bruteau (MaryKnoll: Orbis Books, 2001), 31–44.

24 Martin Buber, *Two Types of Faith* (Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2003).

25 Council on Centers of Jewish-Christian Relations (1945-2020), <https://ccjr.us/> [Accessed: 31.08.2025].

26 The Holy See, “Declaration on the Relation of the Church to Non-Christians Religions, *Nostra Aetate*,” 28.10.1965 https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decl_19651028_nostra-aetate_en.html.

weaken Jewish practice, (viii) Jews and Christians must work together for justice and peace.²⁷

Among the many Protestant contributions to interfaith and inter-theological collaboration is A Response to Dabru Emet (2003), by the European Lutheran Commission on the Church and the Jewish People (Lutherische Europäische Kommission Kirche und Judentum, LEKKJ) an umbrella organization of twenty-five European Lutheran church bodies:

“In its Driebergen Declaration (1991), the European Lutheran Commission on the Church and the Jewish People (. . .) rejected the traditional Christian “teaching of contempt” towards Jews and Judaism, and in particular, the anti-Jewish writings of Martin Luther, and it called for the reformation of church practice in the light of these insights. Against this background, LEKKJ welcomes the issuance of Dabru Emet: A Jewish Statement on Christians and Christianity. We see in this statement a confirmation of our own work of these past years (. . .). We know that we must reexamine themes in Lutheran theology that in the past have repeatedly given rise to enmity towards Jews (. . .). Fully aware that *Dabru Emet* is in the first instance an intra-Jewish invitation to conversation, we see in this statement also an aid to us in expressing and living out our faith in such a way that we do not denigrate Jews, but rather respect them in their otherness, and are enabled to give an account of our own identity more clearly as we scrutinize it in the light of how others see us.”²⁸

A 2015 assessment of *Nostra Aetate*’s outcomes, composed by the Anti-Defamation League, a non-profit that monitors and documents anti-Semitic incidents, further states that,

In the past 50 years, the Church has continued the process that began with *Nostra Aetate*. It has developed a sophisticated theology of Jews and Judaism expressed in documents like “We Remember: A Reflection on the Shoah” (1998) and “The Jewish People and the Sacred Scriptures in the Christian Bible” (2001). Another important moment was the Vatican’s recognition of the state of Israel and the establishment of diplomatic relations in 1993 (. . .).

The commitment of both Jews and Catholics to overcoming the past, and especially the warm personal relationships that have developed at the highest levels as well as locally, have made constructive engagement and honest exchange possible, even about difficult subjects. The relationship is strong enough that it has continued despite unresolved issues, such as the opening of the Vatican archives from the Second World War and the proposed canon-

27 Institute for Christian & Jewish Studies, Baltimore, Maryland, “Dabru Emet: A Jewish Statement on Christians and Christianity,” Council on Centers of Jewish-Christian Relations, 10.09.2000 <https://ccjr.us/dialogika-resources/documents-and-statements/jewish/dabru-emet>.

28 Council on Centers of Jewish-Christian Relations (1945-2020), “Section on European Protestantism,” 12.05.2003 <https://ccjr.us/dialogika-resources/documents-and-statements/protestant-churches/eur/lekkj03may12>.

ization of Pius XII (. . .). The friendship of Pope Francis with Rabbi Abraham Skorka is itself one of the fruits of *Nostra Aetate* and a model for Jews and Catholics around the world.²⁹

One can hope for more in this direction. Yet less frequent to date is joint research where scholars from different traditions work together to explore theology, understandings of *theos*, *cosmos*, *anthropos*, and their relations. That is, for inter-theological work *done inter-religiously*. Also less frequent is work that explores a particular theological concept by drawing on ideas and texts from various traditions. Scholars such as Shaul Magid feel the need to call for such exploration precisely because it remains on the edges of theological inquiry and intermittent in endeavor.

3 A Challenge to Inter-Theological Inquiry

An important challenge to inter-theological inquiry is highlighted in a presentation by Konrad Schmid on the history of Hebrew Bible scholarship in Europe from the late nineteenth century to the present. Schmid looks at why—given the consistent focus on philology and on comparative mythology, religion, and legal codes—radically different accounts nonetheless emerged of the Hebrew Bible’s meaning and value. Schmid finds that the differences emerged not from technical scholarship but from historical and cultural factors, specifically the influence of rising anti-Semitism on the scientists of fin de siècle Europe. The prejudicial climate shaped their application of even scholarly tools to arrive at predictably negative judgments of the Hebrew Bible.

Self-reflexivity regarding the influence of culture on science is now part of the research playbook. Yet this self-reflexivity must also humbly assume that, at times, culture informs research in ways that are no more visible to today’s scientists than the influence of anti-Semitism was on those a century and more ago. This holds, Schmid notes, when one thinks one is positing a radical break with the methodologies of the past. The erudition of late nineteenth century scholars as accomplished as Wellhausen, Harnack, and others was cutting-edge. Yet, Schmid writes, in their investigations of the documentary hypothesis, their dating of the “P” source, and much else, “cultural, historical, social and religious factors

²⁹ Jonathan Greenblatt, “How *Nostra Aetate* Transformed Catholic-Jewish Relations,” The Jewish Anti-Defamation League, 27.10.2015
<https://www.adl.org/resources/news/how-nostra-aetate-transformed-catholic-jewish-relations#:~:text=In%20its%20fourth%20chapter%2C%20Nostra%20Aetate%20effectively,rejected%20by%20God%20and%20their%20covenant%20revoked.>

influence the current analysis and interpretation of historical literary documents."³⁰

There is always much to which state-of-the-art science is blind in part because, as Donald Rumsfeld, George W. Bush's Secretary of Defense, famously said, there are knowns, there are known unknowns, and there are unknown unknowns.³¹ In the last case, one doesn't know that there are extant somethings out there yet to be known. One doesn't recognize, for instance, that a theological or sociological assumption is coloring hypothesis-making, data collection, or interpretation. One doesn't know that the assumption exists and so one cannot grapple with it.

This unavoidable blind spot might sound like a call for research protocols that guard against bias. In part it is, as such protocols are essential in limiting the influence of cultural assumptions on research. Yet much bias and assumption-influence occur upstream of protocols, in the background *Denkstil*³² that is always already in place as protocols are established. One may think of the now classic example of birth control research that had excellent protocols but which assumed the female body as its object. The idea of tampering with the male body and virility did not for many decades come onto the screen of fertility science. Research protocols work against the corruption of discovery by unconscious assumption but do not always address the cases where one cannot pre-empt what one cannot see. One cannot guard against unknown unknowns.

Yet limiting such corruption of method is of prime importance to research overall and to the sensitive arena of doing inter-theological research inter-religiously. This chapter looks at a few considerations not only for keeping our individual work honest but specifically for this sort of inquiry. In *American Post-Judaism*, Shaul Magid seeks a post-exclusionary metaphysics, where religious/faith traditions, most specifically Christianity and Judaism, do not respectfully tolerate each other but explore and work with each other's concepts. He describes a

³⁰ Konrad Schmid, "The Exegesis of the Pentateuch between Judaism and Christianity: From Julius Wellhausen to Baruch Schwartz and Beyond," *Transformation of Traditions through Interreligious Encounters: Inaugural Conference of the Berlin Interdisciplinary Center "Traditions in Transformation,"* (Berlin, Humboldt-University, June 23–25, 2024).

³¹ Donald Rumsfeld, "DoD News Briefing - Secretary Rumsfeld and Gen. Myers," US Department of Defense, 12.02.2002 <https://web.archive.org/web/20160406235718/http://archive.defense.gov/Transcripts/Transcript.aspx?TranscriptID=2636> [Accessed: 31.08.2025].

³² Ludwik Fleck, *Entstehung und Entwicklung einer wissenschaftlichen Tatsache: Einführung in die Lehre vom Denkstil und Denkkollektiv* (Berlin: Surkamp, 1935); Ludwik Fleck, *The Genesis and Development of a Scientific Fact: An Introduction to the Theory of Thought Style and Thought Collective*, trans. Fred Bradley, Thaddeus J. Trenn and Robert K. Merton (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1979).

“transition from pluralism (as merely tolerance) to multiculturalism, combined with the normalization of hybridity in which diversity is celebrated and not simply tolerated, and constructed ethnic identities are considered normative.”³³

What follows is a look at an approach or orientation for such post-boundaried, inter-theological exploration that may offer guardrails against the always-already occupation of research protocols by “upstream” religio-cultural assumptions.

4 Human Relationality as Distinction-amid-Relation: A Research Project

Several years ago, I had an opportunity to work on an inter-theological project on relationality, drawing from Christian and Jewish traditions—a challenging task owing to the historical terrain. Even if one does not accede to Richard Rubenstein’s Christian determinism and its unavoidable anti-Judaistic outworkings,³⁴ the empirical record predicts an uphill climb.

The central topic of inquiry was the role of relationality in human nature. Of what does it consist; is it foundational or does it develop, and if it develops, under what conditions? Is human relationality robust, fragile, in conflict with other aspects of human nature? Among whom are the relevant relations and are they mutually supportive or in tension?

The understanding of relationality developed in this project works from the idea of distinction-amid-relation.³⁵ That is, there could be nothing, but there’s something. No “something” can cause itself into existence, and since things exist, there thus must be a ground for their presence. That ground is what some people call God. Franz Rosenzweig called it “the eventfulness of the limitless possibilities that will come to exist, the not-nothing that is the ‘divine essence in all infinity’ prior to there being a distinct something or a distinct nothing.”³⁶ After the kabbal-

³³ Magid, *American Post-Judaism*, 22.

³⁴ In brief summary: Rubenstein describes what he believes is the enduring Christian view of Judaism: (i) God established a special covenantal relationship with the Israelites, who (ii) tragically and wrongly rejected God’s new covenant in Jesus and who instead (iii) killed the incarnate God, and so (iv) they are deserving of God’s punishment, see, Richard Rubenstein, *After Auschwitz* (Baltimore: The John Hopkins University Press, 1992), part I, chs. 1, 2, notably 11–12, 13, 24.

³⁵ Marcia Pally, *Commonwealth and Covenant: Economics, Politics, and Theologies of Relationality* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2016), 37.

³⁶ Cited in Elliot R. Wolfson, *Giving Beyond the Gift: Apophasis and Overcoming Theomania* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2014), 79.

ist principle of Eyn Sof, this ground is not so much what precedes effects as what is realized as it yields effects. Existence is God’s self-expression. In the poetic words of Genesis: God breathed *nishmat cha’im* (the spirit of life) into Adam and so into all persons (נִשְׁמַת חַיִּים Gen. 2:7)

On one hand, each existing particular is radically different from the transcendent God—differences in materiality/immateriality, finitude/infinity, etc. Yet on the other, each particular is of this source in order to exist. Poetically, this is expressed in the imago/*b’tselem Elohim*. Persons are radically different from the incorporeal, imageless God; there is no divine physiognomy for humanity to be like. Yet nonetheless, in existing at all, we are of the divine *imageless* “image.” In Aquinas’s words, “in all things God works intimately.”³⁷ Martin Buber reprises, “God is the ‘wholly Other,’ but He is also wholly Same . . . He is also the mystery of the self-evident, nearer to me than my ‘I.’”³⁸ God is that mysterious relation with another that is radically different yet so intimate that it is nearer to me than myself because it is the cause of myself.

In short, radical difference or distinction from the transcendent God *yet* foundational relation is the way anything comes to be. The structure of existence is distinction-amid-relation. We may say that relationship-among-different-beings is a technology for existence. As distinction-amid-relation is the structure of existing, persons are also distinct from each other yet in necessary relation. Each distinct person is who she is through the layers and networks of relations that form her. No infant develops alone. John Zizioulas writes, “The person cannot be conceived in itself as a static entity, but only as it *relates to* . . . [it is] in communion that this being is *itself* and thus *is at all*.”³⁹ Or in Elisabeth Moltmann-Wendel’s elegant words, “Life begins as life together.”⁴⁰

This ontology or technology for existence is not a balance between distinction on one hand and relationship on the other. It is reciprocal constitution. Each unique person emerges through her relations, and in turn, those relations are constituted by her distinct influence. Existence is a case neither of univocity, the sameness of all particulars, as each is unique. Nor is it a case of equivocity, a difference among particulars so thorough that relation is impossible. Rather, exis-

37 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, trans. Fathers of the Dominican English Province, vols. 1–5 (Westminster: Christian Classics, 1948; original 1265–1274), Ia, q. 105, art. 5.

38 Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, trans. Ronald G. Smith (New York: Charles Scribner’s, 1958), 79.

39 John Zizioulas, “Human Capacity and Incapacity: A Theological Exploration of Personhood,” *Scottish Journal of Theology* 28 (1975): 401–448, quote from 409.

40 Elisabeth Moltmann-Wendel, *I Am My Body: A Theology of Embodiment* (New York: Continuum, 1995), 43.

tence is metaxalogical, “being between,” allowing for differences within relationality and for relation that allows for difference.

In sum, the DNA of existence is a double helix of relations between each person and God *and* among persons. As there are no persons without these relations, there is no flourishing, no *summum bonum*, without caring for them. Relations may be proximate or through our paths of global connectedness, as our educational and economic opportunities, nutrition, health care, etc. are formed by those who are not necessarily nearby.

This brief sketch of distinction-amid-relation is not meant as a detailed investigation of ontology or ethics but rather as a description of the project through which an approach or orientation for inter-theological study emerged.

5 Reciprocal Illumination: A Quasi-Midrashic Approach to Inter-Theological Inquiry—or Continuing Jewish Epistemology

5.1 Preliminary Remarks

To move forward in the work on distinction-amid-relation, an approach was sought that builds on the cultural exchange, debate, “co-production,” and “entanglement” of long Jewish experience as these approaches themselves acknowledge ontological relationality. For if all extants are distinct amid relation, our ideation and research too are distinct amid relation. They are thought emerging in complex, mediated relation to other thought and life circumstances, including ideas from multiple faith traditions. While all ideas are in complex ways in relation, however extended, Judaism and Christianity are ideationally proximate as Boyarin, Klausner, Buber, Heyden and Nirenberg, S. Heschel among other have noted. Thus, the project sought to explore human relationality by drawing on these two traditions, distinct yet brought together to illuminate a common theme. This is not the Mendelssohnian idea that there exists, besides Judaism, a “universal religion,” with such tenets as the existence of an infinite, immaterial one God, creator, omniscient, omnipotent, and in communication with humanity.⁴¹ Nor is it Emil Hirsch’s exploration of a (universal) World Religion.⁴²

⁴¹ Moses Mendelssohn, *Jerusalem or on Religious Power and Judaism*, trans. Allan Arkush (Lebanon: Brandeis University Press, 1983).

⁴² Hirsch, “Elements of Universal Religion,” 386–390.

Rather, the tenets of Judaism and Christianity *in their particularity* were brought to bear on the concept of relationality.

The approach that emerged was one of reciprocal illumination, where each tradition's ideas about *theos*, *cosmos*, *anthropos*, and their relations enrich the common topic of relationality without any tradition assimilating to another. Light comes from many quarters. This approach, it seemed, bears faint echoes to the methodology of midrash, rabbinic explication of a source text by drawing on several other scriptural texts or proof texts. This is yet another way in which this project follows Jewish tradition and epistemology. Proof texts do not necessarily remark directly on each other but rather help interpret the source passage. Light on the source text comes from many proof text quarters. "The idiom and idea of this verse," Judah Goldin explains, "are made concrete and are illuminated by a number of verses in other parts of Scripture."⁴³ Proof texts achieve their impact by a number of means. One is accumulation, where each proof text alone is of modest interest but together, they create a substantial point. Listing the divine wonders of the exodus from Egypt would be one example. Another midrashic method is juxtaposition, where bringing together proof texts with opposing views moves the understanding of the source text to a more nuanced level.

Reciprocal illumination is not classic midrash, so one may informally and somewhat tongue-in-cheek call it quasi-midrashic. A key difference is that midrash may accumulate proof texts into a new, independent text that interprets the source. Boyarin writes, "The verses of the Bible function for the rabbis much as do words in ordinary speech. They are a repertoire of semiotic elements that can be recombined into new discourse, just as words are recombined constantly into new discourse . . . the fundamental moment of all of these midrashic forms is precisely the very co-citation of several verses."⁴⁴ In reciprocal illumination, the ideas, narratives, imagery, etc. from each tradition are not semiotic units to be combined as words are combined into sentences. Rather, they remain distinct and intact, situated in their traditions and illuminating relationality from their respective perches.

A second way in which reciprocal illumination differs from classic midrash is that midrash allows itself to attribute to proof texts meaning that was not in the original context. Reciprocal illumination does not. To explicate the source text, midrash may change the punctuation or simply omit words of a proof text to

⁴³ Judah Goldin, *The Song at the Sea* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1971), 124.

⁴⁴ Daniel Boyarin, "Reciting the Torah: The Function of Quotation in the Midrash," in *Intertextuality and the Reading of Midrash* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1990), 22–28, quote at 28, 29.

achieve the intended interpretation of the source passage.⁴⁵ Boyarin understands these and other midrashic techniques as a tool kit with which to keep Jewish thought and texts relevant under the drastically new circumstances after the destruction of the Second Temple. He writes,

“The rabbis, faced with the disruption of their times . . . and with the necessity of appropriating Scripture for their times, found in the creation of an explicitly and pervasively intertextual literature the ideal generative and reconstructive tool, which preserved the privileged position of the biblical text by releasing it from its position of immobilized totality.”⁴⁶

However helpful to premodern Jewish exegetes, this technique is not in the tool kit of reciprocal illumination, where the source text meaning remains intact.

In this project, false starts and unproductive rabbit holes were many. Below is a brief summary of the upstream orientation or ways of thinking that we found allowed for Jewish-Christian reciprocal illumination of the concept of human relationality.

5.2 The Heterogeneity of Experience

The German-Jewish philosopher Joseph Soloveitchik notes that all particulars are iterations of the possible. As these particulars are plural and varied, each person experiences different ones and so has a different “version” of the world. As each person’s account of world differs from others, the condition of human inquiry is one of “teleological heterogeneity” and “pluralism.” Such heterogeneity, Soloveitchik writes, is “founded on reality itself.”⁴⁷ Paul Ricœur echoes in his theory of language. The plurality of languages and the need for explanation even among users of a common language evince, for Ricœur, our plural and varied understandings of world.⁴⁸ Honing in specifically on religious heterogeneity, John Thatamanil notes that diversity and multiplicity are present not only among religions but within them.

⁴⁵ In Sifre Numbers 42, for example, Judges 6:24 is cited in support of the idea that *God’s name* is peace, a meaning achieved by changing the punctuation from the original, where it is an *altar* that is named God-peace. More dramatically, the same Sifre midrash quotes Isaiah 45:7 to say that God is one “Who creates light and forms darkness and makes peace,”—a meaning achieved by excising from the Isaiah the words “I [God] make peace *and create woe*.”

⁴⁶ Boyarin, “Reciting the Torah,” 38; see also, Elizabeth Shanks Alexander, “The Orality of Rabbinic Writing,” in *The Cambridge Companion to The Talmud and Rabbinic Literature*, eds. Charlotte Elisheva Fonrobert and Martin Jaffee (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 38–57, especially 44–45.

⁴⁷ Joseph B. Soloveitchik, *The Halakhic Mind* (New York: Free Press, 1986), 16.

⁴⁸ Paul Ricœur, *On Translation*, trans. Eileen Brennan (London: Routledge, 2006).

“No religion,” Thatamanil writes, “is a monolith but is instead a terrain marked by robust internal contestation (. . .). Religious traditions are communities of argumentation, arguments that, in some cases, have lasted for more than two millennia.”⁴⁹

The heterogeneity of experience is an assumption of the natural sciences as well. When Niels Bohr observed discontinuities in matter and energy—i.e., quantum packets rather than continuous streams of matter/energy—he understood that his observation was in fact not observable. He was working not from empirical evidence but from traces of the unperceivable within what he perceived. As what actually exists cannot be directly detected, physics relies on multiple accounts of the traces. In short, on heterogeneity of experience and interpretation. This, Bohr wrote, is the sort of effort that thinkers in religious traditions make. They try to get at what cannot be seen or “proved”—the existence of God, for instance—from what can be perceived and understood in the natural world. “A whole new background,” Bohr wrote, “for the relationship between scientific research and religious attitude has been created by the modern development of physics (. . .) it will be attempted to show the development in our time has forced us [scientists] to look into epistemological problems of a kind which recalls the common problems of the religions.”⁵⁰

The understanding of experience as heterogeneous brings us to the second aspect of our orientation for inter-theological study.

5.3 Epistemological Humility

Given the multiplicity of experience and teleological heterogeneity, all arenas of human knowledge are limited. Truth may be truth, but the human episteme is limited and incomplete. Thus, in addition to experiential variation, epistemological humility is an unavoidable condition of reciprocal illumination, recognition both of one’s limited access to truth and of the access that others have.

Incompletion is not free-fall relativism. On one hand, not knowing all truth does not mean that no aspects of truth are known or knowable, or that all ideas have equal claims to truth. Investigations are subject to the highest standards of repeatability, validity, reliability, and error correction. On the other hand, science does in fact err, however rigorous the effort at accuracy. Eighteenth century sci-

⁴⁹ John J. Thatamanil, *Circling the Elephant: A Comparative Theology of Religious Diversity* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2020), 76.

⁵⁰ Notes dated August 26 and 27, 1953; MSS: 20 in the Niels Bohr Archive, cited in John Honner, “Unity-in-Difference: Karl Rahner and Niels Bohr,” *Theological Studies* 46/3 (1985): 480–506, quote from 499.

entists were confident in their belief that combustion was caused by the release of phlogiston, ostensibly a chemical contained in all substances—until Antoine Lavoisier debunked the idea and demonstrated the role of oxygen in combustion.⁵¹

In short, appreciation of epistemological limitation is necessary in the physical sciences even with their empirical measurability, probability calculations, and traces. It is a requirement perhaps more so in endeavors that raise, again Bohr, the “epistemological problems of a kind which recalls the common problems of the religions.”⁵² As Glen Stassen writes, “nor am I arguing for only one tradition as having all truth; all traditions need continuous correction.”⁵³ Colin Gunton similarly notes, if in being human Jesus was fallible, churches run by human beings cannot be otherwise.⁵⁴ And it is a premise and structure of Jewish study since the rabbinic period that one inches towards knowledge through debate, considering minor and dissenting views, with decisions understood to be provisional to the next level of argument. This is both a principle and the history of the production of Jewish thought. As David Kraemer explains, interpretation of tradition and sacred texts “was (and remains) a profoundly human activity (. . .). Humans are, by definition, imperfect; it is this that distinguishes them from God. Human interpretations must also, therefore, be imperfect, and even, on frequent occasions perhaps, wrong.”⁵⁵ Thus, the third feature of our orientation for inter-theological scholarship is:

5.4 Appreciation of Studying Broadly

That is, it is not only interesting to read in other traditions; it is necessary for a solid grasp of any phenomenon and for critical reflection on one’s own interpretive framework. Thinkers from different faith traditions may begin from various

51 Anton Lavoisier, *Traité élémentaire de chimie* (Paris: Chez Cuchet, 1789); see also, Anton Lavoisier, *Elements of Chemistry*, a facsimile reprint of the original 1790 English translation by Robert Kerr (Garden City: Dover Publishing, 1984).

52 Notes dated August 26 and 27, 1953; MSS: 20 in the Niels Bohr Archive, cited in Honner, “Unity-in-Difference,” 499.

53 Glen Stassen, *A Thicker Jesus: Incarnational Discipleship in a Secular Age* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2012), 14; see also, Stanley Hauerwas, *The Peaceable Kingdom: A Primer in Christian Ethics* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1983), 101.

54 Colin Gunton, “The Church on Earth: The Roots of Community,” in *On Being the Church: Essays on the Christian Community*, eds. Colin E. Gunton and Daniel Hardy (London: T. & T. Clark, 1993), 48–80, quote from 61.

55 David Kraemer, *The Mind of the Talmud: An Intellectual History of the Bavli* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1990), 121.

starting points and genealogies. Their work may not map onto each other. They will surely display aporia and may not be "in conversation." Yet the benefit of deep engagement with various traditions is great. "It is of the essence of what we mean when we speak of something as being biblical in character," Yoram Hazony writes, "that it presents its truth by means of a diversity of views."⁵⁶ Or as Richard Kearney puts it, "If divinity is unknowable, humanity must imagine it in many ways. The absolute requires pluralism to avoid absolutism."⁵⁷ The Catholic theologian Bernard Lonergan makes this point in *Method in Theology*,⁵⁸ as does his interpreter Robert Doran: "Anyone engaging in direct theological discourse must always be engaged as well in a continual *ressourcement*," involving critique within the faith community and exchange with those outside it. "The church itself," Doran continues, "in its concrete practice will always stand under the judgment both from within and from without of women and men of intellectual, moral, religious, and affective integrity."⁵⁹

This holds not only for Doran's theology but for Wellhausen's biblical exegesis. Terence Fretheim suggests that the "advances and regressions" of sacred texts, including philological and narrative inconsistencies, "are a plus and are revealing of a complex understanding of the development of law within the canonical shape of things."⁶⁰ Understanding the circumstances that brought about these textual inconsistencies requires Doran's "continual *ressourcement*" within and across disciplines and traditions. As Thatamanil writes, "any pluralism that imagines religious traditions flourishing (or even existing) apart from mutual encounter and transformation is mistaken because it indulges in ahistorical fiction. Our traditions have always needed each other and always will."⁶¹

56 Yoram Hazony, *The Philosophy of Hebrew Scripture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), 227.

57 Richard Kearney, *Anatheism: Returning to God after God* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2009), Preface. Writing even about orthodoxy, Graham Ward notes that our knowledge of world and God comes from our texts of revelation understood on "the basis of faith." Faith "is a courageous groping towards promises in Christ that may or may not have been understood." It is "an endless formulation and reformulation," an "ongoing set of interrelated activities," and a "process" completed "only when time and creation itself come to their completion . . . When it stops being a process of discernment and it starts being an ideology then orthodoxy is reified; and reification is always possible and, when it occurs, always dangerous." Graham Ward, "Receiving the Gift," *Modern Theology* 30/3 (2014): 84.

58 Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2000), 267.

59 Robert M. Doran, *What Is Systematic Theology?* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005), 198–199.

60 Terence E. Fretheim, *God and World in the Old Testament: A Relational Theology of Creation* (Nashville: Abingdon, 2005), 152.

61 Thatamanil, *Circling the Elephant*, 65.

In sum, exegetical and theological ideas evolve with continued, broad exploration. The effort makes them not less reliable but more so as they are pondered and tested over centuries by people in varying circumstances, as they confront the best and worst of human conduct, and as they take into account accumulated and new knowledge. The accumulation, critique, and comparison across multiple sources is how humanity gets at what there is. The benefit of studying varied traditions emerges from the heterogeneity of experience, epistemological humility, and from the fourth feature of our orientation:

5.5 The Simultaneity of Theological Validity or Suspension of Imposing Judgment

There is less to be learned from studying with the *a priori* intention of refuting unfamiliar ideas than from studying with an openness to them. Refutation was the purpose of medieval, church-mandated disputations between rabbis and Christian theologians, where church officials unsurprisingly judged Christian theologians to be the “winners” and little was learned by anyone. To engage in productive inter-theological study, not only is interest in various notions of *theos*, *cosmos*, and *anthropos* important (see, above) but also a suspension of imposing judgment in favor of one notion or the other.

That is, believing one set of ideas to be true does not exempt those ideas from illumination by other traditions. True ideas may also be illuminated by many sources. Further, the suspension of imposed judgment moves beyond tolerance, when faith traditions remain distant but mostly disinterested, and allows for the co-development and co-elaboration of concepts. Irving Greenberg argues that it is ironically an outworking of the Holocaust that Jewish and Christian thinkers reach beyond tolerance to engage each other’s theological tenets: “After the Holocaust, a model of the relationship of Judaism and Christianity ideally should enable one to affirm the fullness of the faith-claims of the other, not just offer tolerance.”⁶² Moreover, inter-theological study—believing one tradition to be true while studying others—does not void or alter the claims of either tradition. Multiple ideas may be on the screen at the same time, so to speak, revealing repetition or reappearance, affinity, contrast, aporia, etc.

Importantly, while affinities do not erase differences, differences need not be erased for affinities to remain noteworthy. David Bentley Hart notes, “It may be that one faith is truer than any other, or contains that ultimate truth to which all

⁶² Greenberg, *For the Sake of Heaven and Earth*, 146.

faiths aspire in their various ways; but that still would hardly reduce all other religions to mere falsehood.”⁶³ The illumination of true ideas by a variety of sources, the suspension of imposed judgment, and the possibility of simultaneous validity imply a fifth and final feature of reciprocal illumination:

5.6 A Bracketing of Syncretism

Wide-ranging study does not require that faith traditions (or personal beliefs) assimilate into something syncretic with other traditions. Some contemporary thinkers are indeed interested in this sort of syncretic exploration. In Jewish thought, that would include Zalman Schachter-Shalomi, Daniel Matt, Magid, and others, who are exploring the inclusion of Jesus in a kabbalist-hasidic pietism, for instance. Magid writes, “The kind of overt syncretistic experimentation, here represented in a Jewish Christology from a ‘kabbalistic-hasidic’ perspective steps outside the normative boundaries of inherited Judaism.”⁶⁴ Yet this fertile terrain is only one approach to inter-theological work. Much co-plumbing occurs with syncretism bracketed. Ephraim Meir, in his work on “Interreligious or dialogical theology,” writes that this sort of inquiry does not assimilate or combine traditions but rather:

“(. . .) creates bridges. Interreligious theology is the intellectual account of interreligious and intercultural meetings and discusses a multiplicity of aspects in “trans-difference.” The uniqueness of one’s religion does not prevent the lofty possibility of communication. If I am not opening myself up to the other’s understanding of the Ultimate, I may miss an aspect of religiosity that is relevant to my own religious life . . . To be in interreligious dialogue is first of all to be there for the other in non-indifference.”⁶⁵

Inter-theological work that exemplifies this five-part orientation includes Wonhee Anne Joh’s “Christology of *Jeong*,”⁶⁶ which looks at tenets and practices from both the Christian and Korean traditions. Raymond Aldred looks at the Christian Trinity alongside the American aboriginal people’s trinity of land, people, and spirit. “Consider,” Aldred writes, “that the primary categories of relationships for

⁶³ David B. Hart, *The Experience of God: Being, Consciousness, Bliss* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013), 4.

⁶⁴ Magid, *American Post-Judaism*, 156.

⁶⁵ Ephraim Meir, “Levinas’s Approach to the Other in Its Relevance for Interreligious Theology,” lecture at Humboldt University, Theological Faculty, 09.07.2015; see also, Ephraim Meir, *Interreligious Theology: Its Value and Mooring in Modern Jewish Philosophy* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2015).

⁶⁶ Wonhee Anne Joh, *The Heart of the Cross: A Postcolonial Christology* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2006), 20–26; ch. 5.

the First Peoples of North America include relationship with land or creation, relationship with people, individuals and other groups, and the relationship with the spiritual.”⁶⁷ Vajrayana Buddhism too posits a trinity of sorts in its idea of the specific self, one’s eternal spirit, and one’s bonds to others and nature.⁶⁸ None of these inter-theological explorations assimilates traditions to each other or creates a syncretic third. Rather, ideas are explored with their differences and affinities for enrichment of each other or of a common theme.

6 John Thatamanil’s Methodology for a “Theology of Religious Diversity”

In his book *Circling the Elephant*, Thatamanil develops a companion methodology for a “theology of religious diversity” (TRD).⁶⁹ As with our process of reciprocal illumination, he sought a set of commitments upstream of research protocols themselves. He asks: how do we need to think in order to draw from more than one wisdom tradition? His four criteria are:

- (i) Difference without incommensurability, where “traditions are different enough that we have something new to learn from them, but not so different as to be incommensurable.”⁷⁰ Echoing the premise of distinction-amid-relation, Thatamanil suggests that faith traditions offer their singular wisdom in ways that bear on our common condition. Faith traditions are themselves distinct amid relation, and one may learn from more than one tradition, its beliefs and practices. Thus:
- (ii) One has something to learn from traditions other than one’s own without trying to “solve” those traditions, to make them into something more compatible with one’s “home” belief. This is Thatamanil’s echo to epistemological humility and bracketing imposed judgment. He describes “a theory of religious diversity that welcomes the hospitable reception of wisdom and the ongoing mutual transformation of traditions. If a TRD offers reasons for and commends interreligious learning, then other traditions may become more than

67 Raymond C. Aldred, “Freedom,” in *Prophetic Evangelicals: Envisioning a Just and Peaceable Kingdom*, eds. Bruce E. Benson, Malinda E. Berry and Peter Heltzel (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2012), 150–167; 152–153.

68 Vajrayana Buddhism contrasts with the more monastic Buddhist traditions, in which one may disengage from worldly attachments and a focus on life on earth.

69 Thatamanil, *Circling the Elephant*, 67–68.

70 Ibid.

stubborn facts to which I must be reluctantly reconciled or soteriological problems I must resolve."⁷¹ For Thatamanil, this implies that:

- (iii) We are "intrinsically" interested in other traditions because:
- (iv) At least some aspects of their beliefs we recognize as having merit—echoing simultaneity of interest or validity, above. "The question is not just, 'Can the Buddhist help me be a better Christian?' but instead, 'Can I desire to know what Buddhists know as they come to know it?'"⁷² without trying to change it or to change Christianity.

7 Wellhausen Reprised

Wellhausen and his colleagues conducted precise, philological analyses of the Hebrew Bible and from this brilliant, exacting methodology concluded, as Schmid and others have noted, that Judaism was an exacting, legalistic faith. This is the pathetic fallacy with an exclamation point. Had they been working from the reciprocal illumination discussed above, they might have been curious as to how other interpreters understood the Bible and about the life forms that emerge from those interpretations. They might have studied with Catholic and Islamic scholars or with Jewish ones in Berlin's Hochschule für die Wissenschaft des Judentums (founded in 1870), in the Breslau "Jüdisch-theologisches Seminar" (1854-1938), in the "Rabbinerseminar" (Budapest, founded 1877), or in the "Israelitisch-Theologische Lehranstalt" in Vienna (1893-1938). Or they might have consulted more traditional rabbinic circles, which would have opened up a rich interpretive world that had supported Jewish communities, philosophical investigation, and ways of life for millennia.

Such consultation might have suggested that Jewish interpretive traditions, from the rabbinic through the modern era, have merit both in themselves and as illumination for Wellhausen's own research. That is, for his understanding: of Jewish-Christian difference without incommensurability; of the multiplicity of experience and interpretation; of possible reciprocal illumination without assimilation or syncretism; of possible joint illumination of a common theme; and of epistemological humility. In a non-sectarian example of reciprocal illumination in the country where Wellhausen spent his career, since 2007 Rabbi Professor Dr. Tsvi Blanchard has taught Jewish law not in a Jewish or Religious Studies Department but in the Law Faculty at Humboldt University. The point is not to have German

⁷¹ Ibid., 67.

⁷² Ibid., 68–69.

law adopt Talmudic statutes but rather mutual enrichment: how can the premises and methods of rabbinic and modern law illuminate each other and the cultural assumptions, norms, and values in which they are situated?

Wellhausen et al. did not engage in such study because, as noted in the Schmid presentation discussed above, they thought Judaism primitive. That is, it was not part of their scholarly orientation to see that their rejection of Jewish perspectives *allowed* them to think Judaism primitive.

Wellhausen's error was the sort that David Burrell describes in his long study of cross-fertilization in the Abrahamic traditions. Burrell notes that studying a variety of traditions allows one to identify flaws in one's own—if not in their ideals, then in their humanly imperfect or self-interested iterations. Burrell writes, "the presence of other believers can help the faithful in each tradition to gain insight into the distortions of that tradition: the ways it has compromised with the seductions of state power, or ways in which fixation on a particular other effectively skewed their understanding of the revelation given them."⁷³ Wellhausen's anti-Judaism is a case in point.

That it did not occur to Wellhausen et al. to study the Hebrew Bible from perspectives other than their own was an error not entirely of their own making. As Shulamit Volkov notes, both the low-level uneasiness about Jews as well as overt anti-Semitism—aggravated by the destabilization and new urban poverty of industrialization and the recession of the 1870s—had become a broadly embraced "cultural code." The writings of Otto Glagau, Heinrich von Treitschke, Wilhelm Marr, and others made "an unsatisfactory [socio-economic] situation" "comprehensible"⁷⁴ by providing Germans with a culturally familiar "other" that was ostensibly responsible for the nation's socio-economic woes. The "solution" of targeting the longstanding Jewish scapegoat was understandable, ready-to-hand, doable, and emotionally satisfying. That it was wrong—that persecuting Jews would not address the economic, geo-political, and technological factors bearing on *fin de siècle* economic instability—held little sway against the power of a culturally familiar prejudice.

Intellectuals were not immune to the *Denkstil* of the day. Treitschke in the 1860s had opposed anti-Jewish prejudice but with the conservative turn of 1878/

⁷³ David Burrell, *Towards a Jewish-Christian-Muslim Theology* (Hoboken; Chichester: Wiley-Blackwell, 2011), 135.

⁷⁴ Shulamit Volkov, "Antisemitism as a Cultural Code Reflections on the History and Historiography of Antisemitism in Imperial Germany," *The Leo Baeck Institute Year Book* 23/1 (1978): 25–46, quote from 43.

1879, Treitschke too began to "see the light" and the utility of anti-Semitic tropes.⁷⁵ Volkov explains:

Virulent attacks on capitalism, on socialism and the demands for social reforms along corporatist lines [class, ethnic, and religious groupings] were invariably associated with anti-semitism. In the eyes of many the slogan [the Jewish "other" is to blame] replaced reality. The link was made as a matter of course. It became part of the prevailing culture.⁷⁶

This returns us to Konrad Schmid's warning at the opening of this chapter: "cultural, historical, social and religious factors influence the current [scholarly] analysis and interpretation of historical literary documents." I will close by returning to the project on human relationality in more detail as one application of reciprocal illumination.

8 A (short) Case Study in Christian-Jewish Reciprocal Illumination

To reprise, the notion of relationality that began this project works from the idea of reciprocal constitution, where each distinct particular becomes what or who it is through relations with others, world, and transcendent. Existence is distinction-amid-relation. In developing this idea, a five-part orientation for reciprocal illumination emerged and was re-incorporated as premise and rulebook for continued inquiry. That is, explanation and examples of distinction-amid-relation were sought in a range of Christian and Jewish thought, building on the practice of debate, cultural exchange, and co-production of Jewish tradition and from the principles of: the heterogeneity of experience, epistemological humility, the value of broad-based study, and the bracketing of syncretism and imposed judgment. No idea was excluded owing solely to tradition of origin, and inclusion was based on the illumination shed on our topic of relationality. There was no expectation of convergence or reconcilability but rather of the integrity of each tradition as it illuminates relationality from its own perch.

This may sound prosaic, but it is what Magid, Thatamanil, and Meir note is not yet standard practice. Still and too often, in explicating theological ideas within a given tradition, others are felt to be extraneous or disruptive to the field of inquiry. As the task in our project was to illuminate relationality from the idea-

⁷⁵ Ibid.

⁷⁶ Ibid., 41.

tionally close but historically fraught Jewish and Christian traditions, Trinity and covenant emerged as productive sources of understanding.

8.1 Perichoresis

Perichoresis, the Cappadocian Fathers' concept of the Trinity, is one way to think about distinction-amid-relation. On this view, each distinct Trinitarian Person is who he is through donative relation, giving and receiving identity from the other Persons. God is the distinct Persons in their relations, and in turn, the Persons and relations together constitute the whole of the Godhead. John Milbank writes, person is a relational term (while essence or substance is not). Drawing on Aquinas, Milbank continues, person is "the point of equipoise between relation and substance . . . (*ST [Summa Theologica]* I, q. 29, a. 4 resp.)."⁷⁷

The identity of each Trinitarian person and, inseparably, the relations among them together constitute what each is: not just a person but a Person *of the Godhead*. These identity-relations comprise the Godhead of which each is a part. That is, absent the identities of each amid their relations, there is no Godhead to be part of. While each Trinitarian person has "its own particular distinguishing notes," as Gregory of Nyssa writes,⁷⁸ each is equal in constituting the triune whole through relation. In the Trinity, as Hans Urs von Balthasar puts it, "the principles of individuality and community are at work together simultaneously."⁷⁹ Kirk Wegter-McNelly reprises: "The deity of this God resides not in the persons as distinct from one another but within and among the persons as they are related to one another, i.e., in the relationality that constitutes them and binds them."⁸⁰ Or in the words of Edith Stein, the German Jewish philosopher who became a Carmelite sister, for the persons of the Trinity, "I am' is identical

⁷⁷ John Milbank, "Christianity and Platonism in East and West," in *Divine Essence and Divine Energies: Ecumenical Reflections on the Presence of God in Eastern Orthodoxy*, eds. Constantinos Athanasopoulos and Christoph Schneider (Cambridge: James Clarke & Co, 2013), 158–209, quote from 177.

⁷⁸ Gregory of Nyssa, "Ad petrium," in *Saint Basil: The Letters: Vol. II (Ep. 197–227)*, Loeb Classical Library, trans. Roy J. Deferrari (London: Heinemann, 1961), 207–209.

⁷⁹ Hans Urs von Balthasar, *Engagement with God*, trans. R. John Halliburton (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2008), 30–31, 41.

⁸⁰ Kirk Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God: Divine Relationality and Quantum Physics* (New York: Routledge, 2011), 128–129; Wegter-McNelly is building on Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Systematic Theology: Vol. 1*, trans. Geoffrey W. Bromiley (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1991), 298, 323, 335.

in meaning with ‘I give myself totally to you,’ ‘I am one with a you,’ and so also identical with ‘we are.’”⁸¹

Wolfhart Pannenberg adds that the Trinity is not only the relations among the Trinitarian Persons but relations also between the Persons and humanity.⁸² After all, two of the three Trinitarian Persons, Son and Spirit, are who they are in engagement with humanity. They are doubly relational, in the immanent Trinity (within the Godhead) and in the economic (in relation with humanity). Finally, the Trinitarian Persons teach us not only about God but also about the human condition, as Aquinas held.⁸³ God’s act of creation involves both existence coming into being and the individuation of worldly beings that are yet in relation. Said another way, as the triune God is the source of humanity, humanity is in the image of a God that is distinct Persons in necessary relations. The *imago* is triune, distinct Persons together. Thus, as we are in the image of a relational community, we too are *au fond* relational. Or as Aquinas put it: “persona est relation.”⁸⁴

If this is the case—if reciprocal formation among different entities is the *ontos*—the *telos* entails seeing and seeing *to* the layers and networks of relations that form who we are. Each person—dependent on the transcendent and on other persons for existence, identity, and flourishing—must attend to those on whom she depends as others must attend to her and as all must attend to the common weal.

8.2 Covenant

One name for this reciprocal responsibility is covenant. Covenant is a reciprocal bond where each, developing *through* relation with others, gives *for* the flourish-

⁸¹ Edith Stein, *Endliches und Ewiges Sein* (Leuven: Nauwelaerts; Freiburg: Herder, 1950), 324.

⁸² Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Jesus—God and Man*, trans. Lewis L. Wilkins and Duane A. Priebe (Louisville: Westminster, 1977); Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Systematic Theology: Vol. 1–3*, trans. Geoffrey W. Bromiley (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1991–1998); Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Theology and the Kingdom of God*, ed. Richard J. Neuhaus (Louisville: Westminster, 1969); Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Basic Questions in Theology: Vol. 1–2*, trans. George H. Kelm (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1971).

⁸³ Thomas Aquinas, *Scriptum super libros sententiarum magistri Petri Lombardi*, ed. Pierre Mandonnet (Paris: Lethielleux, 1929), d. 2, q. 1, a. 3; d. 22, q. 1, a. 3; Thomas Aquinas, *Quaestiones disputatae de potentia Dei*, ed. Paul M. Pession (Turin: Marietti, 1965), q. 10, a. 5; see also, Adrian Pabst, *Metaphysics: The Creation of Hierarchy* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2012), 256.

⁸⁴ Roland Walls, “The Church: A Communion of Persons,” in *Christ in Our Place: The Humanity of God in Christ for the Reconciliation of the World: Essays Presented to Prof. James Torrance*, eds. Travor A. Hart and Daniel P. Thimell (Eugene: Pickwick Publications, 1989), 102–109, 104–105.

ing of others. It is, Jean Lee writes, the “promise with one or more counterparty under common pursuit of shared values for long term cooperation and well-being of the community.”⁸⁵ It is the promise, shared values, and long-term communal well-being that are key and distinguish covenant from other human interactions.

Reciprocal covenants among equals are easily imagined. One innovation of the Hebrew Bible is reciprocity between unequals, between the divine and human and among persons of different status. This principle grounds the extensive biblical mandates for aiding the poor, stranger, and enemy. It contrasts with the Hittite, Assyrian, and Hammurabi codes, which provide different punishments for persons of different social status. The biblical *lex talionis*, by contrast, establishes two principles: proportionality of sanction to crime (an eye for an eye, paid in financial compensation) and the same sanction for all; no privileges for the powerful.

A second biblical innovation is that covenant is not between a greater lord and a lesser one, a vassal (as ancient suzerainty treaties were). It is a commitment between God and each person directly. The consequences of direct covenant with God include removing covenantal values, norms, and practices from the purview of the monarch, who may follow, change, or ignore them to suit royal interests. Covenantal commitments between person and God cannot be tweaked to suit regnant powers. Shai Held notes:

“The entire [human] race collectively stands vis-à-vis God in the same relationship of choiceness and protection (. . .). Genesis 1 thus represents a radical democratization of ancient Near Eastern royal ideology (. . .). The Torah’s assertion that every human being is created in the image of God is a repudiation of the idea, so common in the ancient world, that some people are simply meant to rule over others.”⁸⁶

In sum, the Hebrew Bible covenant, Robert Bellah writes, is “a charter for a new kind of people, a people under God, not under a king, an idea parallel to Athenian democracy though longer lasting . . . a people ruled by divine law, not the arbitrary rule of the state, and of a people composed of responsible individuals.”⁸⁷

Unlike contract, which protects interests, covenant protects relationships. In the reciprocity-of-giving, stipulative features might arise. But covenant is not stip-

⁸⁵ Jean Lee, “The Two Pillars Paradigm: Covenant as a Relational Concept in Response to the Contract-Based Economic Market,” PhD diss. (University of Edinburgh, 2010), 59.

⁸⁶ Shai Held, *The Heart of Torah, Volume 1: Essays on the Weekly Torah Portion: Genesis and Exodus* (Philadelphia: The Jewish Publication Society, 2017), 8.

⁸⁷ Robert Bellah, *Religion in Human Evolution* (Cambridge: Belknap/Harvard University Press, 2011), 311, 323.

ulative in motive or *telos*. Where breach of contract requires compensation and generally voids the agreement, covenant endures through breaches as the biblical prophets remind us: in the most dire of times, the bond remains and will flourish anew. Hosea 14:5–6:

I will heal their [Israel's] affliction,
 Generously will I take them back in love;
 For My anger has turned away from them.
 I will be to Israel like dew;
 He shall blossom like the lily,
 He shall strike root like a Lebanon tree.

Covenant begins dyadically—God-Noah, God-patriarchs—but does not remain dyadic. Persons give to God also by giving to others in need, *hekhdedesh* in Hebrew, or made holy. In these triune relations, one gives to God by giving to third parties, persons in need. These triangulated relations-of-giving are mutually constitutive: covenantal commitment to others is part of covenant with God, and covenant with God sustains us in covenantal commitments to others. Like the triune *imago*—understanding humanity as the image of a relational community—covenant extends out from dyad to broader communal commitments. Gift from God to person (life, sustenance) generates gift from person to neighbor and on to the next person through the giving loop, thus sustaining it.⁸⁸

Membership in the covenantal, gift-giving loop pertains to all the nations. The Bible's first covenant is with Noah, representing all humanity. The patriarchs covenant not only with God but with pagans. Indeed, the covenantal promise in Genesis three times declares that “all peoples on earth will be blessed through you” (Genesis 12:3, 26:4, 28:14). Like the idea of covenant between unequals, this commitment to others undergirds the extensive poor laws in biblical writings⁸⁹ and in rabbinic texts.⁹⁰ The effectiveness of these laws was such that the emperor Julian cited the Jewish poor laws to prod improvement in Roman poor relief. “It

⁸⁸ See also, Jacques T. Godbout and Alain Caille, *The World of the Gift*, trans. Donald Winkler (Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 1998).

⁸⁹ For instance, Exodus 21:2; Exodus 22:21, 25–27; Leviticus, ch. 17–26; Deut. 14:22; Deut. 15:1–2, 12–15, Deut. 20:10, 7–9, 12–15; Deut. 23:15–16, 19; Deut. 24:19–20; Ezekiel 47:22–23.

⁹⁰ Robert Gibbs, “Returning/Forgiving: Ethics and Theology,” in *Questioning God*, eds. John Caputo, Mike Dooley and Michael Scanlon (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2001), 73–91, 78.

is disgraceful,” he said, “that, when no Jew ever has to beg (. . .) all men see that our people lack aid from us.”⁹¹

Textually, we find the triune covenant—God, person, others—in the Ten Commandments, the first few of which pertain to person and God, the rest, seamlessly, to conduct among persons. In Numbers 5:6, harm to persons—that is, abrogating covenant with them—abrogates covenant with God: “Any man or woman who wrongs another in any way *and so* is unfaithful to the Lord is guilty.” The lesson of the entwined covenant—the inseparability of bond with God and among persons—is one of the most consistent teachings of prophets. Amos 5:21–24 declares: “I [God] hate, I despise your religious festivals; your assemblies are a stench to me . . . But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream.” One cannot have bond with God while neglecting the needy. Proverbs 21:3 reprises: “To do what is right and just is more acceptable to the Lord than [ritual] sacrifice” (see also, Hos. 6:6, Ezek. 34:1–6, Ps. 51:17, Ps. 72, Mic. 7:2–7, among others).

In modern Jewish thought, many voices reprise the covenantal point. To mention just a few, Zecharias Frankel was among the major figures in the nineteenth-century, German Reform movement before he broke with it over its extensive use of the vernacular in Jewish liturgy. He later inaugurated what became Conservative Judaism. In his “Speech at the Memorial Service for the Benefactor of the Jewish Theological Seminary, Breslau” (1855), he reminded his audience: “‘So, too, do the righteous among the nations of the world have a share in the World to Come.’ And with such respect of human worth that was established and sustained by faith, it was further declared [*b. Sanhedrin* 59a]: ‘Even the non-Jew who recognizes one God and observes the ethical laws is like unto a high priest—this first promoter of faith.’”⁹² Later in the century, the Pittsburg Platform (above) rephrased the idea: “We recognize in every religion an attempt to grasp the infinite (. . .) we extend the hand of fellowship to all who cooperate with us in the establishment of the reign of truth and righteousness among men.”⁹³ In the twentieth century, Abraham Joshua Heschel too held that covenantal commitments toward different others are essential to covenant with God. He writes: “righteousness is not just a value; it is God’s part of human life.”⁹⁴ Righteousness among persons is the occasion and moment of God’s presence in our midst.

91 Menahem Stern, *Greek and Latin Authors on Jews and Judaism: From Tacitus to Simplicius* (Jerusalem: Israel Academy of Sciences and Humanities, 1980), 549–550, No. 482.

92 Kessler and Kohler, *Modern Jewish Theology*, 42.

93 Meyer and Plaut, *The Reform Judaism Reader*, 198, 199.

94 Abraham Joshua Heschel, *The Prophets* (New York: Harper Perennial Classics, 2001), 255.

Yet perhaps more than any other thinker, Emmanuel Levinas’s work is an elegy to covenantal commitment. It is foundational for him (i) that each person is unique, different from others, (ii) that one’s own uniqueness is formed through covenantal commitment to the “face” of the other, and (iii) that nearing God happens through this covenantal responsibility.⁹⁵ Levinas writes, “To follow the Most-High is also to know that nothing is greater than to approach one’s neighbor.”⁹⁶ For Levinas, this is no “figure of speech” but a description of God, “who approaches precisely through this relay to the neighbor—binding men among one another with obligation, each one answering for the lives of all the others.” This “relay to the neighbor” is “the highest possible theological knowledge one can have.”⁹⁷

9 Concluding Thoughts

This chapter has sought to describe an approach to inter-theological work that emerged through a trial-and-error project on human relationality. The relationality under investigation was understood as distinction-amid-relation. The inter-theological work was envisioned as efforts by co-archeologists, together enriching the understanding of *theos*, *cosmos*, *anthropos*, and their relations. The approach that emerged from this project was one of reciprocal illumination, which strives to set self-reflexivity about habits of the mind upstream of research protocols in order both to limit the influence of cultural bias and to allow for inter-theological research that draws unprejudicially from multiple traditions. Five aspects of reciprocal illumination were discussed, along with four companion criteria from John Thatamanil’s work on a “theology of religious diversity.” As these emerged, they were recycled back into the relationality project as premises and rulebook for further inquiry. The chapter concludes with an example of reciprocal illumination where notions of Trinity and covenant together shed light on the concept of relationality as distinction-amid-relation.

Three aspects of reciprocal illumination are epistemological humility, the value of studying broadly, and the possibility that ideas considered true in one

95 Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1979), 78.

96 Emmanuel Levinas, *Beyond the Verse: Talmudic Readings and Lectures*, trans. Gary D. Mole (New York: Bloomsbury, 1994), 142.

97 Emmanuel Levinas, *In the Time of the Nations*, trans. Michael B. Smith (London: Athlone Press, 1994), 171.

tradition may nonetheless be enriched by another. These are longstanding in the production of Jewish thought, in its reliance on debate among multiple positions, exchange, “entanglement,” inter-religious “co-production,” and the epistemological humility of considering many sources and views. Reciprocal illumination is quasi-midrashic. Said more poetically by a wise mind who thought a good deal about this: “A confident people is not exclusive. A great religion affirms other religions. A great culture affirms other cultures. A great nation affirms other nations. A great individual affirms other individuals, validates the beingness of others”—Leonard Cohen, 1994.⁹⁸

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⁹⁸ Jeff Burger, ed., *Leonard Cohen on Leonard Cohen: Interviews and Encounters* (Chicago: Chicago Review Press, 2014), 388.

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Chapter 12

Leo Baeck's Double-Critique of Christianity and Islam

1 Apologetic Religion

"If one wants to understand a spirit," observed Franz Rosenzweig in 1923, "then one must not abstract it from the body that belongs to it."¹ Leo Baeck and Max Brod, lamented Rosenzweig, did just this type of abstraction when they universalized Judaism and caricatured Christianity. A prime example for Rosenzweig was Baeck's "Romantic Religion" (1922), which offered a dichotomy between two types of religion: classical religion, which Baeck identifies with Judaism (to which Jesus firmly belonged), and romantic religion, which is represented by Christianity.² Romantic religion, whose founder is Paul and its more modern representative is Luther, risked becoming unethical according to Baeck as it is too self-centered and focused on redemption from without, thereby unwilling or unable to act in the world, which is a prerequisite of morality.³

Leo Baeck (1873–1956) was a leading rabbi, teacher, and public intellectual during the Wilhelmine Empire and the Weimar Republic. When the Nazis came to power, he became the official leader of German Jewry. After having survived Theresienstadt Ghetto, he was described as a "a symbol of German Jewry."⁴ Baeck's name and work, in other words, carry historical and symbolic value and he was seen as a representative of the German-Jewish tradition.

1 Franz Rosenzweig, "Apologetic Thinking," in *Philosophical and Theological Writings*, ed. Paul Franks and Michael Morgan (Indianapolis: Hackett, 2000), 101.

2 Leo Baeck, "Romantic Religion," in *Judaism and Christianity*, trans. Walter Kaufmann (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society of America, 1960), 213, 250; see Ernest Rubinstein, *An Episode of Jewish Romanticism: Franz Rosenzweig's The Star of Redemption* (Albany: SUNY Press, 1999); Yaniv Feller, "Romantic Politics in the Thought of Gustav Landauer and Leo Baeck," in *Skepsis and Antipolitics: The Alternative of Gustav Landauer*, ed. Cedric Cohen-Skalli and Libera Pisano (Leiden: Brill, 2022), 276–85.

3 Baeck, "Romantic Religion," 211. He later ameliorated his judgement of Paul, see Leo Baeck, "The Faith of Paul," in *Judaism and Christianity*, 139–68.

4 Eva Reichmann, "A Symbol of German Jewry," *Leo Baeck Institute Yearbook* 2, no. 1 (1957): 21–26; a recent biography of Baeck is Michael A. Meyer, *Rabbi Leo Baeck: Living a Religious Imperative in Troubled Times* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2020).

Baeck was part of a Jewish minority in Protestant society. As a rabbi, theologian, and scholar of religion, he was therefore concerned with the relation between Judaism and Christianity. In addition to “Romantic Religion,” he wrote works such as *The Pharisees* (1927) and *The Gospel as a Document of the History of Jewish Faith* (1938). The latter, written in Nazi Germany, was an insistence on the Jewishness of the synoptic gospels at a time when church historians were attempting to de-Judaize and Aryanize Christianity.⁵ Baeck’s description of Christianity, especially his highly critical portrayal in “Romantic Religion,” has been the subject of criticism not only by his contemporary Rosenzweig but also by later scholars. Samuel Sandmel, for example, criticized Baeck’s knowledge of contemporary scholarship on Christian origins and sees in the decision to work with the categories of “romantic” and “classical” as “two Procrustean beds” that led to the fact that “as New Testament scholars had distorted Judaism, Baeck seems in turn to have distorted Paul.”⁶

Nothing equivalent to the analysis of Baeck’s relation to Christianity exists regarding his views on Islam and Muslim culture.⁷ Yet this does not mean they were not a concern for Baeck. Highlighting the presence of Islam and Muslim culture in Baeck’s thought is the first task of this article. Triangulating his treatment of Judaism, Islam, and Christianity achieves several purposes. First, it contributes to a better understanding of this central representative of German-Jewish thought by reconstructing his position from references scattered in major and minor works across seven decades. Second, a study of Baeck’s view of Islam exposes a

5 Christian Wiese, “Das Evangelium als ‘Urkunde der jüdischen Glaubensgeschichte’: Spuren der Zeitgenössischen jüdischen geistigen Widerstand gegen die theologisch-völkische Religionswissenschaft des Eisenacher ‘Entjudungsinstitut,’” in *Das Eisenacher ‘Entjudungsinstitut’: Kirche und Antisemitismus in der NS-Zeit*, ed. Christopher Spehr and Harry Oelke (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2021), 119–54; on the attempts to de-Judaize Christianity, see Doris Bergen, *Twisted Cross: The German Christian Movement in the Third Reich* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1996); Susannah Heschel, *The Aryan Jesus: Christian Theologians and the Bible in Nazi Germany* (Princeton University Press, 2008).

6 Samuel Sandmel, *Leo Baeck on Christianity* (New York: Leo Baeck Institute, 1975); for another critical assessment, see Reinhold Mayer, *Christentum und Judentum in der Schau Leo Baecks* (Stuttgart: W. Kohlhammer, 1961); a more positive view is in Albert Friedlander, *Leo Baeck: Teacher of Theresienstadt* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1973), 120.

7 Marshall Hodgson distinguishes between the cultural and political elements. He suggests the terms Islamicate and Islamdom rather than Islam, which is the religion. Critics pointed out the distinction is artificial and diminished the religious aspect of culture. See Marshall Hodgson, *The Venture of Islam: The Classical Age of Islam* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2009), I.56; Shahab Ahmed Ahmed, *What Is Islam?: The Importance of Being Islamic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015). My use of the terms Muslim thought and culture is meant in the latter sense, and I talk about Islam when Baeck explicitly references what can be seen as the religion.

twofold relation. On the one hand, Baeck, especially in the post-Holocaust era, offered a positive picture of Islam and Muhammad, as well as of the so-called Spanish Golden Age. At the same time, he reiterates typical prejudices and stereotypes, for example about Arab people, and Muhammad, as being simple and static in their beliefs. Put differently, I contend that Baeck's positive appreciation of Islam represents not only a critique of Christianity but also a type of appropriation. He saw Islam, like Christianity, as having a role in propagating monotheism, and as such as having a valuable task in the world. But this role was dependent for Baeck upon Judaism and emerges from it. This leads to Baeck's somewhat surprising acceptance of Muslim and Christian missionizing. In his thought, however, they are secondary to Jewish missionizing, which he actively advocated throughout his life.

2 Islam as a Foil

Although Baeck's dissertation was on the early reception of Spinoza in Germany, one of his earliest published texts was a short review of Martin Schreiner's *The Kalām in Jewish Literature*.⁸ As a German-Jewish rabbi who is a product of the late nineteenth century, Baeck was thereby participating in the tradition of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, the scholarly examination of the Jewish tradition, which often emphasized the recovery of medieval poetry, philosophy, and architecture.⁹

Baeck praised Schreiner for proving what was only assumed, namely that early Jewish medieval philosophy—such as that of Saadia Gaon—was profoundly shaped by the contemporary Muslim philosophy of the *kalām*, a rational theology of Islam that emerged in the 8th–9th century CE.¹⁰ Baeck used the occasion to make a broader point: religions receive an impetus to develop their own theoreti-

8 Leo Baeck, "Rezension zu *Der Kalam in der jüdischen Literatur* von Martin Schreiner (1895/6)," in *Werke* 6, ed. Michael Meyer (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 26–28; Leo Bäck, *Spinozas erste Einwirkung auf Deutschland* (Berlin: Mayer & Müller, 1895).

9 Ismar Schorsch, *From Text to Context: The Turn to History in Modern Judaism* (Hanover, NH: Brandeis University Press, 1994); Nils Roemer, *Jewish Scholarship and Culture in Nineteenth-Century Germany Between History and Faith* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2005), and the discussion below.

10 On *kalām* see Oliver Leaman and Sajjad Rizvi, "The Developed *Kalām* Tradition," in *The Cambridge Companion to Classical Islamic Theology*, ed. Timothy Winter (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008), 77–96; and Harry Austryn Wolfson, *The Philosophy of the Kalam* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1976).

cal system only when interacting with other religions. Attempts to be self-contained monads, by contrast, lead to ossification of religious creativity. This was particularly true for minorities such as the Jews: “If one confession oppresses the other, then any stimulus for philosophical treatment of religion is lost. The winner believes to have the right, because he has the power.”¹¹ This statement can be seen as representative of much of Baeck’s later thought, including the rejection of power and coercion as well as the insistence on Jewish creativity.

The plea for toleration would be central less than a decade later in Baeck’s first major work, *The Essence of Judaism* (1905), written as a response to Adolf von Harnack’s highly popular *The Essence of Christianity*, which described Jesus’ ethical message as singular by presenting a negative picture of the Pharisees.¹² Jewish scholars rejected the leading church historian’s claims about the pureness of Jesus’s message in contrast to what he deemed a Pharisaic-legalistic tradition on both methodological and historical grounds. Baeck, then an unknown rabbi from Oppeln, was one of the first to critically review *The Essence of Christianity*. He pointed out that Harnack was confusing two different types of Jewish texts (*halakhah* and *aggadah*) and suggested that the church historian did not have the necessary mastery of the relevant Jewish languages such as Hebrew and Aramaic.¹³

A few years later, in *The Essence of Judaism*, Baeck moved to a self-standing presentation of Judaism rather than a critique of the adversary. As in his review of Schreiner, Baeck began the *Essence* with the interaction of minority and majority cultures. “A minority is compelled to think,” he wrote, because it is in an ongoing struggle for “that consciousness of truth which success and power comfort-

11 Baeck, “Rezension zu *Der Kalam in der jüdischen Literatur*,” 26.

12 Adolf von Harnack, *What Is Christianity?*, trans. Thomas Baily Saunders (London: Williams and Norgate, 1901), 9, 36; on negative images of the Pharisees in scholarship, see Susannah Heschel and Deborah Forger, “The Pharisees in Modern Scholarship,” in *The Pharisees*, ed. Joseph Sievers and Amy-Jill Levine (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2021), 361–83.

13 Leo Bäck, “Harnack’s Vorlesungen über das Wesen des Christentums,” *Monatsschrift für Geschichte und Wissenschaft des Judentums* 45 (1901): 97–120. On the essence debate, see Uriel Tal, *Yahadut Ve-Natsrut Ba-’Raikh Ha-Sheni’* (Jerusalem: Magnes University Press, 1969); Uriel Tal, “Theologische Debatten um das ‘Wesen’ des Judentums,” in *Juden im wilhelminischen Deutschland, 1890-1914*, ed. Werner Mosse (Tübingen: Mohr, 1976), 599–632; Michael Zank, “Vom Innersten, Äußersten und Anderen: Annäherungen an Baeck, Harnack und die Frage nach dem Wesen,” in *Religious Apologetics – Philosophical Argumentation*, ed. Yossef Schwartz and Volkhart Krech (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2004), 25–45; Christian Wiese, *Challenging Colonial Discourse: Jewish Studies and Protestant Theology in Wilhelmine Germany* (Boston: Brill, 2005), 159–69.

ingly assure to rulers and their supporting multitudes.”¹⁴ The majority, in other words, does not have to engage in dialogue, which is a necessity for a minority like the Jews. But it is precisely this dialogue that fosters creativity throughout Jewish history.

Schreiner presented Maimonides's refutation of the *kalām* in the *Guide for the Perplexed* (1190) as having a fatal influence. “No rabbinic thinker now allowed the *kalām* to influence his religious thinking.”¹⁵ Baeck concurred, writing that after Maimonides “the influence of *kalām* is as good as annihilated.”¹⁶ This harsh language entails an implicit argument about what constitutes a legitimate source of influence. Georg Kohler has shown the centrality of Maimonides for German-Jewish self-fashioning since the late eighteenth century and throughout the nineteenth century.¹⁷ Baeck and Schreiner claim the influence of Aristotelianism on Maimonides is a philosophical influence on Jews and Muslim alike, rather than a religious confluence.¹⁸ Put differently, the influence of philosophy is legitimate, but religious mixture or syncretism is not. More recent work by Sarah Stroumsa revises the analysis of Maimonides's thought, showing that he was well-versed in *kalām* discourse.¹⁹ But the point extends beyond historical knowledge and has potential socio-cultural implications. When Baeck argued that after Maimonides Muslim thought had nothing to contribute to Judaism, he made a twofold claim: on this important Jewish thinker, and on a supposed decline in the relevance of Muslim thought.

In Baeck's description, the two main streams of *kalām*, the *mu'tazila* and the later *ash'arite* school, differed in their degree of tolerance. The former offered a position that tried to mediate between revelation and reason, whereas the *ash'ar-*

14 Leo Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums* (1905), in *Werke* 1, ed. Albert Friedlander and Bertold Klappert (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 321. On the centrality of the minority position within an imperial context for understanding Baeck's thought, see Yaniv Feller, *The Jewish Imperial Imagination: Leo Baeck and German-Jewish Thought* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023).

15 Martin Schreiner, *Der Kalam in Der Jüdischen Literatur* (Berlin: Itzkowski, 1895), 56–57; Maimonides, *The Guide of the Perplexed*, trans. Shlomo Pines (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974), I.73–76.

16 Leo Baeck, “Rezension zu *Der Kalam in der Jüdischen Literatur*,” 28.

17 George Kohler, *Reading Maimonides' Philosophy in 19th Century Germany: The Guide to Religious Reform* (New York: Springer, 2012).

18 A similar issue resurfaces in another article on medieval Jewish philosophy, where Baeck seems reluctant to engage in the question of influence. See Leo Baeck, “Gerechte und Engel (1930),” in *Werke* 4, eds. Albert Friedlander et al. (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 217–21.

19 Sarah Stroumsa, *Maimonides in His World: Portrait of a Mediterranean Thinker* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2009), 24–52.

ites “held strictly to the word of the prophet.” Despite the importance of the *ash’arites*, Baeck argued that “this orthodox strand did not influence Jewish thinkers in the least.”²⁰ From the perspective of scholarship in the twenty-first century, this is a mischaracterization on at least two accounts: First, this assessment fails to recognize the diversity of the *ash’arite* school. Second, it fails to recognize the influence of al-Ghazali, a staunch *ash’arite*, on the thought of Maimonides.²¹

In the distinction between *ash’arites* and *mu’tazila*, Baeck clearly sides with the latter. I suggest this part of an inner-Jewish polemic, as well as a critique of Christianity. At stakes is a debate about dogmatic assertions. From Moses Mendelssohn onward, Jewish thinkers have argued that whereas Christianity necessitated dogmas—a set of belief to one which the believer must subscribe—and was therefore limiting thought. Judaism has no such set of beliefs and hence was more rational and moral. The dogma debate was not over with Mendelssohn, and in fact has been revived in Jewish and Christian circles in the twentieth century.²² Adolf Harnack, whose *The Essence of Christianity* prompted Baeck to reply, was widely celebrated as the author of the seven volume *History of Dogma*, in which he tried to show how dogmas developed historically and were therefore not necessarily obliging for modern Christians.²³ For all his criticism of Harnack, Baeck agrees that dogmas constrain thought and are historically conditioned. But Baeck turns the tables and uses the discussion of dogmas to criticize Christianity and praise Judaism.

In “Orthodox or Ceremonial?,” an essay published the same year as the review of Schreiner, Baeck makes this point explicitly, stressing that while there were suggestions for article of faith (Maimonides’ Thirteen Articles of Faith being the most prominent), they were never obligatory.²⁴ In *The Essence of Judaism*, and especially in its expanded and revised second edition, Baeck elaborated on this

20 Leo Baeck, “Rezension zu *Der Kalam in der jüdischen Literatur*,” 28.

21 Amira Eran, “Al- Ghazali and Maimonides on the World to Come and Spiritual Pleasures,” *Jewish Studies Quarterly* 8, no. 2 (2001): 137– 66; Alfred L. Ivry, “The Guide and Maimonides’ Philosophical Sources,” in *The Cambridge Companion to Maimonides*, ed. Kenneth Seeskin (Cambridge University Press, 2005), 58–81; Stroumsa, *Maimonides in His World*, esp. 61–79.

22 Kerstin von der Krone, “Jüdische Wissenschaft und modernes Judentum: Eine Dogmendebatte,” in *Die „Wissenschaft des Judentums“: Eine Bestandsaufnahme*, ed. Andreas Kilcher and Thomas Meyer (Paderborn: Wilhelm Fink Verlag, 2015), 115–38; Michah Gottlieb, “Does Judaism Have Dogma? Moses Mendelssohn and a Pivotal Nineteenth-Century Debate,” *Yearbook of the Maimonides Centre for Advanced Studies* 2 (2019): 219–42.

23 Adolf von Harnack, *History of Dogma*, trans. Neil Buchanan (New York: Dover, 1961)

24 Leo Baeck, “Orthodox oder ceremoniös? (1896/7),” in *Werke* 6, ed. Michael Meyer (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 31–35; on the debate in Jewish medieval thought about articles of

point. Although Judaism has sentences and words in which the sound of revelation sings to the people from one generation to the next, these are not dogmas because they are not declared as binding, and the salvation of one's soul is not conditioned upon accepting them. Furthermore, Baeck claimed that dogmas in the strict sense need enforcement mechanism. This is not the case in Judaism because it does not have one figure authority like a pope; nor does Judaism use any type of coercion or violence in the name of enforcing opinion.²⁵

Baeck's verdict on the the *ash'arites* early in his career might therefore be a foil for an anti-dogmatic position that is simultaneously a critique of Christianity. In turning to Islam for this purpose, Baeck is in line with German-Jewish scholarship at the time.²⁶ The discussion of *kalām* served as a guise by which to discuss Judaism's ongoing creativity, that is, its ability to engage its surrounding, while also showing that rationality and lack of coercion take precedence in Judaism. Baeck's argument is developed in later texts. In his telling, Judaism is willing to engage Islam and Christianity, as long as it is done freely and in the spirit of honest exchange, that is to say without dogmatic coercion.²⁷

It would be wrong, however, to assume that Baeck gives Islam preferential treatment over Christianity in his early writings. While he identified both Christianity and late medieval Islam as dogmatic religions, his assessment of them differed significantly. He acknowledged the historical impact of Muslim culture and thought but argued for their current irrelevance for Jews. Baeck did not apply the same treatment to Christian influence. Despite his criticisms of Christianity, he never characterized the culture he inhabited as stagnant, even as his criticism of it, as evident in "Romantic Religion" was harsher and more explicit than that of Islam.

faith, see Menachem Kellner, *Dogma in Medieval Jewish Thought: From Maimonides to Abravanel* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986).

25 Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums* (1926), 44–46; Leo Baeck, "Hat das überlieferte Judentum Dogmen? (1926)," in *Werke* 4, ed. Albert Friedlander et al. (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 12–27.

26 Susannah Heschel, "German Jewish Scholarship on Islam as a Tool for De-Orientalizing Judaism," *New German Critique*, no. 117 (2012): 91–107; Susannah Heschel, *Jüdischer Islam: Islam und jüdisch-deutsche Selbstbestimmung*, trans. Dirk Hartwig (Berlin: Matthes & Seitz Berlin, 2018); and the articles in Martin Kramer, ed., *Jewish Discovery of Islam: Studies in Honor of Bernard Lewis* (Tel Aviv: Moshe Dayan Center, 2001), especially the articles by Jacob Lassner and Lawrence Conrad. Another reason was more pragmatic. Jews also turned to the study of Islam, or Orientalism more broadly, because this was the field that was open to them, and their knowledge of a semitic language like Hebrew was an advantage.

27 Leo Baeck, "Unsere Stellung zu den Religionsgesprächen (1910)," in *Werke* 6, ed. Michael Meyer (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 80–83.

3 Empires of Faith

Baeck's oeuvre shows a continued interest in the academic study of religion.²⁸ During the Weimar Republic, for example, he was a participant in Hermann von Keyserling's School of Wisdom, alongside figures such as Ernst Troeltsch and Carl Jung, which further enhanced his stature as a representative of Judaism.²⁹ In the 1930s, and increasingly after the Holocaust, Baeck turned to questions regarding Jewish historiography. They materialize in his later works such as the series of lectures titled "Epochs of Jewish History" and *This People: Jewish Existence*.³⁰ Based on his understanding of the Jews as a minority, it is not surprising that the two strands – interest in other religions and in Jewish history – are intertwined.

Baeck read the history of the Jewish people as a continuing renaissance, a position he might have taken from Nachman Krochmal.³¹ In Baeck's presentation, Jewish history was divided into four different eras, each lasting about a millennium and containing two centers of Jewish existence. The first era, which Baeck calls the era of the prophets, roughly covers the Hebrew Bible from the Exodus to the return to the land following Cyrus's edict. The second era, that of the teachers, spans from the Second Temple period until the Christianization of the Roman empire. The final epoch is that of hope, from the period from the expulsion from Spain all the way to the contemporary moment.

The third epoch, corresponding to the medieval period, contains Baeck's most detailed account of Muhammad and Islam. Jews, in Baeck's account, had to choose between remaining true to their religion or converting to the religion of what Baeck calls "empires of faith." The geography of the era is primarily European: Sepharad (the Hebrew term), also known as al-Andalus (the Arabic term) or Muslim Spain, and Ashkenaz, or parts of France and Germany. This period ended with the expulsion of the Jews from Spain and Portugal in the late fifteenth

28 Hans Liebeschütz, "Judaism and the History of Religion in Leo Baeck's Work," *Leo Baeck Institute Yearbook* 2 (1957): 8–20.

29 Michael A. Meyer, *Rabbi Leo Baeck: Living a Religious Imperative in Troubled Times* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2020), 61–65.

30 Albert Friedlander, "Leo Baeck - Der Weg vom Wesen zur Existenz," in *Zwischen Geheimnis und Gebot: Auf dem Weg zu einem Progressiven Judentum der Moderne*, ed. Frank Wössner and Walter Homolka (Karlsruhe: EPB, 1997), 14–25.

31 Eliezer Schweid, "From *The Essence of Judaism* to *This People Israel*: Leo Baeck's Theological Confrontation with the Period of Nazism and the Holocaust," in *Wrestling until Day-Break: Searching for Meaning in the Thinking on the Holocaust* (Lanham: University Press of America, 1994), 56–7; Asher Biemann, *Inventing New Beginnings: On the Idea of Renaissance in Modern Judaism* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2009), 177–222.

century.³² The foci of Jewish life then shifted to Western and Eastern Europe. Baeck's perspective implies that Muslim influence on Judaism diminished after Maimonides. Consequently, his historical account of Judaism largely overlooked the Jews of North Africa and the Ottoman Empire, who are conspicuously absent from his overarching narrative.

At the peak of the “empires of faith” era is the so-called Spanish Golden Age. The term was apparently first coined by the Franz Delitzsch, who led an active program of proselytizing Jews, but it was quickly adopted and propagated by scholars in the tradition of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, who saw in al-Andalus, a hub of Jewish creativity and rationality that were achieved through the productive co-existence with Muslim culture.³³ Al-Andalus is a Rorschach test, revealing more about the people who imagined it than about the actual historical facts. Ivan Marcus, for example, has shown how historiography prefers elite over the masses, and Christina Civantos noted how diverse figures utilize it for various political agendas, from a vision of coexistence to that of a militarized caliphate.³⁴

In his view of al-Andalus, Baeck is an heir to the nineteenth century *Wissenschaft des Judentums*. He is also his father's son. In *The History of the Jewish People and Its Literature*, Leo Baeck's father Samuel Bäck praised Spanish Jewry for being fully integrated in every aspect of society, contributing to the country and its rulers while never forgetting their Jewishness and maintaining their adher-

32 Leo Baeck, *This People Israel: The Meaning of Jewish Existence*, trans. Albert Friedlander (New York: Holt, 1964), 253; for a scholarly assessment of the conditions of Jews under these empires, see Mark Cohen, *Under Crescent and Cross: The Jews in the Middle Ages* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2008).

33 Aaron W. Hughes, *Shared Identities: Medieval and Modern Imaginings of Judeo-Islam* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017), 23.

34 Ivan Marcus, “Beyond the Sephardic Mystique,” *Orim: A Jewish Journal at Yale* 1, no. 1 (1985): 35–53; Ismar Schorsch, *From Text to Context*, 71–92; Gil Anidjar, “Our Place in al-Andalus”: *Kabbalah, Philosophy, Literature in Arab Jewish Letters* (Stanford University Press, 2002); Christina Civantos, *The Afterlife of Al-Andalus: Muslim Iberia in Contemporary Arab and Hispanic Narratives* (Albany: SUNY Press, 2017); Pablo Bornstein, *Reclaiming Al-Andalus: Orientalist Scholarship and Spanish Nationalism, 1875-1919* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2020); Charles Hirschkind, *The Feeling of History: Islam, Romanticism, and Andalusia* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2020).

ence to Jewish law.³⁵ “Spain under the rulership of the Arabs,” Bäck senior wrote, became the center of Jewish life.³⁶

Leo Baeck’s bifocal model of Jewish history maintains this positive assessment but offers a different historical interpretation. He praised Sepharad, but as only one part of Jewish existence. In 1954, Baeck held a lecture in Düsseldorf commemorating the 750th anniversary of Maimonides’s birth. Even in this occasion, celebrating the famed Sephardic rabbi and philosopher, Baeck stressed that in the medieval period one encounters Maimonides alongside Rashi, the great Ashkenazi exegete. The two great scholars, Baeck told his listeners, had different approaches to the Jewish sources and their interpretation, but both are indispensable to Jewish learning.³⁷ In *This People*, the difference between Ashkenaz and Sepharad is described in more abstract terms, as two idealized types. Sephardim symbolize the Jewish orientation outward, they express a “piety of culture”; Ashkenazim, by contrast, developed a “culture of piety.” “The Ashkenazim centered their gaze primarily upon the individual in all his uniqueness, the Sephardim upon the structure of all being.” Baeck’s point is that both were innovative, and necessary. “One is tempted to say,” Baeck wrote in *This People*, “that it was a predestined division of labor. The one found the way from the outside to the interior; the other attained the external from within.”³⁸ The Sephardic achievements are thereby celebrated, but they are understood as just one side of the equation.³⁹

Baeck achieved several purposes with this presentation of Jews in Muslim culture: First, like other scholars of the era, it enabled a criticism of the current predicament of German Jewry. The imagined, idealized existence in al-Andalus was alluring to German Jews for two reasons: First, the myth of peaceful and intellectually productive coexistence in Spain proved an appealing counterexample to the discrimination Jews were facing in Germany. In the nineteenth century, it allowed Jewish scholars to imply Muslim openness versus Christian persecution, and Jewish economic integration in Sepharad versus exclusion in Ashkenaz. Second, it was a way to distinguish oneself from the *Ostjude*, the East European Jews. German Jews identified themselves with purity of language, education, and civic

35 Samuel Bäck, *Die Geschichte des jüdischen Volkes und seiner Literatur vom babylonischen Exile bis auf die Gegenwart* (Frankfurt am Main: J. Kauffmann, 1906), 264.

36 Bäck, *Die Geschichte des jüdischen Volkes*, 264. Leo helped his father with the revised, third edition (vii).

37 Leo Baeck, “Maimonides - Der Mann, sein Werk und seine Wirkung (1954),” in *Werke* 5, ed. Albert Friedlander and Bertold Klappert (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 155–156; see also Leo Baeck, “Mittelalterliche Populärphilosophie (1900)” in *Werke* 4, ed. Albert Friedlander et al. (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), esp. 293–295.

38 Baeck, *This People Israel: The Meaning of Jewish Existence*, 270.

39 *Ibid.*, 276.

virtues, all of which they read into the Spanish Golden Age while rejecting Yiddish and what was seen as backward education and lack of integration.⁴⁰ For Baeck, it the former was more paramount. Yet his account goes beyond mere idealization of al-Andalus. The argument that it was only one of the focal points meant ameliorating earlier one-sided celebrations of the era and potentially diminishing its centrality.

4 Judaizing Islam and Christianity

Baeck placed importance not only on Jews' status as a minority but also on Judaism's foundational role within Christianity and Islam. In *The Essence of Judaism*, Baeck grouped Christianity and Islam alongside Buddhism. He wrote, for example, that they are all centered around their founders, and consequently, the spiritual pinnacle of the religion diminishes upon the founder's death.⁴¹ Implied in this view is the idea that Judaism, based in Baeck's view on the revelation to the entire people, has a stronger capacity for creativity and survival than other religions and peoples.

Baeck's treatment of Jesus and Muhammad reveals his views about the relation between Judaism and the respective Abrahamic religions.⁴² Judaism for Baeck stood at the heart of teaching of Jesus, who, despite what Christian theologians might argue, brought nothing new to the world. He was Jewish through and through. This allowed Baeck, following Abraham Geiger, to claim that everything that is valuable in Christianity is essentially Jewish.⁴³ Although Muhammad, un-

⁴⁰ John Efron, *German Jewry and the Allure of the Sephardic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2016).

⁴¹ Leo Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums* (1905), 328, 357; Leo Baeck, "Zur Frage der Christumythe (1910)," in *Werke* 6, ed. Michael Meyer (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 78. On the role of Buddhism in Jewish thought, see Sebastian Musch, *Jewish Encounters with Buddhism in German Culture: Between Moses and Buddha, 1890–1940* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2019), 82–85.

⁴² For a critical genealogy of this term, see Aaron W. Hughes, *Abrahamic Religions: On the Uses and Abuses of History* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012).

⁴³ Leo Bäck, "Harnack's Vorlesungen über das Wesen des Christentums," 118; Leo Baeck, "The Gospel as a Document of the History of the Jewish Faith," in *Judaism and Christianity*, trans. Walter Kaufmann (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society of America, 1960), 41–138; Susannah Heschel, *Abraham Geiger and the Jewish Jesus* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998); Gösta Lindeskog, *Die Jesusfrage im neuzeitlichen Judentum: Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der Leben-Jesu-Forschung*. (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1973).

like Jesus, cannot be historically counted as a Jew, Baeck emphasized Muhammad's knowledge of certain *aggadic* materials, which were later incorporated in the Quran, thereby claiming a positive role for Judaism in Islam. In *This People*, Baeck described Muhammad as a religious and political leader possessing "creative genius." He praised Muhammad's achievements and the expansion of Islam in Arabia, which brought in his words "true democracy"—there were no different estates as everyone were united under faith in God. Furthermore, although Muhammad's tolerated slavery, slaves were treated well, unlike in Christian Europe or the Americas. This was due to the promotion of a "pure, serious, indeed severe monotheism."⁴⁴ Like the treatment of al-Andalus, this was another implicit criticism of Christendom by turning to Islamdom.

In late nineteenth century and early twentieth century European depictions of Muhammad, such as in Alyos Sprenger's biography, presented the founder of Islam as a deeply flawed character, at times even as hysterical and fraudulent. Baeck, by contrast, followed a more positive understanding of the life of the prophet, along the lines sketched by Jewish Orientalists such as Gustav Weil and Ignác Goldziher.⁴⁵ Baeck wrote that the driving force of Muhammad's faith, and the reason Islam was able to expand rapidly, was the "simplicity" of its message. Although Baeck insisted that the word was to be understood in "its good and noble sense," akin perhaps to Harnack's insistence on the simplicity of Jesus's message, such a claim could betray prejudices about Muhammad and the peoples of Arabia, as if they were unable to formulate or accept a more complex message.⁴⁶

When comparing Judaism and Islam, Baeck turned to a spatial metaphor. Islam "has a geometric character. Line adds to line, to what is clear, definite, closed." Based on this image, Baeck claimed that Islam was a static religion. It is unclear what inspired this image by Baeck, but I surmise that it is based on the geometric forms prevalent in Muslim architecture and decorative arts. If this is the case, then the image can be turned on its head, for it is just as plausible to

⁴⁴ Baeck, *This People*, 258–60; Baeck, "Brücken zwischen Judentum, Christentum und Islam (1955)," in *Werke* 5, ed. Albert Friedlander and Bertold Klappert (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 487.

⁴⁵ John Tolan, *Faces of Muhammad: Western Perceptions of the Prophet of Islam from the Middle Ages to Today* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2019); Susannah Heschel, "German Jewish Scholarship on Islam," 96, 100.

⁴⁶ Baeck, *This People*, 261; Baeck betrays a similar attitude when he talks about Indigenous peoples, see Leo Baeck, "Epochen der jüdischen Geschichte," in *Werke* 5, ed. Albert Friedlander and Bertold Klappert (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 227–229.

argue that these geometric patterns point outward, multiplying ad infinitum.⁴⁷ But Baeck sees in Islam a sealed system, as opposed to the open-ended nature of the Jewish prophetic teachings, where “Every line reaches out towards the infinite, toward the eternal; every answer creates a new question, and no question can exist without the living certainty of the one, final, and enduring answer.”⁴⁸ This supports the thesis that for all of Baeck's positive statements about Muhammad, Islam, and al-Andalus, in his mind the religion became ossified, which is clearly a negative in his view given the centrality he assigns to religious creativity.

Judaism for Baeck is both the apex of religion, and the yardstick by which others should be measured. His interpretation of Christianity and Islam is predicated on this idea, implying that most, if not everything, that was and is valuable in Islam and Christianity has to do with their Jewish origins. It is most evident in Baeck's treatment of what he saw as the Marcionite trends in contemporary Protestantism during the Weimar Republic, exemplified in Harnack's monograph *Marcion*. When Christianity tried to move away from its Jewish roots, Baeck cautioned, it ran the risk of becoming an inward religion that disregards this world; it becomes an unethical religion. Baeck would admit in a private letter to Rosenzweig that he intentionally misrepresented historical Christianity in “Romantic Religion,” justifying it by the need to present this dark side of a de-Judaized Christianity.⁴⁹

This is the negative side of the equation. A positive corollary is that Christianity and Islam have a role to play in propagating monotheism. According to Baeck, the three religions share a telos. They must pursue it separately while recognizing and respecting that the other is following its own path. The guarantee that Christianity and Islam would not stray away from the monotheism is the fact that Jews remain in the world as Jews, a reminder of the ethical message.⁵⁰ The implication of such a position is the somewhat surprising fact that Baeck was in favor of Christian and Muslim missionizing. In a 1949 public address, Baeck discussed how missionaries—he focused on Christianity, Islam, and Buddhism – brought “consolation, comfort, help,” and “clearness of mind” to many people in the world,

⁴⁷ I thank Oludamini Ogunnaike for offering this contrasting interpretation.

⁴⁸ Baeck, *This People*, 261.

⁴⁹ Leo Baeck to Franz Rosenzweig, March 8, 1923, in *Werke* 6, eds. Michael Meyer et al. (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 578–79; Yaniv Feller, *The Jewish Imperial Imagination*, 63–72.

⁵⁰ Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums* (1905), 404–5; many Jewish thinkers had similar ideas about the role of other religions, especially Christianity. See Adam Sutcliffe, *What Are Jews For? History, Peoplehood, and Purpose* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2020).

which should be acknowledged with “deep gratitude.” He praised Islam in particular, saying that whereas Christianity committed “a serious crime” against Africa by introducing “gunpowder, new forms of alcoholism and some very unpleasant maladies,” Islam’s expansion in Africa, Southeast Asia and Indonesia “was like the triumphal march of prohibition. Many a good thing was done in Africa to many people by this missionary work of Islam.”⁵¹ He noted, however, that Islam had been politicized, thereby losing its religious strength. Writing a year after the founding of the State of Israel, this is a possible allusion to the Arab-Israeli conflict or, on more general terms, to the idea that Islam, like Christianity, also turned to state authority and use of coercion in its attempt to gain converts and force conversions.

The support for Christian and Muslim missionizing, in so far as it is done ethically and with no violence, was a naïve position historically. What is interesting is that Baeck extended the positive view of missionizing to the Jewish case. Unlike other thinkers, who thought about Jewish contribution to the world in abstract terms, Baeck was an ardent believer in Jewish missionizing. He thought that Jews were successful missionizers in antiquity, but that they were prevented from doing so due to historical circumstances of living under other empires of faith. But when given the chance, Jews resumed missionizing, such as in the story about the conversion of the King of Khazar and later the people, made famous by the medieval Jewish thinker and poet Judah Halevi, another favorite representative of the Spanish Golden Age.⁵² In the postwar era, Baeck claimed, the condition are ripe for the resumption of Jewish missionizing, not only because of the current weakness of other missionizing religions but also because “we are in need of expansion for our own sake.”⁵³ After the Holocaust, Baeck implied that Jewish missionizing was different than Christian and Muslim missionizing. It was not only about expansion and the spread of monotheism by two of the largest religions in the world; it was about the preservation of the Jewish minority, whose teachings stood at heart of Christianity and Islam.

51 Leo Baeck, “Die Mission des Judentums (1949),” in *Werke* 6, ed. Michael Meyer (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 527; see also Leo Baeck, “Some Questions to the Christian Church from the Jewish Point of View,” in *Werke* 5, ed. Albert Friedlander and Bertold Klappert (Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 2006), 456

52 Baeck, *Das Wesen des Judentums* (1905), 409–10.

53 Baeck, “Die Mission des Judentums (1949),” 528.

5 Conclusion

From his early review of Schreiner's work, through *The Essence of Judaism*, and all the way to the postwar era, Baeck engaged not only Christianity, but also Islam and Jewish life under Muslim rule. At times, Baeck praised Islam as a way of criticizing the treatment of Jews by Christians. He did so, however, without raising al-Andalus to the level of a single focal point of Jewish medieval history. Rather, he insisted on the value of Ashkenaz as an equally worthy pole of Jewish existence thereby offering a more nuanced picture of Jewish history, one that stresses unity and exchanges. Baeck's description of simplicity of the Muhammad's message, the static nature of Islam, and lack of recognition of Muslim contributions to Jewish life after the Middle Ages combine to suggest that his views remained confined to biases of his era.

But Baeck was constantly reassessing his position. "Bridges between Judaism, Christianity, and Islam" (1956) was a lecture given half a year before his death. He returned to al-Andalus and the expansion of Islam one last time, in what could be seen as a plea for peace and cooperation in the Middle East. This was not a new position for Baeck, an advocate of co-existence who espoused a vision that acknowledge simultaneously a Jewish right to settle in the land with a binationalist ideal.⁵⁴ Baeck saw the problem of what he calls "our Land of Israel"—a telling statement in itself—but instead of tackling the issue politically, he tried to shift the focus.⁵⁵ Looking at history, Baeck suggested, should be done not on the scale of a national map (*Landeskarte*) but on a global scale. Once this change of perspective was, one would realize just how widespread Islam was, and how the Land of Israel was surrounded by Muslim countries and culture.

Such a description should not be read as an attempt to present Israel as bastion of light as opposed to oppressing forces. On the contrary, a better approach, according to Baeck, was to see the Land of Israel as part of the area: "It is a question, in which the religious steps in the historical. Everything depends on finding a way from Islam to Judaism, from the Arab to the Israelite world and its religion, just as it had once been a blessing for both of them in the Middle Ages."⁵⁶ For all his complex relation to Islam and Muslim culture, al-Andalus is imagined once more as a model to imitate. Muslim expansion (its role as a proxy for Judaism)

⁵⁴ Yaniv Feller, *The Jewish Imperial Imagination*, 163–166.

⁵⁵ Leo Baeck, "Brücken zwischen Judentum, Christentum und Islam (1955)," 488.

⁵⁶ Leo Baeck, "Brücken zwischen Judentum, Christentum und Islam (1955)," 488.

made it possible for Islam to recognize its Jewish origins and usher a new Golden Age that would be a boon for Jews and Judaism. This was a position that was hopeful, looking for the past as a way to try and envision a better future. Not many believed this vision in 1956; even fewer are able to cling to it today.

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